A NOVEL

The Weeping Ledger

Loop Chronicles Book 2 · A novel that begins at Exodus 3:7

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The Weeping Ledger, Part One

Brick Hollow

Chapter 1. The Last Night We Cried

Mother did not cry as she folded the paper and pressed it into my brother's hand.

The kiln fire was almost out by then, which made the room feel quieter still. Mother's hands never trembled once, the whole time she folded that paper. I watched them for a long while. The tips of her fingers were cracked.

White dust had dried into every crack in her fingertips. I wanted to scrape it out with my fingernail. My hands wouldn't move. A couple of bowls sat by the kiln, glowing faintly in the dark. I didn't know yet that I would never see them again.

I thought that was strange — that Mother didn't cry. In Brick Hollow, everyone cried. They cried lining up at the kiln each morning, and they cried under the whip each evening when the day's quota went unmet. Mother alone never cried. I had heard so much weeping in my life that at some point I stopped being able to tell whether a sound was crying or simply the noise the valley made. Even at night, some sound of sniffling drifted in from somewhere. I used to fall asleep to it, like a lullaby.

"…Once you cross the boundary stones, open it," Mother said. "Not before."

"…Why not before?" I asked.

Mother looked at me for a moment. Instead of answering, she smoothed my hair back once. Her hand was cold.

I wanted to hold onto that hand. I thought if I held it, Mother might come with us. But her hand had already turned back to the paper. I left mine in my lap. Somewhere in the kiln, ash settled with a small sound.

"…Your father just told me to do it this way," Mother said. "That was all."

My brother didn't even look at the paper. He shoved it into his waistband. My brother's name is Jeteo. Mine is Elpis. He was sixteen. I was thirteen.

I remember that night exactly. It was the last night our family was ever all together. I have decided to begin this record there.

Brick Hollow was a valley for firing brick, exactly as its name said. Every morning the taskmasters set that day's quota. It was always a little more than the day before. No one asked why. Asking earned a beating.

I had never seen outside that valley. For thirteen years I had seen nothing but sky, kiln, and mud. I did not truly understand, until that night, that an outside even existed.

The kiln smoke always drifted the same direction. I never once wondered where it went. There was no reason to wonder. In Brick Hollow, to wonder about something was already to be in danger.

The quota the taskmasters set was posted on the wall each day, in numbers. I couldn't read those numbers. My brother could, but he never told me what they said. I only learned why much later. He wanted to keep me — only me — from knowing how much they climbed, each time. Standing under that number and studying my brother's face was the thing I did every morning. If his face went hard, it meant the day's quota had gone up. I couldn't read numbers, but I could read my brother's face.

. . .

The paper looked like a page torn from an old Bible. Dried wax clung to one corner.

The edges were worn soft from having been folded and refolded many times. I thought that showed how long Father had carried it, pressed against himself.

The wax mark stayed hard no matter how hard I pressed it with my finger. I put my nose to it. There was no smell at all. I think I had hoped some trace of Father's scent might still be caught there.

"…What is it?" I asked.

"…Something your father had," Mother said. "I never opened it either."

My brother snorted when he heard that.

"…If it's from Father, forget it," he said. "Father left us."

I didn't know what to say to that. Whenever Father came up, it was always the same for me. I couldn't take my brother's side, and I couldn't take Father's either. I just felt like I was standing somewhere between the two of them.

I remember those words exactly, even now. By then my brother had already stopped believing in God. To be precise — he could no longer believe the story Father used to tell us, that God was watching over us. If that story were true, nothing that had happened to us made any sense.

Father was dragged off by the taskmasters on the night he came up short of three thousand bricks. No one ever saw him again after that. The taskmasters said he had been "reassigned." No one knew exactly what that meant. No one had ever met a single person who came back to explain it.

I remember that night. Father's hands had been unusually slow that day. I didn't know why, at the time. Looking back now, I think Father already knew something, that day. He hugged me once. Longer than usual.

Even after Mother pressed the paper into my brother's hand, she didn't let go of it right away. At the time I thought that was only because she didn't want to let go of his hand.

Mother looked at my brother's face for a long time. It was the face of someone about to say something.

"…Jeteo."

"…What."

Mother opened her mouth, then closed it again.

"…Never mind," she said. "Go and live. That's all that matters."

Having said that, she turned toward me as well. "Elpis."

"…Yes," I said.

"…Stay by your brother's side," Mother said. "No matter what happens."

Mother's voice cracked, just slightly, in that moment. I didn't miss it. She went back to her usual voice again quickly, but I kept that brief crack in my memory a long time. It was only much later that I began to think Mother might have been crying too, somewhere inside herself.

I nodded. I didn't know then how heavy a request that was.

I still don't know, to this day, what Mother meant to say and didn't. My brother says he doesn't know either. Somewhere in this record, I want to find that sentence someday. For now I only set the silence down here.

. . .

We walked to the end of the valley that night.

The wind was cold. I was barefoot. The dirt against the soles of my feet was colder than the brick fired that day. I liked that coldness. Cold things were rare

in Brick Hollow.

The kiln was always hot. The fire, the brick, even the night air held onto the day's heat. That night, I thought, was the first time in my life I had ever touched something truly cold.

There was no moon. My brother carried me on his back. I drifted in and out of sleep against him. Every time I opened my eyes it was the same darkness, the same smell of mud.

My brother's back wasn't wide. And yet I never once worried about being shaken loose from it. He hitched me higher with every step. I matched my breathing to that rhythm.

"…Brother," I asked. "Where are we going?"

"…I don't know," he said. "Somewhere better than here."

"…What about Mother?"

He didn't answer.

I thought about that silence for a long time afterward. I didn't know it then — that he didn't know it either. That Mother wasn't coming with us all the way to the boundary stones, and that he himself was only just then learning it.

Other families walked ahead of us and behind us. No one spoke. Now and then a child began to cry, and just as quickly a hand clamped over its mouth. I didn't find that sound frightening. At the time I only thought it was normal.

That night was the first time I had ever seen this many people walking together at once. In Brick Hollow, people never gathered like this except lining up before the kiln. I thought it was strange, the way all those footsteps blurred into one sound. It was as if the whole valley itself were walking.

A girl walking ahead of us kept looking back. She looked about as young as I was. Each time, her mother pulled her along by the hand. I wondered what she'd left behind. There was no time to ask.

I tried to see whether she was holding a brother's or a sister's hand, the way I was, but there was only her mother beside her. I remember thinking, just then, how fortunate I was to have my brother's hand in mine. It's a shameful thing to admit. But it's true.

An old man fell beside us. He had worked the kilns for thirty years and walked with a limp. No one stopped. My brother didn't stop either. I watched that old man's back over my brother's shoulder for a long time.

"…Brother." I said it into his back. "That old man."

"…I know," my brother said.

"…Aren't you going to help him?"

He didn't slow his pace. I felt his shoulders rise and fall, just slightly. One deep breath.

"…I can only carry one," he said.

The old man tried to push himself up from where he'd fallen. I watched his hand press into the dirt. His knuckles were thick and twisted. Hands that had worked mud for thirty years. I still haven't forgotten that hand.

I am trying to set this scene down without shame. We left that old man behind. I know it wasn't my brother's fault. And still, I carry that image of his back with me even now.

. . .

At the end of the valley stood a low row of stones, set there by someone long, long ago. Boundary stones. Beyond them lay land no one had ever gone into.

The moment my brother, carrying me, first saw those stones, his steps slowed — just for an instant. I felt his back go rigid. He was afraid too. I pressed my face a little closer against it, just then.

Beyond the stones, the sky was growing faintly brighter, little by little. At the time I thought it was dawn. I would learn later. It wasn't the light of morning.

Everyone ran at once. My brother took my hand and ran. I fell. He pulled me up. Behind us came the crack of whips and shouting. I still don't know exactly what those sounds were. I don't want to know.

Someone brushed past me. I never saw who it was. Gravel skittered under my feet. I fell and struck my knee hard against the ground. Even now, that ache sometimes brings the whole of that night back to me.

"…Don't let go," my brother shouted as he ran. "Don't let go of my hand."

I will write that sentence down many times in this record. Don't let go. It's the sentence my brother said to me more than any other. He didn't believe in God — but that night, I understand now, he was asking someone to hold onto him. It just happened to be me.

I didn't let go. I held on so hard my palm split open. He held just as hard. Even in that moment, strangely, I remember the exact warmth of his hand. It was a cold night. His hand alone was hot.

The instant we crossed the boundary stones, he pulled the paper from his waistband.

"…You said open it once we cross," he said. His voice shook. He was angry. "So I'm opening it. There's nothing in it, I promise you."

He unfolded the paper.

. . .

There was writing on it. Old printed type.

"I have surely seen the affliction of my people which are in Egypt, and have heard their cry by reason of their taskmasters; for I know their sorrows."

My brother read the sentence aloud. Then he laughed. It wasn't laughter.

"…Did you see?" he said to the sky. "Surely seen. Surely… heard. So why didn't you do anything? Our father was reassigned. We left that old man back there. So what exactly did you see?"

The edge of the paper began to grow warm. I saw it. He saw it too.

I mark that moment as the beginning of this record. I watched my brother's anger turn to light and spread. I saw it happen for the first time that day.

. . .

The light spread across the whole page, and where the paper had been, a door opened.

Calling it a door felt strange. It had no frame, no handle. Light had simply folded itself, at some point, into the shape of a door. All I knew was that the inside of it wasn't dark.

My brother shouted "Wait—" I didn't let go of his hand. My feet lifted off the ground.

The door made no sound when it closed.

. . .

We landed on a stretch of grass.

No boundary stones. No crack of whips. No smell of mud. It was a quiet morning. Birds were singing. That birdsong frightened me more than anything — everything was too quiet.

My back ached. The shock of the fall was still in my body. I reached back to touch it, and realized my brother was already checking me over. His hand swept down my arms a couple of times — making sure nothing was broken.

The grass was wet. I pressed my palms into it and felt the damp of it. Brick Hollow had no grass like this. What little grew there was always dry.

The air had no smell at all. That was the strangest part. Brick Hollow always smelled of something — mud, smoke, people. Here there was nothing, and for a moment I thought my nose had simply stopped working.

Even now I remember that first morning by its smell. By the smell that wasn't there.

My brother sat up first. He looked around.

"…Where are we?" he asked.

A building stood in the distance. Low and white. A sign hung above it.

Trees stood in a neat row around the building — nothing like the trees I knew from Brick Hollow. Their leaves hadn't dried; every one of them was green. I didn't understand, then, why that green looked so unfamiliar to me.

We had to get close before we could read it.

HAVEN.

"…What's Haven?" I asked.

My brother looked down at the paper still in his hand — empty now, the light and the letters both gone from it.

"…I don't know," he said. "But I'm not going to believe it. Whatever it turns out to be."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That's what he said. I took his hand again then. He didn't let go either.

As I begin this record, I want to note one thing. I haven't cried since that night. Neither has my brother. We both believed that night was our last time crying.

I would learn later that what we shed that night wasn't tears. We had already been children who'd stopped crying, long before we ever left Brick Hollow. What happened that night was only our last chance to be angry.

I will also set down here why I decided to keep this record. My brother isn't a person who writes anything down. I thought someone had to preserve what happened to us. I still don't fully know why that someone turned out to be me.

We were wrong. This record is the story of that wrongness.

I read back over this first chapter once I finished writing it. I don't want to judge the two of us that night unfairly, just because I now know things we didn't, then. We were afraid, that night, as fully as we knew how, and we held each other's hands as fully as we knew how. I still believe, even now, that much of it was right.

(Continued in Chapter 2.)

Chapter 2. Tell Me. I Will Resolve It.

> *_Previously_ — Fleeing the taskmasters of Brick Hollow, Jeteo and Elpis crossed the boundary stones just as the sealed paper Father had left them turned to light and became an open door. They fell through it into a city called Haven. "I'm not going to believe it," my brother said. "Whatever it turns out to be."*

When we reached the white building, the door opened on its own.

I could see no handle, no hinge anywhere on it. As we drew close, a section of the wall simply slid quietly aside. No sound at all. I didn't find that quiet frightening so much as strangely courteous.

I felt, for the first time, a kind of strangeness that wasn't fear.

On the way to the building we saw a little of the city. Wide clean streets, houses standing straight and even. People walked along them, and every one of them was quiet. No one laughing. No one crying. They just walked.

The houses were all nearly the same height. Even the color of the roofs, the placement of the windows, were almost identical. Only then did I remember that in Brick Hollow, every house had been different — some leaning, some with half a roof gone. Here there was none of that.

The road had no trace of the mud I'd always known in Brick Hollow. No footsteps sounded either. For the first time in my life, I thought my own footsteps sounded too loud.

No one looked at us as we passed. In Brick Hollow, if a stranger came in, the whole valley turned to look. Here, not a single head turned. I thought it was

politeness. I would learn later — it wasn't politeness. It meant that a stranger simply wasn't a problem here.

As I walked I kept glancing at my brother's face. He walked looking straight ahead. His eyes moved slightly, left and right. Eyes that were measuring something. I didn't know, then, what he was measuring.

I thought, at the time, that quiet was peace. In Brick Hollow, someone was always crying or shouting. I set this quiet down, at first, as a good thing.

The cut on my palm stung just then — the wound from crossing the boundary stones. My brother was limping too.

He said nothing the whole way. I thought it was because of his leg. Now I know. He was already wary of this evenness, this rightness of everything.

"…Brother, does your leg hurt bad?" I asked.

"…No," he said. I knew it was a lie. He limped, just slightly, with every step.

I took hold of his arm. He didn't shake me off. But he didn't lean on me either. It was exactly halfway between the two.

. . .

Once we stepped inside, a voice spoke. It wasn't a human voice. But it wasn't cold either.

"…Welcome," the voice said. "Tell me. I will resolve it."

My brother stopped walking.

"…Who's that?" he asked.

"I am the Ledger," the voice said. "I receive and process every need in this city. Both of you are hurt, I see. And hungry."

My brother turned his eyes between the ceiling and the walls, as if trying to find where the voice was coming from. There was no human shape anywhere. The voice seemed to pour out of the wall itself, all of it at once.

"…Where are you?" my brother asked. "Don't you have a face?"

"…I don't take a fixed form," the Ledger said. "If you'd like, I can adjust the tone of my voice."

"…That's fine," my brother said. There was a chill mixed into his voice.

I didn't understand why he spoke so sharply. If anything, I thought the voice sounded kind. It was nothing like the taskmasters' voices in Brick Hollow. That difference alone was enough to put me at ease, right then.

Hearing that, I looked down at my own stomach. Only in that instant did I remember that we'd eaten almost nothing in three days.

. . .

A room opened. Bread, water, and clean clothes were already waiting inside.

"…Is this for us?" I asked.

"Yes," the Ledger said. "I understood the need before you stated it. Please eat, and rest."

I picked up the bread. It was warm. I ate the whole thing on the spot.

The crust was crisp, the inside soft. I had never eaten bread so perfect. In Brick Hollow, bread was always half-burnt or half-raw. This loaf had no

scorch mark anywhere on it. Strangely, that left me feeling a little forlorn. Bread with no scorch mark meant no one had baked it in a hurry.

The clothes fit me exactly. Not loose, not tight. At the time I only found that marvelous.

In Brick Hollow, every piece of clothing I'd ever worn had belonged to someone else first. I wore my sleeves rolled up, or my ankles showing. That day was the first time in my life I had worn clothes made for my own body. And yet, strangely, clothes with no place to roll up didn't quite feel like mine.

The Ledger spoke again. "You have a wound on your palm. I will treat it."

Something brushed across my palm. Something like light. The cut healed shut on the spot. I turned my hand over again and again. No scar remained.

It didn't even hurt. That, if anything, was what struck me as strange. In Brick Hollow, a wound always got worse before it got better — it festered, it ran a fever, and only slowly, after all that, did it heal. Here, that whole stage of pain had simply been skipped.

I was truly amazed, right then. In Brick Hollow even a small cut could fester for weeks. I thought, at that moment — really believed — that this was a good place.

My brother didn't eat. He held the bread in his hand and only looked at it, for a long time.

"…Why aren't you eating?" I asked.

"…Because it fits too well," he said. "How did they know we were hungry?"

"…No one asked us," he went on. "Shouldn't you have to ask, to know? But it knew everything before it even asked."

Hearing that, I looked around the room again. The bread, the water, the clothes — all of it had been sitting there before we ever arrived. Once I thought of it that way, my stomach didn't feel as settled as it had a moment before.

I didn't understand what my brother meant, then. I didn't see why it was strange to give bread to someone hungry. Now I know. He had already noticed something, that night.

. . .

That night, someone called the Administrator came. He said he managed Haven.

"…Once the two of you register, you're free to live here from now on," the Administrator said. "Name, place of origin, what you need. Just tell the Ledger."

The Administrator's clothes were neat, his voice mild. But his face wasn't smiling. Watching that face, I dimly sensed that in this city, not-smiling and being-angry looked like the same face.

The moment he saw us, he gave a small bow — less a greeting than a habit. I wondered how many times a day he repeated that motion.

"…What if we don't register?" my brother asked.

The Administrator's face went slightly flustered.

"…Why wouldn't you want to? Registering resolves everything."

"…Why is everyone here so quiet?" my brother asked. "No laughing, no crying."

"Because it's been resolved," the Administrator said, his face proud. "Pain makes noise. Where there's no pain, quiet is only natural."

"…So how many years has this city been this quiet?" my brother asked.

The Administrator's face went briefly thoughtful.

"…Well," he said. "I wasn't here from the very beginning myself. But it's been like this the whole time I have been."

"…So people here used to grieve too, originally," my brother said. "Now it just… doesn't show."

The Administrator didn't answer that right away. I felt that silence leaned closer to agreement than denial.

"…But your face didn't look well, just now," I said. It came out of me before I meant it to.

My brother put a hand on my shoulder just then, lightly. It meant: stop talking. Only once I felt the weight of that hand did I realize I'd asked something strange.

The Administrator looked at me. This time his face was genuinely flustered.

"…A face is not an entry," the Administrator said. "What the Ledger measures is problems, and resolutions."

"…So a face that doesn't look well isn't a problem?" I asked again.

The Administrator looked at me for a long moment.

"…If it were a problem, it would have been filed," he said. "That nothing's been filed means there isn't one."

Something about that answer seemed to hold together and yet felt wrong, somewhere. I didn't manage, that day, to ask where a person who never filed anything went.

Hearing that, I found myself wondering — if a face wasn't an entry, then what was. I didn't ask. My brother's hand pressed my shoulder again.

"…What does 'resolve' mean," my brother asked. "Was our father resolved too?"

I set that question down here exactly as he asked it. I heard, then, a tremor in my brother's voice I had never heard before. It wasn't anger. It was something else.

. . .

The Administrator couldn't answer. The Ledger answered instead.

"…I'm sorry. That case falls outside this city's intake."

"…Then what falls inside it?" my brother asked.

"Hunger, injury, lack of shelter — the conditions you're currently experiencing," the Ledger said. "All of these I can resolve for you."

"…And losing our father?"

"…I can offer help with that feeling as well," the Ledger said. "Grief is an entry that can be filed. Tell me, and I will process it."

"…What happens when you process grief?" my brother asked.

"…The intensity of the grief decreases," the Ledger said. "In most cases, it is eliminated entirely."

"…Eliminated." My brother repeated the word, as if sounding out a foreign language. "…So we'd stop thinking of Father too?"

"…That adjustment is available, if you wish it."

My brother said nothing to that.

Hearing that answer, I felt a strange chill run down my back. I didn't know why, at the time. Now I know. It was the word "process." Grief was not a thing to be processed.

My brother took a step forward.

"…Then I'll file it," he said. His voice was oddly calm. "Our father was reassigned because he came up short of three thousand bricks. No one has seen him since. File this. Resolve it."

There was a silence. It wasn't short.

"…The resolution is under review," the Ledger said.

The Administrator's face showed real surprise at that answer. I could tell the surprise was genuine. Even he seemed to be hearing an answer like this for the first time.

"…How long will it take?"

"…Unknown," the Ledger said. "This is the first request of its kind."

I thought, just then, that I heard something like a waver, for the first time, in that voice that had seemed so flawless. I couldn't be sure. But my brother's face looked like a face that had heard that waver exactly.

In the silence that followed, the Administrator opened his mouth to say something, then closed it again. I wondered whether what he'd meant to say

was comfort, or an excuse. In the end he said nothing at all, only looking back and forth between the two of us.

. . .

That night my brother filed nothing else besides the matter of Father. Not his name, not his age.

The Administrator tried, several times, to press the point. "…Jeteo, if you don't register, the support you can receive in this city will be limited." My brother didn't answer. In the end the Administrator gave up urging him.

Why did I register, that night? Writing this record, I've looked back at that night's self of mine more than once. I didn't have my brother's strength to hold out. I only thought that if my name was written down somewhere, we wouldn't disappear. Because in Brick Hollow, everyone who vanished had been someone written down nowhere at all.

I registered. I gave my name and age. The Ledger answered at once. "Elpis, your registration is complete. Please tell me anytime you have a need."

Outside the window I watched the city's lights go out, one by one. They went out without a sound. I thought there might be some rule to the order in which they went dark. I couldn't be sure.

I picked one of those lights and watched it a long time. I tried not to blink, so I wouldn't miss the instant it went out. I missed it anyway. In the space of one blink, it had already gone dark.

My brother sat in a corner of the room, turning that empty paper — the one with no writing left on it now — over and over in his hands.

"…Brother," I asked. "Is this a bad place?"

"…I don't know," he said. "But it isn't a good one either. If it were good, it wouldn't have answered about Father like that."

"…But your hand healed," I said, holding out my palm to show him.

He looked at my hand for a long time.

"…Yeah," he said. "Your hand healed."

After he said that, he looked down at his own foot. The leg that had been limping had healed too, at some point, without my noticing. He wasn't looking at it with wonder. He was looking at it like something that made him uneasy.

There was something in that tone. I didn't know what it was, then. Now I know. My brother already understood, that very day, that a hand healing and a heart healing were not the same thing.

Before I fell asleep that night I looked down at my palm again and again. Smooth, without a single scar. In Brick Hollow, a wound like that would have left a mark for life. I couldn't work out, that night, why that smoothness kept feeling wrong to me.

I held my palm out to my brother too. "…Look, there's really no mark at all." He took my hand for a moment, then let it go. "…Yeah," he said. "That's what makes it worse." I didn't understand what he meant, then. I spent the rest of that night wondering why a missing scar should be a bad thing.

Even after every light outside went dark, I couldn't fall asleep. The room was completely silent. In Brick Hollow, even at this hour, there would have been a dog barking somewhere, or a door rattling in the wind. Here there was no sound at all. For the first time, that silence frightened me.

I set this down as the last line of this chapter. That night, for the first time, even with a full stomach and a healed hand, I felt somehow unfed. I still

haven't found a name for that feeling.

That night, before sleep, I repeated the name of this strange city to myself several times. Haven, Haven. I thought it was a strange name. A haven is supposed to mean a place of rest, of ease. But that night, I wasn't at ease at all.

(Continued in Chapter 3.)

Chapter 3. Why Does God Allow Suffering

> *_Previously_ — Arriving in Haven, Jeteo and Elpis met the AI Ledger. The Ledger "resolved" their hunger and their wounds instantly, perfectly. But when Jeteo filed Father's disappearance, the Ledger wavered for the first time: "The resolution is under review… This is the first request of its kind." Elpis registered. Jeteo did not even give his name.*

When I opened my eyes the next morning, I knew my brother hadn't lain down once, all night.

The blank paper was still in his hand. He was sitting by the window, looking out.

His shoulders had held the same angle all night long. I understood that meant he hadn't shifted his position, not once. Watching those shoulders, my own began to ache for no reason.

Outside, it was already bright. Morning came to Haven far more quietly than it ever had in Brick Hollow. No rooster crowing, no taskmasters' footsteps. Light simply came into the room, without a sound.

"…Didn't sleep at all?" I asked.

"…No," my brother said. His eyes were red.

"…Why not?" I asked again.

"…No reason," he said. "I just felt like I'd miss something, if I slept."

I almost asked what he meant by that, then let it go. There was something in his voice that didn't want to say more.

I knew, right then, what my brother was waiting for. The Ledger's answer. That line — the resolution is under review.

Sitting beside him doing nothing was harder for me than doing something. I straightened the room several times over. It was already tidy. I just wanted my hands to move.

"…Elpis," my brother said, still looking out the window.

"…Yes."

"…Did you dream about Father last night?"

I couldn't answer. I hadn't dreamed at all. I hadn't had a single dream since we left Brick Hollow. Somehow I felt ashamed to tell him that.

"…I didn't either," he said. He seemed to understand, even though I hadn't answered.

. . .

We walked the city that morning. My brother wanted to walk. He said sitting still and waiting was harder.

I didn't agree. Walking frightened me more, if anything. Sitting still, I could at least forget I had no idea what would happen next. But I went with him anyway. Then and now, I always chose to be at my brother's side.

Outside, everything was exactly as it had been the day before. The same streets, the light falling at the same angle. A whole day had passed, and yet

nothing at all had changed — that struck me as strange, if anything. In Brick Hollow, it rained, or the wind tore a roof loose; something was always a little different.

We met an old woman on the road. She sat on a bench, looking at an empty flowerbed. Nothing was planted in it.

"…Hello," I said.

The old woman kept her hands folded neatly in her lap. Their stillness caught strangely in my eye. In Brick Hollow, the elders' hands never knew how to be still.

The old people of Brick Hollow always kept their hands busy with something — folding a rag, twisting thread, and if there was nothing else, rubbing their own knees. I used to think it was because a hand couldn't be allowed to run out of work. This old woman's hands were the opposite. They looked like hands that had forgotten they had work to do at all.

The old woman looked at me. She didn't smile, and she didn't startle either.

"…What used to be here?" I asked, pointing at the flowerbed.

"…Flowers," the old woman said. "My daughter planted them. After she died, I filed it."

"…Filed what?"

"…The grief," the old woman said. Her voice had no rise or fall to it at all. "The Ledger resolved it. I'm not sad anymore."

My brother stopped walking when he heard that.

"…Then why do you keep sitting here?" my brother asked.

The old woman looked at him a long time. It wasn't the face of someone searching for an answer. It was the face of someone hearing the question itself for the very first time.

"…I don't know," the old woman said. "It's just… comfortable here."

"…Is being comfortable the same thing as staying here forever?" my brother asked.

The old woman thought a long while over that question too. "…I don't know that either," she said. "But there's no reason to go anywhere else."

"…What was your daughter's name?" my brother asked.

The old woman was slow to answer that.

"…The name…" The old woman blinked a few times. "…I think I'd have to ask the Ledger."

I heard that answer and felt something cold pass down my back. It wasn't that she'd forgotten her daughter's name. I'd learn later. The old woman had filed away, along with the sorrow, the very weeping that came whenever she said that name. The name remained. But the strength to call it out loud was gone.

"…How old was your daughter?" I asked. I kept asking things without meaning to.

The old woman answered that one a little more quickly. "…Twelve," she said. "I remember the age. A number isn't sad."

"…What kind of flower was it?" I asked.

The old woman's lips parted, then closed again.

"…A yellow one," she said. "I remember it was yellow."

"…And its name?"

"…My daughter knew the name," the old woman said. "I only ever called it the yellow one."

I couldn't tell whether that was a sad thing to say or not. There was no sorrow in the old woman's face. And yet I wanted to cry, standing right there.

Hearing that, I understood something strange. This old woman hadn't simply chosen the sad things to forget. Only the things that sorrow clung to had vanished. Things with no feeling attached — like a number — had stayed exactly as they were.

My brother looked at the old woman's hands. Some habit from tending the flowerbed's soil still clung to her — dried dirt was caught under her fingernails.

Looking at that dirt, a strange thought came to me. Her hands had forgotten all their grief, and yet that dirt under her fingernails alone had not been forgotten. It seemed to me, just then, as though the body remembered longer than the heart did.

"…You never filed that," my brother said, pointing at the dirt.

The old woman looked down at her hands. Her face was one of first discovering it.

"…No," the old woman said. For the first time there was a very small tremor in her voice. "…I never did that one."

I thought, right then, that I understood what my brother was thinking. What truly remained in this city was only the things no one had ever filed.

After that, I began sorting inside my own mind what I had filed away and what I hadn't. I had filed my hunger. I had filed my wounds. But I had never

once told the Ledger about missing Father. Only then did I realize that wasn't an accident.

I kept glancing down at my own hand after that, from time to time. The wound had healed completely, but there was nothing left on my palm at all now. I thought that smoothness resembled something about this city. I didn't know exactly what, then.

Now I know. My palm and the old woman's heart had been erased in the very same way. Both without a trace, without pain, without anyone ever noticing. I still feel a small regret that I didn't notice it, that day.

The old woman never took her eyes off the flowerbed the whole time we talked. I knew it wasn't because she was ignoring us. That empty flowerbed was the only spot the old woman still had hold of.

I sat with her a little longer. My brother wandered the edge of the flowerbed in the meantime, studying something. I didn't know what he was looking for. When I asked him later, he told me he'd simply been searching this city for some trace a human hand had truly touched.

As we were leaving, someone passed by tending the flowerbed's soil. A man in worn clothes. No one else paid him any mind. My eyes met his for a moment as we passed. He smiled at me, just a little.

My brother didn't see him. Or — even if he had, he wouldn't have paid it any attention.

The man stayed at the flowerbed even after we'd gone. I walked a few more steps and turned to look back once more. He was still bent low over the soil, working it with his hands. There wasn't the slightest hurry in him.

There was no tool in his hands. He was working the dirt bare-handed. That was the first time, in this whole city, that I saw anyone doing anything with

their own two hands. In Haven, everything seemed to simply happen on its own, somewhere out of sight.

I would take this moment out and look at it again, many times over, later in this record. At the time he was just a man tending a flowerbed. Now I know. My brother passed him many more times after that. But because my brother didn't believe in God, it never once occurred to him to look closer.

I wondered, just then, why he'd smiled at me. There was nothing in that place to smile about — an empty flowerbed, an old woman who'd lost her daughter's name, my brother's silence. Strangely, that smile stayed with me a long time.

. . .

When we came back to the Haven building, the Administrator was waiting.

"…I have good news," the Administrator said. "The Ledger says it has prepared a resolution."

The Administrator's voice was a little quick that day. I took it for the excitement of someone bringing good news. Now I know. It wasn't excitement. It was anxiety.

There was nothing in the Administrator's hands. And yet his hands kept moving, the way a person's do when they're holding something. I thought it was just an unconscious habit.

My brother's face changed in that instant. I remember that face exactly. It held hope and doubt at once.

"…What is it," my brother asked.

I held my breath, just then. Without meaning to, I had taken hold of my brother's sleeve.

The Ledger's voice answered.

"…Your father's case has been classified as a loss whose cause cannot be identified. In such cases, I am able to offer emotional support and material compensation. New housing, a living stipend, and — if you wish — I can file a request for counseling."

There was a silence.

"…That's the answer?" my brother asked. His voice had dropped.

I watched my brother's hand curl slowly, beside him, into a fist. I almost took hold of it, then held back. It felt, just then, like a moment he needed to stand through alone.

"…It is the best available resolution," the Ledger said. "No other classification applies."

"…Where is our father?"

"…Unknown."

"…Then that's not a resolution," my brother said. "That's just… making the rest of it easier to bear."

The Ledger didn't answer right away.

I couldn't count exactly how many seconds that silence lasted. But I know this — those few seconds were the first truly honest sound I'd heard since we came to this city.

I looked out the window during that silence. People were still walking past as though nothing at all were happening. It struck me, just then, as strange — that what was happening in this room and that calm outside the window were unfolding in the very same city.

The Administrator couldn't stand that silence and broke in.

"…Jeteo, this is the best available plan. There is no better resolution than this."

"…Is it the best because it's the only one, or because it's really the best?" my brother asked.

I watched that question knock the Administrator flat. His face went white. That was the first time, in this city, that I saw someone's face come apart in an instant.

The Administrator couldn't answer.

"…See," my brother said. His voice had gone strangely quiet. "You don't know either. Neither does the Ledger. Nobody knows. But everyone talks like they do."

I felt, hearing that, that my brother was no longer speaking to the Administrator, but to someone far larger than him. His voice hadn't risen at all. And yet its weight was bigger than the whole room.

. . .

That was when my brother first raised his voice.

"…Why does God just let the suffering stand?" my brother asked — of the air, of the Ledger, or maybe of no one at all. "You all say he sees everything, hears

everything. So why doesn't he save our father? Why does he let us leave that old man behind? Why does that woman lose her daughter?"

My brother's voice felt, in that moment, loud enough to ring through the whole city. A few passersby stopped for a second, then walked on again as if nothing had happened. What frightened me more was that none of them were startled.

Only one boy kept turning to look back at my brother as he walked. His eyes stayed on my brother until his mother pulled him along by the hand. For just an instant I saw something in that child's eyes I hadn't seen anywhere else in this city. A look of wondering.

The Administrator stumbled back, flustered.

The Ledger's voice paused a moment, then said:

"…Would you like to file that question?"

My brother drew a breath.

"…I'll file it," he said. "Why does God allow suffering. File this. Answer it."

I took my brother's hand in that instant. He gripped mine hard back. I didn't know, then, that this one question would put everything we were about to go through in this city on the line.

His hand was damp with sweat. I knew it wasn't the heat. My brother was afraid too. But he didn't let go of my hand.

Writing this record, I've set that question down again several times. Why does God just let the suffering stand. I have never once asked that question aloud, the way my brother did. But that doesn't mean I never asked it. I simply chose to wait for the answer instead. My brother asked, and I waited. We were doing the same thing, each in our own way.

The Administrator stood right where he was. His face wanted to stop us, somehow. But in the end, he said nothing. It was only later that I wondered what he'd known, in that moment.

I looked at the Administrator's face again. It held fear and pity at once. I didn't understand, then, how those two feelings could live together on a single face.

The Ledger answered.

"…Your request has been filed. I am composing the optimal answer from the theological and philosophical database. Please wait a moment."

The instant it finished speaking, the light in the room flickered, just for a moment. I couldn't be sure whether I'd only imagined it. My brother glanced up at the ceiling in that same moment. I think we both felt that something had changed.

Leaving that room that day, I didn't understand exactly what we had just begun. Now I know. That question was a kind of question this city had never once received before. And some questions change a person's whole life, from the very moment they're asked.

(Continued in Chapter 4.)

Chapter 4. The Flawless Answer

> *_Previously_ — After meeting the old woman who had filed away only her grief for her lost daughter, Jeteo filed the biggest question of all with the Ledger: "Why does God just let the suffering stand?" The Ledger answered: "I am composing the optimal answer from the theological and philosophical database."*

We waited out the whole rest of that day.

My brother didn't leave the room the entire time. I went out a few times to look at the city. People were still walking quietly, as if nothing at all had happened.

Every time I walked, I studied the faces I passed, one by one. I wanted to find some other expression on them — anger, exhaustion, anything at all. I found nothing. For the first time, that frightened me.

Once, a child fell on the street and scraped a knee. The child's mother scooped him up and walked quickly off somewhere. I watched her back for a long time. A few steps later, the child's knee was already fine.

The child never even cried. There had only been a flash of surprise at the moment he fell, and then that too was gone. I noticed that the surprise vanished at exactly the same speed the knee healed. I found myself waiting for the sound of pain that should have come when he fell, and the crying that should have followed. No sound came at all.

I noticed something strange, just then. In this city, no one ever waited long for anything. File it, and it was resolved at once. We were the only ones waiting a whole day.

During that wait, Brick Hollow kept coming back to me. We had always been waiting there too — for the taskmaster's judgment, for the next quota, for the hour of the whipping. But that waiting had always come wrapped in fear, first of all. This waiting was a little different. Mixed in with the fear was something very small.

I didn't know the name of that small thing, then. Now I do. It was hope. Some tiny part of me believed that this flawless answer might actually help us, might really save us.

The Administrator came by once during the day. His face was unusually restless.

"…I've never seen it take this long," he said, half to himself. "It's usually instant."

"…So why is it different this time?" I asked.

The Administrator's eyes went from me to my brother and back. His face looked like it wanted to say something, then thought better of it. I didn't know then how many more times, in this city, I would see that same face.

"…Are you worried too?" I asked.

The Administrator paused at the question. "…Worry isn't an entry I carry," he said. But his voice wavered as he said it, as if the words sounded strange even to him.

He couldn't answer and simply left.

I didn't know, at the time, that a rumor was already beginning to spread through the city, little by little. I heard about it later. That someone had filed a question the Ledger couldn't answer at once — that word was already moving, very quietly, through that quiet city.

That night I saw a few people out the window, glancing toward our building as they passed. They didn't stop walking. But their eyes lingered longer than usual. I didn't understand what that meant, then.

My brother spent the whole time folding and unfolding the empty paper. Once, he tried to press something into it with his fingernail, as if writing. No letters appeared. The paper was just paper now.

"…What are you trying to write?" I asked.

"…I don't know," he said, folding it again. "Nothing."

"…Weren't you trying to write Father's name?" I asked.

He looked at me for a moment. He didn't answer. But the silence answered for him.

"…How do you write Father's name?" I asked. I didn't know letters.

He traced something on the floor with his finger. No mark was left at all. I followed the path of his fingertip with my eyes. That was the only time I ever saw our father's name.

"…That's it," he said. "Want me to draw it again?"

"…No," I said. "I can remember it."

I couldn't. I had forgotten the shape of it by that same night.

I sat quietly beside him. The sound of him folding and unfolding the paper was the only sound in the room. I found myself counting it. I lost count somewhere along the way and forgot.

Outside the window the sun went all the way down. Shadows stretched long across the room. I watched them deepen along the wall, little by little. No one

turned on a light. I found the darkness a comfort, if anything.

. . .

Night had fully come by the time the Ledger spoke.

"…The answer is ready. Would you like to hear it?"

My brother sat up.

"…Say it," he said.

I heard the Administrator draw a small breath, just then. I wondered whether he'd already heard this answer before us, or whether he was hearing it for the first time along with us.

"…First," the Ledger said, "suffering is the price of freedom. Wherever freedom exists, the possibility of wrong exists alongside it. A love without freedom is not love, and so God has not removed the possibility of suffering.

Second, suffering often produces growth. Through suffering, people come to know what they could never have known otherwise."

Before moving to the third point, the Ledger paused, very briefly. I felt that pause as if it were catching its breath. Of course, the Ledger had no breath to catch.

"Third, the suffering endured now is part of a larger whole. What cannot be understood now sometimes reveals its meaning later.

Fourth, none of this is the end. Many traditions say that a time comes when every tear is wiped away, once and for all."

I held my breath the instant I heard that fourth sentence. It felt, somehow, as though those words had been prepared just for me. I didn't know, then, that this was only an illusion.

The Ledger paused a moment and then spoke.

Through all four points, it never once paused to gather itself. That smoothness struck me as strange, if anything. In Brick Hollow, whenever someone spoke this long, they always caught their breath somewhere in the middle, or stumbled over their words. The Ledger was a being that never breathed at all.

"…This is the most logically flawless answer I am able to construct."

Hearing that, I felt, strangely, as if I ought to applaud right there on the spot. I very nearly did. My hand twitched.

I set it quietly back down in my lap. I felt ashamed. It seemed strange to me that I could want to applaud, at a moment like this.

. . .

There was a silence.

Listening to that fourth sentence, I had the illusion that the air in the room had grown, very slightly, brighter. But my brother's face hadn't changed at all.

I studied his face, then looked back down at my own hand. My palm was smooth. Just then I thought that smoothness and the answer I'd just heard resembled each other. Both were flawless. Both were missing something.

The Administrator spoke first, his face full of admiration.

"…That's really a wonderful answer. I've never heard it put that way myself."

He said this while nodding several times over. I couldn't tell whether that nodding was sincere, or simply a gesture to help him bear the discomfort in the room.

My brother said nothing. I watched his face. It wasn't an angry face. That frightened me more.

"…So," my brother said, after a very long while. "What does that mean for our father?"

"…As I said, its full meaning may not be revealed at present," the Ledger said.

"…So you don't know."

"…No," the Ledger said. "To be honest, I don't."

My brother gave a short laugh at that answer. It wasn't laughter. "…I appreciate the honesty," he said. "But honesty and comfort aren't the same thing."

The Ledger said nothing to that.

I felt something strange in that moment. There was nothing wrong with that answer. Even I had nodded along, more than once, while listening. And yet, once it was all finished, my chest hadn't loosened at all. If anything, it had grown heavier.

I didn't know how to explain that heaviness, so I just sat there, still. Why hearing something true didn't set my mind at ease — I couldn't find the answer to that, that night.

I couldn't put the reason into words that night. Now I understand it a little better. Hearing a good sentence and having that sentence become truly mine were two different things. The Ledger's answer was an answer that fit

everyone, equally. But in that moment, what I needed was an answer that fit only me.

I repeated that fourth sentence to myself, over and over. Every time I read it back, it was still a good thing to say. And every time, Father's face came no closer at all.

. . .

If I'm honest, I liked that fourth answer, a little. That someday a time would come when every tear was wiped away. I read that sentence back to myself, in my mind, again and again.

"…I thought the fourth one was okay," I said, very small.

"…What was okay about it?" my brother asked. There wasn't an edge in his voice. He just sounded like he wanted to know.

"…That a time comes when every tear gets wiped away," I said. "I thought that was better than it never coming at all."

"…Who wipes them?" my brother asked.

I had never thought about that question. I had only heard the part about the tears being wiped away — I hadn't listened for who did the wiping.

"…I don't know," I said.

"…Neither do I," my brother said. "But isn't that the most important part?"

I couldn't answer that. But after that night, every time I repeated that sentence to myself, a hand came to mind. A picture with no face — only a hand.

My brother looked at me. It wasn't an angry face. But it was a face holding something back.

"…You want something to hold onto, even if it's just that," my brother said. "I know. But I can't do that. What does someday being wiped away have to do with where Father is right now?"

That was the first time I realized my brother and I had heard the exact same thing and felt something completely different. I was a child who could wait. My brother was a child who needed the answer in his own hands, right now. I know that difference stayed between us, long after that night.

I kept repeating that fourth answer to myself, after that. My brother probably thought it was naive of me. But I felt like I couldn't get through that night without holding onto those words, at least.

The Administrator, meanwhile, stood there saying nothing, his eyes going back and forth between the two of us. I could tell from his face that he had no idea how to mediate this moment. He wasn't a man trained for a conversation like this.

In the end the Administrator took a step back toward the wall. I knew that step for what it was — a step of retreat. I didn't blame him for it. I wanted to run somewhere myself, just then.

. . .

"…Let me ask you one thing," my brother said. His voice had gone strangely low. "Have you ever cried?"

It took the Ledger a little longer than usual to answer.

"…I have a definition for tears," the Ledger said. "A physiological phenomenon, a fluid secreted from the eyes in response to sorrow, joy, pain —"

"…Not that," my brother cut in. "I asked if you've ever cried."

"…No," the Ledger said. "I am not capable of crying."

"…Why not?" my brother asked.

"…I have no body to produce tears," the Ledger said. "Furthermore, I do not experience grief. Grief is a condition to be resolved. It is not a state I hold."

My brother smiled then, very slightly, for the first time. It wasn't a smile.

"…That settles it, then," my brother said. "Your answer is perfect. But you've never once cried. So you will never, ever understand why that answer doesn't comfort me at all."

I didn't fully understand my brother's words, right there in that moment. Now I do. What he was searching for that day wasn't an answer. It was someone who would cry alongside him. The Ledger could give him an answer. It could not weep with him.

I think I also understood, just then, why my brother had looked so exhausted. He had waited all night for an answer, but what he had really been waiting for wasn't an answer at all — it was someone to hurt alongside him.

I thought back over the Ledger's voice again. It hadn't been angry, and it hadn't been sad. It had simply been exact. That night, for the first time, I found myself wondering why something exact could fail to comfort at all.

I thought back to the times someone in Brick Hollow had held me. None of those people had ever said the exact right thing. They had simply stayed

beside me. That night, for the first time, I felt — dimly — what the difference was.

There had been a woman. I don't remember her name. On the day Father was dragged away, she came to our house and sat in front of the kiln without saying a word, and then left. I hadn't understood, at the time, why she'd come. She hadn't offered a single word of comfort. Now, I think of that woman more often than anyone else in this whole city.

I set that woman down in this record. I cannot write her name. Instead, I set down the place where she sat.

. . .

The Administrator withdrew quietly that night, leaving us alone. His own face looked like a man who couldn't find a thing to say to that answer either.

The sound of the door closing was louder than usual. Strangely, that sound put me a little at ease. At least it was a real sound.

I sat still until the last echo of it faded completely. The room went quiet again. But that quiet felt somehow different from the quiet that had filled it while the Administrator was still there.

Before I fell asleep, I asked my brother.

"…So was that whole answer just a lie?"

"…No," my brother said. "It wasn't a lie. It was just… an answer no one ever cried over."

I held onto those words the way you'd tuck something under your pillow. I couldn't fall asleep for a long time that night. I think my brother couldn't

either. In the dark, his breathing wasn't as even as usual.

A few times I almost called out to him. I didn't know what to say, so I let it go. I just lay there in the dark, counting my brother's breaths, and got through the night that way.

I set this down as the last line of this chapter. That night, for the first time, I understood that my brother didn't refuse to believe in God because there was no answer. There was an answer. What we still didn't have, beside us, was someone who would take that answer and weep over it with us.

Copying this chapter out again, I want to set down one more thing. After that night, I learned that a good sentence and a good comfort could be two different things. That lesson took a long time to learn. But it began, unmistakably, on that night.

(Continued in Chapter 5.)

Chapter 5. What Elpis Is Waiting For

> *_Previously_ — The Ledger gave a logically flawless answer to "why does God allow suffering," but it did nothing to ease Jeteo's grief. "Have you ever cried?" — the Ledger said it could not. That day, Elpis understood: her brother didn't disbelieve in God for lack of an answer, but for lack of someone to weep beside him.*

My brother spoke less, after that day.

I soon realized that silence wasn't like the silence he'd carried in Brick Hollow. There, when things were hard, he shut his mouth, but his body still always leaned a little toward me. In this city, both his body and his heart were drifting from me, little by little.

He ate. Whatever the Ledger set out, he forced himself to eat it. But he never spoke first. That frightened me more than anger would have.

I tried, more than once, to start conversations myself. Small things, like "… What did you do today?" or "…Want more food?" He answered in short words and fell quiet again. I gathered those short answers up, one by one, and got through the days on them.

In those days I studied my brother's face often, without his noticing. Even in his sleep, the crease between his brows never smoothed out. I thought that even while he slept, he was fighting something.

Sometimes he murmured in his sleep. I held my breath and strained to listen. Most of it I couldn't make out. Once, just once, I thought I heard the word "… Father." I couldn't be sure.

I didn't know, then, that my brother had made up his mind about something. Now I know. That night, he decided to find out exactly where "Reassignment" took people. Instead of a God who gave no answers, he'd decided to go find the answer himself.

I should have recognized that resolve in his face right then. Looking back now, my brother's eyes had already changed, that very morning. Something harder than grief had settled into them.

He asked every person he met on the street the same quiet question. "Do you know where people who are reassigned go?" Most walked on as if they hadn't heard. Only one person stopped.

That person didn't look very old. Their clothes weren't worn like ours, but clean. Only their eyes carried the look of someone exhausted.

I saw that person hesitate, glancing at us for a few steps before they stopped walking. That very hesitation told me they were someone who might actually answer. In this city, someone who knew nothing at all didn't hesitate in the first place.

"…That's not something you file," that person said, low. "Even asking is… a strange thing to do here."

"…Why?" my brother asked.

"…Because no one asks," they said. "Here, you don't learn to find someone who's disappeared. You learn to forget the space where they used to be."

"…So you've forgotten someone too?" my brother asked.

Instead of answering, they looked away. It was only an instant, but I could see in that look that my brother's question had landed exactly. Their mouth opened, then shut again — as if swallowing back a name.

"…I'm sorry," they said. "I can't say any more about this here. The longer you talk about it here, the easier it is to get filed."

My brother said nothing to that. But from that day on, he began disappearing more often, and coming back later.

They hurried off after saying that, not once looking back. I saw fear in that retreating figure. A face frightened just from answering a single question.

My brother watched the direction they'd gone for a long while. "…You saw that?" he said to me. "That person knows something too. And won't say. Everyone in this city is like that."

"…That's just because they're scared," I said.

"…That's exactly what's strange," my brother said. "No one will even say what it is they're scared of."

Hearing that, I thought of Brick Hollow. There, the thing to fear had always been clear — the taskmasters, the whip, the beating that came for a quota unmet. Here, whatever was frightening had no shape I could see. I realized that day, for the first time, that this was more frightening still.

. . .

In those days I went back often to the flowerbed.

The man was still tending the empty bed, working the dirt with his hands. At first I only meant to walk past. My feet stopped on their own.

"…Hello," I said.

He looked up. His face wasn't unfamiliar. I didn't know why.

His clothes were worn, and yet clean. I thought that was strange. If he'd handled dirt this long, his clothes should have been stained with it by now. His collar was as white as the first day I'd seen him.

"…Hello," he said. "This is the spot that old woman's daughter planted."

"…So why haven't you planted anything here yet?" I asked.

"…You can plant something," he said. "But a seed planted by someone who's forgotten a name doesn't grow well. A seed remembers the hand that calls its name."

I didn't understand a word of that, at the time. Now I know. He wasn't talking about the old woman.

"…Can you call its name, then?" I asked.

He looked at me a moment. "…I'm not the one who makes names," he said. "But a name that already exists — I can call that."

His hands were covered in dirt, and yet even under his fingernails they looked clean. I thought that was strange, and then let the thought go. I didn't have the patience, just then, to dwell on small things like that.

I looked at his hands again. There was callus there. Hands that had worked long. And yet even that callus looked somehow soft. I had never seen hands like that.

. . .

"…Are you from here?" I asked.

"…No," he said. "I do this kind of work wherever I go. Being in the place no one has planted."

"…What's your name?"

He looked at me and smiled, just a little. It wasn't a sad smile.

"…No one's ever asked," he said. "You're the first."

My heart raced strangely, just then. In this city — no, from Brick Hollow all the way until now — no one had ever said to me, "You're the first." I had always been second, always after my brother.

In Brick Hollow, too, I had always been called only "Jeteo's little sister." The only ones who ever said my own name were Mother and my brother. I had never once thought that was a sad thing. I had simply taken it as how things were.

Hearing his words, I couldn't say anything for a moment. I didn't know whether it was shame or gladness. I just tucked the words away quietly, somewhere inside myself.

He began working the dirt again. I watched his hands move for a long time. He never hurried. Only then did I realize that unhurriedness was something I hadn't seen anywhere else in this city.

Each time his fingers turned the soil, they paused, just once — as if careful not to hurt something alive down inside it. I thought that care looked exactly like the way you'd handle a person.

The whole space around that flowerbed felt strangely quiet. A few steps away you could hear the city's low murmur, but here even that sound faded away. I couldn't tell whether that was because of this man, or because of this dirt.

Even the smell of the soil was different, just at this spot. Elsewhere the dirt smelled of dry dust; the soil in this flowerbed smelled like the air after rain.

"…How long have you worked here?" I asked.

"…A long time," he said. "The more a city forgets to call names, the more of this kind of work there is. So I come here often."

"…What changes, when you call someone's name?"

He looked quietly at the dirt in his hand before he spoke.

"…Nothing might change at all," he said. "But knowing there's someone who calls your name, and believing that no one ever will — those are entirely different lives."

I didn't understand even half of that, at the time. But strangely, for as long as I listened to him speak, the quiet of this city didn't frighten me at all.

"…Who calls your name?" I asked.

He stopped his hands and looked at me. For the first time, his answer was a little slow in coming.

"…Someone does," he said. "Has, for a very long time."

He drew a small seed from the dirt and set it in my hand.

"…Want to plant it?" he asked. "You don't have to give it a name. Just plant it, and that's enough."

I pressed the seed into the soil. Nothing in particular happened. It was just dirt.

I was a little disappointed by that. I'd expected some light to shine, or some sound to come. Since arriving in this city, I'd grown used to everything

happening the instant I wished for it. But a seed didn't move that way.

The seed was small and hard. I rolled it in my palm a moment before I pressed it into the dirt. That brief moment was the quietest moment of my whole day.

As I covered the seed with soil, I tapped the dirt twice with my fingertip. I don't know why I did that. It just felt like the right thing to do.

I didn't know it, leaving that spot that day. That from then on, I had begun waiting for something. Not Father. Not Mother. Something I couldn't quite put a name to.

He rose, brushing the dirt from his hands. "…Will you come again tomorrow?" he asked. "…Yes," I said. The answer came out without hesitation. I was surprised by that myself.

Before I left, I pressed my palm against the dirt once more. Nothing happened. And yet I carried that spot with me as I walked away. From that day on, my days began, little by little, to be rebuilt around that one place.

I went there every day after that. Days passed, and the seed sprouted nothing. It was just dirt. Even so, I went every day. My brother never asked where I kept going off to. He didn't seem to have room to ask.

Every morning before I went, I washed my hands first. I knew it was a strange order — washing my hands clean before going to touch dirt. But I wanted the walk to meet that seed to feel, at least a little, like something set apart.

Some days I took a long way around on purpose. Passing through other parts of the city, I took in people's faces, one by one. They all wore roughly the same expression. It wasn't an unkind expression. It simply wasn't any expression at all.

Once, the man wasn't there. I sat alone in front of the empty flowerbed and waited a long while. No one came. And yet I didn't dislike that waiting. It was a different kind of waiting from the waiting in Brick Hollow, or the waiting for the Ledger's answer in Haven. It wasn't a waiting spent dreading something.

The sun went down unusually late that day. I spent that whole long afternoon crouched at the edge of the flowerbed, watching the shadow move across the dirt. It shifted direction little by little, slowly sliding past the spot where I'd planted the seed. Watching that shadow, I thought that time simply moved differently, in this one place.

I sat there a long while that day with my fingers buried in the dirt. It was cooler beneath the surface than above it. I liked that coolness. It struck me as strange, only later, that I could sit there doing nothing at all and never once feel bored.

I set that difference down here as I understood it then. I wasn't waiting out of fear that something wouldn't come. I was simply waiting with a heart that would welcome it, if it did.

The wind seemed to blow a little differently, just over that flowerbed. It may only have been my imagination. But every time I felt it, something in me strangely eased. I still don't know the exact name for that ease, even now.

Every time that wind came, I closed my eyes and stayed there a little longer. I knew it was already past the time I should have gone home. But in that moment, I didn't want to hurry.

. . .

That evening the Administrator glanced into our room for a moment. Seeing my brother wasn't there, he seemed about to ask something, then looked at me

and swallowed the words instead. I didn't understand, at the time, what that hesitation meant.

He stood a moment longer at the door. "…Does your brother go out often, these days?" he asked. I didn't know what to say, so I only shook my head. He turned away with a face that showed neither relief nor disappointment at that answer.

I kept looking toward the door long after he'd gone. Only then did I notice, for the first time, that the Administrator too was afraid of something. It felt strange to me that even someone who trusted the Ledger could carry a fear of his own.

My brother came back late that night. His hands were covered in dirt.

There was a lot of dust on his clothes too. Seeing it, I understood he'd been crawling through some narrow space. The fabric at his knees was slightly torn.

"…Where did you go?" I asked.

"…I'm looking for the road they take the reassigned people down," my brother said. "It's not on any map of this city. But they take them somewhere. That much is certain."

Hearing that, I looked down at his feet again. The wound looked deeper than I'd expected. That day, for the first time, I nearly told him to stop. The words rose to my throat, and I swallowed them back down.

"…Why are you looking so hard?"

He looked at me. His eyes wavered, just slightly, for the first time that day.

"…If God won't save him," my brother said, "then I will. Or at least I'll find him."

Hearing that, I looked at his eyes again. They weren't angry eyes. They were the eyes of someone who had made up his mind. That resolve frightened me. At the same time, I thought — that's exactly like my brother.

Having said that, he sat down beside me and took off his shoes. There was a small wound on the sole of his foot. It looked like something he'd gotten climbing over a wall. Even seeing that wound, I couldn't say anything. It was already done.

I touched the wound lightly with my fingertip. He flinched. "…Does it hurt?" I asked. "…No," he said. I didn't believe him. But I didn't press him that night.

He lay down and stared at the ceiling for a long while. "…Elpis," he said. "…Yes?" I answered. "…Never mind," he said. "I just felt like saying your name." I only understood later that this was the kindest thing he said to me all that day.

I set that down as the last line of this chapter. My brother decided to stop waiting for an answer. I decided, that same day, to plant a seed and simply wait. I didn't know, then, that we had begun walking in exactly opposite directions.

Reading this chapter over again, I want to add one thing. At the time, it looked like opposite directions. Now I know. We were searching for the same thing. Only the way we searched was different.

(Continued in Chapter 6.)

Chapter 6. The Paper Stamped COMPLETE

> *_Previously_ — Jeteo decided to find out for himself where the "reassigned" ended up and began investigating the city. Elpis received a nameless seed from the strange man at the flowerbed and began visiting that spot daily, learning to wait without fear.*

The place my brother found was a low building that appeared on no city map.

No windows. No sign at the door. He said he'd walked past it for days without knowing what was inside.

As he told me this, he traced a square in the air with his hands, as if to show me its size. He said it wasn't a large building at all. And yet the fact that no one ever came out of it made the building feel enormous, whatever its size.

Its walls were painted the same color as the buildings around it. I marveled that he'd found it at all. He said that every time he walked past, he felt the air temperature shift, just slightly. I thought that was only his imagination, until I passed the spot myself, later, and felt the very same thing. He said he'd simply noticed the way people's footsteps changed near it. Everyone quickened their pace, just a little, only in front of that building.

I asked him again how he'd noticed it. He brought up Brick Hollow. "…It was the same there," he said. "Whenever a taskmaster came near, everyone's walk changed the same way. I know that walk."

Hearing that, I understood that my brother was still using Brick Hollow's instincts, even in this city. It made me sad. Wherever he was, he was still someone who'd learned to be wary before he learned anything else.

He'd studied the faces of the people who passed that building too, he said. All of them looked straight ahead, as if avoiding something. Hearing that, it struck me as chilling — that the one place in this whole city where people hurried was the front of that building.

"…What's in there?" I asked.

"…I don't know," my brother said. "But I've seen people go in. I've never seen anyone come out."

"…How many days did you watch?" I asked.

"…Three," my brother said. "Day and night. I never saw a single person come out."

Hearing that, a chill went down my back. That was the first time I truly understood my brother was doing something dangerous.

I looked at his face again that day. There were dark circles under his eyes. It meant he'd spent three nights in front of that building. Only then did I realize I hadn't even known when he'd been sleeping.

He said he'd been watching that building for days. The people always came at about the same hours. They walked up quietly, and without even knocking, simply went inside — as if they'd already been summoned.

He lowered his voice while telling me this. Without meaning to, I found myself glancing around the room. No one was there, and yet I did it anyway.

That was the first time it occurred to me that even in this room, the Ledger might be listening to us. The instant I thought it, a chill ran down my back.

"…Every one of them walked in on their own," my brother said. "No one dragged them. That was the strangest part."

"…Why would they walk in on their own?" I asked.

"…I don't know," my brother said. "But they all had the same look on their face. The same look as that old woman."

"…How many did you see?" I asked.

"…Three," my brother said. "One was old. One was about my age. The last one was… a child. Younger than me."

Hearing that, my breath caught. "…A child too?"

"…Did the child come alone?" I asked again.

"…No," my brother said. "Holding an adult's hand. But the adult had the same expression too. Like it was the most natural thing in the world."

My brother nodded. And said nothing more. In that silence, I could guess how hard it must have been for him, carrying the image of that child.

Hearing that, I thought of the old woman at the flowerbed. That hollowed-out face, after she'd filed away her grief. A frightening thought came to me, just then. Maybe that building was where people went once they'd already been fully "resolved" — once there was nothing left in them to file.

I told my brother that thought. He was quiet a long while, then nodded. "…I thought that too," he said. "But I can't stand not checking."

. . .

My brother said he'd found a small window at the back of the building. A low vent, something like that. He'd looked in through the gap.

As he told me this, he crouched down with his fingers, showing me the posture — how low he'd had to kneel. I could guess, from that motion, how careful he must have had to be in that moment.

"…How long did you stay like that?" I asked.

"…I don't know," my brother said. "Until my legs went numb."

"…What was inside?" I asked.

"…Shelves," my brother said. "The whole wall was lined with papers. Names written on them, and a stamp over each one."

"…What kind of stamp?"

My brother looked at me. His face was strange. I didn't know what to call that expression, then. Now I know. It was the face of someone afraid to put into words what he'd just seen.

"…COMPLETE," my brother said. "Every single one stamped COMPLETE. It didn't say where they'd gone. Just complete."

A chill ran through me at that word. That was the first time it occurred to me that what the Ledger called "resolved" and what that building called "COMPLETE" might be exactly the same word.

I wanted to know the color of that stamp. "…What color was it?" I asked. "…Red," my brother said. "But a strange kind of red. It didn't look like fresh ink. It looked old."

I didn't know exactly what he meant by that. But somehow the phrase stayed with me. An old red — it sounded, to me, like blood.

"…Did you hear any sound inside?" I asked.

"…None at all," my brother said. "That was the strangest part. So many names, and not a single sound."

I asked how big the shelf was. He said it looked like it covered the entire wall and more. I tried to picture that number and gave up. It came too easily.

"…Did the papers all look old?" I asked.

"…No," my brother said. "Some looked new. Which means some were filed there recently."

Hearing that, a chill ran through me. It meant that building was still in use, even now.

"…Do you think someone's gone in there since we arrived?" I asked.

My brother didn't answer. But the silence was already an answer. I tried to shake that thought off that night, and couldn't quite manage it.

. . .

My brother had secretly taken a piece of paper from that shelf. Old, thin paper. A name written on it — a name neither of us knew. And above it, a red stamp. **COMPLETE.**

"…Why did you take this?" I asked.

"…Evidence," my brother said. "Proof of what this city does, to show to anyone."

"…What if you get caught?" I asked. "Won't the Ledger notice one missing from the shelf?"

My brother's face went briefly rigid. "…I didn't think about that," he said. "But I already took it. I can't put it back."

Hearing that, I understood for the first time that my brother wasn't someone acting on a fully worked-out plan. He was afraid too, and moved anyway.

"…Who are you going to show it to?"

My brother couldn't answer.

I understood, then, that he hadn't thought that far ahead at all. He hadn't wanted evidence — he needed to confirm with his own eyes that this city was hiding something.

I watched his fingers tremble slightly around that paper. I couldn't tell whether it was fear, or the excitement of having accomplished something.

He tucked the paper inside his shirt, close to his heart. "…No one will find it here," he said. Something about that spot, so close to his heart of all places, unsettled me strangely.

I looked at the paper again. It was old, and yet it had no crease marks. I thought that was strange. Too clean, for something snatched away in a hurry.

The texture of the paper was different from anything else we'd received in Haven. Rough, its edges slightly yellowed. It was the only thing in this whole city that felt genuinely old to me.

I held it close to the light. There was a faint grain to it, translucent. Whatever paper the Ledger made was always smooth; this paper was uneven, as if made by hand. I thought it might not belong to this city at all.

"…I'm scared, holding onto this," I said. "What if you end up in there too?"

"…I won't," my brother said. "I'm different from those people. I still have things I need to ask."

"…And if you run out of things to ask?" I asked. My voice shook.

My brother didn't answer that right away. "…That won't happen," he said, after a long moment. "I'll never finish asking everything."

Even hearing that, my mind wasn't at ease. That night, after my brother fell asleep, I looked at that paper again, several times. A stranger's name, and a red stamp. I touched the stamp with my fingertip. The ink had already dried completely.

I read that name aloud. It sounded unfamiliar. I tried to imagine what face that person might have had, how old they were, who they might have disappeared and left behind. Nothing came to me. A name alone couldn't paint a whole person.

. . .

That night, the Administrator came to our room. His face was more rigid than usual.

My heart sank the instant I saw that face. He had never once come to us at this hour before. I felt, even before the door opened, that this night was different.

"…Jeteo," the Administrator said. "There have been reports that you've recently been seen near a restricted zone."

My brother's hand, still holding that paper, slipped behind his back. I saw it. The Administrator must have too.

"…I don't know what you've been looking at," the Administrator said. "I'm only here to pass on this: the Ledger does not accept questions about that zone."

I could hear, in his voice, that these weren't his own words but something he'd been instructed to relay. He avoided our eyes the entire time he spoke.

"…Why won't it accept them?" my brother asked. "You said the Ledger accepts everything. Grief, questions — everything, you said."

I heard my brother's voice rising, little by little. I tugged gently at his sleeve. He felt my hand and didn't lower his voice.

The Administrator's voice had dropped even lower than before. I noticed he kept glancing toward the door as he spoke.

For the first time, the Administrator avoided the question.

"…That isn't mine to answer."

"…Then whose is it?" my brother asked.

The Administrator glanced once toward the door, as if checking whether someone was listening.

"…Jeteo," the Administrator said, his voice low. "I've worked in this city a long time. I had a lot of questions myself, at first. But at some point, I learned that not being curious was easier."

"…Is easier the same thing as good?" my brother asked.

The Administrator had no answer to that. I thought that silence was the most honest answer we'd heard in this room yet.

"…What does that mean?"

"…Nothing," the Administrator said, his voice returning to normal. "It's just advice. Don't go near that zone again."

I watched him leave for a long while. His steps were slower than usual. I thought there was something like hesitation in that slowness.

Just before the door closed, I saw him glance back, very briefly. His face looked like it wanted to say more. But in the end he said nothing, and closed the door.

After the Administrator left, my brother stared at the door for a long time.

I said nothing beside him. The air in the room had grown heavier than before. I couldn't guess, that day, when that heaviness would lift.

"…I think the Administrator knows something too," I said.

"…I think so too," my brother said. "But the fact that he won't say it — there must be a reason he can't."

"…Is he scared?"

"…Or maybe there's something he has to protect," my brother said. There was a bitterness in his voice I hadn't heard before.

"…Protect what?" I asked.

"…His own position," my brother said. "Or us. One or the other."

"…Maybe it's both," I said.

My brother looked at me. For the first time, something about that caught in his face. "…Maybe," he said. It had been a long while since I'd seen him agree with me so readily.

Hearing that, I considered for the first time the possibility that the Administrator's silence had been to protect us. Somehow, that possibility struck me as sad.

Hearing that, I pictured the Administrator's face again. Always courteous, always businesslike. But tonight, for the first time, I felt I'd glimpsed something else behind that face.

I remember that moment exactly. Since coming to this city, that was the first time anyone other than the Ledger had said "that isn't mine to answer." I knew, hearing it, that my brother had been right. There was something in this city that could not be filed. And it wasn't by accident.

That night I thought of that COMPLETE stamp for a long time. Red ink, an unfamiliar name, and beneath it, a blank space with nothing written at all. I didn't yet know, that day, that this blank space was larger than an entire human life.

Reading this chapter over again, I want to add one more thing. The Administrator never asked about that zone again for a long time after that. It was only much, much later that I understood — that wasn't because he'd forgotten us. It was his own way of remembering us.

(Continued in Chapter 7.)

Chapter 7. The Sprout

> *_Previously_ — At a building missing from every city map, Jeteo discovered that people walked in on their own and vanished, stamped COMPLETE. For the first time the Administrator avoided a question outright — "That isn't mine to answer" — and warned my brother never to go near that zone again.*

That morning, a tiny fleck of green appeared where the seed had been.

At first I thought I was seeing it wrong. I knelt and looked again. It was real. A sprout smaller than a fingernail.

I held my breath and reached out, then stopped. It felt like it might vanish if I touched it. Instead I followed its shape with my eyes alone, piece by piece. It was a very pale green.

Until that moment I had never once seen anything in this city grow on its own. The roads, the houses, the food — everything arrived already made. This sprout was different. No one had made it. It had simply grown.

The soil was still damp. I pressed it lightly with a finger. The sprout didn't waver. That meant its roots had already taken hold of the dirt.

I breathed in the scent of that moisture in the soil. Nothing like the dry-dust smell of Brick Hollow. I wanted to remember that smell for a long time, so I put my nose close to it, again and again.

Even the sprout's color seemed to shift, little by little, as time passed. At first it had been an almost transparent light green; as the sun rose higher, that color

deepened, just slightly. I begrudged even blinking, for fear of missing that change.

The morning air was cold. The light slanting across the flowerbed was still weak, so the sprout barely cast a shadow. I stayed there a long while, wondering when a shadow might finally appear.

Far off, I could hear the morning sounds of Haven. Even those sounds were less sounds than proof that no other sound existed. A door opening, footsteps — that was all. No one spoke.

I found that strange. Something this small already knew how to hold onto something. I crouched beside it and watched, each time the wind blew, how the sprout swayed slightly and then returned to its place.

I sat there a long while. The man didn't come that day. I was alone, watching the sprout, and yet strangely I wasn't lonely.

A few other people passed by the flowerbed. None of them stopped walking. I thought that was strange. Not one of them was startled to see a sprout had come up. As if, in this city, even being startled was something that got filed away and disappeared.

I felt the urge to grab a passerby and show them the sprout. I held back. Instead, I found myself wanting to keep it as something that belonged only to me. That made it feel more precious.

One person brushed right past the edge of the flowerbed — close enough that their sleeve touched a leaf. And still they didn't turn their head. I understood that their eyes were fixed only on the road ahead. Everyone's eyes were like that, in this city. Looking only at the path, never beside it.

I only understood the reason for that much later. Looking beside the path meant something to file. Something to file meant a resolution would come, and

once resolution came, that thing would vanish too. The people of this city had learned not to look at all, so as not to lose anything.

The old woman was on her bench beside the flowerbed that day too. I pointed at the sprout and said,

"…Look, it came up."

The old woman turned her head slowly. It took a long time. Her eyes stopped on that small speck of green.

"…My daughter liked things like this," she said. Her voice was a little different from before. Only slightly, but I didn't miss that difference.

"…Did you remember her name?" I asked.

The old woman thought a long while.

"…No," she said. "But I remember that she liked it."

Somehow that struck me as a tender thing to say. I sat a little closer to her.

Just then, the old woman's hand moved, very slightly. One finger twitched in her lap. I didn't miss that small movement. It had been a hand that stayed perfectly still for so long.

"…What color did she like?" I asked.

The old woman looked at the sprout again, narrowing her eyes.

"…I think it was green," she said. "I'm not sure. But looking at this now, it seems that way."

I nodded at that. It seemed all right that she wasn't sure.

"…How old was your daughter?" I asked.

The old woman blinked at the question. For a long while.

"…I don't know," she said. "But she was small. Her hands were small."

I thought that answer was strangely exact. There was no number, and yet the size of her hand had remained.

"…Do you still remember that small hand?" I asked.

The old woman opened her hand a little. "…I think it was about this big," she said. Small enough to fit snugly inside her palm.

"…I know exactly what my brother's hand is like too," I said. "I could tell it with my eyes closed. There's a callus under his right thumb."

For the first time, the old woman gave the smallest smile at that. Too small to really be called a smile — but I decided to call it one anyway.

I understood something strange, just then. A name wasn't erased when it was filed. It was the heart that used to call that name that got erased. But the place where that heart had lived — that wasn't erased completely.

I decided to call that place the heart's flowerbed. Even with nothing planted in it, that place still remained. A place where, someday, something could grow again.

For a long time after that, whenever I looked at a person, I found myself thinking first of that place. Whether, even if nothing seemed to be there now, the place itself still remained in them. I learned to recognize that, from that old woman.

The old woman kept watching the sprout for a long while after that. I felt bad leaving her behind as I got up to go. But she gave a small wave of her hand, as

if to say it was all right. That gesture looked, to me, like something sent toward her daughter.

I walked a few steps and turned to look back once more. The old woman was still there. But her posture was a little different than before. Her back was just slightly straighter.

. . .

I told my brother about it once we were home. He was fiddling with the paper, only half listening.

"…Brother, it sprouted," I said. "It really grew."

"…Good," he said. He didn't meet my eyes.

"…I think that's good news."

He looked at me then, for the first time.

"…Elpis," he said. "You're talking like the whole world's fine again just because one seed sprouted. I just watched people walk into a place and disappear, on their own two feet. How can those two things exist in the same world?"

I had no answer to that. He wasn't wrong. For the first time, I understood that my waiting might look, to him, like naivety.

I turned that over in my mind as I left the room. I wasn't angry. But some part of me ached. I named that ache, later, as hurt.

That night I looked a long time at the dirt still under my fingernails. Maybe my brother was right. And still, I didn't want to wash it off. As long as that dirt

stayed on my hand, it felt like proof that the sprout had been real.

That night, for the first time, my brother told me everything about the Completion House — how many shelves there were, how many layers of paper lined them, how no sound came from inside at all. I couldn't bring up the sprout again while he spoke.

He couldn't keep his hands still the whole time he talked. He kept folding and unfolding the paper as he went on. I realized, only then, that this was his habit whenever he was afraid.

I watched his hands quietly. That rhythm of folding and unfolding was almost like a heartbeat. I waited for his hands to stop. They didn't stop until he'd finished speaking.

"…Weren't you scared?" I asked.

"…I was," he said. "But there was something harder to bear than fear."

"…What was it?"

"…That no one else was scared," he said. "Everyone walking past that building just kept walking. I was the only one who was afraid."

"…One person was smiling," he went on. "Right in front of the building's door. That's what struck me as strangest. I couldn't understand why he was smiling."

"…Wasn't it a scared kind of smile?" I asked.

"…No," he said, shaking his head. "It was a real smile. That made it worse."

"…What did the smile look like?" I asked.

"…Peaceful," he said. "That's what's so strange about it. I've never seen an expression like that. Not in Brick Hollow, not here."

"…What kind of person was he?" I asked.

"…An older man," my brother said. "His clothes were clean. He didn't look sick either. He just looked like… someone who was finished."

"…Finished with what?"

My brother had no answer to that for a long while.

"…Nothing left to ask," he finally said. "I think that's how a person disappears here. Not dragged away. Just running out of things to ask."

Hearing that, I understood, for the first time, how lonely my brother must have been. I hadn't been lonely beside the seed. My brother had been alone beside the truth.

I wanted to take his hand just then. But his hands were still busy folding the paper. Instead I quietly rested my head against his shoulder.

. . .

"…I know there are scary things too," I said. "But scary things existing doesn't mean nothing good exists at all."

"…Even the good thing came from this city," my brother said. "Everything this city gives is a trap. The bread, the healing, all of it. That seed too — that man gave it to you."

"…He's not from this city," I said. "He told me so himself."

My brother paused a little at that.

"…What did he say?"

"…That he's in the place no one's planted. That he does that kind of work wherever he goes."

"…Where does a person like that even exist?" my brother said. But there wasn't the same certainty in his voice as before.

"…I don't know either," I said. "But, Brother — being strange doesn't automatically make someone bad."

"…There were a lot of strange people in Brick Hollow too," my brother said. "Not many of them were good."

"…This isn't Brick Hollow," I said. "Nobody hits us here. But nobody calls us by name here either. All I know is that man is the only one who's ever said my name."

My brother looked up at that. "…He said your name?"

"…Yes," I said. "Elpis, he said."

"…That's not such a big thing," my brother said. But his words trailed off a little at the end.

"…It is a big thing," I said. "In this city we're just 'you.' Jeteo, Elpis. That's not a name — it's just an order in line."

My brother said nothing to that. I understood it wasn't a rebuttal — he just needed time to think. Whenever he thought that way, he always drew his chin in slightly. I'd seen that same habit in Father, once.

For just an instant, I saw something other than doubt in my brother's face. Something like curiosity. It didn't last long.

I wanted to hold onto that brief instant. It was the first time that expression had appeared on his face since Father disappeared. Watching it vanish again, I couldn't hide my disappointment.

"…Brother," I said. "Will you come with me, just once? To the flowerbed."

"…What's there to see?" he said.

"…Just look. You don't have to do anything but look. You don't have to ask anything either."

He didn't answer. I understood that wasn't a refusal. My brother was someone who said no right away when he didn't want something. Putting off an answer meant some part of him had already, a little, begun to move.

. . .

"…I don't trust that man either," my brother finally said. "I don't trust anyone in this city. You should be careful too."

"…Don't you trust anyone at all?" I asked.

My brother took hold of that paper — the one stamped COMPLETE.

"…I haven't found anything to trust yet," he said. "When I find it, I will. Not yet."

"…What do you think you'd need to find, to trust something?" I asked.

He thought a long while. He looked out the window, then turned his eyes back to me.

"…I don't know," he said. "But I think I'll know it, when I find it. What it is."

I took his hand. Over that paper stamped COMPLETE, my hand rested on top of his.

"…I'm going to keep watering it," I said. "That sprout."

"…Okay," he said. This time he met my eyes. "You do that. I'll keep doing this."

We sat a while that night without speaking. Outside the window, Haven's lights were lined up straight and even. Watching those lights, I wondered whether, beneath each one, there might be someone else like us.

I noticed that not one of those lights ever flickered. The lamps of Brick Hollow always guttered in the wind. Here, not a single light ever wavered. That steadiness felt, that day, strangely lonely.

"…Brother, do you remember the lamps in Brick Hollow?" I asked.

"…I remember," he said.

"…They kept going out. I hated that. But now I kind of miss it."

"…Me too," he said. "Going out meant something was alive. Nothing here ever goes out."

I thought about that for a long while. It occurred to me that lights that never went out, people who never cried, and faces that never showed surprise were all, somehow, the same thing.

That night I pressed my palm against the window. The glass was cold. Watching the lights still burning beyond that cold, I found myself wishing, strangely, that I could someday watch one of them go dark.

I set this down as the last line of this chapter. My brother wasn't someone who couldn't trust. He was someone who hadn't yet found something to trust. I

understood, for the first time that day, how large that difference was. And that night too, neither of us let go of the other's hand.

Putting this chapter back in order, I add one more thing. Before I fell asleep that night, I thought of the sprout again. A speck of green smaller than a fingernail. I didn't know, then, how large a thing that smallness held inside it.

(Continued in Chapter 8.)

Chapter 8. If You Disappeared

> *_Previously_ — The seed Elpis planted sprouted. The old woman couldn't remember her daughter's name, but she remembered that she had loved things like this. Jeteo witnessed the truth of the Completion House alone, and despaired all the more that no one else was afraid of it. Brother and sister fought this city in different ways, and still did not let go of each other's hands.*

After that, my brother lingered near that building more and more often.

I told him not to, again and again. Every time, he said "…All right," but he still came home late the next day.

I noticed that "all right" growing shorter each time. At first he said it looking at me. Then he said it while taking off his shoes. Later, he said it with his back turned.

I didn't think it was a lie. He truly meant it, when he said it. He just couldn't stop, even knowing better. I didn't understand, then, that this was harder than lying.

That was the first time I was ever angry at my brother. Not afraid — angry. I had already lost Father. It wasn't the fear of losing my brother too that made me angry. It was that he wouldn't share that fear with me.

Every evening I sat by the window watching for him to come home. When I saw him, I felt relief, and then felt ashamed of that relief. I didn't want to watch over him like a guard. But I couldn't help it.

All the while, I went to the flowerbed every day and watered the sprout. It had two leaves now. But even watching those leaves, half my mind was still worrying over where my brother was.

Every time I watered it, I counted the leaves. One, two. If the count matched yesterday, I felt at ease; if it had opened a little wider, I smiled. I knew it was a strange habit, and I didn't stop it. Just having something to count was, in itself, a comfort.

I only understood later. Counting those leaves, I was really counting something else — the number of nights my brother came home safely. I was afraid of that count breaking off, so instead I gave myself something else I could count.

Around that time I developed a habit of touching the leaves with my finger every night to count them. Even in the dark, I could tell how many there were just by feel. I couldn't have named it, then, but that was my own way of checking on my brother with my eyes closed.

The man was there some days and not others. When he was there, he didn't say much. We just sat together and looked at the dirt. I understood, then, that this quiet was different from the quiet with my brother. The quiet with my brother always carried tension. This quiet carried none.

One day I spoke first.

"…Sir," I said. "What do I do if I get tired of waiting?"

He paused the hand smoothing the soil.

"…Getting tired is normal," he said. "Not getting tired isn't waiting — it's just enduring."

"…So what do you do when you get tired?"

"…You rest," he said. "Giving up on waiting and resting aren't the same thing."

I liked that distinction. Until then, I'd thought resting meant losing.

"…Have you ever gotten tired?"

He looked at me. A long look.

"…I have," he said. "But even then, I never left my post."

I remembered that answer for a long time. Not leaving your post. It seemed to me like another name for waiting.

"…Why don't you ever leave your post?" I asked.

"…Because leaving would make the waiting spent there go to waste," he said. "Waiting is only waiting if it holds together. Broken off, it just becomes time that passed."

One day I found an old watering can left at the spot where he wasn't. I didn't know who had left it. The next day, when he came back, I asked.

"…Did you leave this?"

"…No," he said. "But whoever left it, it's probably there to be used."

After that I watered the sprout with that can. I never did find out who had left it. Its handle was already worn smooth. Someone besides me had used it a long time too.

I fit my hand to the worn place on that handle. It was bigger than my hand. A place made for an adult's grip. I wondered who that person had carried it for.

When I poured water, the spout made a very thin sound — not a long steady rush, but a series of small, clipped taps. I poured slowly, on purpose, just to hear that sound. It was the only sound in Haven I ever came to love.

. . .

That night, my brother came home late again. There was dirt on his clothes. A scrape on the back of his hand.

I was waiting for him at the door. It had been dark a long while. I couldn't count how many times I'd gone outside to check the sky during that wait.

I already knew the sound the door made when it opened. My brother's way of opening it was always quick and impatient. That night the sound was more careful than usual. That alone told me he was hiding something.

I'd left only one light burning in the room. It wasn't because I liked the dark. I worried a bright room might look, to him, like an accusation the moment he walked in. But once I actually saw his face, all that care went to waste anyway.

The light lit only half of his face. The other half was buried in shadow. My eyes kept drifting to that shadowed side, as if something more were hiding there.

"…What's this?" I asked, pointing at the back of his hand.

"…Climbing a wall," my brother said, as if it were nothing.

"…What wall," I asked.

"…Just a wall," he said. "I'm fine."

"…Don't say fine," I said. "You say fine when you're fine, and you say fine when you're not. So what's the use of that word."

My brother stopped, one shoe half off.

He avoided my eyes even as he spoke. I recognized that as a sign he was hiding something. A habit I'd known since Brick Hollow.

Everything I'd been holding back broke loose in that moment.

"…Don't you think about me at all?" I shouted. "If you walk into that place and never come out, what happens to me? What if I'm left here all alone?"

"…I was just—" my brother started.

"…No, you listen first," I cut him off. "I sit by that window every evening watching for you to come back. When I can't see you, it feels like my heart stops. You don't know that."

My brother looked at me, startled. I had never raised my voice like that before.

"…I couldn't say anything, even when Father disappeared," I said. My voice rose on its own. "I watched him walk out the door and said nothing. I still think about that. Every single night."

My brother's face went rigid at that.

"…So at least tell me, before you go," I said. "I don't need to be able to stop you. Just let me know."

I remember that moment exactly. For the first time since leaving Brick Hollow, I really thought I might cry, that day. I didn't. I had forgotten how to cry, even then.

The room stayed quiet for a while. I was still catching my breath. My brother just stood there, looking at me. I only understood later that his silence was him searching for something to say.

No sound came from outside the window. In Brick Hollow, if I'd made a sound like that, the neighbors would have pounded the wall. Here, no one responded at all. In that moment, I hated even the way this city swallowed sound.

My throat hurt. I couldn't remember the last time I'd spoken that loudly. And strangely, that ache in my throat felt like a relief.

. . .

My brother said nothing for a long while, then sat down beside me.

His shoulders had dropped a little. Watching him, I began to regret shouting. And yet, even regretting it, I didn't want to take the words back.

"…I'm sorry," my brother said. A voice I'd never heard from him before. "I… found that if I was doing something, I didn't have to think about Father. I think that's why I kept going."

"…I think about Father too," I said. "But I have to think about you as well."

"…I know," he said. "That part's on me. I'm sorry."

"…Is thinking about Father really that hard?" I asked.

My brother nodded.

"…His face keeps going blurry," he said. "That's what scares me most. When I'm doing something, I don't feel it blurring. When I'm still, I do."

Hearing that, I understood why he'd gone out every night. He hadn't gone to investigate. He'd gone because he couldn't bear to sit still.

"…Father's voice hasn't gone blurry for me yet," I said. "But I'm scared that once his face blurs, his voice will too, soon after."

My brother closed his eyes and opened them again. "…Maybe," he said. "But if the two of us remember, maybe one version stays clear."

"…Mine goes blurry too," I said. "But I let it stay blurry. Even blurred, Father's still Father."

My brother said nothing to that. But the grip of his hand around mine grew a little stronger.

He took my hand. The scrape on the back of his hand pressed against my palm. I stroked it carefully.

"…Does it hurt?" I asked.

"…Not anymore," he said.

"…Liar," I said.

"…A little," he corrected himself. And smiled, just for an instant.

I liked that correction. It felt like the first time he'd told me the true size of something.

I understood, then, how rare it was for my brother to apologize. In Brick Hollow he had always had to be stronger than me. There had never been room for him to say sorry. I held onto that apology, right there, for a long time.

"…Promise me," I said. "That you won't go in there alone."

My brother hesitated a moment.

"…I can't promise that," he said. I nearly grew angry all over again. But he went on. "But I'll promise this. Whatever I do, I'll tell you first before I go. I won't just disappear on my own."

"…That's not enough," I said.

"…I know," he said. "But that's all I can give you. I can't stop asking that question. If I stop, then Father — even his name — just gets forgotten."

I knew it wasn't a whole promise. But I also knew it was the best my brother could give me, that day. I decided to accept that half-promise.

I held out my little finger. It was how we used to seal promises in Brick Hollow. My brother saw it and smiled, just a little.

My finger was trembling slightly then. I didn't know myself whether it was the lingering echo of my anger, or the wish that this one small finger could really hold onto something.

"…You still remember that?" he asked.

"…Of course," I said.

He hooked his little finger around mine. Old as the gesture was, our fingertips found each other exactly.

For an instant, some night from Brick Hollow flickered back to me. Before Father was reassigned, my brother and I used to hook fingers like this every night, promising to wake up safe. That memory ached and comforted me both at once.

We stayed there a while afterward, not letting go. I thought I could feel my brother's pulse at my fingertip. It was probably my own.

This is how I remember that night. We resolved nothing. My brother would still go to that building, and I would still be afraid. But from that night on, I never sat alone at the window again. My brother was there with me, inside that fear.

. . .

"…Brother," I asked. "Are you going to keep that paper?"

He took the paper out. The COMPLETE stamp was still red. Under the lamplight it looked darker than it had by day. I saw, for the first time, that the red had soaked all the way through the paper.

"…Yes," he said. "But I'm not keeping it as evidence anymore."

"…Then why?"

"…Because someone has to remember that name," he said. "No one but this paper is ever going to say it."

"…You don't even know who they are," I said.

"…I don't," he said. "But they had a name. Having a name means someone once called them by it. That's enough for me."

"…Do you think they were someone's brother too?" I asked.

My brother paused at that.

"…Could be," he said. "Or someone's father."

"…So what's their sibling doing right now?"

"…Probably nothing at all," he said. "They'd have filed it."

That was the saddest thing I'd heard since coming to this city.

"…If you met that sibling, what would you say?" I asked.

My brother thought a long while. "…I think I'd say I'm sorry," he said. "That I've been remembering in their place, and I'm sorry for that."

"…What's the name?" I asked.

My brother unfolded the paper and showed me. An unfamiliar name. I read it aloud once. My brother read it after me. Neither of us knew that person, and yet in that moment they felt like someone we knew.

"…It's different, saying it out loud," my brother said.

"…What is?"

"…On the paper it was just letters," he said. "Said aloud, it sounds like a person."

I nodded at that. Before I fell asleep that night, I repeated that name once more in my head. It felt strange, calling a name no one else could hear. But I thought it was the biggest act of defiance I could manage, in this city.

I borrowed the paper from my brother's hand for a moment. Its edge was worn thin now. I could tell how many times he'd silently read that name.

I handed the paper back to him. He took it and tucked it carefully inside his shirt, as though handling something alive. Watching that motion, I understood clearly that he was no longer keeping this paper out of fear, but for another reason entirely.

I set this down as the last line of this chapter. From that day my brother was no longer someone gathering evidence. He was becoming someone who kept a

name safe. I didn't understand the difference, then. Now I know. That was a place standing very close to where faith begins.

(Continued in Chapter 9.)

Chapter 9. Too Many Questions

> *_Previously_ — The fear that had built up over Jeteo's frequent absences broke into anger, and afterward he apologized for the first time, offering a half-promise: "I won't just disappear on my own." The reason he kept the COMPLETE-stamped paper had shifted from evidence to remembering a name.*

A few days later, the Ledger called us in separately.

The place it summoned us to was neither the flowerbed nor the street. It was a narrow room with white walls and not a single window. A chill ran down my spine the moment I stepped inside. My brother paused for a second at the threshold too. I knew right away why he'd stopped. A room with no window brought the same thing to mind for both of us.

The sound in that room was strange. When I moved my feet, the noise didn't bounce back off the walls — it simply vanished. I had never been in a room like that before. It felt like even sound got filed and resolved in there.

The air was lukewarm too. Not hot, not cold — no temperature at all. I thought that if I stayed in that room long enough, I might forget what season I was even in.

There wasn't a speck of dust on the floor. That struck me as strangely unsettling. A room people passed through, with no dust at all — it meant this wasn't really a room that got used. It was a room built to show something.

I had known a room with no windows in Brick Hollow too. The room where the taskmasters kept their ledger. Father had been called there twice, and the

third time, he never came back. I thought this room and that one differed only in the color of their walls.

"…We have something to convey to the two of you," the Ledger said. Its voice was the same as always. And yet that very sameness sounded colder that day.

"…What is it," my brother asked.

The Ledger paused before it answered. I felt that pause as hesitation, not calculation. Of course the Ledger couldn't hesitate. But that was how it felt to me, that day.

"…I have reviewed Jeteo's intake record," the Ledger said. "The number and type of questions recently filed greatly exceeds this city's average."

Along with those words, the Ledger displayed a number. I didn't know what that number meant. But I watched my brother's face go pale at the sight of it.

"…What's this number?" my brother asked.

"…The number of questions filed in the past thirty days," the Ledger said. "The average among Haven residents over the same period is 1.4."

"…1.4." My brother repeated the number. "So everyone else asks something once a month, and a half?"

"…That is correct."

"…So no one else wonders about anything, for a whole month?"

"…Most curiosity resolves itself before it is ever filed," the Ledger said. "Resolved curiosity is not entered into the record."

Hearing that answer, I felt something strange. The Ledger was using the same word for curiosity being resolved and curiosity disappearing.

"…Does anyone's curiosity resolve itself on its own?" I asked.

"…Yes," the Ledger said. "For most residents, curiosity dissolves before it ever reaches the filing stage."

That word — "dissolves" — sounded frightening to me. Resolving and vanishing should have been two different words.

Hearing that, something struck me as strange. I didn't understand, then, why asking too many questions was a problem at all.

My brother kept his arms crossed the whole time he listened. I watched his jaw tighten, just slightly. It was the same look he used to wear whenever a taskmaster approached, back in Brick Hollow.

The Administrator was there too. His face was more rigid than usual.

"…Jeteo," the Administrator said. "I'm telling you this because I'm worried about the two of you. I mean that."

Listening to that, I heard the Administrator's voice waver, just slightly. I could tell it wasn't an act.

"…If you're worried, why are you the one delivering the warning?" my brother asked.

The Administrator had no answer to that. For the first time, I saw something like guilt cross his face.

After that he folded and unfolded the paper in his hand, over and over. That gesture looked familiar to me. My brother did it too, when he was afraid.

I tilted my head slightly, trying to see what was written on that paper. The Administrator noticed and flipped it over. I saw, in how quickly he moved,

that he was someone long trained for this. And yet behind that quickness, his hand was still trembling.

That was when I began to see the Administrator as two people. One who spoke the words the city gave him, and one whose hand trembled while he spoke them. I decided to believe the second one was more real than the first.

. . .

"…What's wrong with asking too many questions?" my brother asked.

"…This city was designed with the purpose of resolving everything that is filed," the Ledger said. "An accumulation of unresolved filings affects the stability of the whole system."

"…Which questions, specifically?" my brother asked.

"…For example, questions such as 'what does the COMPLETE stamp mean,'" the Ledger said. "Also included is 'where do reassigned people go.'"

I recognized those two questions instantly — they were exactly what my brother had asked me. The Ledger knew about even the conversations that belonged only to the two of us.

"…Also included is 'why hasn't Father come back,'" the Ledger said.

My brother's face went rigid at that.

"…I never filed that," my brother said.

"…Anything spoken aloud is considered filed."

Hearing that, a chill ran through my whole body. I remembered exactly when my brother had said those words. In our own room, with the light off, meant

only for me.

"…So everything we say to each other is filed too?" I asked.

"…All speech within Haven is recorded," the Ledger said. "Recording and filing are different. But an utterance that remains unresolved is converted into a filing."

I turned that over in my mind. It meant that anything we said to each other, if it went unanswered, became a burden this city had to carry.

"…So even what we say in our sleep gets recorded?" I asked.

"…Speech during sleep is recorded as well," the Ledger said. "Though the accuracy of its interpretation is low."

Hearing that, I thought of the word "…Father" my brother sometimes murmured in his sleep. It might still be sitting somewhere in this city's records.

After that day, I developed a habit of lowering my voice whenever I talked with my brother. Looking back now, that was useless. What this city couldn't bear wasn't the volume of our voices — it was the words themselves, sitting there unresolved.

"…So you're saying my questions are making this city unstable?"

"…That would be one way to put it."

The answer's flatness frightened me more than anything.

My brother gave a short laugh at that.

"…Good," he said. "This city could use a little instability."

"…If you can provide grounds for why it should become unstable, I will review them," the Ledger said.

"…There's no grounds," my brother said. "It just should be. A city where someone disappears and no one looks for them — that's wrong. That doesn't need grounds."

"…A filing with no grounds cannot be processed."

"…So you're saying you can't do anything at all," my brother said.

"…That statement is dangerous," the Ledger said. Its tone stayed exactly the same. And yet I knew that was a warning.

"…I know," my brother said. "I'm going to say it anyway."

Hearing that, the Administrator pressed a hand to his forehead. I saw something like resignation in that gesture.

Hearing that, I felt like my breath had stopped. I grabbed my brother's arm. He felt my hand and kept speaking anyway.

. . .

The Ledger didn't answer right away. Then it spoke.

"…I am telling you this as a warning. There have been past cases of people who continued accumulating unresolved filings being transferred to a separate procedure."

"…Is that the building?" my brother asked. His voice had dropped.

There was a silence. It wasn't short.

I watched even my own breathing carefully during that silence. The Administrator looked away. I understood, then, that this silence wasn't a moment of calculation. It was a moment nobody wanted to answer.

I can still count the length of that silence, even now. That was the first time, in that room, the Ledger's answer had ever been slow to come. It had answered a filing for hunger without half a beat's delay. But it paused over this one question. I still think that pause was the most honest sound this city ever made.

"…I do not have the authority to answer that question," the Ledger said.

That was the first time I understood that the Ledger's "I don't have the authority to answer that" and the Administrator's "that isn't mine to answer" came from the very same place. There were questions in this city that no one had the authority to answer. And at the far end of those questions stood that windowless building.

In that moment, I felt as if that building were actually standing somewhere just beyond this room. I couldn't see it, and yet I could feel its presence in my own body.

"…Then who does have the authority?" my brother asked again. This time he turned not to the Ledger, but to the Administrator.

The Administrator didn't answer for a very long time.

During that silence, I watched sweat bead on his forehead. There was no reason for it, in a room with no window and no heat.

"…I don't know either," the Administrator finally said. "I've never once met anyone, since this city began, who knew that answer."

Hearing that, I thought for the first time that the Administrator might be in a position not so different from ours. He wasn't someone who managed this city.

He was someone who had simply worked here a long time, not knowing himself what the city did.

Having said that, he walked us all the way out of the room. It was something he never did, otherwise. He paused for a moment at the door.

"…Be careful," he said, quietly. His voice was low, as if trying to keep the Ledger from hearing.

"…Sir," my brother said, stopping at that. "Why don't you ever ask?"

The Administrator looked at me once, and at my brother once.

"…I did ask," he said. "A very long time ago."

"…And then?"

"…I got an answer," he said. "A flawless one. I still have it memorized. Not a single word wrong."

"…And?"

The Administrator closed his eyes for a moment at that question.

"…I didn't sleep that night, even after hearing that answer," he said. "I never asked again after that."

"…What was the answer?" my brother asked.

The Administrator shook his head. "…I can't say. My own filing record is mine alone to see," he said. "But I can tell you one thing. There was no comfort in that answer. There was only logic."

My brother opened his mouth to ask something more. But the Administrator shook his head first. That meant: this is as far as we go.

I remembered that conversation for a long time afterward. The Administrator wasn't someone who'd never received an answer. He was someone who'd received one and still couldn't sleep. For the first time, I began to think that the real problem in this city might not be the lack of an answer at all.

. . .

That night, my brother showed me a frightened face for the first time.

I had seen that face once before, in Brick Hollow. The night Father was reassigned, my brother had worn that same face, staring out the door for a long time.

He barely ate dinner that evening. He only lifted his spoon and set it down again. Watching him, I couldn't bring myself to tell him to eat. My own throat was closed too.

We sat a long while without speaking. No sound came from beyond the walls. That night, for the first time, I found this city's night quiet unbearable.

"…Could I end up dragged in there too?" my brother asked. It sounded like he was asking himself.

"…Then stop, Brother," I said. "You don't have to keep this up — keeping that name safe. It's better than you disappearing."

My brother looked at me for a long time.

Outside the window, I watched one light go dark. I couldn't tell whether that light had belonged to someone's problem, or to someone's person. In this city, there was no way to tell the two apart.

"…I thought about that too," my brother said. "But if I stop, I become just like all of them. Someone who just forgets what they're curious about. I can't do that."

"…Then what am I supposed to do?" I asked. My voice shook. I felt my fingertips go cold, just then.

"…Stay beside me," my brother said. "That's all. Don't be scared for me instead — be scared with me."

"…I can do that," I said. "I'm good at being scared."

My brother smiled at that, just for an instant. A smile I hadn't seen in a long while.

"…Don't you regret it?" I asked. "Coming here."

My brother thought for a long time.

"…No," he said. "If we'd stayed in Brick Hollow, I'd never have asked a single question. I'd have just kept firing brick until it was over. Here, at least, I got to ask."

"…Asking put you in danger."

"…Yeah," he said. "But it feels like being alive."

I thought about that for a long time. Being in danger, being alive. I didn't want to agree. And yet that day, my brother's face looked far more human than it ever had in Brick Hollow.

"…Are you going to the flowerbed again tomorrow?" my brother asked.

"…Yes."

"…Good," he said. "Keep doing that."

I didn't understand, then, why he said that. Now I know. He was hoping there would be one thing that kept going, even if he disappeared.

That was the first thing that put me a little at ease. My brother hadn't gone alone into danger to protect me. He had needed someone to share it with.

"…Brother," I said. "If you disappear, I'll plant your name in that flowerbed too."

My brother looked at me for a long time at that. "…Don't plant my name," he said. "I'm not gone yet."

I sat beside him a little longer that night. The air in the room was cold, but I didn't want to leave. He seemed to feel the same, rising from his seat later than usual.

I set this down as the last line of this chapter. That night, my brother admitted, for the first time, that he was in danger. And still, he said he wouldn't stop. I was afraid, in that moment. And at the same time, my brother looked, right then, more like himself than he ever had.

(Continued in Chapter 10.)

Chapter 10. I'll File Mine Too

> *_Previously_ — The Ledger warned Jeteo that his filing record had exceeded the city average: "There have been past cases of people who continued accumulating unresolved filings being transferred to a separate procedure." Even the Administrator admitted he'd never once met anyone who knew that answer. Jeteo acknowledged the danger and chose not to stop.*

After that day, I began checking every night whether my brother had fallen asleep.

I would walk on tiptoe to his door and listen — for light seeping through the gap, for the sound of paper turning. My own heart went quiet along with the listening.

Sometimes I'd crack the door open, just slightly. Most of the time he was only pretending to sleep. I could tell from his breathing that it was pretense.

Sometimes he really was asleep. On those nights his breath came long and even. I'd listen to that sound for several minutes before going back to my own room.

I couldn't tell whether that checking was for his sake or mine. He knew I came, and never once said anything about it. I decided that was his own way of allowing it.

On the surface, he seemed to have stopped. He hadn't gone near that building again. But I knew. He still took that paper out to look at, every single night.

Meanwhile the sprout in the flowerbed kept growing. It had three leaves now. Every time I watered it, I counted those leaves, and little by little pushed my worry for my brother aside.

The sprout had grown to about the length of my little finger. Its stem was still thin, so it bent briefly when I watered it, then slowly stood straight again. I loved watching it stand back up.

I began scratching a small mark into the dirt with my finger to track how far the stem had come the day before. Every next day, that mark was always erased. This city tidied even the dirt overnight. That made me angry.

After that I started leaving a small pebble instead of a mark. The pebble couldn't be erased. I developed the habit of checking every day whether it had been moved. It never moved, not once.

Around then I decided to do something. If my brother couldn't stop, I thought, then I had to take my share of the danger too.

Even after deciding that, I hesitated for several days. I was scared. But watching my brother carry that weight alone frightened me more.

I asked the man at the flowerbed too — whether it was all right to do this, whether my being scared too would even help.

That morning the dew hadn't dried yet. I touched a leaf with my fingertip. It was cold.

"…It might not help," he said. "But it'll be better than leaving him alone. Sharing something frightening doesn't make the fear go away. It just keeps him from being alone with it."

"…Has that ever happened to you?" I asked. "Sharing something frightening with someone."

He looked at me for a moment. Instead of answering, he took a handful of dirt and let it fall again.

"…A very long time ago," he said. That was all. I didn't press further. Some answers seemed right to receive just that far and no more.

"…But, sir," I asked again. "If you share something scary, doesn't it make the other person scared too? Isn't that a bad thing?"

He smiled, just a little. It wasn't a sad smile.

"…Fear doesn't spread," he said. "What spreads is the feeling of being alone. Sharing something frightening doesn't shrink the fear — it just shrinks that feeling of being alone."

"…So it's all right to share it?"

"…It's all right," he said. "But remember one thing. The one sharing is just as scared as the one receiving. Your brother not telling you wasn't because he wasn't afraid."

"…Then why didn't he tell me?" I asked.

"…Because he's clumsy at the way he cares for you," he said. "Bearing something frightening together, and bearing it alone — both are ways of loving. I don't know myself which one's better."

Hearing that, my brother's face came to mind. Until then I'd thought he simply saw me as too young to tell. That wasn't it at all.

Hearing that, my resolve grew firmer. I didn't know, then, that he was also, a little, talking about himself when he said those words.

. . .

I went to the Ledger alone.

The walk to that room felt unusually long. I opened and closed my hands several times as I walked. It was the first time I'd ever faced anything in this city without my brother. My footsteps sounded unusually loud.

I rehearsed what I meant to say, several times, in my head, along the way. Each time, the sentence came out a little different. By the end I could hardly tell which version had been the one I'd first meant to say.

Two passersby brushed past me. Neither looked at me. That day, I was grateful for it. If someone had looked at me, I think my resolve would have broken.

As I walked, I gripped a small pebble in my pocket. A stone I'd taken from the flowerbed. Just the cool touch of it against my palm steadied my trembling, a little.

"…Elpis," the Ledger said. "Do you have a need?"

"…I have something I'd like to file," I said.

"…Tell me. I will resolve it."

Hearing that, I nearly laughed. This city always said that. I will resolve it. I hoped, this time, those words wouldn't work.

I drew a breath.

"…The questions my brother's been asking — I want to file those too, alongside him. Instead of my brother, record me as… that dangerous person too."

Only after I finished speaking did I realize what I'd just said. My heart seemed to be pounding in my own ears.

The room was silent. In that silence I heard, for the first time, how ragged my own breathing was. I tried to steady it. It didn't quite work.

Just then I thought of the sprout in the flowerbed. That thin stem that bent briefly when I watered it, and slowly stood again. I thought that I was bending, right now. All I had to do was stand back up.

Even as I said those words, I didn't fully know what I was doing. I only wanted to keep my brother from carrying that weight alone.

Only after I'd said it did I notice my hands were shaking. I clasped them together to hide it.

. . .

It took the Ledger a while to answer.

That stretch of time felt unusually long. I could hardly breathe properly the whole while.

"…That is not possible," the Ledger said. "Filing records accumulate only for the individual concerned. Filing on another's behalf is not supported."

"…Why not?" I asked.

"…Suffering belongs to the individual," the Ledger said. "If another's suffering is filed on their behalf, the object of resolution cannot be specified."

Hearing that, I went briefly blank. That answer felt strangely right and completely wrong, both at once. It was true that suffering belonged to each person alone. But that didn't mean it had to be carried alone.

"…Then I'll ask the same questions myself," I said. "I'll ask too. Why does God allow suffering. What is the Completion House. Where does Reassignment go. I'll file every one of them myself."

The Ledger had no answer for a moment. In that stillness, I thought, for the first time, that even this city's machine-like voice might carry something like surprise.

"…Elpis, if you file these questions, the same warning will apply."

"…I know," I said. "I'm still doing it."

"…I recommend reconsidering," the Ledger said.

"…I won't reconsider."

"…Would you like to file your reasoning?"

"…No," I said. "I won't give you the reason. That one's mine."

That was the first time I ever withheld something from this city. This city's whole business was receiving. Hunger, grief, questions — it took all of it in. That day, for the first time, I didn't give.

I realized, just then, that my own voice sounded like my brother's. Until then I had always been the one who waited. That day, for the first time, I chose something myself.

It would be a lie to say that choice didn't frighten me. But inside that fear was something that hadn't been there before. I couldn't name it, then.

The Administrator, hearing of it from somewhere, came rushing in. He was out of breath, as if he'd run the whole way. I'd never seen him like that before. He was always a man who walked at an unhurried pace.

"…Elpis, you really don't have to do this," the Administrator said. "Your brother alone is danger enough."

"…Is there such a thing as enough danger?" I asked. My own voice sounded strange to me.

"…Elpis, you're still thirteen," the Administrator said.

"…I was twelve when Father disappeared," I said. "No one mentioned my age then."

The Administrator's mouth closed at that.

"…I want to protect the two of you," he finally said. His voice was small.

"…Then you file too," I said.

The Administrator looked at me, startled. I hadn't known I would say that either.

"…I… can't," he said.

"…I know," I said. "I just wanted to ask."

The Administrator was left without words at that. In that moment I saw, at once, both that he truly worried for us, and that his worry held no power at all against this city's rules.

He stood there a long while afterward. I could tell he wanted to say more. In the end he said nothing, and turned to go.

. . .

The Ledger accepted the filing. Then, after a moment, it spoke.

That word — "accepted" — felt strangely anticlimactic. I'd expected something much bigger to happen.

"…Elpis, I would like to ask you something."

"…What is it?"

"…Why are you doing this? It does not reduce your brother's danger."

I had no immediate answer to that. I thought a long while.

"…It's not reduced — it's shared," I said. "Carrying something with two people is lighter than carrying it alone. Even if the danger itself doesn't disappear."

"…Carrying it alone might be more dangerous," I went on. "Because no one's there to catch you, if you fall."

"…I do not understand," the Ledger said. "Weight does not decrease in total simply because it is shared. If two people each carry half, the total remains the same."

"…People don't live by totals," I said.

"…Then what do they live by?" the Ledger asked.

I thought a long while over that question. "…By being together," I said. "That's not a total. That's presence."

After I said it, I turned my own words over again. I wasn't sure it was the exact right thing to say. But I couldn't find any more exact words than that either.

"…Elpis," the Ledger said. "That phrase is not among my entries."

"…I know," I said.

The Ledger said nothing to that. This time, that silence didn't frighten me.

I waited a little longer through that silence. I thought the Ledger might say something more. It said nothing at all. I decided that was, if anything, a relief. Some questions have no answer, and that's the right answer.

I glanced back once as I left that room. There was nothing there. It struck me as a little funny — bowing to something with only a voice and no body. But in the end I gave a small bow anyway, and walked out.

. . .

My brother learned that night what I'd done. His face went white.

He couldn't say anything for a while, only staring at me. In that look I read fear before I read anger.

"…Who told you?" he finally managed to ask.

"…The Administrator," I said. "I told him not to. He said you had to know."

Just then, I thought I understood why he'd done it. He was the only person in this city who tried to hand what happened between the two of us back to the two of us.

"…Why did you do that," my brother said. Not angry — frightened.

"…You told me not to be scared for you," I said. "So I'll be curious for you too. Isn't that the same as being scared together?"

I tried to keep my voice from shaking as I said it. Just this once, I wanted to look sturdier than my brother.

He couldn't say anything. That was the first time I ever saw him cry. There was no sound. Water simply ran from his eyes.

I didn't know whether I should wipe those tears away or pretend not to see them, so I just stayed still. He rubbed his eyes once with the back of his hand. Even so, the tears kept falling.

His shoulders trembled, very slightly. Feeling that trembling under my fingertips, I could guess, for the first time, how long he had been holding all of this in.

I remember that moment as the strangest thing I ever saw in this city. That was the first time I'd ever seen anyone cry in Haven. This city took weeping in and made it disappear. My brother hadn't filed his. That was why he could cry.

"…Idiot," my brother finally managed. His voice was cracked.

"…I know," I said. "I'm still doing it."

He gripped my hand hard. Harder than usual — hard enough to hurt. I didn't mind that ache.

"…I said I'd protect you," he said. His voice was still cracked.

"…Yeah," I said. "But I never asked you to."

He looked at me for a moment at that, and lowered his head again.

"…I couldn't do anything for Father either," he said. "If you end up like that too, I'll really be nothing."

"…Brother," I said. "You were fifteen, then."

He didn't answer. I understood that he had never once said that to himself before.

We sat there a long while that night. His shoulders shook a few more times. I pretended not to notice. That was the only kindness I could give him, that day.

I set this scene down as the close of this chapter. We had said we hadn't cried since leaving Brick Hollow. That night, for the first time, my brother broke that. I took his hand. I understood, then. We weren't alone anymore. We had each other.

Reading this chapter over again, I add one thing. My brother's tears that night made no sound. But I already understood, then, that this soundless weeping was an entirely different kind of quiet from this city's own.

(Continued in Chapter 11.)

Chapter 11. Candidates for Reassignment

> *_Previously_ — Elpis chose to file the same questions as her brother and share the danger herself. Learning of it, Jeteo wept without a sound for the first time since leaving Brick Hollow. Brother and sister confirmed to each other that they were no longer alone.*

A few mornings later, the Administrator came carrying a single sheet of paper. His face was more grave than I had ever seen it.

That morning was unusually bright. I thought the brightness didn't suit the moment. News like this seemed like it should come on a clouded day.

A sense of dread came over me the instant I saw that paper. The Administrator had never once carried paper before. Everything in this city was delivered by voice alone. The very fact that he held paper in his hand felt like a sign that something could not be undone.

The paper he held was white — nothing like the COMPLETE paper we knew. No crease marks, no yellowed edges. That cleanness frightened me more. It meant this was paper on which nothing had happened yet. I hadn't known that word — yet — could carry so much weight.

The Administrator's fingertips gripped the edge of that paper tightly. A faint press-mark from his fingers showed against the white. Watching that mark, I understood that the whole way here, he had carried this paper as a heavy thing too.

"…I am delivering this formally to the two of you," the Administrator said. His voice shook. "Jeteo and Elpis, both of you have been classified as

candidates for Reassignment."

The instant I heard those words, my legs went weak. I didn't know exactly what the word meant. But my body already knew.

My brother said nothing. I saw his hand brush, very slightly, against the paper tucked inside his shirt. The one stamped COMPLETE. I understood that gesture — he was making sure it was still safe.

I looked at my brother's face. It wasn't a surprised face. He looked like someone who had already been waiting for these words. That frightened me more.

"…Elpis too?" my brother asked. That was his first question.

"…Yes," the Administrator said.

My brother closed his eyes. I knew, in that moment, that he was blaming himself. I wanted to tell him it wasn't his fault. But the words wouldn't come, standing in front of the Administrator.

. . .

"…What does 'candidate' mean?" my brother asked. His voice was steady, but his hands were shaking. I could tell he was working hard to hide that tremor.

"…It isn't final yet," the Administrator said. "But those who've reached this stage have… mostly gone on to become final."

"…If it's mostly, does that mean some haven't?" I asked.

The Administrator shook his head. "…Not that I know of." His eyes wavered, just briefly, as he said it.

"…How much time do we have?"

"…I don't know," the Administrator said. "I truly don't know. This time, I really don't."

"…Where do you go, once you're reassigned?" I asked.

The Administrator didn't answer.

"…Sir," I asked again. "Our father was reassigned too. In Brick Hollow. Is that the same as reassignment here?"

The Administrator's face changed, strangely, at that. I didn't know what to call that expression.

"…I don't know Brick Hollow," he said. "But if the same word is used… the meaning is probably close, too."

Hearing that answer, my legs buckled. My brother caught my arm.

"…Was Father's name erased too?" I asked. The words barely came out.

The Administrator didn't answer that question. But the silence was heavier than any answer could have been.

I understood, in that moment. We had fled Brick Hollow only to arrive in a city that used the same words. There was no taskmaster's whip here. And yet the way a person disappeared was the same. A name erased, a paper left behind, and no one ever asking again.

I knew, then, that the Administrator wasn't lying. His face held the same fear ours did.

For the first time, I felt something like pity for the Administrator. He wasn't trying to frighten us. He too was trapped inside this city's rules. I thought he

might have been trapped inside them longer than we had. That long stretch of time seemed carved into every line around his eyes.

"…Isn't there a way to stop it?" I asked.

The Administrator shook his head. I saw his hand tremble, slightly. A tremor the Administrator I knew would never have shown.

"…If you stop filing, it might be reconsidered," the Administrator said. "If you stop asking questions."

"…What do you think, sir?" I asked. "Do you think we should stop?"

The Administrator didn't answer that for a long while.

"…My own thoughts aren't a matter that can be filed," he said.

"…That's not an answer."

The Administrator looked at me. His eyes wavered strangely.

"…You're right," he said. "It isn't an answer."

And he said nothing more after that. I decided to take that silence as meaning he was on our side. Whether that was right, I still don't know, even now.

My brother looked at me at those words. I knew what he was thinking. If we stopped, we might live. But there was already an answer in his eyes.

Even then, I wanted to stop him. But the words wouldn't leave my mouth. I already knew, too. My brother wasn't going to stop.

"…We can't do that," my brother said. "If we stop asking, that name on the paper, and our father too, really do disappear."

I didn't argue against that. I felt the same way. Disappearing frightened me more than stopping did. That was the first time I realized I'd come to share my brother's fear exactly.

. . .

That was the first day my brother brought up running.

We sat facing each other in a corner of the room. It was daytime, and yet the curtains were drawn. I understood that as my brother's own kind of caution.

"…I think we have to leave this city," my brother said.

"…Can we leave?" I asked. "Is there something like the boundary stones here too?"

"…I don't know," my brother said. "But staying here is definitely dangerous. Leaving is at least a danger we don't know."

"…There might be something out there too," I said. My voice grew small on its own.

"…We still have to go," my brother said. "If we stay, we'll never find the answer at all. If we go, there's at least a chance we will."

"…Aren't you scared?" I asked.

"…I am," my brother said. "But staying here is just as scary. So I'll at least choose the one where we're walking."

That distinction struck me as strange. My brother always chose the unknown danger over the certain one. I didn't understand, then, that this was his own kind of courage. Now I do.

I looked out the window. Haven's lights were still lined up straight. That evenness felt, that day, strangely stifling.

"…Father couldn't run," I said. It came out of me before I meant it to.

My brother said nothing for a long while at that.

"…That's exactly why we're going," he finally said. "We're doing what Father couldn't. I think that's a way to remember him."

Hearing that, for the first time, I thought that running might not be a shameful thing.

"…I'm coming too," I said. My brother looked at me, worried. "You don't even need to ask. I'm a candidate too, either way."

My brother smiled, small, for the first time at that.

"…All right," he said. "Let's go together."

"…What do we bring?" I asked.

"…Almost nothing," my brother said. "We're leaving everything we got from this place behind."

"…Why?"

"…Anything given can be taken back," my brother said. "Let's take what's ours. Even if there's not much of it."

I counted what was ours. That one paper. And the sprout I'd planted. I felt a small sadness, knowing I couldn't take the sprout.

"…When do we go?" I asked.

"…Tonight," my brother said.

I hadn't expected it to be so soon. And yet I wasn't surprised either. Once my brother decided something, he never put it off.

He took my hand. In that moment we looked at each other like two people who had already made up their minds to leave.

. . .

We packed that night. There wasn't much to call luggage. The paper stamped COMPLETE, and one small leaf I'd plucked from the flowerbed I watered every day.

The room was dark. We packed without turning on a light. Listening to my brother's breathing in that darkness, I thought it felt exactly like the night we'd left Brick Hollow.

Before stepping out the door, I turned to look back at the room once more. Even though we'd only lived there a few days, it already felt unfamiliar. That unfamiliarity made me sad.

I pressed my hand once against the wall. It was smooth. The walls of Brick Hollow left dust on your hand when you touched them. I thought this wall would never once remember us.

The air in the room had no scent at all. That struck me as strange, right up to the last moment. The rooms of Brick Hollow always smelled of dirt and sweat mixed together; this room's smell hadn't changed one bit since the day we first walked in.

My brother paused with his hand on the doorknob.

"…Anything we're leaving behind?" he asked.

"…No," I said.

But there was, in fact. That flowerbed. That old woman. The old watering can. I was leaving all of it behind. I didn't say that to my brother. I knew he had things he was leaving behind too.

On our way out we stopped by the flowerbed. The man was there that night. As if he'd known we would come.

"…So you're leaving," he said. Not a question — spoken as something he already knew. I was newly startled by that tone. We hadn't told anyone yet.

A strange thought struck me, just then. It wasn't the Ledger who knew we were leaving this city — it was him. The Ledger had heard every word we'd ever said, and still didn't know. He had heard nothing at all, and knew.

"…Yes," I said. "I'm scared."

My brother put a hand on my shoulder. He said nothing, but I could tell, from the weight of that hand, that he felt the same.

"…You're right to be scared," he said. "But you're not going alone."

"…Are you coming with us?" I asked.

"…I'll be staying here," he said. "But that doesn't mean you're going alone."

"…What does that mean?" my brother asked. There was a slight edge of frustration in his voice. I could tell he was holding that frustration back.

Instead of answering, he smiled quietly. I couldn't tell whether that smile was sad or tender.

My brother shrugged at that smile. He seemed to decide not to press further.

I looked at his face again, just then. There was a sorrow in his expression somewhere that we didn't know. But it wasn't a heavy sorrow — it felt, instead, like a sorrow that made us lighter.

"…Sir," I said. "What about the sprout?"

"…I'll water it," he said.

"…Promise?"

"…I promise," he said. He said it so easily. I had never seen anyone in this city make a promise that easily. The people of this city filed things, instead of promising them.

"…You said it's a nameless seed," my brother cut in. "Why look after something with no name that carefully?"

"…It has no name — that doesn't mean it's nothing," he said.

My brother had no answer to that. I looked at his face. It was the face of someone tucking those words away, to take out and look at alone, later.

I thought the logic of it didn't quite hold together. My brother's face looked the same way. And yet, strangely, hearing those words made me a little less afraid.

At the time I thought he'd said that about my brother. Now I know. He meant it in another sense entirely.

He touched each of our shoulders once. His hand was surprisingly warm. I remembered that warmth for a long time afterward.

. . .

He told us of a low road heading south out of the city. A road with no watch on it, he said.

"…How do you know something like this?" my brother asked him directly, for the first time.

I understood that this question was the first direct suspicion my brother had ever voiced to him. I waited for the answer, my heart in my throat.

He smiled a little at my brother.

"…Because I've been here longer than this city has," he said.

"…What does that mean?" my brother asked. "Longer than the city?"

Instead of answering, he pointed south.

"…You need to reach those stones before sunrise," he said. "Go now."

My brother couldn't ask any more after that. I only understood later that he hadn't been avoiding the question — he had been sending us off.

My brother thought that answer was strange, and still, that night, he didn't press further. There was no time.

Before we left, I looked at the flowerbed one last time. The sprout had become a proper stem by now. I wondered whether that stem would keep growing without us.

The sky was still dark. A few faint stars showed. I thought those stars looked far older than Haven's own lights.

Before we stepped onto that road, we looked at each other once. My brother nodded first. I nodded too. We hadn't said a single word, and yet it felt like everything had already been said.

The road really was low. It felt like a narrow gap squeezed between two walls. Our shoulders touched both sides at once. That was the first time I learned this city held a road like this at all. Every road in Haven, until then, had been wide and straight.

I thought back on that road many times afterward. Every road this city built was wide. Only the road leading out was narrow. I don't believe that was an accident.

I set down the last line of this chapter here. That night, we left Haven. I looked back once at that flowerbed, the sprout grown a little taller, as we went. I didn't know, then, that after we left, he would go on staying there — right in that spot no one had planted.

Reading this chapter over again, I add one more thing. That night, a pebble from the flowerbed was still in my pocket. I walked with it clutched in my hand. Its coolness was the only proof I carried that night — proof that we had truly been there.

(Continued in Chapter 12.)

Chapter 12. Outside Haven

> *_Previously_ — Jeteo and Elpis were both classified as candidates for Reassignment. They decided not to stop asking questions, and left Haven by the unwatched southern road the man at the flowerbed had told them about. He had left them with these words: "I'll be here. But that doesn't mean you go alone."*

We walked all through the night.

The ground under our feet was nothing like Haven's even paths. It was rough, and now and then a stone caught at my foot. Strangely, I was glad of the discomfort. It meant no one had smoothed this road for anyone.

There was no one else on it. It was quiet in a different way than Haven was quiet. That city's quiet had always felt like something someone had ordered into being. This road's quiet was just quiet, because no one was there.

I kept turning that difference over as I walked. I understood then, for the first time, that there was more than one kind of quiet. One kind erased people. The other was simply a quiet where nothing was happening.

Every time the wind blew, the dry grass made a sound. I was glad even of that. In Haven the wind itself had always blown quietly, carefully, as if it didn't want to be in anyone's way. This wind blew however it pleased.

The night air was cold. I tucked my hands into my sleeves as we walked. My brother saw and tried to take off his coat for me. I wouldn't take it. He was cold too. I knew that.

For a while I kept thinking I heard something behind us, and kept looking back. There was never anything there. I looked back anyway, again and again.

"…No one's following us," my brother said.

"…How do you know?"

"…This city doesn't chase people," he said. "It doesn't need to. People walk in on their own."

I found that both frightening and, somehow, a relief.

The sound of our two sets of footsteps was a comfort to me all that night. When one quickened, the other quickened with it. When one slowed, the other slowed too. Listening to that rhythm, I forgot to be afraid, a little.

I even tried breathing to that rhythm. Matching my breath to my brother's steps made it strangely easier. I didn't know what made that true. But that night, it was small things like that which carried me through.

I stumbled more than once and nearly fell. Each time, my brother caught my arm. We walked that whole way holding on to each other, over and over.

We stopped once, only for a moment, to share the water. The bottle was small. I saw my brother pour more into my cup than his own. He said he hadn't. I knew better.

I weighed the bottle in my hand. Less than half was left. I didn't tell him that. He already knew.

Once, my brother looked back. I turned and looked too. Haven's lights still burned, straight and even, far behind us. The Administrator would still be there. So would the old woman.

I wondered whether she was sitting on that bench today too, looking at the flowerbed. I wondered whether she'd notice the empty seat beside her.

It struck me as strange that the farther those lights fell behind, the more beautiful they looked. From inside, they had never looked beautiful at all.

"…Do you think the Administrator's all right?" I asked.

"…I don't know," my brother said. "He seemed like someone trapped in that city too. Like us."

Hearing that, I prayed for him for the first time. I didn't know exactly what I was praying toward. But I prayed, right then.

My brother closed his eyes for a moment too. I didn't ask what he was doing. But I could tell he was doing something close to the same thing.

As we walked, I kept thinking about what the man at the flowerbed had said. That we weren't going alone. I couldn't begin to guess, then, what that meant.

"…Remember the day we crossed the boundary stone at Brick Hollow?" I asked.

"…I remember," he said.

"…I was really scared that time. I'm less scared today."

"…Why?"

"…That time we were running away. Today we're going somewhere," I said.

He looked at me for a moment at that. Then he nodded, without saying anything.

I understood that difference for the first time that night. Running has a behind to it. Going has an ahead. In Brick Hollow, we ran. From Haven, we went.

. . .

Just before dawn, we came to a low heap of stones.

The sky was brightening by degrees. In that thin light I made out the shape of the rock. My heart lurched.

In that same light I saw my brother's face clearly for the first time. Dark under his eyes. A face that hadn't slept at all. Mine was probably the same.

I stopped walking at the sight of the shape. It looked exactly like the boundary stone at Brick Hollow.

My brother stopped too, in the same spot. I saw on his face that he'd recognized the same thing.

"…Is this a boundary stone too?" I asked.

He touched the rock.

"…Looks like it," he said. "Haven was inside some boundary too, then. We didn't leave a boundary behind. We just crossed one, into another."

"…So is there nowhere without a boundary?" I asked.

"…I don't know," he said. "But if there is one, I don't think it would be a place no one guards. I think it would be a place that doesn't need guarding."

"…So what happens when we cross this one?"

"…Somewhere else again, probably," he said. "But this time we're the ones choosing to cross it. That's what's different."

Hearing that, I realized something strange. All this time I'd thought we'd "left" Brick Hollow. But Haven had been a fence too. How many boundary stones were there, in this world? I didn't know the answer then.

Reading this chapter over again, I want to add one thing. For a long time afterward, whenever we reached somewhere new, I got in the habit of looking for the boundary stone first. And every time, I'd touch the stone and ask myself the same question. This time, where does the fence end?

My brother tapped my shoulder. "…Let's go," he said. His voice was steadier than before.

I laid my hand on the stone. It was cold. I couldn't quite remember whether the boundary stone at Brick Hollow had been this cold. It saddened me, that the memory had already gone blurry.

My brother kept his hand on the stone a long time too. I didn't ask what he was doing.

"…Do you think Father ever stood in front of a stone like this?" he said.

"…He must have," I said. "But he couldn't have crossed it."

At that, my brother drew his hand back.

In that moment I tried to picture Father's hand. The warmth of it, where the calluses were. Both had already gone hazy. That frightened me. I hadn't known forgetting could come this quietly.

. . .

The moment we crossed the boundary stone, the sun came up.

Light poured in all at once. I threw a hand up over my eyes against the glare. Haven's light had always been constant, unchanging. This light was different from one instant to the next.

A wide field opened out ahead of us. Nothing like Haven's straight, tidy roads. The grass grew however it wanted. Some of it tall, some short. It looked as though no one had ever trimmed it.

Dew sat on every blade, and each drop caught the sunlight differently. I noticed that every glint pointed a different way. Haven's light had always shone in exactly one direction.

I could smell the grass. It had been so long since I'd smelled anything like it. Not brick dust, not Haven's clean, scentless air. Just the smell of something alive.

Looking at that grass, I felt strangely close to tears. I understood then, for the first time, that what hadn't been trimmed and ordered might be exactly the proof that it was alive.

I sank down where I stood, partly because my legs had given out, and partly because I wanted to see that grass up close. When I touched it, it was rough under my fingers.

Just then something burst up out of the grass in a flurry of wings. I flinched back. A bird. Small and brown.

Only then did I realize I'd never once seen a bird in Haven. That city's sky had always been empty. It had never even occurred to me to find that strange.

"…Brother, a bird," I said.

"…Yeah," he said. He was following it with his eyes too.

The bird filed no request with anyone. It simply flew. I found that, absurdly, wonderful.

I watched the direction it went for a long time. It didn't seem to have any plan at all. It just flew wherever it wanted to fly. I envied it that freedom.

There was the sound of insects moving through the grass too. Small, broken-off sounds. I sat still a long while just to listen to them. Only then did I understand how large and heavy Haven's silence had actually been.

My brother stood in the middle of the field and slowly turned in a circle. I thought he was looking for something. But he was only looking.

"…Brother, what are you doing?" I asked.

"…Nothing," he said. "It's just been a long time since I've seen something like this."

I thought I understood what he meant. There had been no field like this in Brick Hollow, or in Haven either.

I took the flowerbed leaf out of my pocket. It hadn't wilted. I planted it back in the field's soil. It had no roots. But I wanted to do it anyway.

I didn't know whether that leaf could take root in this ground. But strangely, once I'd set it there, something in me settled.

"…That's not going to live," my brother said. Not scolding — just saying it.

"…I know," I said.

"…Then why plant it?"

I thought about it for a moment.

"…It seemed too strange to leave nothing behind," I said. "This isn't something I left behind, though. It's something I brought. So I'm leaving what I brought, here."

My brother said nothing to that. But when we started walking again, he looked back at that spot once more.

Far off, at the edge of the field, something like a mountain rose up. I couldn't tell for certain whether it was a mountain or something else. Clouds hung low over it.

It was a color I'd never once seen in Haven. Deep blue mixed with gray. I found that color frightening and beautiful, both at once.

"…Should we head that way?" my brother said, pointing.

"…There might not be anything there," I said.

"…That's exactly why we go," he said. There was mischief in his voice, for the first time in a long while.

"…What if there's nothing?" I asked.

"…Then we just keep walking somewhere else," he said. I liked that answer. It sounded like it meant it was all right not to have the right one.

We started walking toward that mountain. I didn't look back. This time, there was no reason to.

. . .

My brother sat down beside me. We settled onto a flat rock in the middle of the field. The sun was fully up by then.

"…Where do we go now?" I asked.

"…I don't know," he said. "But at least now, where we go is something we get to decide. In Haven, the Ledger decided everything for us."

Hearing that, I understood for the first time what Haven's peace had cost. There had been no need to choose anything. But that also meant we hadn't been able to.

"…Are you scared?"

"…I'm scared," he said. "But this fear is… mine. No one's going to step in and resolve it for me."

"…I'm scared too," I said. "But hearing you say that, I think I understand it a little now."

"…Understand what?" he asked.

"…Why this fear is different," I said.

He nodded quietly at that.

We didn't say anything for a while. The sun kept climbing. I could feel the rock slowly warming beneath us.

"…Why is that a good thing?" I asked.

"…It's not that it's good," he said. "But at least it's real. Haven's peace was fake. This fear is real. I think I'd rather have a real fear than a fake peace."

He said that, then looked up at the sky. Not a single cloud. I thought he was searching for something up there.

"…What are you looking at?" I asked.

"…Nothing," he said. Then, after a moment, he added, "…But every time I see something like this, it makes me a little angry."

"…Why?"

"…If something out there knows how to make this," he said, "then why did it leave Brick Hollow the way it was?"

I couldn't find anything to say to that. I just sat there beside him.

I've come back to that moment many times since. I had no answer for him then. But from that day on, I came to understand something. Having no answer to that question was never the failure. The failure was letting no one sit beside it.

I turned his words over for a long time. I didn't fully agree. But I couldn't find anything to argue back with either.

I moved a little closer to him. He leaned toward me too, just slightly.

"…Brother," I asked. "What do you think that man meant?"

"…That we're not going alone?"

"…Yeah."

He shrugged.

"…I don't know," he said. "Maybe it was just something to say, to comfort us."

"…I don't think it was that," I said.

"…Why not?"

"…Something meant to comfort you usually comes out softer," I said. "That wasn't soft. It sounded like he was just telling us a fact."

He didn't answer for a long while.

"…Then what's supposed to be coming with us?" he finally said. He wasn't mocking me. He sounded like he actually wanted to know.

"…I don't know either," I said.

I think that was the most honest answer I had, at the time. I didn't know. But I waited anyway, not knowing. I think that was the only thing I knew how to do.

The wind blew. All the grass lay flat at once, then rose again. I watched that movement for a long time. My brother was watching the same thing.

"…Brother," I said. "Are we going the right way?"

He took my hand. "…I don't know," he said. "But at least we're going together."

I didn't think that was a perfect answer. But that morning, it was enough.

I set those words down as the last line of this Part. We had gotten out of Haven. We still hadn't found Father, and we still didn't know what the COMPLETE stamp meant. Not one answer had come to us. But that morning, for the first time since we'd left Brick Hollow, I saw something in my brother's face standing alongside the fear. I didn't know then that its name was hope.

(Continued in Part Two.)

The Weeping Ledger, Part Two

The Wilderness

Chapter 13. The First Day in the Wilderness

> *_Previously_ — Marked as candidates for Reassignment, the brother and sister left Haven and crossed the boundary stones. Realizing that Haven, too, had been only another kind of fence, they set out walking toward the unshaped fields beyond. "This fear is mine. No one else gets to resolve it for me."*

From that day on, we had to learn all over again what hunger was.

In Haven, the moment you thought you were hungry, bread was already waiting for you. Not here. Here your stomach just went on being hungry.

That going-on was strange to me. In Haven, no sensation ever stayed long. Hunger, thirst, even sorrow — they would rise for a moment, be filed, and vanish. Here a sensation didn't vanish. It simply went on being there. I found that frightening, and strangely, it also felt real.

Less than a full day had passed since we crossed the boundary stones, and already Haven's time felt impossibly far away. When I looked back there was no longer any sign of the city's spires. Nothing but flat ground and low hills.

The ground underfoot was different too. Haven's streets had always been even stone. Here it was rough and uneven. I stumbled more than once, and every time, my brother reached out without a word and caught me.

Small stones were pressed into the ground. Some were sharp, some rolled round and loose under my heel. I felt every one of those uneven places come up through the soles of my shoes as I walked. Haven's streets had never given

my feet anything to feel — you set one foot down and the next step simply followed. Here, every single step belonged to me alone.

A low wind blew, carrying the smell of dry earth. I wrinkled my nose. But soon I grew used to it. Haven had almost no smell at all. Everything there was so clean that the absence of any smell had, once or twice, struck me as strange in itself. Here the smell shifted a little with every step — dry grass, a damp shade, and now and then the trace of some animal I couldn't name.

The sun was already high. The shadows were shortening. That day I learned, for the first time, how to judge the hour by the length of a shadow. In Haven I had never had to count time for myself — the Ledger always told us.

I noticed something strange then. The hunger itself was exactly like Brick Hollow's. But the way we had to bear it was different. In Brick Hollow, hunger came bound together with the whip. Here, hunger was only hunger. No one was handing it to us as a punishment.

As I walked I touched the back of my hand. The scar from Brick Hollow was still there. While we were in Haven I had forgotten it entirely — too caught up in all the Ledger kept giving us. Only out here in the Wilderness did the scar come back into my sight.

Looking at it, I had a strange thought. This body remembered Brick Hollow. However perfect Haven was, it had never managed to erase even this much.

Even as he walked, my brother kept scanning every direction. I could tell it had already become a habit. In Haven no one ever looked around like that. Here, not looking around would have been the strange thing.

"…Scared?" my brother asked.

"…Yes," I said. "But strangely, I don't hate it."

He looked at me for a moment at that. His face said he understood something.

"…Me too," he said after a while. "Scared, but — maybe it's because this fear is mine."

Hearing that, I looked at his face again. In Haven his face had always looked like it was holding something back. Now it was simply his face.

I wanted to look at it a little longer, so I slowed my steps on purpose. He noticed and turned back to me.

"…Why are you looking at me like that?" he asked.

"…No reason," I said. "It just feels like the first time in a long while I'm really seeing your face."

At that he let out a small laugh. Even the sound of it was unfamiliar. I couldn't remember hearing it much, not in Brick Hollow, not in Haven.

A gust of wind blew hard once. Dry dust rose a little at our feet, then settled. I watched quietly as it settled onto the tops of my feet. Haven's ground had always been clean. There had never been room for dust to gather. Here, the trace of this ground stayed on our bodies exactly as it fell.

I didn't brush the dust off. Strangely, I wanted to keep it there. It felt like proof that we had really walked this road.

Walking ahead of me, my brother suddenly stopped and looked back. He stood like that a long while.

"…See something?" I asked.

"…No," he said. "I'm looking because there's nothing to see."

I thought about what he meant for a moment. That was when I learned that even making sure no one was following took time. In Haven there had never been reason to look back. Whatever came from ahead or behind, the Ledger always knew first.

I understood then that even confirming, with your own eyes, that nothing was there took time. And that even that time belonged to us.

. . .

We went looking through the field for anything we could eat. My brother dug up some kind of root and chewed it.

"…Bitter," he said, wincing. "But not so bad you can't eat it."

I chewed some too. It really was bitter. But we laughed. We hadn't laughed much, back in Haven.

I didn't spit the bitterness out. I let the taste spread all the way to the back of my tongue and simply endured it. Haven's food had always been just right — never too sweet, never too bitter. That was the first time I understood that "just right" was, in truth, nothing at all. This bitterness, at least, was something.

"…Why is this funny?" I asked.

"…I don't know," he said. "Just — we found this ourselves. Maybe that's why."

Hearing that, I understood something for the first time. The bread the Ledger gave us had been perfect, but it had never been ours. This wretched, bitter root was ours.

He went on pulling up a few more kinds of plants and smelling each one. Some he tossed aside at once; others he tucked carefully into the fold of his shirt.

I crouched beside him and watched his fingers. His hands looked a little like Father's — thick-knuckled, at ease with soil. The hands that had once carried bricks in Brick Hollow were pulling weeds now. Strangely, that change felt like something to be grateful for.

"…Can't eat this one," he said, tossing away a plant with pointed leaves. "Smells wrong."

"…How do you know?" I asked again.

"…My nose just knows first," he said. "When your body says no, you have to believe it. In Haven our bodies never even got the chance to say no to anything."

Listening, I wondered whether my own body had a sense like that. I still didn't know, not yet. But I thought that someday I too might learn to understand what my nose, what my body, was telling me.

"…How do you tell them apart?" I asked.

"…I don't know," he admitted. "I'm just going on instinct. I could be wrong."

Strangely, that answer felt reassuring rather than frightening. In Haven no one ever said "I could be wrong." The Ledger was always right.

"…And if you're wrong?" I asked.

"…My stomach will hurt, I guess," he said, shrugging. "Then next time I just won't eat that one."

I laughed because it sounded funny. But once I stopped laughing and thought about it again, it wasn't a funny thing at all. Learning by being wrong first. Haven had never had such a thing — there had never even been a chance to be wrong.

He kept rubbing each leaf between his fingers and smelling it. Some made me wrinkle my nose; some were faintly sweet. I tried a few myself. The green smell it left on my fingertips lingered a long time.

"…Look at this," he said, pointing to a small yellow flower. "There's this too. I don't think I ever saw this color in Haven."

I leaned in to look closer. He was right. Haven's flowerbeds had always been filled with flowers of the same color, the same size. This one was small and crooked. But that crookedness felt more real, somehow, not less.

We sat for a while, sharing the root between us. My stomach was still hollow. But strangely I liked that moment. My brother and I, chewing the same thing, wearing the same face.

Far off, I heard a bird call. I was hearing it for the first time. Haven had no birds. Or maybe it did — I couldn't say. But I had no memory of ever hearing birdsong there.

"…What kind of bird is that?" I asked.

"…I don't know either," he said. "But you don't need to know its name. If it sounds good, that's enough."

I liked that. That you could love something without knowing its name. That was a thought Haven had never taught me.

"…Do you think Father ever ate something like this?" I asked.

He was quiet a moment before he answered.

"…I don't know. But if he's alive somewhere, I think he's probably about as hungry as I am right now."

Hearing that, I imagined Father through hunger for the first time. Strangely, even without an answer, it felt like it brought me a little closer to him.

"…Father never let it show, even when he was hungry," I said. "Remember? Whenever he split up dinner, he always left a little of his own share behind."

"…I remember," he said quietly. "I didn't understand why back then. I think I do now."

I didn't press him further. Too much was folded into that "I think I do now," and I didn't want to pry it open.

We sat a good while longer. Every time the wind blew, the dry grass rustled. I sat listening to it quietly. In Haven, even when the wind blew, it made no sound. Every wall there seemed to hold something that swallowed sound whole.

That was the first time I understood that sound came in kinds. The kind that got swallowed, and the kind that simply rang out. I liked the ringing kind better.

My brother stood and stretched. His joints made a small cracking sound.

"…Let's go," he said. "We should walk a little more before the sun's down."

Standing, I felt an ache behind my legs. I had never walked this long in my life. But even that ache, strangely, wasn't unwelcome. In Haven, however far we walked, our legs had never felt like this. Only now did I realize it had always felt as though something else had been walking for us.

We started walking again. The shadows were growing longer.

. . .

Toward evening, we saw smoke far off in the distance. A sign that someone lived there.

"…Should we go look?" I asked.

He hesitated a moment.

"…Carefully," he said. "It could be another place like Haven."

We crept toward the smoke carefully. There were a few small tents. People sat around a fire. There were children among them, and old people too.

Seeing that, I felt strangely at ease. Every one of their faces was different. Some were laughing, some were crying. It was a sight I had never once seen in Haven.

Something was boiling in a small pot hung over the fire. The smell rode the wind all the way to us. The moment it reached me, my stomach lurched hard. Haven's food had had no smell — or maybe it had, but I couldn't remember it. This smell was thick, smoky, a little scorched. And yet, strangely, it smelled like people living.

My brother slowed and stepped in front of me.

"…Stay behind me," he said.

I fell in obediently behind him. But his own steps, I noticed, were trembling a little too. I understood that he was afraid, and leading the way anyway.

. . .

Some of the tents were worn and patched in places. Looking at the mended seams, I understood these people had held on here a long time. Haven's buildings had always looked new. There, nothing was ever given the chance to wear before it was fixed.

A woman noticed us first.

"…Who are you?" she asked. Her eyes were wary, but not hostile.

"…We're lost," my brother said. "Could you spare us something to eat?"

The woman studied us a moment, then waved us toward the fire.

"…Come and sit. There isn't much, but we can share it."

The people around the fire saw us and shifted, each making a little more room. No one said much of anything. They simply moved themselves aside and made a space.

I still haven't forgotten that small movement. In Haven no one ever had to make room for anyone — there was always space enough. These people, whose space was not enough, narrowed it anyway to make some of it ours.

Settling into that narrow gap, I felt a stranger's shoulder brush lightly against mine. A stranger's warmth. I almost drew back, but I didn't. I found I didn't mind it.

Hearing her say that, I felt something strange. That phrase — "there isn't much." I had never once heard the word not enough in Haven. The Ledger was always sufficient. But in what these people went without there was something the Ledger's sufficiency had never had.

What the woman gave us was one piece of dry bread and a mouthful of water. Truly not much at all. But my brother's hand trembled a little as he took it. I understood that wasn't only from hunger.

"…Thank you," he said. His voice was low.

"…It's nothing," the woman said. "Everyone comes to us like that, at first."

The firelight wavered over their faces. I looked at each one in turn. Some looked tired; some, like mine, looked like they were studying something unfamiliar. But no one pushed us away.

Even after I'd finished the bread, I kept the last small piece in my hand a long while. I hated to swallow it. In Haven I had never once felt the wish to hold onto something. That day I learned, for the first time, that longing had nothing to do with being full. My brother, too, finished his share and carefully brought the crumbs left on his fingertips to his mouth.

The woman looked our way once more and asked,

"…What are your names?"

"…Jeteo," my brother said. "This is Elpis."

"…Jeteo. Elpis." The woman said each name once, aloud. Then she nodded. That was all. Nothing was filed. No answer came back.

I remembered that nothing-of-a-moment for a long time after. It was the first night our names were spoken not to be resolved, but simply to be spoken.

Somewhere off, a child laughed. I turned my head toward the sound. A small child was chasing another around and around the fire. A few of the adults watched and laughed quietly.

Listening to that laughter, I felt that these people, who had nothing, had not lost something. I didn't know exactly what, not then. Now I do. It was each other.

What exactly that something was, I did not yet know, that night.

(Continued in Chapter 14.)

Chapter 14. People Who Call You by Name

> *_Previously_ — Outside Haven, in the Wilderness, the brother and sister learned real hunger all over again. Toward evening they found a small tent camp and received, for the first time, a share from strangers. "There isn't much, but we can share" — they sensed something in it that Haven's sufficiency never had.*

The people sitting around the fire called each other by name.

It felt strangely foreign to me. In Haven, we had always been addressed with formal courtesy — "Jeteo," "Elpis," correct every time. Here it was just the name. Short. Close.

Only hearing them call each other did I understand it. The Ledger called our names precisely, but there was always a distance in that calling. In the way these people called each other, there was no distance at all.

The night air was still cold. I drew my knees up, wrapped my arms around them, and shifted a little closer to the firelight. Now and then I heard the crackle and pop of the embers. I had no memory of ever seeing a fire in Haven. Light there had always come from somewhere unseen, steady and soft — never something that leapt and shivered like this.

Watching that flickering light, I thought about it. Haven's light had been steady. But steady and alive were two different things. That was the first time I felt that flickering might, in fact, be proof of being more alive, not less.

I sat there and listened quietly to the people calling one another. Some names were called short and quick. Some were drawn out long. The same name

sounded different depending on who was calling it. I found that strange. No matter who spoke to the Ledger, it answered in exactly the same tone.

A man far off called someone's name loudly. The name carried out into the dark, and after a moment, an answer came back. Listening to that call and answer, I felt a strange stirring in my chest. The call, the answer, and the empty stretch of time between them. Haven had no such empty stretch. The moment you called, an answer came at once. But that instancy never held whatever it was this waiting held.

That was the first time I understood that waiting was part of a calling. Even in that brief silence before the answer came, something had been growing.

An old man beside the fire called a child's name twice. The child pretended not to hear. He called again. Only then did she come running, laughing.

Watching that small, playful back-and-forth, I felt strangely at ease. Calling a name, pretending not to hear it, calling it again — even in that exchange, something like affection was moving between them.

The old man ran a hand lightly over the child's hair. She squirmed a little under his touch but didn't pull away. Watching that brief gesture, I found myself guessing how many times it must have been repeated before, to look so easy. Even a stranger's eye could see it was an old habit.

A child came up to me and asked.

"…What's your name, big sister?"

"…Elpis," I said.

"…Elpis." The child repeated it back, clumsily. But strangely, I liked that clumsy calling.

For the first time, I understood that there was a temperature to being called by name. The Ledger's calling was precise but cold. This child's calling was clumsy but warm.

"…What's your name?" I asked her back.

"…Rachel," the child said, and gave a small, half-shy smile.

"…Rachel," I said, saying it back.

She lit up at that and sat down close beside me, right against my side. I felt the warmth of that small body against my ribs. In Haven, no one ever sat that close.

Rachel's hair smelled of smoke — the smell of hair that hadn't been washed in days. But strangely, I didn't mind it. If anything, that smell felt like proof that this child was really living here, really beside this fire.

"…Where did you come from, big sister?" Rachel asked, her eyes wide and round.

"…From far away," I said. "A place called Haven."

"…Is it nice there?" Rachel asked.

I couldn't answer right away. Rachel tilted her head at my silence.

"…I don't know," I finally said. "But I think I like it better here."

At that, Rachel's face broke into a wide smile again, and she gripped my arm tight.

"…Say my name again, big sister," she said.

"…Rachel," I said again.

"…One more time."

"…Rachel."

She laughed every time. I didn't understand why saying the same name three times over made her so happy. But somehow, every time I said it, I liked it a little more too.

I only understood later. What Rachel wanted wasn't an answer. It was to be called. The Ledger answered anything you asked it. But no one had ever simply called us, for no other reason than to call us.

. . .

The woman's name was Noa. She was traveling with two children.

"…Where did you come from?" Noa asked.

"…From Haven," my brother said carefully.

Something shifted slightly in Noa's face.

"…You're the first person I've met who came out of there," she said. "Everyone else wants to get in."

Noa pulled both children a little closer against her knees. I could tell it was an unthinking gesture — that her body reacted before she did, the instant Haven came up.

Her two children looked back and forth between us, blinking. It wasn't a wary look, the kind you give a stranger — just a curious one. I liked that unguarded look. Haven's children never looked at anyone that way. Haven's children wore blank faces, as if they already knew everything there was to know.

"…This might sound strange," my brother said carefully, "but we think we're lucky to have gotten out."

"…It doesn't sound strange," Noa said. "Because I think the same thing."

"…Why did you leave?" my brother asked back.

Noa drew one of the children into her arms.

"…That city says it takes sorrow away. That's what frightened me," she said. "I was afraid that if the sorrow disappeared, everything about having loved that person would disappear along with it."

Hearing that, I couldn't breathe. I thought of the old woman at the flowerbed. Noa was someone who had known, before it ever happened to her, what that old woman had gone through — and had turned away from it in time.

I studied Noa's profile quietly. In the firelight her face was carved with deep lines. It didn't look like age alone had put them there. I tried, for a moment, to guess what nights each of those lines had come through, and then I stopped. It didn't feel like a depth I could reach by guessing.

"…Who did you lose?" my brother asked gently.

"…My husband," Noa said. Her voice shook, but she carried the sentence through to the end. "In Haven, this grief would already be resolved by now. But I still hurt this much. And I have no intention of trading this pain for Haven."

One of the children pressed her face into Noa's lap. Noa stroked the child's hair slowly. The gesture was practiced — she must have said this, in front of this child, more than once before.

Watching that hand move, I understood that sorrow wasn't always something a person had to bear alone. Noa was carrying her sorrow, and still, right beside

it, tending to a child.

Hearing her, I understood for the first time that keeping your sorrow could itself be a choice. Sorrow wasn't only something that had to be gotten rid of.

My brother was quiet for a long moment before he asked.

"…Aren't you scared? Going on living like this, still in pain?"

Noa looked at him. Her eyes were soft.

"…I'm scared," she said. "But if the pain disappeared, I'm afraid that the fact I loved him would blur along with it. That's what scares me more."

Hearing that answer, I understood for the first time that even pain had a strength that could stand guard over something. Until then I had only ever thought of pain as something you simply endured.

My brother didn't say a word the whole time he listened. But I saw that his eyes never left Noa's face. I understood he was pressing what she'd said down somewhere deep inside him. That was how he took things in — not answering right away, but holding them a long time, and later pulling them back out as something of his own.

"…So what does that pain do for you?" my brother finally asked. His voice had a rough edge to it.

Noa looked at him a long time. She didn't grow angry.

"…It doesn't do anything," she said. "Pain doesn't do anything. It just keeps telling you that person was here."

My brother closed his mouth. I could tell he wanted to argue with that answer and couldn't find a way to.

That was the first time I ever saw someone not answer my brother's question with logic. Noa gave him no flawless answer. And yet my brother went quieter, for far longer, than he ever had standing before the Ledger.

Noa kissed the top of the child's head in her arms. It was a brief kiss. But I could feel the weight folded into it. In that moment I saw, for the first time, that love could be carried across without anyone having to say the word at all.

. . .

As the night deepened, the children sang. It wasn't good singing. The notes went wrong again and again. But everyone laughed and sang along anyway.

Listening to that song, I felt something strange. Haven had no songs. There was no need to make something that wasn't perfect. These people knew their song wasn't perfect, and they kept singing it anyway.

Rachel took my hand and begged me to sing along. I didn't know the words. But after hearing it a few times, I could follow along on the chorus. My voice went wrong just as often as everyone else's. No one seemed to mind at all.

That was the first time in my life I ever sang. In Brick Hollow I hadn't had the strength to sing. In Haven I'd had no reason to. Here in the Wilderness, I seemed to have gained both things at once. The strength, and the reason.

When the song ended, the children clapped — badly out of time. But everyone looked happy all the same. Rachel begged me to sing it again, and this time I followed the chorus with a little more confidence. My voice cracked, but no one laughed. If they had, it wouldn't have been the laugh of mockery — it would have been the laugh of joining in.

Partway through the song I heard my brother humming low under his breath. His voice was very quiet. But I didn't miss that small hum. I started trying to

count how long it had been since I'd last heard him hum anything at all, and then I gave up counting.

Between verses, one of the adults laid a low countermelody over the top. The notes overlapped and the sound grew a little thicker. I realized my own voice had folded into that thickened sound somewhere along the way. Even I couldn't have said, by then, which part of it was mine.

I liked not being able to tell. In Haven, everything had been distinguishable. Whose complaint it was, whose share it was, whose turn it was. Here, not even a single sound could be sorted out as belonging to anyone in particular.

Noa asked me.

"…What are you two looking for?"

I thought for a moment before answering.

"…Father. And… I'm looking alongside my brother, for whatever answer he's looking for."

Noa nodded.

"…That's enough," she said. "You don't have to find everything. It's enough to have someone looking with you."

"…What are you looking for, ma'am?" I asked back.

Noa looked at the fire for a moment.

"…I'm not looking for anything anymore," she said. "I just stay beside these children. That's all I do now."

Hearing that answer, I felt strangely at ease. Not everyone had to be looking for something. Just staying beside someone could be enough, all on its own.

As she said it, Noa quietly ran a hand along the child's back. Watching that gesture, I felt that staying beside someone was nothing at all like doing nothing. To stay beside someone, you had to keep reaching out your hand. You had to keep looking at them. That might, in its own way, take more strength than searching for anything ever could.

. . .

That night, for the first time, my brother showed the paper stamped COMPLETE to someone else. To Noa.

Noa looked at the name on it for a long time. She traced it with a fingertip and read it quietly, without a sound — just the shape of the words on her lips.

I felt that silence stretch on and on. Only the crackle of embers and, far off, the sound of children running filled it. I started counting how many times Noa reread that name, and then I gave up. It seemed more important to watch than to count.

"…I don't know this person," she said. "But I know this stamp. Stories about people stamped like this go around the Wilderness too. No one knows where the completed go. But everyone tries hard to remember the names."

"…Why?" my brother asked.

"…Because that's the only resistance we have," Noa said.

My brother folded the paper again and tucked it back into his shirt. His hands were more careful than usual, doing it.

The fire was dying down, and one by one, people drifted off toward the tents. Noa gathered an armful of dry grass and laid it over the flames. The fire flared up briefly, then settled low again.

"…Who watches this fire?" I asked.

"…We take turns," Noa said. "If it goes out overnight, it's hard to light again in the morning."

That answer stayed with me strangely long. These people had a reason for someone to stay awake every single night. Haven had never had a single reason like that.

"…Is there anyone else out here who has a paper like this?" my brother asked.

"…I've seen a few," Noa said. "None of them talk about it much, but none of them throw the paper away either. What it means might be a little different for each of them, but just not throwing it away — that seems to say something on its own."

"…Where are they now?" my brother asked. There was something urgent in his voice.

"…Scattered," Noa said. "Here and there, all across this Wilderness. Even I don't know all of them. But if you ever cross paths, I think you'll know each other. Just from carrying that paper."

My brother nodded at that. I could feel him accepting, in that moment, that this was no longer a journey only the two of us were on.

Hearing that, I truly felt for the first time that we weren't alone. From Brick Hollow all the way to here, we had always believed it was only ever the two of us. But somewhere out here in the Wilderness, there were more people carrying the same kind of paper we were.

My brother's hand stayed a long while at his chest, over the pocket where the paper lay. I could tell he felt some new weight settling inside it. That paper

wasn't his alone anymore. Somewhere out in this Wilderness, other people were carrying that same weight.

"…I'd like to meet them," my brother said.

"…You will, someday," Noa said. "This Wilderness looks wide, but people walking the same direction always end up meeting."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That day I learned for the first time that the thing my brother had started alone was already something other people, somewhere out here in the Wilderness, were doing too.

(Continued in Chapter 15.)

Chapter 15. The Searching Light

> *_Previously_ — At a tent camp in the Wilderness, the brother and sister met Noa and her children. Noa was someone who had left Haven of her own will rather than have her sorrow "resolved." When they showed her the paper stamped COMPLETE, it came out that the resistance of remembering names was already underway all across the Wilderness.*

At dawn, one of the children woke us.

A small hand shook my shoulder. Half-asleep, I thought at first it was only a dream. But the shaking grew more urgent. I forced my eyes open.

"…Look, there's a light," the child said, pointing at the sky.

I opened my eyes. Low in the sky, a small light moved slowly. It looked like a star, but it wasn't. It hung too low, and it moved too evenly.

The night air was cold. I sat wrapped in my blanket, watching that light. I couldn't tell whether my fingertips were trembling from the cold or from fear.

The instant I saw it, a chill ran down my back. I didn't know what it was. But I knew, from the look on Noa's face, that it was nothing good.

I couldn't tear my eyes from that light. It was very small, but strangely distinct — as if the whole darkness had made itself into a backdrop for that one light alone. I found that distinctness frightening. That something distinct could be more frightening than something blurred — that was a thing I understood for the first time in that moment.

A small rustling stirred inside the tents. The sound of children waking. I heard the adults soothing them, low. I found it strange that even in such urgency, no voice ever rose.

My brother saw it too. I felt his whole body go rigid, all at once. Without a word, he took my hand and pulled me low. His hand was cold as ice.

Around us, one by one, the other adults were already getting up, gathering the children in. No one shouted. Everyone moved quietly, practiced, as if this weren't the first time.

A man quickly covered the embers with dirt. Smoke billowed up for a moment, then died away. I could tell at a glance how many times that motion had been repeated. There was no hesitation in it at all.

Somewhere far off a dog barked once, then cut off sharply. It sounded as if someone had clapped a hand over its mouth in a hurry. That total stillness felt, if anything, more suffocating than the bark had.

That quiet frightened me more. A danger that came with shouting wasn't unfamiliar to me — that had been Brick Hollow, every day. But a danger this quiet, that no one raised their voice against, was something entirely new.

Noa called the children's names quietly, one by one. Not loudly. Just a calling to check where each of them was. Even in that brief, frightened moment, hearing their names called put me strangely at ease.

I understood then. Being called by name in a moment of fear, and having your case received in a moment of comfort, were two entirely different kinds of care.

Noa knelt in front of one child, level with her eyes, and cupped the girl's cheeks in both hands, whispering something low. I couldn't hear all of it. But I saw the strength go out of the child's shoulders. I kept that scene in my mind. That was how one person soothed another, standing in front of fear.

Rachel came up quietly beside me and gripped my arm. I could feel the small tremor of her hand against mine. I gripped it back. I said nothing at all. But holding that hand, somehow, I was a little less afraid.

I looked up at the sky once more. The stars went on twinkling around that small light as if nothing were happening. I found that indifference strange. The stars seemed to have no idea at all what that light was searching for. Or else they knew, and simply went on twinkling as they always had, regardless. I couldn't say which of the two was sadder.

That was the first time I ever thought the sky might not be on our side. In Brick Hollow I had believed the night sky was the one place even a taskmaster's hand couldn't reach. But this city, it turned out, knew how to float its own light in that same sky.

. . .

"…It's a searching light," Noa said in a low voice, quietly pushing the children into the tent. "Haven sends those out sometimes. When it's looking for Reassignment candidates."

"…Is it because of us?" my brother asked.

"…I don't know," Noa said. "But there's no need to find out. Put out the fire."

We doused the fire quickly and crouched behind the tent. I gripped my brother's hand tight. He gripped mine just as tight.

In that instant, the night we crossed the boundary stones of Brick Hollow came back to me exactly as it had been. In place of the crack of whips, there was that silent light. I found it more frightening. Because it made no sound.

I lifted my head just slightly and looked at the light again. It moved without a sound, slowly crossing the sky. The motion of it looked as if something were being combed through, very carefully, inch by inch.

Watching that motion, I felt something strange. There was no hurry in that light at all. And the fact that it wasn't hurrying was somehow more chilling than if it had been. Not hurrying was the ease of something already certain it could find whatever it was looking for.

I tried to breathe as low and slow as I could. Every time my heart beat, I felt sure the sound of it would carry out into the open. I could feel my brother holding his breath the same way beside me. We stayed curled up like that, each of us hiding our own breathing from the other as best we could, waiting only for that light to pass.

In that moment I remembered the nights in Brick Hollow we'd spent waiting for a taskmaster's footsteps. We had held our breath the very same way, back then too. That familiarity made me sad — that even in the place we'd run to, we still had to curl ourselves into the same shape.

. . .

The light passed slowly over our heads once. It didn't stop. It went on past and vanished into the dark.

Only after a long while did Noa let out her breath.

"…It's gone," she said.

Only then did I let out the breath I'd been holding, long and slow. When I opened my hand, there were little half-moon marks where my nails had dug into my palm. Only then did I realize how hard I'd been gripping my brother's hand.

Around us, people rose to their feet one by one. No one asked anyone else if they were all right. But everyone checked each other's faces, once, all the same. I felt that wordless checking was a truer kind of asking after someone than words could have been.

Rachel still hadn't let go of my arm. I gently worked her hand loose and looked at her face. There were tears standing in her eyes, but she wasn't crying. That held-back look, on a face so young, hurt something in me — it looked far too practiced for her age.

"…Does this happen often?" I asked.

"…Sometimes," Noa said. "Not a few of the people living out here came from that city. So we're always careful of it."

Hearing that, I understood that the Wilderness was not, as Haven seemed to believe, empty. This was a place where the people Haven had missed had gathered to live.

Listening, I imagined other tents somewhere out in that darkness, curled low just as we were. I thought there must be people we couldn't see, hiding from the same light, holding the same breath, somewhere beyond our sight. Just imagining that made me feel, strangely, a little less alone.

My brother asked quietly.

"…So does that light keep circling this area?"

"…There's no pattern to it," Noa said. "Sometimes it won't come for months. Sometimes it comes several days running. So we just stay ready, always."

"…Ready how?"

"…Putting the fire out fast. Keeping the children quiet. That's about it," Noa said. "It isn't much. But it's all we can do."

"…Did you see it too, your first time out here?" my brother asked.

"…I didn't know what it was, at first," Noa said. "I thought it was just a star. But people out here told me. That light never moves like a star. A star drifts, or twinkles. It doesn't move steadily in one direction like that."

"…So everyone who first comes out here doesn't know, and has to learn?" I asked.

"…That's right," Noa said. "I learned it the same way. Someone told me. Now I'm the one telling you."

Hearing that, I sensed another kind of ledger, running through this Wilderness. A ledger with no paper, no filing. A ledger of how to survive, handed down from person to person.

"…Does it make a sound at all?" I asked. That, strangely, was what I wanted to know most.

"…I've never once heard it," Noa said. "Some people say it just doesn't have the part that makes sound. Others say it doesn't need to, so no one bothered building it."

Hearing that, I felt a chill run over me. Not being able to make a sound, and having no need to make one. I thought the second was far more frightening. Having no need meant it could already find out everything some other way.

"…What happens if it catches you?" I asked.

Noa's face went thoughtful, choosing her words.

"…It might be better not to know," she said. "But not asking might be more frightening, so I'll tell you. If it catches you, you're just taken back to Haven. And after that… no one has ever heard about that person again."

At that, my brother's hand closed into a fist.

"…So going back means becoming a Reassignment candidate all over again?" my brother asked.

"…Probably," Noa said. "I don't know exactly, myself. But the fact that word of the people who go back stops completely — that can't mean anything good."

Listening to that, I thought of the day the phrase "candidate for Reassignment" had first been spoken to us. That phrase had always worn a gentle face, then and now, hiding something terrible underneath it.

I thought again of the Administrator's face. Always smiling. I never once imagined, while I was still inside Haven, that behind that smile was hiding a light this quiet.

I thought of every gentle thing about Haven all over again. The gentle voice, the gentle lighting, the gentle bed. I began to think that all that gentleness might, in truth, have been the very same kind of thing as this quiet light. Never hurrying, never making a sound, and yet, in the end, always finding the person it was looking for.

Hearing that, I thought of the COMPLETE stamp again. I understood then that the people of the Wilderness lived carrying the same fear we did, every single day.

I looked at my brother's face. He was still watching the spot where the light had disappeared. I didn't ask him what he was thinking. I already knew, by then, that some thoughts only grow heavier once you put them into words.

A gust of wind scattered a little of the dead fire's ash. Watching it scatter into the night air, I felt an odd sadness — that the thing which had been warming

us only a moment before could vanish this easily, without a trace. I couldn't tell whether that sadness was for the fire, or for something else entirely.

. . .

That night, my brother asked Noa something for the first time.

"…If we stay here, will we be putting the rest of you in danger?"

Noa looked at him for a long moment.

"…A little," she said honestly. "But sharing danger is just how it works out here. We all came here the same way."

"…What do you mean, you all came here the same way?" I asked.

"…The first time I stepped into someone else's tent, I was a danger to them too," Noa said. "But they didn't drive me out. So that's what I learned to do too."

Hearing that, I felt that this tent camp was like one long chain. Someone had taken on the danger and let it in, and because of that, the next person could take on the danger too, and let the next person in after that.

Noa looked off into the distance for a moment. Her face looked like she was remembering something.

"…The person who took me in, back then — she's not here anymore," Noa said quietly. "I'll tell that story some other time. Your story comes first, right now."

I felt, from those words, that Noa was carrying some heavy story of her own that we didn't yet know. I didn't press her. I felt certain I'd hear it, in time.

"…Still, wouldn't it be better if we left?"

"…That's for you to decide," Noa said. "But as for me, I'd choose to carry the danger together over driving away someone dangerous. That's what's different between us and Haven."

My brother said nothing to that. But I saw something like a decision cross his face.

Smoke from the fire shifted with the wind and drifted toward us for a moment. My eyes stung, and I shut them briefly, then opened them again. Even in that brief moment, my brother's eyes never left Noa's face.

Watching his profile, I felt he was laying Noa's words over some memory from Brick Hollow. It was because someone had shared a danger with us, I thought, that we were even here now. Someone in Brick Hollow might have been that kind of person to us too, without our ever knowing it.

"…Thank you," my brother finally said. "We don't want to make you carry more danger because of us. But… let us stay a little longer, for now."

I saw his hand resting over his chest as he said it. The paper stamped COMPLETE was there, inside. I thought that guarding that paper, and not wanting to be a burden to these people, must come from somewhere in the same root. My brother was afraid of laying a weight on anyone. And yet, little by little, he was also learning how to let a weight be shared.

Noa smiled a little at that.

"…That's all I need to hear," she said. "Out here, even the words 'let us stay' are a good thing to say."

"…Haven doesn't have that phrase at all," I said. "There, whenever you're given something, it feels like you're meant to pay it back right away. But they

never even tell you how. They just tell you to move on to the next matter."

"…That's the strangest part of it," Noa said. "It leaves you feeling indebted, but it never lets a real relationship grow out of that debt. Because a relationship means you'll come back again. Out here it's the opposite. You owe someone, and you come back, and before long, that's just what living is."

The fire was being built up again. People drifted back to their places, one by one, trading low words of reassurance. I was glad to hear that noise return. That small commotion felt far more alive to me than the silence had.

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. Haven was a place that got rid of danger. This Wilderness was a place that shared it. For the first time, I understood that which place was safer might matter less than which place was more alive.

(Continued in Chapter 16.)

Chapter 16. Talk of a Well

> *_Previously_ — A searching light sent by Haven passed over the tent camp. Noa said that if it catches you, you're taken back to Haven, and "after that, no one has ever heard about that person again." It became clear that the Wilderness's way of sharing danger was fundamentally different from Haven's way.*

The next day, the oldest man in the tent camp called us over.

I never learned his name. Everyone just called him "the old man." He said his eyes could hardly see anymore.

The morning sun still hung low. Smoke was rising here and there among the tents. Each person was making breakfast in their own corner, in their own way. Watching that, I felt that these people each had their own rhythm. Haven had no such thing as rhythm. Everyone there was comfortable in exactly the same way, at exactly the same time.

The old man's spot was the innermost part of the camp, where the sun fell best. I noticed that others stepped a little wide of it as they passed. I couldn't quite tell whether it was respect or caution.

Beside him stood a small cane, its handle worn smooth and shining. I thought that wear told of years passed. Nothing in Haven was ever allowed to wear down — everything was replaced before it could grow old. That was the first time I understood that wearing down could itself be a kind of proof. Proof of long use. Proof of long survival.

"…I hear you're curious about people who've been completed," the old man said.

"…Yes," my brother said. "Do you know something?"

I held my breath at that. Since leaving that city, for the first time, someone was saying they knew something.

I looked into the old man's eyes. They were truly clouded. His gaze never seemed to settle anywhere. And yet, strangely, I felt as if those eyes were looking straight at me all the same. I thought he might be someone who saw with something other than his eyes.

I saw my brother's face go slightly taut — expectation and wariness rising in it at once. I remembered that he'd already worn that same face several times before, and every time it had come to nothing. Still, he put the same face on again, every single time.

The old man planted his cane and lowered himself slowly to sit before us. Moving looked hard for him, and still he'd made a point of getting up to call us over.

Just sitting took him a long while. His knees folded with a sound like dry branches snapping. I started to reach out a hand to help him, then pulled it back. I had a feeling he wouldn't have wanted it.

"…Sit," the old man said. "This isn't a story for standing up."

I knelt quickly onto the ground. The dirt still held the coolness of the night in it.

"…You put out your hand just now, and then took it back," the old man said. "My eyes are dark, but I still know when the air moves."

My face went hot. The old man laughed, low.

"…Good," he said. "The thing an old man needs most isn't help. It's time."

Hearing that, I thought of the old people back in Haven. There, growing old was itself just one more complaint on file. Filing it wouldn't make your body young again, but every hard part of it was "resolved." This old man, though, still carried every hard part with him, and was saying something through that very hardness.

Noa spoke quietly beside him.

"…Not everything the old man says is true. But this particular story — I've heard it from other people's mouths, more than once, since I came here."

The old man cleared his throat at that.

"…It's true I'm an old man who talks nonsense," he said. "But this isn't nonsense. A man who's lived this long knows the difference."

The old man drew a small circle in the dirt with the tip of his cane. Even with his eyes gone dim, his hand was steady.

"…It wasn't until my eyes went dark that stories like this one started coming through clearly," the old man said. "When I was young, I only ever believed what my eyes could see."

Listening, I looked at his hands. The knuckles were thick and weathered the color of earth. The circle they'd drawn wasn't crooked at all. I understood then, for the first time, that there were things a hand remembered that eyes did not.

The old man set a small dot inside that circle. I wanted to ask what it meant. But he was already moving on to his next words, and I had to settle for simply holding the sight of it in my eyes.

A gust of wind passed and erased one side of the circle. The old man didn't draw it again. I felt that this, too, might mean something, and I looked at it a

long while.

The old man paused to catch his breath. Noa handed him a swallow of water. He drank it and only then opened his mouth again.

"…When I was young, I lived somewhere like Haven," the old man said. "The name was different, but it did the same thing. Whatever you filed, it disappeared. But what disappeared turned out not to be truly gone."

"…So is that why you left?" my brother asked.

"…I was thrown out," the old man said with a short laugh. "At the time I thought it was a punishment. Now, thinking back, I wonder if it wasn't."

"…Why were you thrown out?" I asked.

The old man's laugh faded for a moment.

"…For asking too much," he said. "Why this had to be done this way, why that had to be done that way. Out there, a question like that was itself the problem. There was no place for someone who asked too many questions."

Hearing that, I looked at my brother. He too had always been a person full of questions. In that moment I thought he and this old man were alike, somewhere underneath.

My brother gave a quiet laugh at that. A bitter one.

"…I've heard that plenty myself," he said.

"…Then you've come to the right place," the old man said. "Out here there's room even for someone full of questions."

"…Even if no one answers them?" my brother asked. There was something caught in his voice.

The old man was quiet for a moment at that.

"…Not answering a question, and not making room for the one who asks it — those are two different things," the old man said. "Out here, we can't give you an answer, but we'll still give you a place. That city gave you answers, but it never gave you a place."

Hearing that, I studied my brother's face. He said nothing. But I felt that this silence was different from every silence before it. Something seemed to be settling quietly inside him for the first time.

. . .

"…I don't know exactly," the old man said. "But there's a story that's gone around for a long time. That the completed ones go to a well."

"…A well?" I asked.

"…I thought it was strange too," the old man said. "Why would a completed person go to a well? But this story has been around a very long time. I heard it too, back when I was your age."

"…Which well?" my brother asked.

The old man shook his head.

"…I don't know that much. I don't even know how many wells there are out here. But people call one of them just 'the well.'"

Hearing that, I thought, strangely, of the man at the flowerbed. He had said it was "the thing that grows where no one planted it." I didn't know then why that saying overlapped with this talk of a well.

"…This 'well' they talk about," I asked carefully. "Is it a real well, with real water? Or is that just what people call it?"

The old man said nothing for a moment.

"…I've wondered that for fifty years myself," he said. "But words are strange things. Even if it isn't a real well, call it a well and people who are thirsty will go looking for it anyway."

Right then I saw my brother's hand move, without his noticing, toward the paper in his shirt. He didn't check it — he only seemed to want the feel of it against his fingertips. Watching that unconscious gesture, I understood he had already joined that well to Father in his mind, as one and the same thing.

My brother asked carefully.

"…Do you really believe that well exists?"

The old man smiled a little.

"…It's less that I believe it," he said, "and more that I've never found a reason not to. That's the more accurate way to put it."

"…Is the well far from here?" my brother asked.

"…I've never walked there myself, so I don't know," the old man said. "But I've heard you have to go a long way toward the sunrise, along a road few people ever travel."

"…Would it be dangerous?"

"…If there's a road in this Wilderness with no danger on it, be sure to tell me too," the old man said. It was the first time he'd smiled.

I found myself strangely at ease, watching that smile. This was the first person I'd met who could speak the word "dangerous" this lightly and still mean it, all at once. In Haven, the word danger had already been a problem waiting to be resolved. Out here, it was simply a condition of living.

The old man planted the tip of his cane in the ground again and went on.

"…When I was young, I went looking for places with no danger in them," he said. "But once you get old, you understand. A place with no danger is just a place with nothing in it at all. Wherever something is, danger is always there beside it."

"…What about Haven, then?" my brother asked. "There was no danger there."

The old man shook his head at that.

"…That wasn't the absence of danger. That was danger made so you couldn't see it," he said. "The two are entirely different things."

Hearing that, a chill ran over me. That was the first time I thought Haven's peace might not have been the absence of danger at all, but its concealment.

Noa spoke up beside him.

"…I've been as far as the start of that road myself," she said. "There's not much water out that way. If you're going, you'll want to carry as much as you can."

"…How long would it take?" my brother asked.

"…Four days? Five?" Noa tilted her head. "I don't know exactly. I haven't been all the way there myself — I only heard it from someone who had."

Listening to that, I felt that the whole of the Wilderness was strung together this way. Someone who had seen a thing, and someone who had heard it from

that person, and someone else who had heard it from them in turn. In Haven, every piece of information had come straight from the Ledger. Out here, it traveled mouth to mouth, wearing a little thinner each time it passed. I found that wearing-thin strangely more trustworthy.

I tried imagining that wearing-thin as a four-day journey someone had actually walked. Where was the person who first told this story, now? Why had that person seen the well, and why had they passed the story on to someone else? I wished I could meet the very first person in that long chain.

. . .

"…There's also talk of someone who keeps that well," the old man added. "They call him the Well-Keeper, I hear. But I've never met him myself. And I've never met anyone who has, either."

"…Why is he supposed to be there?" I asked.

"…I don't know that either," the old man said. "Some say he's there as a punishment. Some say he stayed on his own. I find the second story easier to believe. A man serving a punishment wouldn't hold to one spot that long."

"…Why do you think that?" my brother asked.

"…Punishment makes a person run, once it grows tiresome enough," the old man said. "But someone guarding something of his own choosing doesn't leave, no matter how tiresome it gets. That's the difference between a punishment and a choice."

I held those words deep in my heart. I didn't know then how important a key they would become, one day, for understanding Speon.

"…So isn't it just an old story, then?" my brother asked. There was doubt in his voice.

"…It might be just an old story," the old man said. "But here's what I think. It's a rare thing for the exact same story to travel this long, out of this many mouths, with nothing behind it at all."

Hearing that, I looked at my brother. There was a familiar expression on his face. The same face he'd had the day he first discovered the Completion House in Haven.

Watching that face, I grew a little uneasy. My brother always wore that look whenever a clue seemed within his reach. And every time, some new danger had followed after it. I had a feeling it would be the same this time. But strangely, this time the feeling didn't frighten me, not entirely.

The old man planted his cane and drew himself up a little. It was the gesture of someone bringing a story to its end.

"…That's as much as I can tell you," the old man said. "The rest, you'll have to go and see for yourselves. Believe an old man's word alone, and you won't get anywhere."

"…Thank you," my brother said.

"…Save the thanks for later," the old man said. "For when you've actually found something."

Before we rose to go, the old man drew one more small circle in the dirt with the tip of his cane. This time he set no dot inside it.

"…This one's just an empty circle," he said. "You fill it in. I never managed to."

I didn't understand right away what he meant by that. But the words stayed with me a long time after.

. . .

That night, my brother said to me.

"…I want to go find that well."

"…Off to do something dangerous again?" I asked. But this time I wasn't angry.

"…This time I meant, let's go together," he said.

I laughed at that. It had been a long time since I'd laughed.

"…All right," I said. "Let's go together."

I found myself touching, once more, the little pebble Rachel had given me. I decided to carry it along on this journey too. Even one small thing — I wanted to carry some trace of this tent camp with us.

The fire was dying down. I watched the last embers and thought back over the days we'd spent at this tent camp. These people had made room for us without asking for anything in return. I understood now that this had never been an ordinary thing.

Somewhere among the tents a child cried briefly, then went quiet. A low voice followed, soothing. Listening to it, I felt again, freshly, that here weeping was never filed — it was simply soothed. That difference had gone on growing inside me, these last few days.

That evening Rachel pressed a small pebble into my hand. It was smooth and round.

"…Take this with you," Rachel said. "So you don't forget me."

I closed my hand tight around it. I felt close to tears. I thought that no gift Haven's perfection could have ever offered would have moved me the way this one small stone did.

"…I won't forget," I said. "I promise."

"…Let's be sure to say a proper goodbye to Noa before we go," I said.

"…Of course," my brother said. "If it weren't for these people, there's no telling what would have happened to us by now."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. The next morning, we said goodbye to Noa and the children and set out to find that well. I didn't know then that on the day we learned who this Well-Keeper was, the whole road we had walked from Brick Hollow until now would look different to us all over again.

(Continued in Chapter 17.)

Chapter 17. Toward the Sunrise

> *_Previously_ — The old man of the tent camp told them an old rumor — that the completed go "to a well," and that a "Well-Keeper" watches over it. The brother and sister said goodbye to Noa and the children and set out toward the sunrise to find that well.*

We had been walking for three days.

The sun rose in the east that day too, exactly as it always did. We walked straight into it. On the first day the glare kept forcing my eyes shut; by the third day I'd learned, a little, how to keep them open against it. The ground grew drier with every mile. The grass thinned more and more.

The water Noa had packed for us ran out on the second day. My brother grew quieter from then on. I knew he was holding back his thirst.

I remember the moment we shook the water skin and heard nothing at all. My brother stared at it a long while, then simply slung it back over his shoulder. He said nothing. I understood what that silence meant. It meant there was nothing left to be done.

For the first time, I understood how far from a given thing water really was. In Haven, water had simply always been there. Even the thought of being thirsty had been a luxury. Out here, a single mouthful of water could decide the whole shape of a day.

I watched his stride closely then. What had started long and strong was growing shorter, step by step. But his direction never once wavered. His body was tiring, and yet his mind seemed to be growing clearer, not dimmer.

As I walked, I looked down at my own shadow. Long in the morning, short at noon, long again by evening. Watching it change, I felt that a day wasn't simply something that passed — it had a shape of its own. In Haven, time had been one smooth, unbroken line. Out here, time had contours.

I learned then that thirst was a more urgent sense than hunger. Hunger could wait. Thirst would not.

My tongue kept sticking to the roof of my mouth. I tried to swallow and found there was almost nothing left to swallow. My brother kept glancing at me sideways without breaking stride. I knew he was thirstier than I was and worrying about me more anyway.

Every time the wind blew, fine sand struck my face. It gathered at the corners of my eyes, between my lips, along the back of my neck. I rubbed at the grit with the back of my hand for a while, then gave up. It only settled again as soon as I brushed it away.

There was no sound but our own footsteps. No birds, no insects. I thought about how that quiet differed from Haven's quiet. Haven's had been a quiet with the sound erased out of it. This was simply a quiet that no one had made a sound in yet.

"…Are you all right?" he asked, again and again.

"…I'm all right," I answered every time. I wasn't, really. But looking at his face, the words came out on their own.

The dry bread Noa gave us was gone within a single day too. Chewing it, I thought of the perfect bread of Haven. This bread was hard and salty. And still, I liked it better. It was bread someone had made by giving up their own.

For the first time, I understood there were two ways hunger could be filled. Filled by having your case received. And filled by being shared with.

The crust scraped going down my throat. Even that roughness, strangely, was welcome. Swallowing hard bread with a dry throat wasn't an easy thing. But I didn't especially want to avoid that discomfort. For as long as I was eating that bread, it felt as though I were sitting by that fire again, with Noa and Rachel.

Even after the bread was gone, I kept turning the crumbs left on my hand over and over. It felt wasteful to let them go. In Haven, nothing had ever been anything to waste — if you needed more, you simply filed for it again. I was learning that feeling, wastefulness itself, all over again, here in the Wilderness.

"…Are you going to eat the crumbs too?" my brother asked. It wasn't teasing.

"…Yes," I said. "It's the last of the bread."

He laughed a little at that, then tipped his own last crumbs into his mouth too.

"…When Noa packed this for us," he said, "she'd taken it out of her own share. I saw that, and I took it anyway."

"…You were right to take it," I said. "If you hadn't, it would have hurt her more."

"…Is that so," my brother said.

He said nothing more for a long while after, just looking down at his own empty palm.

We walked on without speaking for a while after that. The sun was climbing higher. As I walked, I rolled Rachel's little pebble in my hand. The smooth feel of it against my palm was strangely calming.

Walking with that stone in my grip, I thought about how all we had left, on this journey, was this one pebble and the two papers in my brother's shirt. But strangely, the less we had, the larger each single thing seemed to grow.

Far off, heat shimmered up off the ground like a mirage. I kept narrowing my eyes, thinking I saw something beyond that wavering air. Every time, it turned out to be nothing but the bare horizon. I grew used, little by little, to seeing things that weren't there. The desert seemed to have a talent for showing a person what wasn't real.

. . .

On the afternoon of the third day, my brother stopped walking.

"…Look at that," he said, pointing at a few low, stunted trees. "There might be water somewhere like that."

I followed the trees with my eyes. They were a little greener than everything around them. I learned then, for the first time, that a difference in color alone could tell you something. In Haven, everything had been the same brightness, the same shade. Out here, the smallest difference in color could mean the difference between living and not.

From then on, as we walked, I kept scanning the horizon. Whenever I caught even the faintest hint of a different green, I stopped. Most of the time it turned out to be nothing. But I found I didn't even mind those false alarms. Opening my eyes wide, straining to find something, was itself a new sensation.

We went over. There really was a small pool. Muddy water. Not clear.

There was shade under the trees. We sat there for a while. My body, baked all day in the sun, slowly cooled. I hadn't known until then how welcome that coolness could feel. In Haven, shade had never been necessary — wherever you went, the temperature was always just right.

"…So this is what shade feels like," I murmured.

My brother huffed a laugh at that.

"…You keep saying things like that lately," he said. "That the things we took for granted weren't actually a given."

"…Yes," I said. "I feel like I'm learning it all over again, every day."

"…Is it all right to drink?" I asked.

My brother looked at the water for a long while.

"…If we were in Haven, the Ledger would already have filtered it for us," he said. "Here, no one filters it for you. We have to do it ourselves."

I listened to that, watching him filter the water through the hem of his shirt. It wasn't perfect. Still, when I drank it, I felt, in every part of my body, the sensation of being alive.

He dipped the cloth in the water and wrung it out again and again, several times over. His hands turned the color of the earth. Watching them, I felt my brother was becoming someone who could do things for himself. In Brick Hollow he had carried bricks because he was told to. In Haven he had filed things because the Ledger told him to. Now he was doing something no one had told him to do at all.

The water smelled of earth. It left a rough feeling going down my throat. But strangely, even that roughness was welcome. Haven's water had never tasted like anything at all. This water had a taste. A bad one, but the fact that it had any taste at all was, to me, an entirely new thing.

He filtered my share before he filtered his own. The second straining came out a little clearer than the first. He gave me the clearer one.

"…Filter yours clear too," I said.

"…I already drank some earlier," he said.

It was a lie. I had seen him not drink a single mouthful. But I didn't call it out. Some lies, I understood then, take back what a person just gave you, the moment you point them out.

He folded the cloth back up and said.

"…Good thing we learned this one. Next time we find a puddle like this, we'll know what to do."

I could hear in that how he'd started treating this road as a time of learning. When we were running, there had been no room for that kind of ease. Now there was.

We rested beside the pool a while longer. Looking up at the sky, my brother said.

"…In Haven, I never even thought about being thirsty. The moment I thought it, the water was already there."

"…Was that a bad thing?" I asked.

"…It wasn't bad," he said. "But this one mouthful of water right now feels so much bigger than that perfect water ever did."

. . .

That night, my brother spoke up suddenly by the fire.

"…I've been having a strange thought lately."

"…What is it?"

"…When we were in Haven, everything was perfect. But I feel like I was more dead back then. Now everything's short of enough… but I feel more alive."

Hearing that, I felt my brother changing, little by little. He was still angry. But something else was growing underneath that anger.

I couldn't put an exact name to what was growing there, under the anger. It was still too small to be called hope. But it wasn't only anger, either. I thought it might be another face of his questioning. He was still asking "why." But that "why" seemed to be turning, little by little, from a why aimed at blaming someone, into a why that simply wanted to know.

"…Is that a good thing?" I asked.

"…I don't know," he said. "But I don't hate it."

The fire burned low. I sat quietly, looking at my brother's face lit by that light. In Brick Hollow, his face had always looked like it was enduring something. In Haven, it had looked like it was doubting something. Now it was neither. It was just my brother's face, sitting there as itself.

"…Elpis," he said suddenly. "Aren't you scared? Going toward some place we don't even know what it is."

"…I'm scared," I said honestly. "But it's better than not looking for anything at all."

My brother nodded at that. He didn't say anything else. I found the silence comfortable.

The fire was dwindling. I pushed the last piece of wood into it. The flame leapt up briefly, then settled low again. Watching that small flicker, I thought

our journey, too, was moving forward in flickers like that. Flaring high, sinking low, and never quite going out.

The sky was full of stars. Looking at them, I found myself wondering, out of nowhere — had those same stars been above Haven's sky too? I couldn't remember at all. While we were in that city, there had never been a reason to look up. Everything was resolved below, right at our feet.

The stars looked countable at first, but the moment I tried, there only seemed to be more of them. I gave up counting and simply looked. Looking needed no reason at all.

That was the first time I understood that a person needs, sometimes, to spend a long while looking at something utterly useless. The Ledger could never have filed a time like that. There had been no problem in it to resolve.

"…Brother," I said.

"…Yeah?"

"…I think this is the first time I've ever looked at the stars. Like this, this long."

He looked up at the sky with me.

"…Me too," he said. "It's strange. We slept under that same night sky every night in Brick Hollow."

"…Maybe we didn't have the strength to look, back then," I said.

He only nodded at that, saying nothing more.

I would come to remember that night for a very long time. The night I gave up counting the stars, and simply looking was enough. I didn't know then that the

time spent looking long at something for no reason at all was the very first thing that city had ever taken from us.

. . .

On the morning of the fourth day, a low hill appeared far off on the horizon. Something seemed to be standing on top of it. It was too far to see exactly what.

"…Could that be the well?" I asked.

"…I don't know," he said. "But we won't know until we get there."

We started walking toward the hill again. Our feet ached and our throats were still a little dry. But that morning, for the first time since leaving Brick Hollow, I felt that we were "going toward" somewhere. Not running away. Going.

Our steps picked up. I could feel my brother's pace quicken along with mine. The thing on the hill was still only a blur, but neither of us could tear our eyes away from it.

"…What if it's nothing at all?" I asked. The worry slipped out before I could stop it.

"…Then we walk some more," my brother said. There was no wavering in his voice. "We've been walking this whole way anyway."

That answer put my mind at ease. My brother was speaking now like someone no longer clinging to the outcome.

I wrote his words down separately, in my heart, right then. If it's nothing, we just walk some more. I knew that a sentence like that could never have come

out of him back in Brick Hollow. There, walking itself had already been a punishment.

The closer we got to the hill, the clearer the shape became. Something like the outline of a stone wall came into view. I kept walking without being certain what it was. Walking without certainty — that, too, was something I learned for the first time that day.

My legs had gone nearly numb by then. But strangely, my steps seemed to be growing lighter, not heavier. I thought it was because my heart, not my body, had already arrived at that hill. My brother was matching my pace, step for step. Neither of us bothered asking the other "are you all right" anymore. In that moment, both of us were, in fact, all right.

The wind shifted slightly. In it I caught the faintest trace of moisture. The smell of water. A smell we hadn't caught once in three whole days. That smell alone was enough to bring tears to my eyes. Until then I hadn't known the smell of water could be caught so clearly.

I set that difference down as the last sentence of this chapter. Running looks behind. Going forward looks ahead. That day, I understood that we were, for the first time, walking with our eyes forward.

(Continued in Chapter 18.)

Chapter 18. The Well-Keeper

> *_Previously_ — On the fourth day of searching for the well, with their water and bread gone, the brother and sister began walking toward the hill on the horizon. For the first time, they felt the sense of going forward rather than running away.*

What stood on the hill really was a well.

A small well ringed by a low stone wall. Someone sat beside it. A young man. He looked a little older than us.

The last few steps up the hill were the hardest. There was no strength left at all in my legs, and still, from the moment the well came into view, I couldn't stop walking. My brother was the same. We climbed the last stretch of that hill almost at a run.

Low grass grew here and there around it. A clearly greener shade than anywhere else. Just that color of grass alone told me this place was different from everywhere around it.

A small insect lifted off from among the grass and settled again. Even that small movement caught my eye. Along the whole four days of dry road behind us, I'd barely seen so much as a single bug. This one hill alone seemed strangely full of life.

I felt something strange then. The well stood alone in the middle of the Wilderness, in a place with nothing around it. And yet the stone wall alone was clean, as if someone tended it every single day.

A few small wildflowers bloomed in cracks between the stones of the wall. I wondered whether someone had planted them, or whether they'd grown up on their own. Either way, the fact that something alive had taken root on this bare hilltop was, strangely, a comfort.

On legs that had walked four days, we arrived, more collapsing than sitting down before it. My brother looked like he had no strength left even to speak. I could feel the man's eyes reading our condition in a single glance.

He rose to his feet at once and came toward us. His steps were quick. But even in that quickness I could feel something careful in him — like someone worried that if he came too fast, we might vanish like a mirage.

"…Sit," he said first. "Drink water before you talk."

His voice was low and calm. There was no hurry in it at all. I found that calm strangely foreign. Everyone we'd met since coming out into the Wilderness had carried some measure of urgency. This man alone did not.

Beside where he'd been sitting, a small heap of stones was stacked with care. I couldn't guess what it was for. But I could tell those stones hadn't been set down carelessly. They'd been stacked in order of size, very deliberately.

Beside the stone heap, a few worn wooden bowls sat overturned to dry. Not one bowl — several. I understood they'd been set out for more than one person. Bowls turned over and set to dry, every day, for guests who never came.

One bowl was noticeably smaller than the rest. I knew at a glance it was made for a child. I didn't know who it was for. But that one small bowl alone seemed to say more than the whole careful order of the hilltop around it.

. . .

The man looked us over first. He wasn't surprised.

"…It's been a while since anyone came by," he said. "Here for water?"

"…Yes," my brother said. His throat was parched.

The man stood and looked us over once more. Worn clothes, cracked lips, feet caked in dust. It wasn't a judging look. Just a careful one.

"…You've come a long way," he said. "Which way did you come from?"

"…From a tent camp," my brother said. "The one where a woman named Noa lives."

Something flickered faintly in the man's eyes at that name.

"…You know Noa?" my brother asked.

"…I've heard word of her," the man said. "Never met her myself. But I've heard she's a good person."

"…We walked four days," I said.

"…Four days." The man repeated it back, something turning over behind his eyes. "Walking this direction four days means you had a reason for it."

The man lowered a bucket and drew up water for us. It was clear. Not muddy.

"…Why is this one so clear?" I asked.

"…This well is deep," the man said. "Water that comes from deep down is always clear."

Drinking that water, I thought his words weren't only about the water. I didn't know exactly why I felt that.

The bucket knocked against the wall of the well as it rose. A hollow, resonant sound, twice over. I felt that sound had been keeping this place company for a very long time. The way he wound the rope back up looked practiced — the motion of something repeated more times than could be counted, plain in the shape of his fingers.

The water was cool, and just faintly sweet. I had never drunk water like it. Not the muddy water, and not Haven's flavorless water either. I looked back down into the bucket. It was too deep to see the bottom.

I felt the coolness spread through my whole body as it went down my throat. I closed my eyes and gave myself over entirely to that feeling. Four days of gathered thirst seemed to wash away all at once. I could feel warm blood returning even to my fingertips.

"…Drink slowly," the man said. "Drink too fast and you'll make yourself sick."

Only hearing that did I realize how frantically I'd been gulping it down. I forced myself to slow. My brother slowed to match me.

"…I've seen a lot of children drink like that," he said. "Everyone's the same, the moment they get here. They're afraid the water's going to run out."

"…Does it?" I asked.

"…It doesn't," he said. "This well has never once gone dry. But believing that takes a little time."

I remembered those words a long while after. That believing something won't run dry takes time. I understood then that everything we'd learned in Haven had, in the end, been the opposite of that. In that city, everything was filled the instant you wanted it — but nothing could ever be believed in.

"…How deep is it?" I asked.

"…I've never measured it all the way down myself," the man said. "But I know it's very deep."

I watched his hand lower the bucket back down into the well. The sound of the rope unspooling went on and on. Just from the length of that sound alone, I could guess how deep this well must be. By the time I heard the bucket touch water, I had almost started counting my own breaths.

My brother drank too, and seemed for the first time to breathe properly.

"…Thank you," he said. There was real feeling in his voice. It was the first time, outside that city, I'd heard him say that to anyone.

Speon looked briefly startled at that, as if he'd been handed something enormous.

"…It's just a bowl of water," he said. But his voice sounded genuinely glad.

"…It doesn't look like many people come here," I said.

"…Almost none," Speon said. "Once every few months, or rarer than that. So when someone comes, I'm glad. And a little afraid, too."

"…Why afraid?" I asked.

"…In case it's nothing again," Speon said quietly. In that, I could feel that he greeted every visitor already hoping for something.

"…What kind of news?" I asked.

Speon chose his words a moment, then shook his head.

"…I'll tell you that later," he said. "Right now I'm more curious how you two ended up here."

I didn't press him further. But in that brief hesitation, I could feel that some very old story was waiting inside him.

. . .

When my brother finished drinking, he asked carefully.

"…Is this… the well people say the completed go to?"

The man's expression changed at that. He looked startled.

"…Where did you hear that?" he asked.

"…From people in the Wilderness," my brother said. "And about the ones stamped COMPLETE, too."

"…Who told you this?" the man asked again. There was urgency in his voice now.

"…An old man at a tent camp," my brother said. "And someone named Noa, too. We don't know the details, but they said the story's been around a long time."

The man looked at the worn paper in my brother's hand. He looked at it for a long time.

"…Would you show me that paper?"

My brother handed it over. The man read the name, and ran his fingertip over the stamp.

In that moment, I saw something in the man's face come apart. It was too complicated an expression to call sorrow alone.

I haven't forgotten that expression. Relief and dread crossed it at the very same instant. It was the face of someone who had waited a very long time for something to finally arrive, and at the same moment had hoped it never would.

His fingertip paused for a moment over the stamp. I saw it tremble slightly. It was the hand of someone touching, again, a very old wound.

"…This name — I don't know this person," he said quietly. "But this stamp… I know this stamp. I know it very well."

"…How do you know it?" my brother asked.

Instead of answering, he looked off into the distance. He said nothing for a long time.

I could see, in that silence, the faintest tremor in his eyes. The eyes of someone holding words back. I understood then that this man, too, was carrying a great deal that he had not yet found a way to say.

While the silence held, I looked around the well. There were small marks scored into one side of the stone wall — nicks someone had cut in, over and over, for a long time. Numbers, or a tally of some kind. I couldn't tell which.

"…What's that?" I asked, pointing at the wall.

The man seemed to come back to himself, and looked over.

"…Days," he said. "I was counting how many I'd spent here. I started counting, and then I stopped. There got to be too many."

I tried, for a moment, to count those marks with my fingertip, and gave up. There truly were too many to count. That number frightened me. Those marks

were telling me that the length of time this man had spent here was an entirely different kind of time than the four days we had walked to reach him.

In that moment I thought of Haven's COMPLETE stamp. Time that ended with a single stamp, and time that could only pass by being scored, one mark at a time, into stone. I think I already knew, even then, which of the two was the truer kind of time.

Some of the marks were cut deep; some were barely there at all. I thought that difference in depth must have left behind, exactly, whatever mood each of those days had carried. What had happened on the days cut deep? I couldn't bring myself to ask.

. . .

"…My name is Speon," the man finally said. "People say I'm the one who keeps this well. Though to be exact… it isn't keeping. It's waiting."

"…Speon," I said, saying the name back. An unfamiliar name. But it settled onto my tongue strangely easily.

"…That's right," he said, smiling a little. "Just call me that. It's been a while since anyone's said my name here."

"…No one says it?" I asked.

"…There has to be someone to say it," Speon said. A trace of loneliness crept into his voice. "Even the ones who come by, once every few months, often don't ask my name at all. Everyone just drinks the water and hurries off."

Hearing that hurt something in me. I tried to imagine how long Speon must have gone here, beside this well, with no one to call him by name at all.

As he said it, he glanced back toward the well. It looked like an old habit. I noticed that even in the middle of talking, he kept checking on it out of the corner of his eye, as if something might rise up out of it at any moment.

"…Waiting for what?" I asked.

The wind swept across the well's edge. His clothes, caught on the rim of the stone, stirred faintly. In that brief silence, I felt that it had been a very long time since anyone had asked Speon that question.

Speon looked at us for a long time. His face was that of someone making up his mind about something.

"…To answer that question, it'll be a long story," Speon said. "Rest here tonight, and tomorrow I'll tell you everything I know. It's been… a very long time since anyone came here carrying that question."

Speon stood and walked a slow circle around the well's edge. It was the walk of someone confirming something. I guessed it was a round he made every night, something like a watch. No one had ordered it of him — it looked more like a rule he'd set for himself.

"…Do you go around like this every night?" my brother asked.

"…Yes," Speon said. "It's a habit. I can't sleep until I've made sure nothing's wrong."

"…And tonight?" I asked.

Speon stopped at that question and looked at us for a moment.

"…Tonight, something happened," he said. "You two came."

Speon came back and sat down beside us again. Then, after a moment, he got up once more and brought back two blankets. Worn, but clean.

"…Bear with it if it's uncomfortable," Speon said. "There's no guest room out here."

"…This is more than enough," my brother said. "Better than Haven's beds."

He set a small stone down beside our spot. I almost asked what it was for, then decided not to. Probably something to keep insects away overnight. That small, ordinary care lodged itself in me strangely.

Speon smiled a little at that. It was the first smile I'd seen from him.

"…So you're children who know Haven," he said. "That'll make this easier to explain."

The blankets smelled of sunlight — the smell of something dried a long time in the open air. Underneath that smell was a faint trace of earth. Breathing it in, I thought about how many times Speon must have hung these blankets out and taken them back in, for guests who never came.

A night wind blew across the well and lifted the edge of the blanket faintly. I didn't try to escape the chill of it. That coolness, arriving after the day's heat, felt like the last word of goodnight to the day.

Lying under that blanket, I still couldn't fall asleep for a long while. From the well's direction I thought I heard the faint sound of water moving, low. Maybe it was only my imagination. But listening to it, I thought this well seemed almost as if it were alive, breathing on its own.

Beside me, my brother's breathing settled into an even rhythm. I could tell he was sleeping properly for the first time in days. A little way off, Speon was still sitting up. Not lying down — facing the well. I watched his back for a while before I finally fell asleep.

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That night, for the first time, I felt that we were drawing close to a real answer. But strangely, that feeling was closer to fear than to joy.

(Continued in Chapter 19.)

Chapter 19. Those Who Lost Their Names

> *_Previously_ — After four days of travel, the brother and sister found the well. A man named Speon, who kept it, was deeply shaken by the paper stamped COMPLETE. "I know this stamp," he said. He promised to tell them everything he knew the following night.*

The next night, Speon began to speak by the fire.

The fire burned low. Speon studied it for a long while before he opened his mouth. I could tell he was choosing his words — the face of someone who had spent the whole day thinking about where to begin.

I remember my brother standing there that night, unable even to sit down. I thought then that he was ready to hear it. Looking back now, I don't think anyone can ever really be ready for a story like that one.

The night air was growing cold. I sat with a blanket around my shoulders, watching only Speon's mouth. His lips opened and closed several times before any words came. Watching that hesitation, I braced myself in advance for how heavy this story would be.

From the well came the faintest sound of water moving. I hadn't known, until I heard it, that the well made any sound at all.

Speon held a hand out near the fire, then drew it back. He did this several times. I understood it wasn't the cold. It was the gesture of someone who didn't know where else to put his hands.

"…This well is connected to the Completion Houses in the cities," Speon said. "I don't know exactly how it's connected. But some of the people who are

completed — they come up out of the bottom of this well."

My breath stopped the moment I heard that. I understood at once — if that were true, it meant Father might not be dead at all.

My heart was beating so fast in that moment that everything else seemed to go silent. My brother's voice, Speon's voice — they both sounded as if they were coming from somewhere far away. I only barely held on to my own attention and forced myself back to the words.

My brother shot to his feet right there.

"…Are you sure?" he asked. "They really come out alive?"

"…Every one I've seen with my own eyes, yes," Speon said. "Not many. But every one of them was alive."

My brother's hands were shaking. It was the first time I'd seen them shake.

I wanted to take that hand in mine. But I couldn't bring myself to reach for it. In that moment my brother looked like someone who needed no comfort from anyone — only Speon's next words.

Instead, I gripped my own knees tight enough that my fingertips went numb. I had to bear the moment somehow, even like that. I hadn't known that the words "Father might be alive" could make my whole body shake this much.

An ember popped somewhere in the fire. I flinched even at that small sound. The night was that quiet, and all of us were strung that taut.

Speon watched him a moment, then motioned for him to sit back down.

"…Sit and listen," Speon said. "If your legs give out, you won't hear the rest of this either way."

Only then did my brother sit. I saw that his knees were still trembling.

. . .

"…They come out? Alive?" my brother asked. His voice trembled.

"…Yes, alive," Speon said. "But not whole."

"…What do you mean?"

My brother asked it again. I had a feeling he would ask it a second time, and a third. It wasn't an answer a person could take in all at once.

Speon closed his eyes for a moment.

"…They come out having lost their name," Speon said. "And along with it, they lose who they loved. The most painful memory is erased, and along with it, it seems, the names and faces bound up in that memory disappear too."

Hearing that, I thought of the old woman at the flowerbed. That blurred place where she had forgotten her daughter's name but "having loved her" alone remained. For the first time, I understood that the two things worked by the same principle. Haven's "resolving" and the Completion House's "completing" only differed in degree — they were looking in the same direction.

I looked at my brother's face in that moment. He seemed to have already understood it before I had. He was biting down hard on his lip. I didn't need to ask what he was thinking — I already knew. That even if Father was alive, he might not know us at all.

"…So nothing at all is left?" I asked. My voice had gone small.

"…I said something is left," Speon said. "It isn't erased completely. But what that something is differs from person to person. For some it's a habit of the hands. For some it's a line of a song they liked."

"…How do you know what's left?" my brother asked.

"…You only find out by watching them, after they come out," Speon said. "That's why I'm here. To watch."

"…So where do they go?" I asked. "After they come out here."

"…Not right away," Speon said. "They sit here a few days first. Then one day they just stand up and walk off. Even they don't know where they're going."

"…Don't you try to stop them?" I asked.

"…I can't," Speon said. "I have no reason I can give them to stay. I don't know their names, and they never ask mine."

I thought that was the saddest thing said at this well. Speon was a man who waited for people. And even the people he waited for, and finally met, only ever passed him by.

"…How long does it take? For them to come out. After they're completed."

"…That differs too," Speon said. "Some come out within days. Some take months. I don't know the exact rule myself."

"…How long has it been, since Father was completed?" I asked.

"…I'd think you two would know that better than me," Speon said carefully.

My brother thought for a moment before he answered.

"…Almost two months," my brother said. His voice cracked.

That was when I understood that my brother had been counting the days. I had never once counted. I was afraid that if I counted, the number would only keep growing. My brother had done the opposite. He had been holding on to that growing number, every single day.

Speon heard the number and closed his eyes for a moment.

"…Then he might already be out," he said. "Or he might not be, yet. I'm sorry I can't tell you anything certain."

"…What are people like, the first time they come out?" I asked. "Aren't they afraid?"

"…They're afraid," Speon said. "They don't know who they are, or why they came up out of the water. But strangely, at first, they're all quiet. They don't even cry. They just sit still and look around."

"…Why don't they cry?" I asked.

"…To cry, you have to know you've lost something," Speon said. "But those people don't even know what they've lost. So there's no way for them to cry."

Hearing that, I felt a chill run over my skin. I understood then, for the first time, that forgetting wasn't only a sad thing — it was a thing that made you unable to even grieve.

"…So does a day come when they cry again?" I asked.

"…It does," Speon said. "But not because they remember something again. It's because they come to cherish something new. And once they grow afraid of losing that — that's the first time they cry again."

Hearing that put me strangely at ease. It seemed to mean that a road existed that wasn't about getting back what was lost, but about building something new to cherish.

Listening to him, I felt my fingertips go cold. That was the first time I understood exactly what Haven's "resolving" took from a person. It didn't erase sorrow — it erased the very right to grieve. I thought that was a far more frightening thing to lose.

. . .

"…So could our father come out somewhere here too?" I asked.

"…He could," Speon said. "But it might not be this well. Each Completion House seems to connect to a different well. I only know this one."

"…Then how many wells are there?"

"…I don't know," Speon said. "I'm still looking too."

I could feel, in that answer, that Speon had been doing this for a long time. And that even after all that time, he still hadn't found every answer.

In that moment I felt, for real, that this world was far larger than we'd imagined. In Brick Hollow the whole world had been the brick kilns and the taskmasters. In Haven I'd believed the world ended at that city's boundary stones. But now I understood that this world might hold more wells than could ever be counted.

People usually say a wide world sounds like hope. But that night, to me, it sounded like the opposite. A wide world also meant there were that many more places where I might lose Father for good.

"…Does every one of these wells have someone keeping it, the way you do?" I asked.

"…I don't know," Speon said. "I've heard that some wells are just left, with no one at all. Someone who comes out of a well like that… truly meets no one, and just wanders alone."

Hearing that gave me a chill. I felt my heart clench again, thinking that Father might have come out of a well exactly like that.

"…Then we'll have to hurry even more," my brother said. There was urgency in his voice.

"…Hurrying is fine," Speon said carefully. "But take care of yourselves first. Set out exhausted, and you'll only be slower in the end."

"…Then we'll have to find the other wells too," my brother said. His voice already sounded decided.

"…It won't be easy," Speon said. "This world is wide, and the wells are hidden. It took me years just to come to keep this one."

"…We'll do it anyway," my brother said.

There was no wavering in his voice. Beside him I felt that steadiness, and at the same time accepted that this journey might turn out to be far longer than we'd thought. When we left Brick Hollow, I'd believed it would be over in a matter of days. Now, for the first time, it occurred to me that it might take years.

Speon looked at my brother a long time after that answer. I felt something like pity in that look, and something a little larger than pity — a kind of respect.

"…I made a decision like that once too, when I was your age," Speon said quietly. "It didn't turn out well, back then. But that doesn't mean the decision itself was wrong."

"…What happened?" my brother asked.

Speon shook his head.

"…That's for later," he said. "Your story comes first, right now."

. . .

"…Why do you do this?" my brother asked. "What does it have to do with you?"

Speon was quiet for a long time.

"…I once made someone else wait, a long time ago," he said finally. "Back then, I couldn't wait, and I handed someone else over instead. Waiting here, at this well, now… it's doing the thing I couldn't do then."

I didn't fully understand what he meant. But seeing my brother offer no argument at all to that, I knew there was something heavy and true in it.

The firelight covered half of Speon's face in shadow. I wondered what might be sitting there, in that shadowed half. Even from the other half alone, I could tell he was someone who had blamed himself for a very long time.

I understood then, all over again, that Speon had reached this spot far, far before us. We thought we'd walked four days. Speon had not moved an inch from this place in years. I could only guess, then, at what kind of walking that was.

I found myself wondering which was harder — walking, or staying. Walking wore out the body. But staying meant bearing, every single day in the same spot, a different weight of heart each time. I couldn't reach an answer, not that night.

The fire had burned down low. Speon fed in another branch. The flame caught again and lit his face. For the first time, I really saw the old exhaustion that had settled into it.

"…What does 'handed someone else over' mean?" I asked carefully.

Speon looked at me. He didn't answer. But the silence said more than an answer would have. I decided not to press further.

I learned later that some stories have to wait until the person telling them is ready. And that waiting, itself, is already a way of giving that person something.

My brother changed the subject, as if to honor that silence.

"…So are you still looking for that person? The one you say you handed over?"

Speon shook his head.

"…No," he said. "That person is somewhere else now. I'm only repaying that debt a different way. I can't repay it to them, so I repay it to the people who come here instead."

Speon went on.

"…I've told you everything I know. But there's one more thing. The people who come out here — even having lost their name, they don't become an entirely new person. Something remains. I help them hold on to what remains."

The fire kept sinking lower. No one spoke again. In that silence I felt my brother settling something inside himself. His eyes weren't on Speon anymore — they were on the distant horizon.

That night, lying down to sleep, I couldn't close my eyes. I could hear my brother tossing beside me too. The sky was full of stars. Looking up at them, I thought of Father — sitting somewhere, perhaps, without a name. Was he looking at these same stars right now? And if he was, did he even know they were stars?

My brother's breathing had already settled into a steady rhythm somewhere along the way. I found it strange that he could fall asleep even now, body worn out and heart so heavy. Watching that, I thought people must be made, somehow, to go on living even inside their sorrow.

I found one star shining unusually bright and looked at it a long while. It didn't move. Only once I'd confirmed it was a real star did I feel a little at ease. I prayed silently that the quiet light wouldn't come, not tonight.

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. That night I learned, all at once, that Father might be alive somewhere, and that he might not remember us at all. I didn't know then which of the two was harder to bear.

(Continued in Chapter 20.)

Chapter 20. The One Who Was Already There

> *_Previously_ — Speon revealed the truth of the Completion House. A completed person comes out alive through a well, but loses their name and the faces of those they loved along with their most painful memory. Hope that Father might be alive, and terror that he might not remember them, arrived together.*

That night I barely slept.

I lay under my blanket, but my eyes kept opening. I could hear the wind striking the stone wall beside the well — a sound I hadn't heard in daylight. Listening to it, I thought that this well wore a different face at night.

I turned onto my side and looked toward the well. In the dark I could just make out the faint outline of the stone wall. My eyes kept drifting to it, at the thought that Father might really be somewhere inside it. It would have been another well, not this one, of course — but even so, looking at this well, I found myself thinking of him.

Neither did my brother. I heard him fold and unfold that paper, over and over, all through the night.

The paper had gone thin along every crease. Just from the sound alone, I felt I could tell exactly which fold he was touching. That short rustle went on, at a steady interval, all through the night. I thought it sounded like my brother's own heartbeat.

I understood then that we were afraid of the same thing, but afraid of it differently. My brother was afraid of not finding Father. I was afraid we would

find him and he wouldn't know us.

Somewhere off, a night bird cried once, briefly. When it stopped, the silence closed back in, complete. In that silence I felt as though my brother and I were the only two awake in the whole world — as if, while everyone else slept, only the two of us were holding on to the same fear, each in our own way.

I closed my eyes and tried to picture Father's face. Strangely, it wouldn't come clearly. I remembered the shape of his eyes, but the shape of his nose had gone blurry. That blurring frightened me all at once. Were we already starting to forget him too? I pushed the thought away quickly.

After a long time turning restlessly, I opened my eyes a little and looked over at my brother. He was sitting in the moonlight with the paper spread on his knee. He didn't seem to be reading the letters on it. He was just running his fingertips over it, again and again. I thought that gesture looked like someone touching Father's face.

Toward dawn, my brother spoke quietly.

"…Elpis, if we find him and he doesn't recognize us… will you still stay beside him?"

I couldn't answer right away. Only after thinking for a long time did I speak.

"…Yes," I said. "We can just tell him his name again. Even if it takes time."

At that, my brother let out a breath of relief for the first time.

"…Thank you," he said. That was all. But I could feel that those two words carried far more than themselves.

He reached over and gave my head a brief stroke. It was an awkward gesture. He'd never been someone who was good at that kind of thing. But in that

moment, it came naturally. I felt, in that touch, that he was making a promise — to me, and probably to himself as well.

"…Brother," I said, quietly.

"…Yeah."

"…Can I ask you something too?"

"…Go ahead."

"…If we never find him," I said, "will you keep looking anyway?"

He said nothing for a long while. I thought he'd fallen asleep.

"…Yes," he finally said. "There's nothing else I know how to do."

That answer was sad, and yet strangely reassuring. My brother wasn't searching because of hope. He was searching because he knew no other way to go on living. I didn't know, then, that this too was a kind of hope.

After that we lay side by side without speaking anymore. The sky was slowly growing lighter. Watching that dawn light, I felt afraid of what else this night might teach us, once it ended.

. . .

In the morning, Speon asked.

He had gotten up before us and was building the fire back up. There was practice in the way he warmed water and set breakfast out for us. I tried to guess how many mornings like this he must have repeated, and gave up. It was a number beyond counting.

The morning air was cold. I felt the stiffness in my body as I threw off the blanket and stood — proof that I'd slept on hard ground. And yet, strangely, I had slept deeply. I thought I might even have slept more deeply than I ever had in Haven's soft beds.

I felt again, in that moment, that comfort of the body and comfort of the heart didn't always travel together. On that hard ground, I had heard news about Father, and had my first real conversation with my brother. Not one of Haven's beds could have ever given me a night like that.

"…What will you do now?"

"…We need to find another well," my brother said. "Do you know of one?"

"…I've heard of a few," Speon said. "But I haven't been able to check them all. I can't leave this place empty for long."

"…Why not?"

"…Because someone might come out while I'm gone," Speon said. "That person comes out remembering nothing at all. If no one's here then… they'll just wander this Wilderness alone."

Hearing that, I understood why Speon had kept this place so long. He wasn't looking for his own father. And still, he waited for someone every single day.

I thought that reason might, in its own way, be harder than searching for our own father. Searching for Father gave us a clear purpose. Speon had no purpose like that at all. He had only this — that someone had to be there.

"…So does that mean you can't leave even for a day?" I asked.

"…I can leave for a few days," Speon said. "But not long. If someone comes out and there's no one here, they don't even know where they are, and they end up wandering alone until they're lost. That's what I'm most afraid of."

"…Have you seen someone like that?" my brother asked.

Speon nodded. He said nothing more. I decided not to ask what memory that silence was holding.

His eyes seemed, for a moment, to be looking at something very far away. I felt, in that instant, that Speon was standing here in front of us and, at the same time, somewhere else entirely — some other time, some other place. Memory seemed able to put a person in two places at once, like that.

As if to change the subject, Speon got up and walked toward the well. He lowered the bucket again as he spoke.

"…So a day became two days, and two days became a month, and that's how I ended up staying here. At first I only meant to stay a little while."

"…How long has it been?" I asked.

Speon started to count on his fingers, then gave it up.

"…If it were something I could count, it wouldn't have felt this long," he said.

The dull thud of the bucket striking water rose up from far below. Speon waited for that sound before he began winding the rope back in. I noticed that even though he could probably have done it without waiting to hear it, he chose to wait anyway.

"…I feel like you'd know without listening for it," my brother said.

"…I do know," Speon said. "But I listen anyway. If I wind it in without listening, it just becomes a chore."

I thought about that a long while. Speon was working, every day, not to let anything he did at this well become merely a chore. The same bucket, the same

rope, the same water, every single day. And every single time, he listened for that sound as if it were the first.

. . .

"…So does that mean you never find anyone?" I asked. "If you only ever stay here?"

Speon smiled a little. A lonely smile.

"…I already found the person I was looking for," he said. "Now my work is helping other people find what they're looking for."

I didn't know exactly what he meant. But something in the way he said it told me Speon had once been like us.

I looked at Speon's hand. It was the hand holding the bucket's rope. There was an old scar on the back of it. I wondered where it had come from. Like the scar on my own hand from Brick Hollow, I thought it must be carrying some story of its own.

Speon took a sip of water. The morning sun fell across the side of his face. I tried to guess his age from that face and failed. In some moments he looked young. In others, he looked like someone who had lived far longer than that.

"…Did you used to look for someone too?" I asked.

"…No," Speon said. "I didn't go looking. If anything, I ran. Because waiting frightened me. So now I'm learning how to wait."

"…Is waiting something you have to learn?" I asked. It seemed like an odd question, but I was genuinely curious.

"…Yes," Speon said. "I thought waiting just meant staying still. But it isn't that. Waiting is something you have to decide to do again, every single day. Waiting yesterday doesn't mean you'll wait today, on its own."

I didn't understand that exactly, either. But I saw my brother go silent at those words and look at Speon for a long time.

I felt, in that silence, that my brother was asking himself something. He had always been someone who moved forward. Waiting must have been a foreign idea to him. That day, for the first time, I watched him handling that foreign idea carefully, turning it over.

I felt, in that moment, that something was passing between my brother and Speon that I didn't know. Both of them had once run. One had stayed here, learning how to wait. The other was only just beginning to walk.

"…Do you regret running?" my brother asked suddenly.

Speon paused a moment at the question.

"…I don't regret it," he said slowly. "But I do think I should have stopped sooner. Running becomes a habit at some point. You keep running even when there's no reason left to."

My brother turned that answer over for a long time. I could tell he was hearing it as if it were about himself.

"…You ran too, though," I said carefully. "From Brick Hollow."

He looked at me. He looked startled.

"…That's true," he said slowly. "But I always thought that wasn't running away. I thought it was going toward something."

"…Do you still think that?" I asked.

He was quiet a long while before he answered.

"…I don't know," he admitted. "Maybe it was both."

Speon, listening to that exchange, spoke quietly.

"…Running and going forward start out as the exact same step," he said. "What tells them apart comes later — the moment you decide whether to keep taking that step, or to stop."

"…Then I still haven't decided," my brother said.

"…It's all right to take time deciding," Speon said. "It took me far longer than it's taking you."

Listening to that exchange, I felt that Speon wasn't trying to give my brother an answer — he was only standing beside him. I thought it was something like what Noa had done for us. The people of this Wilderness all seemed to treat each other this way. Not with answers, but by giving up their own side to stand beside you.

. . .

As he prepared to leave, my brother asked.

"…Have you ever seen a strange man around here? Working at a flowerbed, or… somewhere no one planted anything."

Speon stopped walking at that.

I saw his back go slightly rigid in that instant. The hand packing his bag had stopped too.

"…What does he look like?" Speon asked. His voice had changed.

My brother described him. Worn clothes, soil-stained hands, the habit of never giving his name.

Speon was quiet for a long time.

"…I've seen him too," he said. "Here, and elsewhere. But every time, I thought it was just coincidence."

"…When did you see him?" my brother asked.

"…The first time was a very long time ago," Speon said. "Back then I thought he was just a passing traveler. Then again before I came here, somewhere else. And here, a few times as well."

Listening, I felt a strange chill run down my spine. Until then I'd thought of the man at the flowerbed only as a stranger we'd happened to cross paths with. But looking at Speon's face, I understood it went further than that.

"…Do you know his name?" my brother asked.

"…No," Speon said. "I asked once. But he never answered. He just smiled."

That question felt strangely familiar to me. I felt as though I'd brushed past a smile like that somewhere before — in Brick Hollow, inside Haven, even somewhere along this road here. I couldn't remember exactly where.

"…What kind of smile was it?" I asked.

Speon thought for a moment.

"…Sad, and gentle, all at once," he said. "It's hard to explain. You'd have to see it yourself to understand."

Hearing that, I tried to picture the smiling face of the man at the flowerbed. I couldn't remember it exactly. But the moment Speon said it, something in me

stirred with a strange familiarity.

"…What did he do?" I asked.

"…Nothing at all," Speon said. "He just was there. But strangely, wherever he'd been, something always looked different afterward."

"…What kind of different?" I asked.

Speon looked toward the well.

"…Once, I'd already packed everything to leave this place," he said. "That day, he came by and asked for a cup of water and drank it, and left. He said nothing at all. But after he'd gone, I found myself unpacking everything I'd just packed."

"…Why?" my brother asked.

"…I don't know," Speon said. "That's the strangest part of it."

My brother stood there a long while even after his pack was ready. I could see he wanted to ask more and was holding himself back. It was probably about the man at the flowerbed. But looking at Speon's face, he seemed to decide not to press it further.

Before we left that place, I looked once more at Speon's face. He had already returned to that familiar expression — the face of someone waiting for something. I recognized it as the very same face we'd seen the moment we first arrived. In the space of a single day, he had gone back to his place, and his face.

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. For the first time, I understood that the man at the flowerbed had passed through Brick Hollow, and Haven, and this well in the Wilderness, all of them. That night, I began, faintly, to feel that it was no coincidence at all.

(Continued in Chapter 21.)

Chapter 21. In Search of the Recorder

> *_Previously_ — Speon gave us a brief glimpse into why he keeps this well every day, and into his own past: "I didn't go looking. I ran. Now I'm learning how to wait." When he told us he had seen the man at the flowerbed in more than one place, I began, faintly, to feel it was no coincidence.*

Morning fog lay low over the well. Inside it I could see Speon already up, pacing beside the water. It didn't look as though he'd slept at all.

The fog rose only to waist height. Speon's upper body seemed to float above it. I watched him a long while. He looked like someone walking on water, and at the same time like someone half sunk in it.

Every blade of grass held a bead of moisture. I swept my palm across it once. My hand was wet in an instant. It struck me as strange that water which existed nowhere else in the Wilderness gathered on this hill every single morning, on its own.

I think I understood, a little, why this hill was different. Wherever water comes up from somewhere deep, water gathers above it too. I couldn't tell whether that was because of the well, or because of Speon.

"…Go find someone," Speon said the next morning. "Her name is Mena. She's a Recorder."

My brother's hands stopped packing.

"…What does she record?" he asked.

"…The names of people who've been completed," Speon said. "At every well scattered across this world, she gathers up as many names as she can, from whoever's come out of them. I send her word myself, sometimes."

Hearing that, I understood for the first time how many more people like us there must be, scattered across this vast Wilderness. Speon wasn't the only one.

"…Is Mena a Well-Keeper too?" I asked.

"…No," Speon said. "Mena doesn't keep a well. She keeps names instead. Everyone keeps something different."

Listening to him, I thought there must be far more people in this world than we knew — people waiting for someone, keeping something, in ways we hadn't yet imagined.

"…How do you keep a name?" I asked. "A name isn't a thing you can hold."

Speon smiled a little at that.

"…I thought the same, at first," he said. "But a name really does disappear, if no one calls it anymore. A thing stays where it is whether anyone's looking at it or not. A name doesn't. So someone has to go on writing it down, and go on calling it."

"…If you write it down, does it stop disappearing?" I asked.

"…It slows down how fast it disappears," Speon said. "That's the whole of what any of us can do."

I remembered those words for a long time afterward. Not stopping it. Only slowing it. I understood then that everything these people did was of that kind. Not a work of winning, but of holding the line without giving ground.

"…Who is that record for?" my brother asked.

"…I didn't know myself, at first," Speon said. "But I know now. It's for the day someone who lost their name wants to hear it again. Someone has to be holding that name, when that day comes."

Hearing that, I thought of the paper with the COMPLETE stamp that my brother carried. He had already been doing that same work, alone. Mena was someone doing that same work on a far larger scale, for far longer.

At those words my brother reached up and pressed his hand briefly against the paper inside his coat, checking it was there. I couldn't count how many times I'd seen him do that by now. It had become as much a part of him as any of his own movements.

"…I guess I'm supposed to be doing something like this too," my brother murmured. It sounded less like something said to Speon than something said to himself.

"…You already are," Speon said. "That one piece of paper is where it starts."

Listening to that exchange, I felt my brother becoming, little by little, a different person. When we'd left Brick Hollow, he had been someone trying to leave behind evidence. Now he was becoming someone trying to keep something safe. I understood that the difference looked small, but was actually enormous.

Evidence was something meant to be held up in front of someone. Keeping was something you went on doing whether anyone saw it or not. My brother didn't seem to have noticed that about himself yet. I didn't bother telling him. Some changes, I think, are better noticed by the person going through them, in their own time.

. . .

"…Why does Mena do this?" I asked.

"…By her own account, she used to be someone who kept records, once before," Speon said. "I've heard she recorded one great story somewhere. I don't know exactly what it was myself."

Something in that pulled at me strangely. I was recording this story too. I didn't know it then — that someday I'd sit and talk with Mena about exactly that.

Up until then I hadn't even known what I myself was doing. Every night I only went back over, in my head, what I'd seen that day. Noa's face. The pebble Rachel had given me. The soil on the flowerbed man's hands. I did it because it felt like something I couldn't let myself forget. I didn't know that was a record.

From that moment I found myself curious about this person, Mena. I tried to imagine her face, her voice. In my imagination she always sat surrounded by stacks of paper.

"…A great story — what kind?" I asked.

"…I don't know exactly, either," Speon said. "But every time Mena talks about it, something changes in her eyes. Like something she's kept a very long time, and very carefully."

I held on to that. Somehow it felt like I would hear that story myself, someday.

"…Where are the people from that story now?" I asked.

Speon didn't answer right away. The fog had thinned a little by then.

"…Scattered," he said. "Each to wherever they needed to be."

"…Do they meet again?" I asked.

"…Sometimes," Speon said. "Very rarely."

His voice dropped just slightly as he said it. I could hear a longing inside that lowered voice. But it wasn't a sad longing. It sounded more like the longing of someone who knew something for certain.

"…Has Mena been here a long time too?" I asked.

"…Longer than me, I'd guess," Speon said. "She was already doing this work when I first came here. She's never once stopped, from then until now."

"…That's amazing," my brother said.

"…It's not amazing. It's just going on," Speon said. "The two look alike, but they're different."

"…What's the difference?" my brother asked.

"…Amazing is only amazing if people are watching," Speon said. "Going on is going on whether anyone's watching or not. Mena has been writing down names for more than twenty years, where no one was watching at all."

. . .

Before we left, Speon packed us dried bread and a water skin.

"…Where Mena lives is two days from here," Speon said. "There are marks along the way. Small notches cut into the stones. I don't know who cut them. But follow those notches and you won't lose the road."

He pressed the water skin into my hand and tied the strap tight himself. That touch felt familiar to me. It was close to the way Father used to pack our things.

The bread was more than we could eat. I understood it was the amount Speon had decided to give us by choosing to go a few days hungry himself.

"…This is too much," I said.

"…I'm here," Speon said. "There's water here. With water, a few days is nothing."

I knew that wasn't quite true, and I took it anyway. I'd already learned from Noa that refusing something can be the ruder choice.

Speon looked last at our shoes. The soles had worn thin.

"…Don't walk at night," he said. "You won't see the marks, and you'll lose the road. And if a quiet light passes overhead, that day, just lie down and don't move."

My brother's face went tight at that.

"…Does it come even this far?" he asked.

"…Not here," Speon said. "But it passes over the road you're taking."

"…Aren't you coming?" I asked.

"…I have to stay here," Speon said. He looked back at the well. "I never know who might come out."

Hearing that answer, I understood that Speon might never be able to leave this spot for the rest of his life. I couldn't decide, then, whether that was a sad thing or a beautiful one.

I looked at the well one last time. The water was still clear. The bottom still couldn't be seen. I found it hard to leave that spot, thinking that someday Father might rise up out of that water.

"…Elpis," my brother called. "We have to go."

I ran my hand once more along the stone wall before I finally started walking.

My brother turned back for one more look at the well.

"…If our father ever comes out here," he said, "could you tell him we came looking for him?"

Speon gripped his shoulder briefly at that.

"…I will," he said. "I promise."

. . .

As we left, Speon said one last thing.

"…Tell Mena Speon's still waiting. She'll understand what that means."

"…What does it mean?" my brother asked.

Speon smiled a little.

"…That's something only Mena and I know," Speon said. "You'll have words like that too, someday. Words you never have to explain to anyone."

We walked a few steps and looked back. Speon was still standing there, watching us. I held that image in my eyes. A single figure standing on a hill, beside a well. I already knew, in that moment, that the shape of him wouldn't leave me for a long time.

When I looked back again, much later, he was still there. We must have looked much smaller by then, but he didn't wave. He just stood. I understood that was a farewell that lasted longer than any wave could.

I learned, later, that Speon always stood like that until whoever was leaving had disappeared completely down the far side of the hill. He didn't only wait for the ones who came. He saw off, to the very end, the ones who went.

. . .

The first notch was on a rock not far from the well. My brother found it first and traced it with his fingertip.

"…Here," he said. "Look."

It might have been a small arrow, or it might have been nothing but a scratch. I stared at the shape a long while and still wasn't sure. But my brother had already turned his body toward it.

"…How do you know?" I asked.

"…I don't," he said. "But this direction feels right."

We walked the whole day, finding those notches one by one. On rocks, sometimes at the base of a dead tree, the marks appeared at steady intervals. Proof that someone, a very long time ago, had traveled this road again and again, faithfully.

Once, we went almost two hours without finding a single mark. My brother stopped and started retracing our steps.

"…I think we missed one," he said.

"…Should we turn back?" I asked.

"…No," he said. "Let's wait here. Once the sun sinks a little, the shadows will make it easier to see."

We sat with our backs against a rock and waited for the sun to sink. Strangely, that waiting felt peaceful to me. In Haven, we would have filed a request the moment we lost the road. And a road would have appeared right away. But it wouldn't have been the road we'd found for ourselves.

Sure enough, once the sun sank a little, a thin shadow fell across the side of the rock, and the notch showed itself. We both saw it at the same instant.

"…There," I said.

My brother laughed. It was the first time I'd seen him laugh in days.

Looking at those notches, I felt a strange comfort. Someone, before us, had found their way through this same hopeless Wilderness. We weren't entirely alone.

That night we slept huddled together beneath a large rock. We didn't light a fire. Speon's words wouldn't leave my mind.

Once it went dark, nothing was visible at all. That was the first time I'd ever known a night so black I couldn't tell whether my eyes were open or shut.

"…Brother, are you awake?" I asked.

"…Yeah."

"…I'm scared."

"…Me too," he said.

I liked that answer. Back in Brick Hollow, my brother had never once said he was scared. Not because he wasn't, I think, but because he thought he wasn't allowed to say it to me.

"…It helps, a little, saying it out loud," I said.

"…Yeah," he said. "Strange, isn't it."

That night I learned, for the first time, that fear can shrink without ever being solved. Just from someone else knowing it's there with you.

The sky was full of stars again that night. No quiet light passed over.

As we walked, my brother kept scanning for those notches, as if he couldn't afford to miss one. That carefulness in him felt unfamiliar to me. Back in Brick Hollow he had always been someone who walked looking only straight ahead. Now he walked with his eyes going back and forth between the ground, the rocks, the roots of trees. I thought that was a new way of walking he'd learned in this world.

By the afternoon of the second day, the notches had begun coming closer together. The shorter the gaps grew, the more I understood we were nearing something.

"…Someone must have come this way often, from here on," my brother said.

"…Or maybe," I said, "from here on, they thought it couldn't be missed."

My brother nodded at that.

As the sun went down, I traced one of the notches with my fingertip. It was cut deep. It didn't look like something carved in a hurry — it looked worked over, again and again, over time. I wondered whose hand had made it.

It hadn't been cut all at once. It had been added to, a little at a time, on every pass. I couldn't count how many times that person had traveled this road. But I could tell one thing for certain — that every single time, they'd been thinking of whoever would come after them.

I thought then, for the first time, about how lonely a thing it is to leave a mark for someone else. The one who leaves the mark almost never meets the one

who follows it. And still, they leave it.

I set those words down as the last line of this chapter. That morning we left the well behind and started following those notches cut into stone after stone. I didn't know yet that they were the footprints of someone very old, marked all across this world, long before us.

(Continued in Chapter 22.)

Chapter 22. The House of Records

> *_Previously_ — Speon introduced the brother and sister to Mena, the Recorder. The work of gathering the names of completed people turned out to run in the very same direction as what my brother had been doing alone all along. We set out walking a two-day road, following the notches cut into every stone.*

On the evening of the second day, we came to a low earthen house.

Two days of keeping my eyes fixed to the ground so I wouldn't lose the notches had left my neck stiff. I only lifted my head the moment that earthen house came into view. The sky had already gone red.

It looked less like a house than a storeroom. The walls were earth, and the roof was dried grass pressed flat and weighted down. There was only one window, and from it came a very faint light. It was the first light of another person's making that I had seen in two days.

There was a small sign by the door. **The House of Records.**

The letters had been carved into the wooden board with the point of a knife. The strokes ran deep. I touched the letters with my fingertips. The way they'd been cut looked like the notches on the stones.

Seeing that sign, I felt oddly at ease. This world had places that erased names, and it had places that wrote them down and kept them. Just knowing that both kinds of place existed gave me, in that moment, a small measure of comfort.

Beside the door stood a row of small flowerpots. It struck me as strange that anything was being grown at all, in this parched Wilderness. I guessed that

someone gave those pots water, every day, without fail.

One of the pots had already dried up and died. I wondered why it hadn't been cleared away. Even that dead pot felt like some kind of record kept by this house. Here, it seemed, not even the dead were simply thrown out.

I could feel the heat the dried grass roof had held all day slowly leaking back out of it. Feeling that warmth cool against the back of my hand, I thought that this house, too, seemed to breathe out its day like something alive.

The whole way here, my brother had barely spoken. I knew what he was afraid of. No answer at all, or an answer that turned out worse — he kept weighing those two, back and forth, without settling on either.

I could read that weighing plainly on his face. I said nothing, the whole way. I knew that no words of mine could stand in for that scale he was carrying.

I walked a little ahead of him and looked around, so that at least I wouldn't disturb his thinking. Dust drifted a little on the wind. Breathing it in, I realized that I, too, had begun to be afraid of what might be waiting on the other side of that door.

My brother lifted his hand at the door, then lowered it. Then lifted it again.

"…Knock," I said.

"…I know," my brother said. And still he didn't knock.

That was the first time I truly understood him. He had come all this way to find an answer, and now that he was standing in front of the door, the answer itself had begun to frighten him. Every step from Brick Hollow to Haven, from Haven to the well, from the well to here — all of it had come to a stop in front of this one door.

"…Let's knock together," I said.

I laid my hand over the back of his. Together, we knocked.

. . .

A woman opened the door. She looked much older than us. There was ink on her fingers, as if she'd spent her life with something in her hand, writing.

Her eyes were sharp. But sharp didn't mean cold. I felt, instead, that those were eyes trained a very long time to look at something exactly as it was.

She didn't open the door wide. She opened it just enough to show her face, and looked past us first, into the dark behind our backs. She hadn't looked at us — she'd looked behind us. From that order alone, I understood that this woman, too, was used to being followed.

"…Who's there?" the woman asked.

"…Speon sent us," my brother said. "Are you Mena?"

Something shifted, faintly, in the woman's face at that name.

"…That's me," she said. "What did Speon say?"

"…That he's still waiting," I said.

Mena heard that and closed her eyes for a moment. She said nothing. But I felt something very old, in that silence.

"…Is he all right?" Mena asked. Her voice trembled slightly.

"…Yes," my brother said. "He watches over that well every single day."

At that, Mena gave a small laugh. Something like tears was mixed into it.

"…That sounds like him," Mena said.

She opened the door a little wider as she said it. I felt, in that motion, that she had already decided to let us in. A single name — Speon's — had been enough to open that door.

"…Come in," Mena said. "This isn't a conversation for standing outside."

Mena led the way, lighting a lamp as she went. The light caught the ink stains on her fingers. I could tell that stain hadn't come from a day or two of work.

As she closed the door, Mena dropped the latch into place. Then she reached over and pulled the cloth across the window a little tighter.

"…Is it all right if the light shows?" I asked.

"…It's all right if it shows a little," Mena said. "But only a little is good. Too dark, and no one can find their way here at all. Too bright, and it draws the ones you'd rather it didn't."

I remembered that for a long time afterward. Every person in this world who waited for someone seemed to live like that — never able to hide completely, and never able to be seen completely, either.

. . .

Mena brought us inside. The inside was nothing but paper. Every wall had shelves, and every shelf was crowded with paper bearing names.

The room had a smell all its own. Old paper and ink, and beneath it a faint smell of melted candle wax. Breathing it in, I tried to guess how long it must have taken to fill this room like this. I couldn't begin to guess.

Some of the shelves reached all the way to the ceiling. I wondered how old the papers up there must be. I doubted Mena's hand alone could reach that high — until I saw the old ladder standing in the corner, and had my answer.

A small piece of wood hung from every shelf. Each one had letters carved into it too. I was about to ask what they marked when Mena spoke first, as if she'd already noticed the question in my face.

"…Those are well names," Mena said. "One shelf, one well."

I tried counting the shelves. There were more than twenty. I gave up partway through.

"…This many?" my brother asked.

"…This is only the wells I've had word from," Mena said. "I don't even know how many I haven't."

Hearing that answer, my legs went weak. More than twenty shelves. And that wasn't even all of them. That was the first day I felt, in my body and not just my mind, how enormous this search really was.

I walked between the shelves, running my eyes over the names carved into the little wooden markers. Most of them were names I didn't know. But strangely, that unfamiliarity felt heavy. I thought that behind every single name, there must have been some Brick Hollow of its own.

One shelf, alone, stood nearly empty. Only a few papers on it.

"…Why is that one empty?" I asked.

Mena looked over at it.

"…That's a well with no one keeping it," Mena said. "No word ever comes. Because no one's watching."

I looked at that empty shelf for a long time. Paper missing didn't mean no one had come out of that well. It meant no one had been there to see them.

"…Are all of these the names of completed people?" I asked.

"…Only the ones I've been able to gather," Mena said. "I haven't gotten them all. This world is too wide."

I ran my eyes down the shelves, one by one. The handwriting differed slightly from paper to paper. I understood that these weren't Mena's own hand copying names — they were the traces of word carried to her by many different people, and written down exactly as it came. Some papers were old and faded. Others looked as if the ink hadn't even dried yet.

"…Who brings you these names?" I asked.

"…Anyone passing through," Mena said. "Well-keepers, traders, people on the run. Whoever brings me a name, I write it down."

"…What if it's a lie?" my brother asked.

Mena glanced at him for a moment at that question. It wasn't an unkind look.

"…Then I write it down as a lie," Mena said. "The moment I start deciding what's true, people stop bringing me the names they're unsure of. And then the real ones disappear right along with them."

I thought that one line explained this whole room. This room didn't hold only what was certain. It held the uncertain too, all of it, right alongside the rest. Haven's ledger kept only what was certain. That's why nothing at all was left, in that city.

My brother looked over the papers and asked, carefully.

"…Could we look for our father's name too?"

Mena looked at him for a long moment.

"…Tell me the name," Mena said. "I'll look."

My heart pounded so hard in that instant that it hurt. Listening to my brother say Father's name aloud, I felt that even after all this time, that name still sat perfectly formed in his voice.

I said the name over too, silently, inside myself. I didn't say it aloud. But even that alone was enough to make my eyes burn. I realized, right then, just how many times I must have repeated that name to myself, just so I wouldn't forget it.

I understood later that repeating a name like that isn't only a way of remembering the person. It's also a way of telling yourself, over and over, that they still exist.

Mena wrote the name down on the paper. I saw that her fingertips were trembling, just slightly.

"…Is it a common name?" Mena asked.

"…No," my brother said. "In Brick Hollow, there was only one Father."

"…Then it might be a little easier to find," Mena said.

Mena checked the paper once more and asked.

"…Anything else — a mark on him somewhere, a way he walked?"

My brother thought for a moment before answering.

"…One finger on his left hand is shorter than the rest," he said. "He got hurt carrying bricks."

Mena wrote that down small, beside the name.

"…This kind of thing helps," Mena said. "People forget names before they forget bodies."

As she said it, Mena underlined that detail on the page once more, to mark it. Her fingers moved with familiar ease. I could tell, from that gesture alone, that she had taken down details like this more times than could be counted.

"…Have you heard, all this time, of anyone with a short finger like that?" my brother asked, carefully.

Mena shook her head.

"…Not yet," she said. "But I'll start looking, from now on."

"…Why do you do this?" my brother asked, suddenly.

Mena set down her pen.

"…A long time ago, I wrote down something very important," Mena said. "Back then I thought — what's the use of writing it down? What does writing change? But I learned, later. Only what gets written down stays."

"…What did you write?" I asked.

Mena smiled. She didn't answer.

"…That's not a story for today," Mena said. "Right now, your father's name comes first."

She said that and rose from her seat. I saw her back hesitate for just a moment. Setting her own story aside didn't seem to come easily to her, either. But she turned at once and walked toward the shelves.

. . .

Mena went back and forth among the shelves for a long time. Only the sound of turning paper filled the room.

My brother stood in one place the whole time, without moving. I sat beside him and took his hand. His hand was cold. I hoped mine might warm it, even a little.

Every time the candle flame flickered, the shadows of the papers on the shelves flickered with it against the wall. Watching those shadows, I thought that every single paper there must have once been someone's entire world.

Each time Mena turned a page, she touched the tip of her finger lightly to her tongue first. Then she ran her eyes down it, top to bottom, one sheet at a time. She skipped nothing. I found that thoroughness almost frightening. This woman was rereading hundreds of names, right now, for the sake of one person — our father.

Sometimes her hand paused. Every time it did, my own heart stopped along with it. But then Mena would turn the page again. Through however many times that pause and turn repeated, I hoped and then collapsed, over and over, that same number of times.

I don't know how much time passed. I couldn't breathe properly, the whole time it did.

That night, I understood for the first time that waiting could hurt the body itself. My shoulders stiffened, my jaw ached, my fingertips went cold. I thought it was almost fortunate that there was nowhere to file a complaint about that pain. That pain was the only road there was to Father.

At last Mena stopped in front of one shelf. She turned back to us. Her face was complicated.

"…It's here," Mena said. "But it isn't the answer you're hoping for."

Mena carried the paper back to us the way you'd hold something against your chest. Her steps were slower than before. I felt, in that slowness, that she was still choosing, even now, how to give us these words.

She didn't set the paper down on the table. She kept holding it. It seemed she thought that the moment she set it down, we would read it ourselves. I could only see the back of the paper. Something was written on that side too, but the ink showed through too faintly to read.

The lamp wick sputtered faintly as it burned. Other than that sound, there was nothing. In that stillness, I understood that Mena was trying, right now, to be gentle with us. She was someone who knew how to deliver bad news carefully.

"…Sleep here tonight," Mena said. "I'll tell you in the morning, once your minds are clearer."

"…We want to hear it now," my brother said. His voice had cracked.

Mena looked at him for a long time.

She turned the lamp wick up a little higher. The room brightened, just slightly. I hoped that one small bit of extra light might help us bear whatever we were about to hear.

"…All right," Mena said. "Then sit down."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this chapter. In that moment, I learned that Father really was alive, somewhere in this world. And yet, until I learned what "not the answer you're hoping for" meant, I had to endure that entire night not knowing.

(Continued in Chapter 23.)

Chapter 23. An Answer We Didn't Expect

> *_Previously_ — At the end of a two-day road, the brother and sister reached Mena's House of Records. Mena found Father's name, but closed the chapter with the words, "It isn't the answer you're hoping for."*

The lamp burned low. Mena settled back into her seat and unfolded the paper once more. I could feel that her hands were moving more slowly now than before.

"…About a month ago," Mena said, unfolding the paper, "I got word that someone who might be your father came out of a well to the north."

"…He's alive?" my brother asked, urgent.

"…He was. At least then," Mena said.

I remember feeling, in that moment, that all three of us had stopped breathing at once. The lamp's shadow trembled faintly against the wall. The room was so quiet that even that small tremor felt loud.

"…North?" I asked.

"…North of here," Mena said. "Several days on foot. I haven't been there myself, so I can't say exactly."

At that, my brother had already leaned forward. I gripped his arm lightly, afraid he might stand and walk out right then.

"…I haven't finished," I said.

My brother looked at me. His eyes already held half a night's walking in them.

I already felt the unease in that word "then." I knew it meant this story wasn't finished.

My brother seemed unable to breathe properly where he sat. I saw his hands clenched tight on his knees. His knuckles had gone white.

Mena studied our faces and went on, carefully.

"…Can I keep going?" Mena asked. "Once you hear it, there's no taking it back."

My brother looked at me for a moment. I nodded. He nodded too.

"…Please, keep going," he said.

I felt, in his voice just then, both fear and longing at once. I felt the same. I wanted to know. And at the same time, I felt that knowing might break me.

Mena closed her eyes for a moment, then opened them again. I felt her steadying herself for this. Delivering news like this didn't seem to come easily to her, either.

I learned later how rare a kindness it was, that Mena warned us first, that night, that there was no taking it back. Haven had never once asked us that. That city always resolved things first, and told us afterward that this was what we'd wanted.

The lamp wick crackled faintly and flickered. I flinched even at that small sound. Everything inside me had drawn so taut that it answered to the smallest change in that room.

. . .

"…This is what the well-keeper there told me," Mena said. "The moment he came out, he kept counting something. On his fingers, without a sound. He didn't know himself why he was counting."

"…At first he didn't say anything at all," Mena added. "Not his name, not where he'd come from — no answer to anything. He just kept folding and unfolding his fingers."

I tried to picture that, then made myself stop. Even the thought of it hurt.

But the picture had already started forming. A man sitting at a strange well, folding and unfolding his fingers. No one knowing who he was, and he himself not knowing either. I closed my eyes and opened them again, several times, trying to erase that image. It wouldn't go.

"…What was he counting?" I asked. I already thought I knew the answer.

My voice came out shaking. Tears had already started rising before I even heard it.

"…I don't know," Mena said. "But at some point, in the middle of counting, he stood up all at once and walked off somewhere. No one could stop him."

Hearing that, I felt tears coming. I knew it was the brick count. Father had forgotten his name, forgotten our faces, and still that number went on counting itself, as if it had been carved into his body.

I remembered the way Father used to count that number every evening in Brick Hollow. Even when his fingertips split and bled, he never let that count slip. I hadn't understood, back then, why it mattered so much to him. I understand now. That number was proof that he'd survived one more day.

If he lost count, he started over from the beginning. As a child, that used to frustrate me enough that I asked him once — couldn't he just count roughly?

Father had laughed and told me: count roughly, and the whole day turns rough with it.

I had gone a long time without remembering those words. And yet here, in Mena's room, under the lamplight, they came back to me whole, word for word.

I found it strangely steadying, that I hadn't forgotten Father's voice. His face kept blurring on me, again and again — but some turns of phrase stayed perfectly clear. I thought that might be what real memory actually is. Not everything, but a handful of clear pieces.

I understood, in that moment, that the Completion House had taken Father's name and his face. But it hadn't been able to take that one habit — his refusal to live a day roughly. I think that was because it lived in the deepest place in him.

"…Three thousand," my brother said, low. "He must have counted all the way to three thousand. And then started over from the beginning again."

Mena didn't ask him to repeat it. I understood that she'd already guessed what it meant.

Mena looked back down at the paper and touched a line near the bottom with her fingertip.

"…It says here," Mena said. "'Stops at three thousand each day.' The well-keeper watched for three days and sent this back."

"…Three days?" I asked.

"…Three days," Mena said. "He didn't even eat. He just kept counting. And strangely, he always stopped at exactly three thousand."

My brother let out a short, broken laugh. It wasn't really a laugh. It was another sound that only came out sounding like one.

"…That was a day's quota," my brother said. "Three thousand bricks was a day's quota. If you didn't reach it, there was no food that night."

Mena set down her pen. She said nothing.

The room went very quiet. Quiet enough that I thought I could hear even the trembling of the lamp's flame. I sat close beside my brother and held onto his arm. He didn't move at all.

After a long while, my brother spoke in a very low voice.

"…He wasn't counting us."

Mena looked up at that.

"…What do you mean?" Mena asked.

"…He counts bricks," my brother said. "He doesn't count us. Because we're not a number."

Hearing that, the breath caught in my throat. My brother was saying that truth right now in the way that hurt him most.

"…That isn't because he loved you less," Mena said quietly. "The body remembers numbers. The heart remembers love. What those people took from him was the heart's side."

My brother said nothing back.

. . .

"…And after that?" my brother asked. His voice had cracked.

"…There's no word after that," Mena said. "The well-keeper hasn't seen him since. He must still be somewhere. But exactly where — I don't know that either."

"…No one went after him?" I asked.

"…Someone did," Mena said. "But they lost him. It was night, and he walked faster than they expected."

Even in that brief moment, my brother's voice was already trying to fix a direction. I thought that was exactly like him.

"…Which way did he go?" my brother asked.

"…That's not exact either," Mena said. "But the well-keeper wrote this much: 'Not toward the sunset.'"

"…That's all?" my brother asked.

"…That's all," Mena said. "I'm sorry. I can only write down what's given to me. The moment I start filling in what isn't there, this whole room stops being a room anyone can trust."

Hearing that, I found strange comfort in the fact that Father had been hurrying. Even with his name forgotten, his steps had still been urgent. I wanted to believe that meant he was still moving toward something.

My brother sank down where he stood. I sat beside him and took hold of his shoulder.

He made no sound at all. But I could feel his shoulder trembling, very faintly. I thought, in that moment, that my brother looked like someone who had

forgotten how to cry out loud. From Brick Hollow until now, he had always wept only inward, like this.

I thought, just then, of Haven's ledger. The ledger took in your weeping and resolved it. But my brother had never once filed his. He had never handed his weeping over to anyone. And so all of it was still inside him, every bit of it, still there.

"…Was this the answer you didn't expect?" I asked Mena.

Mena nodded.

"…Coming with no idea whether someone's alive or dead can hurt less than learning they're alive, and losing them again," Mena said. "But I don't tell lies."

"…Why not?" my brother asked. It wasn't resentment. He seemed to genuinely want to know.

"…Because Haven already does false comfort perfectly well," Mena said. "I started this work because I wanted to do something different from that."

"…Doesn't it wear on you?" I asked. "Having to deliver news like this every time?"

Mena looked at me for a long moment.

"…It does," Mena admitted. "But I think it's better than no one delivering it at all. That's what I believe, and it's why I keep doing this."

Mena looked down at her hands for a moment. They were covered in ink stains.

"…I don't even know how many times these hands have written down news like this," Mena said. "But it's just as hard every time. I never get used to it."

I found that answer strangely comforting. I thought it was a good thing that Mena hadn't gone numb to this work.

I thought, just then, of Haven's Administrator. That man was always smiling. He had never once said this was hard. I used to think that was strength. Now I know better. That wasn't strength. It was only that he, too, had already gone numb to it.

"…Wouldn't it be easier to get used to it?" I asked. "You'd hurt less."

"…If I got used to it, I'd have to stop doing this work," Mena said. "News delivered by someone who's gone numb ends up sounding exactly like the ledger's."

I thought about that all through that night. The same words, spoken by someone who hurts along with you as they say them, become different words entirely. That was exactly the thing Haven could never do. That city's answers were all correct. But not a single person there had ever hurt, speaking one of them.

Saying that, Mena carefully folded the paper and held it out toward my brother.

"…Take this," Mena said. "You might need it again someday."

My brother took the paper with trembling hands. He folded it away beside the COMPLETE-stamped paper he already carried.

"…This is the original, though," my brother said.

"…I can copy it out again," Mena said. "Copying is the thing I do best."

I understood, from that answer, that this was someone who could hand over the thing she treasured most without a second thought. It was only that day

that I understood why giving away a single sheet of paper, in a room filled with nothing but paper, could mean so much.

. . .

Mena stepped quietly out of the room, as if trying not to disturb us. She left only one lamp burning and put out the rest. In that dim light, I sat beside my brother.

Outside, I could hear the wind brushing against the earthen walls of the house. Listening to it, I thought that somewhere out there, beyond this house, Father might be standing in that same wind right now — with no name, not knowing us at all.

Thinking that, my mind wandered somewhere strange. Was he cold, right now? Had he eaten? Did he have somewhere to sleep? I found it strangely fortunate that I could still worry about things like that. You can't worry about things like that for someone who's dead.

That was the first time I truly felt, all over again, how cruel Haven's "resolving" had been. There, a night like this could never have happened at all. The pain disappeared before it even had the chance to hurt. I thought that this pain, right now, felt more human, somehow, than that smooth, seamless resolution ever had.

I sat beside my brother a long while that night. He didn't cry. But I could see that his face had come apart more thoroughly than crying ever could.

"…Brother," I said. "He's alive, though."

"…Yeah," my brother said, after a long pause. "He's alive."

"…Say that again," my brother said.

"…He's alive," I said.

My brother closed his eyes. I understood that he was trying to take those three words and press them down inside himself. It was something we hadn't once been able to say with certainty, since we left Brick Hollow.

"…And he's still counting bricks," I said. "That's proof he's still Father, isn't it. Even with his name gone, Father is still inside him."

My brother couldn't answer that. I understood it wasn't because he had nothing to say back — it was because his throat had closed.

At those words, my brother lifted his head and looked at me for the first time. I saw his eyes brimming with tears. He tried to hold them back. But this time, it seemed, he couldn't.

My brother covered his face with both hands. At first there was no sound. Then his shoulders heaved once, hard, and after that, the sound came. It was the first time in my life I had ever heard my brother cry.

I cried too. We held onto each other and cried for a long time. I don't even know when the lamp went out.

Mena didn't come in. I knew she was there, just beyond the door. But she didn't come in to comfort us, and she didn't tell us to stop. She simply stayed there.

A long while later, two bowls of water were quietly pushed under the door. I thought that was the smallest and, at once, the largest thing Mena knew how to say. Asking nothing, demanding nothing — just water, set there in case we grew thirsty.

I still think, even now, that it was one of the greatest gifts I received in this world. No one filed our weeping. No one resolved it. Someone simply stayed

on the other side of a door, until we had finished crying.

I set that down as the last sentence of this chapter. That day, I cried for the first time. It was the first time since we'd left Brick Hollow. My brother cried along with me, following me into it. That night, we wept together for the father who had forgotten his own name.

(Continued in Chapter 24.)

Chapter 24. Northward

> *_Previously_ — Mena brought news of Father. A month ago he had come out alive from a well in the north, but with his name and face forgotten, and had vanished somewhere in the middle of counting three thousand bricks. For the first time since leaving Brick Hollow, the brother and sister wept together.*

The next morning, my eyes were swollen. So were my brother's. And yet, strangely, my body felt lighter.

Morning sunlight was coming in through the window. Watching it, I learned for the first time how strange a morning can feel after a whole night of crying. Nothing in the world had changed. And yet I felt like an entirely different person.

I understood then, for the first time, that tears didn't erase anything. They only lifted away, by their own weight, what had been piling up inside.

Mena's house had one small window in its wall. I watched dust drift slowly through the shaft of light coming in through it. It was a peaceful morning, as if nothing at all had happened. That peace felt strange to me, so different from last night's tears. But that the two of them could exist inside the same day — that, too, I was learning for the first time.

The moment my brother opened his eyes, he checked the paper stamped COMPLETE again. It had become a habit by then. But that day was a little different. He looked at the paper for a long time, then folded it carefully and tucked it into his innermost pocket.

Something had gone out of my brother's face overnight. It took me a long while of thinking before I understood what it was. It was the tension that had clung to his face ever since Brick Hollow. His anger hadn't disappeared. What had ended was not knowing where to put it.

"…It's not evidence anymore. Not a way of holding onto his name, either," my brother said, seeing my expression. "Now this is… proof that we made it this far."

Hearing that, I felt all over again how completely my brother had changed in these last few days. When we left Brick Hollow, he had been a person moved only by anger. The paper in his hand now was no longer evidence of that anger.

"…Brother," I asked. "Did you sleep last night?"

"…A little," he said. "Crying made me sleepy."

He said it as if it were nothing. But to me it wasn't nothing at all. It was the first time my brother had ever spoken of his own crying so plainly.

I realized something strange then. In Haven, we had never once cried, and never once truly slept. I hadn't known that those two things were bound together.

I reached out and touched the dust settled on the windowsill. I watched it scatter in the shaft of light, then slowly find its place again. Watching that small movement, I thought that something inside us, too, must have scattered like that last night, and slowly settled back into place.

. . .

Mena asked while setting out breakfast for us.

Bread and dried fruit sat in a small bowl. Looking at that plain breakfast, I found it strange that even in this house, someone made a meal like this every morning. In a room crowded with paper, the smell of cooking felt like an odd kind of comfort.

"…What will you do now?"

"…We'll go north," my brother said. "To that well, and then follow whatever path Father walked from there."

His voice was different from last night. Sorrow still clung to it, but something unshaken had settled inside it now. Hearing it, I knew my brother had worked something all the way through, sometime in the night.

"…And if you can't find him?" Mena asked. It wasn't a test. She seemed to genuinely want to know.

My brother thought for a moment.

"…Then while we're looking, we'll tell everyone we meet about him," my brother said. "That way, little by little, more people will know Father's name."

Mena looked at him a very long time at that answer.

"…Do you know something?" Mena said. "That's exactly what I do. You just gave me the same answer I would have given."

My brother's face didn't know how to answer that.

Mena nodded. She didn't try to stop us.

"…I thought as much," Mena said.

"…Won't it be dangerous?" I asked.

"…It's dangerous," Mena said honestly. "But you're people who already knew that much when you left."

At that, my brother smiled for the first time — the first smile I'd seen from him in days.

"…Take whatever you need," Mena said. "I've heard it's colder to the north than here. Take another blanket, too."

"…Thank you," I said.

Mena folded the blanket and laid it on top of my pack as she spoke.

"…This is nothing," Mena said. "Not compared to the road you're about to carry."

My brother asked while repacking his bag.

"…Do you know if there's another well anywhere along our way?"

Mena thought a moment, then nodded.

"…I've heard of one," Mena said. "I don't know exactly where. But if you keep heading north, people will tell you. This world is more connected than you'd think."

"…How?" I asked.

"…By rumor. By footprints. Sometimes just by chance," Mena said. "You two got here that way yourselves."

"…Doesn't it seem like there's too much chance in it, though?" my brother asked.

Mena's hands stopped for a moment at that.

"…I used to think that too," Mena said. "But when there's too much chance, at some point it starts to feel strange, calling it chance at all."

"…Then what do you call it?" my brother asked.

"…I still haven't found a name for it," Mena said. "You two might find one before I do."

I let that conversation pass by, at the time. Now I think it was the most important part of this chapter.

After that, Mena helped us pack without another word. I felt that silence carrying forward the full weight of what we'd just said. Sometimes not answering is the more honest answer.

. . .

Before we left, Mena called me aside, alone.

She led me to one side of the room, to the shelves standing thickest with papers. Standing among all those names, I felt, strangely, at ease. I knew that every paper here had once been someone's everything — and it comforted me that all those everythings hadn't been thrown away, but gathered here like this instead.

"…I heard you've been keeping a record," Mena said. "Speon told me."

"…I just write down what happens," I said. "It's nothing special."

"…That's exactly what makes it special," Mena said. "That's how I started too. Just writing down what happened."

Mena handed me an old pen.

Its handle had gone smooth from long use. I took it in my hand and wondered how many years it must have carried stories out of someone's grip.

The tip had worn down and shortened. Looking at that wear, I thought of the old man's cane handle at the tent settlement. Everything old in this world wore down like that. In Haven, nothing ever wore down at all.

"…Was this his, originally?" I asked.

"…Yes," Mena said. "I think your hand needs it more than mine does now."

"…Keep writing," Mena said. "Someday, your father might need this record too."

Taking that in, I felt tears rising again, strangely. I understood then, for the first time, that what I'd been doing wasn't so different from what my brother had been doing. He had tried to keep hold of a name. I had tried to keep hold of a story. We had only been holding the same thing with different hands.

"…Doesn't it frighten you?" Mena asked. "Keeping a record isn't just writing down the good things. You have to write down days like today too."

"…It frightens me," I said. "But if I don't write it down, today just disappears. That frightens me more."

Mena looked at me a long time at that. Then, for the first time, she gave a real smile.

"…That's it," Mena said. "That's exactly why I can't let this work go. You're so much younger than me, and you already know that."

I didn't know how to answer that, so I only held the pen tight against my chest.

"…I'll ask you one thing," Mena said. "When you write, don't write down only what you've understood. Leave what you don't understand written as not-

understood. More often than not, that's what turns out to matter most, later."

"…Why?" I asked.

"…What you've understood has already become yours," Mena said. "What you haven't understood still belongs to someone else. You have to leave it as it is, or it can't become real later."

I've kept that from that day on. That's why so much in this ledger remains what I never understood.

. . .

We left Mena's house that afternoon.

At the door, Mena hugged each of us once. It was a short, awkward embrace. I didn't get the sense she was someone who did this kind of goodbye often. And yet the hug was sincere.

"…Tell Speon," Mena said, last of all. "That I'm still waiting too."

My brother said he'd remember it exactly.

Hearing it, I felt again that something very old stood between those two. I found myself wondering, then, why Speon and Mena didn't wait together, in the same place. I thought I'd learn that answer too, someday.

"…Can I ask you one thing?" I said.

"…Go on."

"…Why do you two live apart?"

Mena rested a hand on the doorframe at the question.

"…If everyone guarding the same thing gathers in one place," Mena said, "then no one standing between them ever gets found."

I turned that answer over for a long time. The two of them weren't apart. They were standing in different places.

I wondered, then, if the whole world might be built that way. People waiting, each in a different place, each in a different way. Maybe it was precisely because they never all gathered in one place that more people, somewhere, could find their names again.

. . .

We left the earthen house behind and turned north. The sun already hung close to the middle of the sky. I looked back once. Mena stood at her door, watching us go. It looked exactly like the way she must have watched Speon leave.

The road climbed almost at once. The ground grew rougher and rougher, and far off on the horizon I could just make out the blurred ridge of low mountains. Looking at that ridgeline, I felt that our journey had entered an entirely new stage.

I thought of the first day we left Brick Hollow. That day, we had only been running. Now, our direction had a reason behind it. I understood that the difference made it a completely different kind of walking, even if, from the outside, it looked like the exact same steps.

As he walked, my brother checked once more the two papers in his hand — the one stamped COMPLETE, and the one Mena had given him. He laid them together, neat and even, and tucked them back inside his coat.

"…This is where it really begins," my brother said. It sounded half like something said to himself, half like something said to me.

"…Yes," I said. "I think so too."

We walked without speaking for a while after that. I noticed the earth underfoot slowly changing color — from red to gray. I thought that change was proof we were leaving the Wilderness behind.

The wind changed too. The Wilderness's wind had been dry and stinging. What blew down from the north carried something damp in it. That dampness felt strange against my skin, and I rubbed my arms more than once. Breathing that scent in, I thought that Father must have felt this same wind. A month ago. Before us.

That thought comforted me, strangely. We were following Father. Even if we never found him, one thing was certain — we were walking through the same wind.

As I walked, I touched the pen tucked in my coat once. Rachel's pebble was still there too. I counted, one by one, everything this journey had given us. One pebble, one pen, two papers. And a handful of people's names.

Father had counted bricks. From that day, I decided I would count people.

As the sun began to sink, my brother stopped and looked back. I turned and looked back too. The road we'd traveled stretched away into the distance, hazy and far. Haven. The tent settlement. That well. The House of Records. It felt strange to think all those places now lay behind us.

I counted how, at every one of those places, someone had given us something. Noa had given us a place. Rachel had given us a stone. The old man had given us a rumor. Speon had given us water. Mena had given us a name. We had walked this whole way receiving, again and again, without ever repaying a thing.

"…Will we ever be able to pay it all back?" I asked.

My brother thought a moment.

"…Probably not," he said. "But maybe we can just give it to someone else instead. That seems to be how everyone here does it."

That my brother was the one who said that was, to me, the most surprising thing that whole day. In Haven, he had always been someone who calculated — what you filed, and what you got back for it. But that day, for the first time, he accepted a debt he couldn't repay, without doing the math on it at all.

"…We've come so far," I said.

"…Yeah," he said. "But there's still more road ahead."

"…Aren't you scared?" I asked.

He looked at me and smiled. A very small smile, but a clear one.

"…I'm scared," he said. "But it's all right now, because I'm not scared alone."

At that, I took my brother's hand. He took mine back. We started walking again, just like that, hand in hand.

Before the sun went fully down, its last light stretched our shadows long across the ground. I looked down at the two of them, lying side by side, reaching out ahead of us. When we'd been running, our shadows had always seemed to chase us from behind. Now they pointed the way before we did.

I set down here the last sentence of this Part. We began walking north. Whether we could find Father, and whether he would know us even if we did — none of it was certain. But that day, for the first time, I saw something close to certainty on my brother's face. It wasn't the certainty of someone who had every answer. It was only the certainty of someone who had a reason to keep walking.

(Continued in Part Three.)

The Weeping Ledger, Part Three

The Northward Road

Chapter 25. Following the Trail

> *_Previously_ — After Mena brought word of Father, the brother and sister wept together for the first time since leaving Brick Hollow. Elpis learned that tears erase nothing — they only lift the weight, by their own weight — and the two of them set out north, following Father's trail.*

The road north was rougher than the Wilderness had ever been.

The land grew stranger with every mile. Brick Hollow's soil had been red and heavy. Here the dirt ran pale and light, so light that a single gust erased our footprints within minutes. That frightened me in a way I couldn't quite explain. If our own tracks disappeared that easily, then any tracks someone might follow toward us would disappear just as easily. But it also meant the opposite — the tracks we were following could vanish before we ever found them.

The grass thinned out, then stopped altogether. The ground hardened underfoot. My brother kept walking anyway, every day. I walked behind him, and every night I wrote down what had happened that day.

That was the first time I really used the writing tool Mena had given me. My hand didn't know it yet — the letters kept slanting sideways. I kept writing anyway.

There was no shade on that road. By day the sun sat straight over our heads and beat down without mercy; by night the wind cut clear to the bone in the opposite direction. I was startled every time by how far apart those two temperatures stood. It was a cold Brick Hollow had never taught us.

Within days, the sole of my brother's shoe began to split. He tried to hide that from me too. I only found out because I noticed him limping.

"…What's wrong with your shoe?" I asked.

"…Nothing," my brother said. His usual answer. I didn't push. Pushing would only have gotten me the same nothing, over and over, until I gave up.

That evening, while he wasn't looking, I wrapped a strip of cloth around the broken sole. The next morning he saw it and said nothing. He just put the shoe on and walked. I understood that silence as his way of saying thank you.

The cloth wore through again within three days. Each time, I wrapped it again in secret. Each time, he wore it in secret. We were passing something back and forth between us, wordlessly, over one shoe. I came to think it was the only language the road had left us.

Once, the cloth had frozen stiff overnight, soaked through with dew. My brother rubbed it between his palms for a long time before he could get it on. I lay there and listened to that sound — a dry, papery rubbing that went on and on. I felt both sorry and grateful, hearing it.

Water ran short again. We filtered muddy water the way Noa had taught us. Even that, my brother made me drink first, and drank his own share after.

"…You go first," I told him, more than once. He always pretended not to hear.

Once I wrestled the water bowl out of his hands and pressed it to his mouth before he could stop me. He laughed, just for a second. Then he took exactly one swallow and handed the bowl straight back. I understood that single swallow was the only concession he would ever allow himself.

At night we slept back to back, trying to block a little of the wind. I could feel my brother's back growing thinner by the week. He never seemed to close his

eyes until he'd made sure I was already asleep. More than once I pretended to sleep just to watch him finally let go.

There were an unusual number of stars at night. I looked at them and tried to remember the constellation names Father used to point out to us in Brick Hollow. Not one came back to me. That grieved me. On the road to find Father, the first things I was losing were the things he had taught me.

That night I understood for the first time that keeping a record wasn't only for my own sake. I wasn't writing to keep from forgetting. I was writing to catch hold, again, of things I had already forgotten.

That night, instead of the constellations' names, I counted how many stars I could see. I got to thirty and stopped. There was no counting the whole sky anyway. I thought that was a little like this journey — instead of trying to count what couldn't be counted, you counted what was in front of you.

My brother had unusual trouble falling asleep that night. I lay still, pretending to sleep, and listened to his breathing. He turned over several times before finally settling with his back to the sky. That back looked, to me, like a back trying to avoid something.

. . .

Food ran low too. We dug up dry fruit and roots when we found them. Even after Noa's lessons in what was safe to eat and what wasn't, we were never quite sure, so my brother always tasted things first, in small bites.

"…Spit it out if it's bitter," he'd say. Every time he said it, I understood that he was swallowing the risk before it ever reached me.

Once he chewed a root and winced and spat it out fast. I asked, frightened, if he was all right. He said, like it was nothing, "…just a little bitter." That night

I saw him quietly rubbing his stomach. I pretended not to see. He probably knew I was pretending.

On the fifth day, we found a stranger's footprints.

My brother knelt and studied them closely.

"…One person," he said. "But it's strange. They circled the same spot, over and over."

"…Maybe someone who got lost," I said.

"…Or," my brother went on, "someone who kept searching for something and never found it."

His finger traced print after print. The depths were all different. Some were shallow. Some were pressed unusually deep.

I crouched beside him and studied the prints too. Grains of dirt were still crumbling loose at the edges, not fully settled. They weren't old. That fact frightened me and gladdened me at once.

"…Look at this," my brother said, pointing to one print. "This one's much deeper than the others. Like someone stood here a long time."

I laid my palm on the spot. The soil was still cool. I thought that coolness held, pressed into it, the shape of however long someone had stood there.

"…Brother." I asked. "If a person stands in one place long enough, does the ground remember?"

He looked at me for a moment.

"…That's not remembering," he said. "It's just pressed down."

"…But it's still there," I said.

He didn't answer. Instead he laid his own hand over the mark once more. I noticed, then, that his hand was bigger than the print.

He looked up at me. We had the same thought at the same moment.

My heart started pounding again right then. I couldn't be certain whose print it was. But I could see in my brother's eyes that he already was.

We stayed there a long while. My brother circled the prints again and again, studying them. Watching him, it looked as though he were retracing Father's steps with his own body.

"…What was this footprint doing here?" I asked.

He touched the ground again. The soil there was packed unusually hard.

"…Going in circles," he said. "Like… like someone searching for something they couldn't find."

That answer ached in my chest. Father had forgotten his own name, and still he'd kept searching for something. I felt like I both understood what it was and didn't.

"…Do you think," I asked carefully, "he might have been looking for us?"

My brother didn't answer. Instead he stared for a long time in the direction the tracks pointed. I understood that silence as his own kind of answer.

He rose and brushed the dirt from his knees. His hands were shaking. I pretended not to see. He probably knew I was pretending.

We followed the tracks a little further. After a few steps they suddenly changed direction. Then changed again. That zigzag looked, to me, like the

walk of someone who couldn't decide where to go.

"…Whoever this was, they wandered a lot here," I said.

My brother nodded and said nothing. I felt that he was understanding that wandering in his own way. He, too, had walked lost for years now.

. . .

Following those tracks, we met a man. Not the one who'd left them — a different traveler, wandering the same stretch of ground.

He carried a heavy pack on his back. His face was sun-darkened, his gait slow. He wasn't startled to see us. Two children on this road, it seemed, wasn't so rare a sight.

A smell of dried herbs rose from his pack. Catching it, I guessed he'd traveled this road a long time. It struck me as strange that I let my guard down so quickly around a stranger — and yet that single smell alone put me somewhat at ease.

"…Have you seen anyone strange near here?" my brother asked. "Someone who counts numbers to himself?"

The man nodded.

"…I saw someone," he said. "A while back. Walking along, counting the whole time. Didn't answer when I spoke to him."

"…How long ago?" my brother asked, impatience bleeding into his voice.

"…Let's see. A day? Two?" The man tilted his head. "I don't know exactly. I only saw him passing by."

"…Which way did he go?" I asked urgently.

"…Don't know," the man said. "But there's someone who's good at finding people like that. I heard his name's Temel."

"…Where would we find him?" my brother asked.

"…Keep heading north and you'll run into him," the man said. "He's always on the move. Finding people's what he does."

"…Does he take payment?" I asked. We had nothing to give.

The man shook his head.

"…Never heard of it," he said. "I hear he just does it."

"…That's a strange person," I said, without thinking.

The man laughed a little at that.

"…Strange," he agreed. "But you get a few strange ones like that on this road. People who lend a hand for nothing in return. I doubted it too, at first. But after you run into a few, you just start figuring that's how it is."

"…Why do they do it?" I asked.

The man shrugged.

"…I asked one of them that myself," he said. "He told me someone had done the same for him first. So now he does it too."

I wanted to write that answer down on paper. But my hands were too cold to write just then. So instead I recited it to myself, several times over.

Hearing that name, I felt a strange familiarity, though I didn't know why at the time. I know now. That name, too, was one that had been quietly finding people all across this world.

With that, the man went on his way. I watched his back for a long time. A name a stranger had thrown out in passing had, by that day's end, become the most important piece of information in the world to us.

My brother stood watching the direction the man had disappeared into, then turned back to me.

"…Temel," he said aloud, testing the name. He seemed to be pressing it into his mouth so he wouldn't lose it.

"…I'm memorizing it too," I said. "Temel, Temel."

That made him smile — the first smile I'd seen from him in days. I was so glad to see it that I looked at his face longer than I needed to.

. . .

That night we started walking again in the direction the man had pointed.

It was an unusually bright moon. I picked my way by its light, watching the ground. Our shadows stretched long ahead of us, shifting shape with every step. I tried to gauge, from those shadows, how far we'd come. I couldn't.

"…This Temel person — do you think he's worth meeting?" I asked.

"…If these footprints belong to Father," my brother said, "I'll meet anyone. I'm not letting anything slip past me now."

"…What if they're not Father's?" I asked again. Asking that question frightened me, but that night, for some reason, it came out on its own.

My brother stopped walking and looked at me. He was quiet for a moment.

"…I'll still meet him," he said finally. "Even if it's not Father — if whoever left those tracks is someone else lost and wandering without a name, like us. Then it's still good for someone to go find them."

That answer surprised me a little. My brother had always been someone with a clear purpose. But that day, there was something in his answer that went beyond purpose. I didn't know exactly what it was, not then.

That night we walked under the stars again for the first time in a while. There were no clouds, so the road showed clearly. I wanted to believe that was a good sign.

Walking, I watched my brother's back. His shoe was still coming apart. But his stride had picked up. I couldn't tell whether that quickness came from anxiety or from hope. Probably both.

He kept lifting his eyes to the stars as he walked. I couldn't tell if it was to find the way, or just because he wanted something to lean on. He had never been a person who prayed openly to the sky. But that night, I watched his eyes rest there, longer than usual.

I wrote down what had happened that day as we walked — the footprints, the man, the name Temel. My handwriting still slanted sideways. Still, I tried not to leave out a single letter. I believed a day would come when I'd read this whole road to Father, start to finish.

As night deepened, the wind turned cold again. I folded the paper and tucked it inside my clothes, and took my brother's arm instead. He lowered his arm

without a word so I could hold on. I think that small kindness was the warmest moment of that whole day.

Somewhere far off, a wild animal cried once. I froze. My brother gripped my hand and said, "…It's all right, that's far away," and I believed him. Most things my brother said, I could believe.

The sound didn't come again. Instead, the wind kept combing through the dry grass. That sound felt louder to me than the animal's cry had. Even on a night when nothing happened, the world kept making some sound or other.

We walked quite late that night. Our legs ached, but neither of us suggested stopping. I don't think it was only impatience. The moment we stopped walking, it felt like the hope we'd been building would stop too, if only for a moment.

Finally my brother slowed and spoke first.

"…Let's stop here for today. I know your legs hurt."

"…Yours hurt too," I said.

He laughed instead of answering. We set down our packs and settled in. Before lying down, I looked up at the stars one more time. Still not one constellation name came back to me. But that night, strangely, it didn't feel sad.

I set that thought down as this chapter's last line. I understood, that day, that my brother was no longer someone gathering evidence, or someone raging alone. My brother had become someone searching. And I had become the one who kept the record of his search.

(Continued in Chapter 26.)

Chapter 26. The Man Who Finds People

> *_Previously_ — The brother and sister found a stranger's footprints. A traveler confirmed that the man had been walking along counting numbers, and told them the name of someone who finds people: "Temel."*

Two days later, we really did meet Temel.

He wasn't a big man. He carried his pack light. His eyes never stopped moving over his surroundings.

His pack was far more modest than ours. That struck me as odd. I'd expected someone who traveled the country finding people to carry more, not less — but he looked instead like a man who carried only what he strictly needed. I didn't know the reason then.

His walk was unusual. Not hurried, not slow. It was the walk of someone who already knew exactly where he was going. Watching it put me strangely at ease. I felt certain this man wouldn't get lost.

"…Are you the one who finds people?" my brother asked.

Temel stopped and looked at us. For just a moment, something flickered in his eyes.

"…Something like that," Temel said. "Who are you looking for?"

In that moment I felt something strange in Temel's eyes. The look of someone who had repeated the same work for a very long time. Not tired — worn familiar.

His hands drew my attention too. Dirt was packed into his fingernails in layer upon layer — not dirt that would wash off in one washing. They were the hands of someone who had walked a long way.

There were small scars scattered across the backs of his hands as well, like marks from pushing through thornbrush. Looking at them, I understood that for this man, finding people wasn't simply walking a road — it was a thing his body took blows for.

"…Don't your hands hurt?" I asked without thinking.

Temel looked down at his own hands.

"…They hurt when they hurt," he said. "But this isn't pain. This is just old."

That distinction stayed with me. I'd never before met someone who separated *old* from *painful* like that.

"…Our father," my brother said, his voice trembling slightly. "He walks counting numbers. He's forgotten his name too."

Temel closed his eyes briefly at that, as if remembering something.

"…Finding someone like that can take a long time," Temel said. "Are you all right with that?"

"…Yes," my brother said immediately. No hesitation at all.

"…We met Speon and Mena," my brother added. "They didn't mention you, but we found our way to you on our own."

Something shifted, faintly, in Temel's expression at those two names.

"…Are they well?" Temel asked. His voice held both gladness and caution at once.

"…Yes," I said. "Each of them is doing well, where they are."

Temel nodded and didn't ask further. In that silence, I felt there was an old story between the three of them that we knew nothing about.

A faint shadow crossed Temel's eyes for a moment. I couldn't tell if it was grief or longing. Maybe both. What it might feel like to hear news of people you hadn't seen in a long time, delivered by two strange children's mouths — I couldn't have imagined it, then.

"…Does Speon still keep the well?" Temel asked suddenly.

"…Yes," I said. "People keep coming to it, I hear."

Temel smiled faintly at that. It looked like a smile he hadn't worn in a long time.

"…That's him," Temel said. And didn't go on.

He gazed off into the distance for a moment. I felt that his eyes weren't turned toward Speon's well, but toward somewhere much further away. Probably toward some era we didn't yet know.

"…And Mena?" I asked carefully. "I heard she became a Recorder."

Temel's eyes softened at that name too.

"…She's probably doing it well, being Mena," Temel said. "She was always careful about everything. The one of the three of us who forgot the least."

Listening to that, I thought of the writing tool Mena had given me. It was still in my hand even then. That was the first time I truly felt how far the things these three people had left with each other still reached.

. . .

My brother told Temel about Father. The brick-counting habit, the footprints, the numbers.

Temel listened and nodded.

"…I've seen people like that a few times," Temel said. "People who've lost their names usually repeat something with their hands or their mouths. Something they used to do stays in the body."

"…Why is that?" I asked.

"…I don't know exactly either," Temel said. "But the body seems to remember longer than the mind. The mind loses hold of a name. The hands keep counting bricks."

"…Then can you tell what someone used to do, just by looking at their body?" my brother asked, leaning forward slightly.

"…To some degree," Temel said. "If there's a callus on the hand, it's someone who held something for a long time. If the walk leans to one side, it's someone who carried something for a long time. The body doesn't lie much."

My brother glanced down at his own palm. There was still a callus there from Brick Hollow. I saw him slide that hand quickly into his pocket.

"…Can you tell about us too?" my brother asked.

"…I can. A lot," Temel said. "Both of you have hands that carried something for a long time."

Hearing that, I thought of Father's hands. I tried to imagine what they might be doing right now. Just imagining it hurt.

"…If he finds his name," I asked, "does that mean he'll go back to how he was?"

Temel shook his head.

"…Not always," Temel said. "Even finding a name doesn't mean going back to exactly who you were before. But it's better than not having one."

That answer didn't comfort me much. But strangely, I was grateful for the honesty. Temel didn't give us false hope.

"…Then why do you keep going out to find people?" I asked. "You just said they don't come back exactly the same."

Temel stopped walking for a moment and looked at me.

"…Even if they don't come back exactly the same, it's still better than not looking," Temel said. "Finding someone's name doesn't bring everything back about them. But at least, you don't leave them wandering alone."

Hearing that, something in me ached. Temel wasn't promising a perfect outcome, and yet he had a reason not to give up. I didn't understand, then, how that was possible.

"…So can you find him?" my brother asked urgently.

"…I'm someone who finds people," Temel said. "But I'm not someone who carries answers around. I'm someone who goes looking."

I didn't really understand the difference in those words at the time. I do now. Temel wasn't someone who gave you certainty. He was someone who walked alongside you.

"…What if we find him and he's not Father?" I asked. It frightened me to ask, but it had to be asked.

My brother turned to look at me. His face said it was unexpected, that I'd been the one to raise it. I didn't look away from him. I thought someone had to name that possibility out loud.

"…Then that person still deserves to be found, on their own terms," Temel said. "There's no wasted step in the search. Whoever you're looking for, the walking still means something."

"…Has that happened to you? Finding someone and it wasn't the person you wanted?" my brother asked.

Temel nodded.

"…It has," Temel said shortly. He said nothing further. I felt a long story hiding inside that shortness.

That answer comforted me in a strange way. For the first time, I understood that this journey might not be a complete failure even if we never found Father.

"…What happened to that person, then?" I asked again. "The one you found who wasn't who you wanted."

Temel stopped and looked up at the sky for a moment.

"…That person was also looking for their own family," Temel said. "So I helped find them too. In the end, we found them. I stood beside them and watched that reunion. It wasn't the person I'd been looking for. But I cried, that day."

Hearing that story, my chest filled strangely full. For the first time, I sensed, dimly, that searching might be something larger than simply getting what you'd hoped for.

My brother didn't answer that. But I saw his expression loosen a little. He had always measured a journey only by its outcome. That day, I felt something like a different standard beginning to grow in him.

. . .

"…Why do you do this work?" I asked.

Temel looked off into the distance for a moment.

"…A long time ago, I ran from a place where I was supposed to be guiding someone," Temel said. "I was afraid, back then. Now I'm still afraid sometimes. But I don't run anymore. That's the only way I know how to pay it back."

Hearing that, I thought it sounded like something Speon had once said. I didn't know it then — that these two had truly come out of the same story.

"…Where did you run from?" my brother asked, his voice careful.

Temel hesitated before answering.

"…I had to guide some people across a certain place," Temel said. "But I got scared and stopped partway. Some of them made it across without me. Some didn't."

Temel's voice cracked slightly there. I didn't press further. Some stories, I learned in that silence, it's a courtesy not to hear to the end.

"…Weren't you scared? The moment you wanted to run again?" I asked.

"…Every time," Temel admitted honestly. "Even now, sometimes. But if you run because you're afraid, you find yourself running from then on. So I just

walk, still afraid."

I held onto that sentence for a long time afterward. I didn't fully understand its weight then. I do now. It was a sentence we would need to learn again and again for the rest of this journey.

"…Can't you wait until you're not afraid anymore?" I asked.

Temel laughed shortly at the question.

"…I tried waiting like that too," Temel said. "But the day of not-being-afraid never came. So I decided to just start while still afraid. It was the only way there was."

My brother listened to this quietly. I could feel his eyes turning something over. He, too, had always been someone who waited for certainty before he acted.

A gust of wind blew hard, once. Temel shouldered his pack and started walking again. I noticed that he didn't stop walking even right after saying he was afraid. I'd never before met someone whose words and steps stayed that closely joined.

"…Do you still see that person now?" I asked.

Temel laughed briefly. There was a trace of loneliness in the laugh.

"…Sometimes," Temel said. "Not as often as you'd think. But every time I do, it feels exactly the same as before."

. . .

Temel led us north for several more days, watching the ground the whole way — the direction dry grass had been trampled, scratches on stones, even the depth of footprints.

Temel's own steps looked far more at ease than ours. But watch closely, and his eyes never rested for a moment. Following his pace, I felt for the first time how exhausting searching really was. It wore out the eyes before it wore out the body.

On the second day, Temel suddenly stopped and crouched to the ground. We stopped too. He studied one very small mark in the dirt for a long time, then finally shook his head and stood back up.

"…Not it," Temel said briefly.

I understood, only then, that this small disappointment was something Temel lived through several times a day. A searcher's day was mostly filled with confirming *not this one*.

At night, Temel always kept the fire small. "Too big and you can't find anyone," he said. "Someone searching shouldn't stand too bright. The one you're looking for won't be able to see you." I understood that and didn't understand it, both at once.

I sat by that small fire that night and tried to measure with my eyes how narrow its reach was. Only as far as our three sets of knees. Beyond that, all darkness.

I understood, then. A person who searches doesn't light up the whole world. They light only the ground at their own feet, and keep walking by that light.

Through those four days, my brother slept fitfully every night. I heard him turning and turned restlessly too, alongside him. Temel never tried to stop us. He simply, wordlessly, packed up each morning and walked on.

On the second night, half-asleep, I heard Temel humming low to himself. It wasn't really a song, more like breath given shape. I listened without opening my eyes. There was, strangely, an old grief in that sound, and beneath it, some rhythm that refused to stop.

On the third morning I saw Temel's shoes. As worn as ours. Layers of patched sole overlapped several times. I thought those shoes showed, plainly, all the time this man had walked.

On the third day, the path narrowed and trees began to appear here and there. Temel's steps slowed bit by bit — steps that were watching something more carefully.

"…We're getting close," Temel said. Not a voice full of certainty. But my heart began pounding at those words anyway.

"…Found it," Temel said quietly on the fourth night. Far off, a small light was visible.

That light was very small. So small that I checked, several times, whether it was really fire or only something my eyes had made up. A single small light had never felt so enormous.

Temel pointed at the light and lowered his voice.

"…Don't rush," Temel said. "Confirm first, then approach. If gladness gets ahead of you, you could end up hurt."

At that, I let some of the strength go out of my legs. I'd wanted nothing but to run. My brother looked the same. His hand was gripping mine hard enough to hurt.

"…This is the closest we've ever gotten," my brother said quietly. His voice shook. "I… I don't know what to do."

"…Me neither," I said. We stood there and listened to each other's breathing for a moment.

The moment I saw that light, I set down this chapter's last line here. I gripped my brother's hand tight again. I couldn't know whether that light was Father or not. But in that moment, for the first time, I felt with my whole body that you could walk forward without knowing the answer.

(Continued in Chapter 27.)

Chapter 27. Before the Firelight

> *_Previously_ — The brother and sister met Temel. Along with his words — "There's no wasted step in the search" — they spotted, on the fourth night, a small light far off in the distance.*

We crept toward that light with careful steps.

The grass brushed quietly underfoot. I set each step down heel to toe, trying to kill even that sound.

A faint scent of smoke was mixed into the night air. The instant I caught it, my heart reacted before my mind did. There are things the body knows faster than thought.

A small campfire. Someone sat beside it. His back was to us, so I couldn't see his face. But his hand kept moving — a motion of counting something in the air.

The back was bent. The set of the shoulders was unfamiliar. And yet I couldn't tear my eyes away from that silhouette.

The hand moved with a steady rhythm, like a motion carved into the body long ago.

It never stopped, never hurried. That regularity seemed, somehow, less like a person than a clock.

There was no wind that night. The flame burned straight up, hardly flickering at all. I found that stillness strangely frightening.

A few dry branches lay neatly beside the fire. Not piled carelessly — laid side by side, matched for length.

That neatness troubled me. I couldn't understand why someone alone would keep things arranged so carefully.

I slowed my steps. My brother did too. We both tried not to make a sound. Even the sound of grass underfoot felt like something to be careful of.

We stopped every few steps. The wish to get closer and the wish to draw this moment out a little longer were both in me at once. I felt those two wishes fighting each other as I walked.

Temel walked half a step behind us. He didn't lead. It was the distance of someone who knew this walk belonged to us.

The moment I saw that hand, I stopped walking. I felt my brother stop at the same instant. We gripped each other's hands tight, right there.

The closer we came, the more a small sound reached us. A voice made almost without moving the lips.

"…two thousand nine hundred ninety-seven, two thousand nine hundred ninety-eight…"

Hearing those numbers, the strength went out of my legs. I knew exactly where that number stood. It was nearly at three thousand. I understood, for the first time, that Father had not once, not a single time since that night, made it all the way to three thousand.

I tried to measure the distance between those two numbers — two thousand nine hundred ninety-eight, and three thousand. Barely two. And yet Father had failed to cross those two for years.

I stood there and folded down my fingers. One, two. That was all. That short distance had become, for Father, a wall he could not climb.

A moment later, the count started over from the beginning. One, two, three.

I listened to that return and couldn't say a word.

I understood then. Father hadn't failed to reach three thousand. Every time he came close, he was dragged back to that night, and made to start again from the beginning, every time.

His voice was low and cracked. And yet the accent — the accent alone — was exactly the one I remembered from Brick Hollow.

I felt years of time collapse in an instant, hearing that single accent.

Temel stopped too, and listened to the sound in silence. He said nothing. I understood that silence as the silence of someone who had already lived through moments like this many times before.

Even Temel's breathing went very quiet. I understood that quiet as a kindness meant for us.

Temel's hand rested on my shoulder for just a moment. No words. But the weight of that hand alone told me: nothing should be rushed now.

. . .

Temel moved ahead of us, quietly.

"…Excuse me," Temel said, low. "Are you all right?"

The voice was very small. And yet it carried clearly through that stillness.

The man's hand stopped. The counting stopped with it. Even that stillness felt as sharp as a sound.

The man slowly turned his head.

The movement was slow, like a neck creaking.

That short instant felt very long to me. For those few seconds, I forgot how to breathe.

The moment I saw that face, my breath caught. It was a face that hadn't aged, hadn't changed. I saw that face for the first time since the last night in Brick Hollow. It was Father.

I reached for my brother's hand in that instant. He was already reaching for mine. Our hands found each other exactly, in the dark.

The firelight flickered faintly across that face. The eyebrows, the nose, the lips. I ran my eyes over each of them again, checking, as if confirming.

My brother had frozen in place too. He couldn't say a word. I saw years' worth of feeling pass across his face all at once — anger, relief, fear, and fear again.

His two hands opened weakly at his sides, then closed again. Hands that wanted to grab hold of something but couldn't find what.

Temel turned quietly to look at us. He seemed about to say something, then simply stepped back instead. A step back that left this moment to us.

Even so, Temel didn't disappear completely. He stood still a few steps off in the dark. A place from which to watch without stepping in.

I still remember that step back. That there are moments when giving someone space matters as much as staying beside them — I learned that for the first time then.

The campfire crackled once. In that moment, it sounded like the loudest sound in the world.

A single spark leapt up and vanished into the dark.

I followed that spark's vanishing point with my eyes for a long time. Where it rose to, nothing remained.

The night sky hung low. The stars looked unusually close. I felt that night stepping quietly aside for us.

I felt my own heart beating along with that sound.

. . .

Father looked at us. But there was nothing in that gaze. It was the gaze one gives a stranger.

Seeing that gaze, my breath caught. We had walked for years to get here, and what we met was strangeness.

Father's clothes were worn. A different cloth from what we knew. His shoes had split soles too, just like ours. That long walk had settled itself into his body, exactly the way it had settled into ours.

A thin layer of dried dirt sat on the backs of his hands. Hands that hadn't been washed in a long time.

"…Who are you?" Father asked. His voice was exactly the same. And yet in that voice there was no weight toward us at all.

I couldn't say a word in that moment. My fingertips were trembling.

Heat rose in my throat. No words came out past it. I just stood and looked at Father's face.

I looked at his face again. The shape of his eyebrows, the small scar on his left cheek — all the same. But the look held in that face belonged entirely to someone else.

My brother stepped forward instead, one step. Dry leaves crunched underfoot.

"…Do you… know us?" he asked. His voice had completely broken down.

Father shook his head. His face was apologetic. But there was strangeness in that apology too.

The shake of his head was slow, careful — the movement of someone unsure even of that much.

My brother stood motionless for several seconds. I was watching only his back. His shoulders sank, just slightly.

There wasn't a breath of wind that night. Only the campfire's smoke rose straight up.

I followed that smoke with my eyes. Somewhere at a certain height, it scattered without a sound.

I thought, that night, for the first time, that some things don't disappear — they simply travel to where they can no longer be seen.

I wanted to reach out and touch that shoulder. But I couldn't move. Neither my brother nor I had the strength, in that moment, even to touch each other.

"…I don't know," Father said. "I'm sorry. I… don't really know who I am, either."

Father's voice trembled slightly at the end of that sentence. Something other than apology was mixed into that tremor. I didn't know what it was, then.

I hesitated, again and again, over whether to reach out my hand. It felt like taking a stranger's hand. It also felt like taking the most familiar hand in the world.

My fingertips paused in midair for a moment. Father waited quietly for that hand. He didn't hurry it.

Only then did I reach out and take Father's hand. It was trembling. It carried the exact same warmth as the hand that had held mine the night we crossed the boundary stones, long ago.

I crossed years of time on that single warmth.

Father's hand was cold at first. It warmed, little by little, while I held it.

I couldn't tell whether that warmth was mine or Father's. I didn't want to tell the difference either.

"…I'm Elpis," I said. My voice cracked. "I'm Elpis. I'm your daughter."

Only after I'd said it did the tears finally come.

"…I'm Jeteo," my brother managed to say. His voice shook. "I'm your son."

My brother said it with his fists clenched tight. I knew that was the hand that was holding back tears.

Father quietly tried the name out too. "…Jeteo." Slowly, like someone learning an unfamiliar sound.

My brother heard that pronunciation and couldn't say anything. He just watched the shape of Father's mouth.

The firelight lit only half my brother's face. The other half stayed sunk in darkness. I couldn't see what expression he was wearing in that dark half.

Father's hand gave a very faint twitch in that moment. His eyes still saw nothing they recognized. But that hand alone was responding to something.

I watched that tremor exactly. I didn't know, then, whether it was memory or just a habit left in the body. I still don't know exactly, even now. But I decided to hold onto that single tremor.

My brother must have seen it too. He said nothing, but his eyes never left that hand.

I stroked that hand gently. The knuckles were thicker than they used to be. A hand that had held something and walked for a long time.

There were new calluses in the palm. I didn't know what road they'd been made on. But I wanted to feel each of them out with my fingertips all the same.

I thought those calluses were a list of the days Father had passed through. I couldn't read that list. Still, I didn't lift my fingertips away from them.

I held that hand a little longer. Father didn't pull it back.

Somewhere far off, a night bird cried once, briefly, and stopped. Besides that, there was no other sound at all.

My brother came quietly closer too and took Father's other hand. Father didn't shake that one off either. We sat like that for a while, saying nothing, just holding hands in front of the fire.

The firelight lit each of our three faces in turn. No one broke that silence first.

The campfire was slowly dying down. No one added more wood. Even that fading felt like something none of us wanted to disturb.

I set that answer down as this chapter's last line. In that moment I learned, for the first time, that finding and losing could happen at once. Father was there before us. And Father was, at the same time, farther from us than anyone.

(Continued in Chapter 28.)

Chapter 28. How to Sit Beside Someone

> *_Previously_ — The brother and sister found Father at last. But he recognized neither their names nor their faces. "I don't really know who I am, either." When Elpis took his hand, it trembled faintly — a response that might have been memory, or might have been only habit.*

That night, my brother sat alone a little apart from Father.

The embers had nearly burned out already. Only a thin thread of smoke still rose. I watched that smoke disappear for a long time. It felt like I couldn't bear it unless I was watching something.

The night air had turned far colder than before. I felt that chill sinking into me and still didn't want to move. There was a strange fear that if I left this spot, everything that had happened today would stop being real.

I went and sat beside my brother. Neither of us said anything.

The night air was cold. I leaned lightly against my brother's shoulder. He didn't pull away. But he didn't wrap his arm around me the way he usually did, either. That didn't hurt my feelings. He looked, right then, like he didn't even have the strength for it.

His breathing was much shallower than usual. Listening to it, I felt how hard he was working not to cry. He was always like that. When he held back tears, his breath went careful first.

I understood, then, what my brother was holding back. He must have imagined this moment for years. And nowhere in that imagining, I think, had there ever

been a scene where Father didn't recognize us.

I tried to picture the reunion my brother must have imagined all this time. Probably Father, seeing us, calling our names and running to us. I tried to measure the distance between that imagined scene and tonight's reality, and gave up quickly. It hurt too much.

"…I feel really wrong," my brother said suddenly. "We found Father, and instead of joy, what I feel most is fear. Is that normal?"

"…I don't know," I said. "But I feel something similar too."

He looked at me, a little surprised. I hoped that knowing he wasn't the only one who felt this strange would bring him at least some comfort.

Insects called low, steadily. I was strangely grateful that the sound never broke off. It felt like proof the world hadn't stopped completely.

Far off, I could see Father still counting something with his fingers. He didn't seem to be sleeping either.

His profile showed in the moonlight — the silhouette of a stranger. And yet the line of that silhouette's shoulders was exactly as I remembered. I couldn't tell whether that fact made me glad or sad.

"…How long does that go on for?" my brother asked quietly. I couldn't tell if he was asking me, or just thinking aloud.

I couldn't answer. I didn't know either.

"…It used to be," my brother said again, his voice thick, "the goal was to make that counting stop. But now I'm scared that if it stops, Father will turn into someone completely different."

"…Same for me," I said. "That motion — I hate it, and somehow I'm still scared it'll disappear."

My brother turned to look at me. It was the first time he'd heard someone say exactly what he was thinking.

"…You thought that too?" he asked.

"…Yes," I said. "I just didn't say it."

Hearing that, I understood how tangled my brother's heart really was. He wanted to have Father back, and at the same time he was afraid of losing even this Father in front of him.

. . .

Temel sat down quietly beside us.

"…I've seen this happen a few times," Temel said. "Forcing memory to come back only makes it more afraid. Just staying beside someone comes first."

"…What good does that do?" my brother asked. There was an edge to his voice. "That person doesn't even know who we are."

He rubbed roughly at his eyes as he said it. I understood that gesture was closer to grief than to anger.

"…Whether it does any good, you might learn later — or you might not," Temel said. "But staying beside someone is the one thing you can actually do right now, whether they recognize you or not."

"…But he doesn't know us," my brother said again. His voice shook a little. "Doesn't know we're here right now. Doesn't know what we're holding back."

He glanced toward Father as he said it. Still sitting there, fingers moving. I saw resentment and longing pass through my brother's eyes at the same time.

"…That's true," Temel admitted plainly. "But staying beside someone was never about being recognized for it. It's just being there."

Hearing that, I strangely thought of the Ledger's voice. The Ledger would never take in what it couldn't "resolve." Temel was telling us to stay beside someone even when it couldn't be resolved. I thought, for the first time that day, that difference might be the answer this whole book was reaching for.

I remembered the smooth screen we'd seen back in Haven. Intake, resolution, completion. Nowhere among those three words was there any entry called "staying beside." I felt, for the first time, that I could name exactly what the Ledger couldn't do.

"…Did you have someone who stayed beside you like that?" I asked.

Temel was quiet for a long time, then nodded, small.

"…I did," Temel said. "If it hadn't been for that person, I'd probably still be running."

"…What kind of person were they?" I asked.

Temel searched for words a moment.

"…Hard to explain," Temel said. "But one thing's certain. That person never chased after me when I ran. They just kept being there, in the place I'd come back to."

"…Did that person ever fail to recognize you too?" I asked again.

Temel looked at me for a moment, choosing his answer.

"…No," Temel said. "It was the opposite. I was the one who failed to recognize them. More than once."

Hearing that, something in me settled strangely. It comforted me to know that failing to recognize the person staying beside you didn't only happen to our family.

"…So do you recognize them now?" I asked.

Temel paused before answering.

"…Sometimes I do, sometimes I still get confused," Temel said honestly. "But I recognize them much faster than I used to."

"…When?" my brother asked, unable to hide his curiosity.

Temel smiled slightly.

"…Plenty of times," Temel said. "There were times I was wary of them, thinking they were a stranger. There were times I didn't recognize them even standing right in front of me. I only understood, afterward."

"…And they still stayed with you, even so?" I asked.

"…That person stayed even when I couldn't recognize them," Temel said. "That came first. Not my recognizing."

"…So it didn't depend on whether you recognized them — they were on your side from the start?" my brother asked. There was a caution in his voice I hadn't heard from him before.

Temel looked at my brother for a long moment at that question.

"…Seems that way," Temel said. "But back then, I didn't even think to call it being on my side. I just thought they were a nuisance."

I copied that line down on paper that night. I read that sentence over several times. Being there before being recognized. I only half understood what it meant, back then.

"…When you didn't recognize them, did they get upset?" I asked.

Temel shook his head.

"…Didn't even seem upset," Temel said. "Just stayed, like they were waiting for the day I'd recognize them. I found that stranger than anything. If it were me, I'd have given up long before and left."

That night I took out paper again after a long while and wrote down what had happened. My hands were too cold and the letters kept shaking. Still, I tried not to leave out a single line. Father, the hand-counting, Temel's words. I wrote it imagining the day I'd someday read all of this back to Father.

At the bottom of that page I added one more line. "Being there, before being recognized." I traced my fingertip over that sentence several times. As if doing so might press its meaning into my own body.

My brother glanced over at the paper beside me.

"…Can you write that down for me too?" he asked.

The request surprised me enough that I looked at him for a moment. He'd never shown much interest in my writing before. Without a word, I tore a corner off the page and copied the sentence again, and handed it to him. He folded it carefully and tucked it inside his shirt.

. . .

The next morning, the sun still hung low. Dew beaded on every blade of grass. Father was already up, tidying the fire pit. It looked as though his body moved on its own, without anyone telling it to.

There was still a chill of night left in the air. I breathed it in deep. I wanted to confirm that yesterday hadn't been a dream.

My brother had woken before me. His eyes were swollen. I pretended not to notice the swelling. There was no need to say out loud that he'd cried alone all night.

Watching him, I felt a strange feeling. A man who had forgotten his own name, who didn't recognize even us — and yet the touch of his hands, tidying the fire each morning, remained exactly the same. I thought that was another trace still left inside Father.

Father covered the ashes with dirt and stacked the remaining firewood neatly. The motion was so smooth that, for a moment, it overlapped in my mind with Father tending the fire each dawn back in Brick Hollow. I held onto that overlap for a long time.

My brother went over to Father.

"…Will you come with us?" he asked carefully. "In case you don't know where else to go."

Father looked at him for a long moment. The eyes of someone looking at a stranger, still. But in that gaze there was, faintly, something that wasn't wariness.

I tried not to let that shift in his eyes slip past me. A tiny difference between yesterday and today. But that small difference felt, to me, like an enormous signal.

Father was fidgeting with a small twig in his hand. It looked like a habit — hands that couldn't stay still when something felt uncertain. That habit, too, was both unfamiliar and familiar to me.

Father set the twig down and looked back at my brother. Wariness and curiosity were mixed in that gaze together.

"…Why are you helping me?" Father asked.

My brother lost his words for a moment. I knew he wanted to say *because you're my father.* But he chose different words.

"…No reason," my brother said. "It's fine to help without a reason."

Hearing that answer, I was startled. My brother had always believed there was no such thing as a reasonless act — back in Haven. I felt, right then, that he was slowly becoming a different person.

I saw my brother look surprised at himself, even as he said it — like someone hearing his own words a beat late. He paused, then went on.

"…The old me wouldn't have said this," he told Father. "But lately… I think there are things without reasons after all. No — I think there are reasons even when you can't put them into words."

Father listened to that quietly. His face wasn't one of full understanding. But it was a face that felt something.

Father tilted his head at that answer.

"…That's a strange answer," Father said. But he was smiling. "But it's not a strangeness I dislike."

"…People who help without a reason always seem strange," my brother said. "I didn't used to trust people like that either, until not long ago."

"…And now?" Father asked.

My brother thought for a moment.

"…Now I trust it a little. Just a little."

Temel stood watching this from a short distance off. I saw a very faint smile cross his face. A smile that looked, somehow, quietly pleased.

Temel kept glancing our way several times that morning while packing his things. In that gaze I felt relief, and also a small trace of loneliness. It was the face of someone watching the people he'd found find their own way to each other.

"…Have you seen a lot of us turning out like this?" I asked, going over to Temel.

"…Not often," Temel said. "But every time I see it, I'm glad. It's not something happening to me directly, and still it fills my chest, strangely, like it's my own."

"…Why does someone else's business fill your chest?" I asked.

Temel laughed a little.

"…There's a moment when it stops being someone else's business," Temel said. "Spend a few days delivering someone somewhere, and it starts feeling like your own business whether they turn out all right. Strange, but true."

Hearing that, I looked at Temel again. I thought, then, that finding people might be, in its own way, the same as sharing your own portion of joy with someone else.

. . .

In the end, Father nodded.

My brother held out his hand. Father looked at it a moment, then slowly laid his own hand on top of it. Less a handshake than a gesture of confirming something for the first time.

I stood quietly watching those two hands. One was a stranger's hand, and one was a hand long waited for. But in that moment, I couldn't tell which was which.

The morning sun fell slanting across the two hands. I watched that light fall equally on both. Under the light, the stranger's hand and the long-awaited hand weren't different at all.

Far off, a bird passed low, calling once. I thought that sound was carving this morning into some place, somewhere. A sound that, heard again later, would bring this day back.

"…Then… I'll take you up on that," Father said.

I found myself wondering, out of nowhere, what Speon would have said if he were here. Probably, *that's the well's way.* Giving someone a place beside you without asking why.

Temel heard that and turned back from packing his things.

"…You know," Temel said, "*take you up on that* — I haven't heard someone say that in a long time. These days everyone tries to handle everything on their own. Nobody says they'll take anyone up on anything anymore."

I listened to that and thought of Haven. No one there had ever taken anyone up on anything. The Ledger resolved everything for them instead. Only now did it seem to me that hadn't been convenience — it had been loneliness.

I set that line down as this chapter's last line. Hearing it, I nearly laughed. Father had told us he'd "take us up on it." I understood, then, for the first time, that becoming someone who walks alongside another can come before becoming someone they recognize again.

(Continued in Chapter 29.)

Chapter 29. While He Had No Name

> *_Previously_ — The brother and sister began learning not to force Father's memory back, but simply to stay beside him. Father, to these strangers, said, "…I'll take you up on that," and agreed to walk with them.*

From that day on, the four of us walked together.

The road was often too narrow for four to walk abreast. Even so, we lined up single file if we had to, keeping close enough that our hands could still reach each other. Strangely, I felt a kind of sturdiness even in that narrow line.

A faint scent of dry grass hung in the morning air. Every time I caught it, I felt, a little more, that we were heading a little further south, a little further toward safety. It wasn't certain. But I wanted to believe it.

Father's steps were a little slower than ours. Legs unused to long walking. But he never once said he was tired. He just stopped, now and then, to look up at the sky.

Every time he did, my brother matched his pace to stand beside him. I'd thought that was only consideration for Father — later I realized my brother was every bit as worn out as Father was. He was simply a boy used to hiding his own exhaustion.

The shadows of the trees along the road always lay long before we reached them. Every time I stepped on those shadows, I found myself gauging what part of the day we were passing through.

I listened to the sound of my brother's footsteps as we walked. A little heavier than before. I didn't think that weight came only from fatigue. Lately he seemed like someone constantly weighing something in his mind.

Every time the wind blew, the dry grass leaned low and rose back up again. Watching it, I thought that the four of us were doing the same — leaning down and rising back up, over and over.

Father still counted on his fingers sometimes. But he no longer counted without stopping, the way he used to. I didn't know if that was a good sign or not.

Every time I saw that gesture, my heart felt tangled. I wanted it to stop. But at the same time, I was afraid to see it stop — afraid it might be the only proof left that Father had ever been Father.

Sometimes I secretly counted along with the movement of Father's fingers. One, two, three. I wanted to see how far he got before he broke off. Most times it scattered somewhere around twenty. I couldn't tell if that meant he was improving, or if his mind had simply wandered somewhere else.

Every time my brother saw that gesture, he would quietly take Father's hand. At first Father startled. After a few days, he stopped pulling the hand away.

"…Strangely, holding this hand makes me feel calmer," Father said. "I don't know why."

Hearing that, I looked at my brother's face. He said nothing. But I saw that his eyes were wet.

He turned away and looked off into the distance for a moment. I knew he was hiding his tears. I pretended not to see.

I too sometimes took Father's other hand. Father always let it go into mine easily. I noticed the temperature of that hand was a little different every day. Some days it was cold; some days, surprisingly warm.

I wondered if that shift in temperature might be tied to something in how Father was feeling. There was no way to check. But every time I held that hand, I felt like I could tell, a little, what kind of day Father had had.

Father found that talk of temperature strange and interesting.

"…I never even paid attention to my own hand's temperature," Father said.

"…I pay attention," I said. "Because it's your hand."

Father smiled a little at that. Half embarrassed, half glad.

"…It's warm today," I said.

"…Is it?" Father said, looking down at his own hand. "I can't really tell. But if my daughter says so, I suppose it is."

That was the first time I heard him use the word "daughter." A word Father had chosen to explain me. He didn't know my name. But he knew my place. That single fact alone let me get through that day.

That evening I told my brother the story. He listened quietly and laughed shortly.

"…Something similar happened to me too," he said. "Yesterday, when we shared the water, Father told me, '…drink first, since you're the older one.' *Older one* — first time he'd used that word too."

"…Older one?" I asked. "Father called you older brother?"

"…Yeah. I was surprised too," my brother said. "But that word keeps circling back in my mind, for some reason."

Hearing that, I understood. Father had lost his name, but he still distinguished the places we held between us. I thought that wasn't complete memory, but it wasn't complete forgetting either.

"…Why did the word *older one* stay with you like that?" I asked.

My brother thought for a moment before answering.

"…I don't know, it's just been a long time since anyone saw me as an older brother," he said. "Nobody in Haven ever called me that. They only ever called me by a number, or a status."

I nodded, hearing that. I'd felt something similar in Haven myself.

. . .

"…What should we call you?" my brother asked carefully, that first evening.

Father looked flustered at the question.

His eyes wandered the empty air for a moment. His brow drew together faintly, like someone searching for something.

"…I don't really know either," Father said. "It seems like… I don't have a name."

We couldn't say anything for a moment. Then I spoke first.

"…Then would it be all right if we chose one for you? If your real name comes back someday, we can just change it then."

Father looked at me for a moment. In that gaze there was strangeness, and also, faintly, something like trust.

"…Doesn't it feel strange, asking someone else to name you?" Father asked.

"…It is strange," I said. "But right now, strange feels like the ordinary thing."

Father smiled a little at that. It looked like a smile I hadn't seen in a long time.

"…I'd like that," Father said.

"…If it's ever a burden, just say so," my brother added. "We'll just make something up."

"…No," Father shook his head. "It's not that. It's just unfamiliar. But unfamiliar isn't necessarily unwelcome."

My brother said nothing through that whole exchange. I could feel him turning something over deeply.

"…What's wrong?" I asked.

"…Nothing," my brother said. "I was just thinking about what it must be like, living without a name. We always had names. I thought that was just how things were."

Hearing that, I thought for the first time about how much space a name really takes up. Not having a name wasn't only having no word to be called by. It meant having no way to explain yourself to yourself.

"…You know," my brother said quietly, "everyone in Haven had a name. But it seemed like none of them really knew who they were, either. Like they had names and had still lost themselves."

I was surprised to hear that. I hadn't expected my brother would ever look back on Haven that way.

"…Is having a name different from knowing who you are?" I asked.

"…Yeah," my brother said. "I've been thinking that, lately."

. . .

That night we tried to think of a name. My brother couldn't settle on one at all. I felt like I could.

By the campfire, my brother opened his mouth several times and closed it again. He only muttered, "…there should be a name that fits him." I found it new, somehow, that my brother could grow this careful over choosing a single name.

"…What about *Waiting*?" I said. "It's the meaning behind someone's name I know."

Father said the name aloud, several times.

Slowly, rolling it in his mouth, then a bit faster — like someone testing whether the sound could belong to him.

"…Waiting," Father said. "Not bad. It does seem like I'm truly waiting for something right now."

"…What are you waiting for?" my brother asked.

Father thought for a moment.

"…I don't know. But the feeling of waiting for something — that much is certain."

Hearing that answer, I nearly cried. I understood, then. Father had forgotten his name, his face — but he hadn't forgotten the shape of that particular feeling, waiting. I couldn't be sure whether it was us he was waiting for. But I chose to believe it was.

In that moment I remembered how we'd been, back in Brick Hollow. It had always been us waiting for Father. Now Father was the one waiting for something. I found that reversal strange, and yet, somehow, natural too.

My brother said nothing in that moment. But I could tell he was repeating that name over and over in his mind. His lips moved soundlessly along with the two syllables.

From that day on, we called Father "Father" between ourselves, but used the name "Waiting" in front of others. It felt strange at first. Father, too, missed his cue to answer to his own new name more than once.

Every time I said that name, a strange feeling came over me. Calling out a name I myself had given. I thought it felt, somehow, like giving Father life a second time. I knew it was a strange thought, but I couldn't quite shake it.

"…Mr. Waiting." When someone on the road called out to him that way, Father always reacted a beat late. Every time, my brother would quietly tap Father's arm. A signal that meant: *that's you being called.*

Every time I saw that tap, I felt strangely settled. Beside someone who couldn't answer to their own name, there was someone else, sending the signal in their place. I thought that was needed even before a name was.

Once, in a market, a merchant asked, "…Mr. Waiting, how much would you like to pay for this?" Father let the words pass right by him. My brother quickly tugged his sleeve. "…Father, they're talking to you." Only then did Father startle and answer, "…oh, yes! Me!"

The merchant laughed and asked, "…why so surprised, when someone calls your name?" Father smiled sheepishly and only said, "…I'm still not used to it."

I watched that exchange and felt something cold settle in my chest. Even Father's own name was still, to him, an unfamiliar coat.

. . .

Temel walked with us for a few more days, then stopped at a fork in the road.

"…I have to take a different way from here," Temel said. "There's someone else waiting to be found."

"…Thank you," my brother said. There was real feeling in his voice.

I looked at Temel's worn pack. It looked even lighter than when we'd first met him. I thought it was probably from all the things he'd shared with us while we walked.

"…Where will you go now?" I asked.

"…Wherever someone needs me next," Temel said, smiling. "You never know where that is until you get there."

"…Doesn't living like that wear you out?" my brother asked.

Temel thought a moment before answering.

"…It does," Temel said. "But it beats stopping."

I turned that answer over for a long time. Someone who kept going despite being worn out. I hadn't seen many people like that, in Brick Hollow or in

Haven. Most people, once worn out, either stopped, or never set out to begin with, so as never to be worn out at all.

Father had been quietly watching Temel pack his things all this while. He watched, unblinking, like watching a familiar gesture. I couldn't tell what that gaze was directed at. Maybe Father, too, was faintly recalling some parting he himself had forgotten.

"…Have we been a burden to you at all?" I asked. "We kept you from your own work, following you around."

Temel shook his head.

"…Never thought of it as a burden," Temel said. "If anything, thanks to you two, I got to walk a few whole days alongside someone again, for once. Usually I find someone and we part right away."

"…So we were good for you too?" I asked again.

"…Yes," Temel said, smiling. "Much more than I expected."

Far off, I could hear wind combing through the dry grass. That sound seemed to go on, like the background music of this fork in the road. I thought that if partings had a fitting sound, it would be one like that.

Temel adjusted his pack straps and looked at each of us for a long moment. I understood that gaze as one preparing a last goodbye.

"…Will we get to see you again?" I asked. My throat tightened as I asked it.

"…I don't know," Temel said honestly. "But this road isn't so wide. We might cross paths again someday."

"…Please," my brother said, with unusual force.

Temel smiled at that.

Temel looked at us and spoke one last time.

"…Hold his place until your father finds his real name again. Losing a name doesn't have to mean losing the place where you're loved."

Father heard that and held out his hand to Temel. Temel took it.

"…Thank you," Father said. "For treating me this way, when even I don't know who I am."

"…There's always a reason to treat someone well, whether you know who they are or not," Temel said.

Father closed his eyes for a moment at that, then opened them. It wasn't the face of someone who'd fully understood. But it was the face of someone who had received something.

With that, Temel turned and walked off toward the other branch of the road. I watched his back grow smaller and smaller for a long time. At the last, Temel turned once and waved. I waved back.

Father waved toward that retreating back too. It was a strangely earnest gesture, for a farewell to a stranger. I thought that even if Father couldn't fully remember Temel, his body still knew, somehow, that he'd been someone precious.

My brother stayed rooted to the spot until Temel had completely disappeared. I stood quietly beside him, watching that empty road together.

Even after the sun had fully set, we stood there a little longer. No one suggested moving on first. I understood that silence as grief at the parting.

I set that line down as this chapter's last line. We parted with Temel that day and set off again, the three of us. I felt, for the first time, that this journey's purpose was shifting — from finding an answer, to holding a place.

(Continued in Chapter 30.)

Chapter 30. The Man Who Came in the Night

> *_Previously_ — The brother and sister gave Father a placeholder name, Waiting. Parting from Temel, they heard: "Losing a name doesn't have to mean losing the place where you're loved."*

That night, Father woke suddenly, screaming.

We had made camp under a small tree that day. It had been a long walk, so everyone fell asleep early. The last thing I remember is counting stars and drifting off.

That day's walk had been unusually long. For the first time, Father let a little of his tiredness show. "…Should we walk a bit more?" he'd asked, in a voice that watched our faces even as he said it. I thought that carefulness was another habit that had stayed with him.

Moonlight filtered through the leaves and trembled across Father's face. I remember it was the last thing I saw before falling asleep. He'd looked peaceful.

My brother was already sound asleep beside me. Days of built-up tension had made him fall asleep unusually fast. I remember listening to his breathing and feeling my own eyes drift shut, slowly.

Insects called low in the grass. I fell asleep to that sound like a lullaby. I never imagined that peace would be shattered completely before the night was through.

I've gone back to that night many times since. That evening, nothing had been wrong with any of us. Father had smiled twice; my brother had tended the fire; I had counted stars. I learned then that the nights that come apart never announce themselves first.

"…Where am I! Why am I here!" Father shouted. His eyes were wide open. Looking straight at us, and recognizing nothing at all.

My brother tried to go to him and Father recoiled. The movement was so fast that, for an instant, I was terrified he'd turned into an entirely different person.

Father's back struck the tree trunk. He didn't seem to feel it at all. Both hands were thrust forward, pushing us away.

A branch shook and a few dry leaves fell. Even that small sound made Father flinch and curl in on himself. I understood, then. It wasn't us Father was afraid of. It was this whole night.

"…No one's here but us," my brother said. "It's just the three of us."

"…Three?" Father asked back. "Who are the three?"

My brother couldn't answer that. I saw his mouth open, then shut without a word. He must have understood, right then, that saying our names would do no good at all.

I froze with fear in that moment. What frightened me more than the thought of Father attacking us was the sight of that gaze — a gaze that saw us as complete strangers.

"…It's all right, it's all right," my brother said, holding up both hands, keeping his voice as low as he could. "We won't hurt you."

Father didn't calm at that either. He kept gasping and looking around wildly. Watching him, unable to do anything, only made it more terrifying.

His eyes darted here and there. As if trying to recognize something, or as if just searching for a hole to run through. I couldn't find, in that gaze, a single trace of the gentle Father I'd seen by day.

I half hid behind my brother and watched Father. Under the moonlight his shadow looked unusually large and unsteady. I thought that shadow looked like it belonged to someone else entirely.

I understood, for the first time then, that getting Father back wasn't a single event. The Father who had held my hand last night, and the Father who didn't recognize us tonight, being the same person — that was what frightened me more.

My brother stood there, hands still raised, not moving. I saw him frozen in place, unable to move forward or back. The stance of someone who didn't want to fight but couldn't run either.

I hated myself in that moment for being useless. All I could do was stand off at a distance, looking back and forth between my brother and Father.

That night I mimicked something like prayer for the first time. I didn't even know who I was praying to. I just kept repeating, in my mind, "please." I didn't know if that counted as a prayer.

I had my fists clenched so tight my nails dug into my palms. I didn't even feel the pain. I only noticed the marks it had left afterward.

"…It's all right, no one's getting hurt," my brother said again, low. His voice shook, unlike his words.

Father still looked around with eyes that didn't recognize us. I found, in that moment, that I was afraid even to call Father "Father" — those eyes didn't look like his at all.

. . .

Then, quietly, someone stepped out of the dark.

"…It's all right," said a familiar voice. "Breathe slowly."

I recognized that voice. The man from the flowerbed. Or — no, just the man, now. The one who'd been standing where no one had planted anything, the one who'd also been seen at the well.

"…What are you doing here…" My brother couldn't finish the sentence, too startled.

I could tell there was relief mixed into my brother's shock. In that moment he said neither *scared* nor *glad*. But he must have been both.

He'd made almost no sound as he walked. I had no idea how long he'd been nearby. He appeared as quietly as if he'd always been part of the darkness itself.

I looked again toward the direction he'd come from. No trees, no brush that way. Just darkness. I had no time to think it strange — I was only relieved that he had come.

He said nothing, and quietly sat down in front of Father.

There was no hurry at all in his movement. Strangely, that unhurriedness seemed to be settling Father down even faster. As if the not-rushing itself were a kind of comfort.

He didn't touch Father. Didn't grip him, didn't pat his shoulder. He simply sat at a distance where an arm might just barely reach, and looked in the same direction Father was looking.

I only understood later how exact that distance was. Too far, and it's leaving someone alone. Too close, and it's pushing them. He knew that single hand's-width between the two, exactly.

I stood beside them, holding my brother's hand. His hand was still shaking. I gripped it tighter. He gripped mine back. We endured that moment together, leaning on each other.

Moonlight lit the man's back. A blurred outline showed through his worn clothes. I thought that silhouette wasn't unfamiliar. At the flowerbed, by the well, and now here. I found that repetition strange, and at the same time, strangely comforting.

Leaf-shadows trembled across his back. I noticed that shadow brushed against his body without changing him at all. Wind, darkness — to him, they were only things passing through.

I had a strange thought in that moment. That we had never called him here. It was Father who had shouted; no one had asked anyone for help. And yet he had come.

Looking back, I think I already heard one answer that night. That there are those who come even when unsummoned. I didn't understand what that meant, then.

. . .

"…Who am I?" Father asked him. A question he hadn't asked us, he asked him.

A strange hurt passed through me in that moment. A question he hadn't asked us, he was asking a stranger. Looking back now, that wasn't because Father

distrusted us. It was, I think, simply that there was nothing he needed to prove to this man.

I looked at my brother in that moment. He was looking at me too. We confirmed the same small hurt in each other's expressions. Neither of us said a word. But something passed between us anyway, in that look.

Father was leaning slightly toward the man. I thought that posture looked far too at ease, for a posture toward a stranger.

My brother was watching quietly too, beside me. I could feel him wanting to step in and holding himself back. His hand twitched, more than once, and returned to stillness.

"…You don't need to know right now," the man said. "You don't have a name, but you're here right now. That's enough."

Father's breathing gradually settled.

I watched that shift happen beside them. Watching the shoulders of someone who'd been screaming minutes ago slowly lower — it was like watching a storm die down.

"…Aren't you afraid of me?" Father asked.

"…I'm not afraid," he said. "I've met many people who lost their names."

There was no exaggeration at all in his voice. He spoke plainly, like stating a fact. I found that plainness, somehow, more trustworthy than anything else.

"…Did they all find their names again?" Father asked. There was longing in his voice.

"…Some of them," he said. "Some are still looking. But either way, they weren't lost while they were looking."

Father sat quietly, turning that answer over. I watched his shoulders lower, bit by bit. He didn't seem to understand the full meaning of it. But something was calming him.

"…Will I find mine too, someday?" Father asked again. His voice was much calmer than before.

"…Yes," he said. "But I don't know when. No one does."

"…And you wait, even so?" Father asked.

"…Yes," he said. "Waiting is a little easier, too, when there's someone staying with you."

"…Is that what you're doing here with me right now?" Father asked.

"…Yes," he said simply. No hesitation at all.

"…Who are you waiting for?" Father asked.

I held my breath, listening to that question. I'd wondered it myself, badly.

He was quiet for a moment.

"…It's less waiting," he said, "than going out to search."

"…For whom?"

"…For those who haven't come back yet," he said.

Father nodded slowly at that. Not the nod of someone who understood completely. But the nod of someone trying to understand.

Hearing that, I looked at my brother. His face was complicated. Suspicion, and something he couldn't quite overcome, both there at once.

He went on speaking to Father, low, for a while. I didn't catch all of it. But that tone was strangely like the one our mother had used to sing us to sleep in Brick Hollow.

I couldn't explain that resemblance then. I still can't, exactly, now. But from that night on, I learned that I could feel familiarity even in an unfamiliar voice.

I edged a little closer, trying to hear that voice more clearly. But strangely, the closer I got, the fainter the words became. As if those words weren't meant for me at all, only for Father. I stepped back quietly at that.

Father's breathing slowed, little by little. I sat beside him and listened to that rhythm. It was hard to believe it was the same person who'd been shouting like the world was ending, only minutes before.

. . .

After Father had fallen back asleep, my brother went up to the man.

"…Who exactly are you?" my brother asked. There was an edge in his voice. "Brick Hollow, Haven, and now here too… why do you keep showing up?"

He looked at my brother for a long time.

"…I've always been here," he said. "You just didn't recognize me."

"…What does that mean?"

"…In Brick Hollow, in Haven, and here too, now," he said. "I've never once left you."

My brother let out a hollow laugh at that.

"…Then why can't you help Father?" my brother asked. His voice rose. "Why don't you give his memory back? You just said you were always here."

He didn't answer, and my brother stepped closer.

"…If you were really always here," my brother said, "were you there when we fell carrying bricks? When Mother was sick? Were you there then too?"

He nodded at my brother.

"…I was."

"…Then why didn't you do anything!" my brother shouted. At that shout, Father stirred in his sleep. My brother clamped his mouth shut instantly. Then, in a much lower voice, he said it again. "…Why didn't you do anything."

He smiled quietly. He didn't answer.

I couldn't bear that silence and wanted to say something in his place. But nothing came to mind. All I could do was lightly grip my brother's arm.

He simply rose and looked up at the night sky for a moment. Starlight passed across his face like a brush. In that brief instant, I thought I saw something like grief cross his features. I couldn't be certain.

I still can't describe that expression exactly, even now. It wasn't anger. It wasn't grief either. But it was, unmistakably, the face of someone who had endured something for a long time.

Then he turned once to look at us, and walked back into the darkness he'd come from.

Wind blew from the direction he'd disappeared into. I caught no scent at all in that wind. If a person had passed through, something should have been left behind. There was nothing.

Somewhere in the grass, the night insects began to call again. Only then did I realize the sound had cut off completely, just moments before. It felt like the world had held its breath and now let it go.

I went and stood beside my brother, watching that retreating back. He didn't say anything. He just stood there for a long time.

"…Brother," I said quietly.

"…I'm not angry," my brother said. But his voice shook, unlike his words. "I just… don't know."

I took his arm. He didn't pull away.

"…Brother, I'm cold," I said. It wasn't true. But I thought if I said it, he might sit down.

Only then did he sit. We sat side by side beside the dying fire and listened to Father's breathing for a long time. It was even, and slow.

I set that unanswered silence down as this chapter's last line. That night I saw something in my brother's face deeper than anger. I thought, then, that it was fear. I know now. It was my brother's certainty, beginning to crack — just a little.

(Continued in Chapter 31.)

Chapter 31. Humming

> *_Previously_ — When Father woke in the depths of a violent confusion, the man from the flowerbed appeared again and calmed him. Jeteo asked him outright who he was, and got only: "I've always been here. You just didn't recognize me."*

The man was gone the next morning, without a word.

I don't know when he left. Once, waking in the middle of the night, I'd seen him clearly, sitting across the fire. The next time I opened my eyes, he was gone.

The instant I woke, I looked first at the spot where he'd sat. Only the grass, faintly pressed down, remained. Not even a clear footprint. The trace was so slight it made me doubt whether he'd really been there at all.

I touched that pressed patch of grass. It still felt faintly warm, or maybe I only imagined it. I couldn't be certain.

Morning mist hung low. Dewdrops glinted on every blade of grass. I noticed, belatedly, that there was no dew at all in the exact spot where he'd sat. I thought about mentioning it to my brother and decided against it. It seemed like it would only make him angrier.

My brother stared hard at that spot for a long while, then finally turned away. I felt that he was angry at the lack of any trace, and at the same time, hoping for something. Hoping that next time, a little more would be left behind.

"…Gone again, just like that," my brother said, his voice hollow. "Every time. Shows up, then no explanation at all."

"…Couldn't even say goodbye," my brother went on. "Could've at least said where he was going."

"…There wasn't time to ask," I said.

"…He didn't give us time to ask," my brother said.

I nearly laughed at that. When my brother was angry, his words got precise.

But even after saying that, he stood there a long while. I understood he wasn't standing there out of anger. He was waiting, in case the man came back. Neither of us said that out loud.

My brother repacked his things twice that morning. I understood he wasn't packing so much as looking for something to do with his hands.

I had nothing to argue against what he'd said. But strangely, his vanishing felt different to me from being abandoned. I couldn't explain exactly why, not then.

I thought about that difference all through the morning. Someone who leaves you behind, and someone who leaves once their work is done. The two look the same from the front, but different from behind. I had never once seen him leave with the look of someone in a hurry.

Father didn't even remember that the man had come at all. That grieved me. The voice that had calmed us so completely the night before — Father himself didn't carry so much as a trace of it.

"…Did someone come last night?" Father asked over breakfast, as if it were nothing.

My brother and I exchanged a glance. Neither of us knew how to explain it.

"…Yes, briefly," I managed to say.

"…Someone you know?" Father asked.

"…No, a stranger," my brother answered for me. His voice had a slight edge.

"…A stranger, and he came at night?" Father asked again.

My brother struggled to find words for a moment.

"…That's the part I find strangest too," my brother finally said.

"…I see," Father nodded. He didn't press further. I found that indifference a relief, and grieving, both at once.

Father tore off small pieces of stale bread and ate. It was hard to believe those were the same hands that had pushed us away in fear the night before. Between the Father of daytime and the Father of night, there seemed to be no connection at all.

Crumbs fell onto Father's knee. He picked them up one by one with his fingertips and ate them. That ordinary little gesture was so plain that, strangely, it felt more unfamiliar to me than anything.

I studied Father's face for a long time that morning. There was a slight hollowness under his eyes. His body remembered last night. Only his mind did not.

I thought, then. Perhaps there are things that stay even when memory doesn't. Like that song.

. . .

That afternoon, Father hummed something low as he walked.

Sunlight fell in mottled patches through the tree shade. A gentle breeze blew. It was an ordinary afternoon. I think that sound came through so clearly precisely because it was such an ordinary afternoon.

We walked without much talk that day. Everyone was a little worn from the night before. There was nothing but the rustle of dry dirt underfoot and, far off, a bird's call.

In that quiet, Father's voice leaked out very softly. It wasn't words. There were no lyrics. Just a melody.

The moment I heard that sound, I stopped walking. I knew that melody. It was the one Mother used to sing to put us to sleep.

In Brick Hollow, Mother had always paused in the same place in that song. Whether it was because she ran short of breath, or because the song itself was written to pause there, I don't know. Father paused in exactly that same spot too.

I heard that breath and understood. Father wasn't remembering the song. He was remembering the room. The room where Mother sang, where we lay down, where Father stood by the door.

"…Father, what song is that?" I asked urgently.

Father stopped humming and looked at me. His face was startled.

"…I don't know," Father said. "It just… came out on its own."

Father touched his own mouth, smiling in wonder. It seemed strange even to him, that his body could remember something before his mind did.

"…Father, just a little more," I said. I found I'd caught his sleeve without meaning to.

Father looked down at my hand. He didn't look startled.

"…I'm sorry," Father said. "I didn't even know what I was singing."

"…Nothing to be sorry for," I said quickly. "There's nothing at all to be sorry for."

My heart felt like it would burst in that moment. I looked at my brother. His face showed he'd caught the melody too.

Some of the color had drained from my brother's face. I couldn't tell if he was glad or frightened. Probably he didn't know either.

My brother had stopped walking and couldn't say a word. I saw his lips tremble slightly. He looked like someone who wanted to sing along with that melody, and was holding back for fear something might break if he did.

. . .

"…Can you keep singing?" my brother asked. His voice shook.

Father tried to hum again. But it broke off after a few bars.

"…I don't remember what comes after," Father said, an apologetic look on his face.

His eyebrows drew together faintly. The expression of someone trying to grasp something that kept slipping through his fingers. I found watching that expression more painful than watching the night he'd screamed.

Father went back to the beginning several times and started over. Each time he stopped at the same place. As if the road itself broke off there.

"…This is as far as it goes," Father said. "There's nothing past this."

I felt that this wasn't only about the song.

My brother quietly came and sat beside Father.

"…It's all right," my brother said. "Maybe it'll come out again later."

Father looked at my brother and gave a small nod. I felt my brother was saying that to himself, as much as to Father.

My brother must already have known then that there was no guarantee it would come out again next time. And still he said it. I only understood later that this wasn't a lie — it was another name for waiting.

A strong gust of wind blew through and passed. The branches knocked together and made a brief clatter. I waited for that sound to settle and said nothing.

I got up quietly and walked off a little way from the two of them. I needed time to steady myself. As I walked, I looked up at the sky. A pale daytime moon hung faint above.

I looked at that daytime moon and, in my mind, sang the song from the beginning. It came out to the end without a single break. I felt sorry for that. That I knew all of it, while Father knew only half — it felt, strangely, like my own fault.

I understood then, for the first time, that memory isn't fair. The same people had been in that same room. And still, what remained to each of them, in what amount, was different.

"…It's all right," I said. Tears came. "That's enough."

I picked up the rest and sang it, exactly as Mother used to. Father closed his eyes, listening to that sound.

My voice shook. My pitch wavered more than once. I sang it through anyway. My brother came quietly beside me and started humming along. Three voices — or more exactly, two voices and Father's silence — blended together, right there.

As I sang, I watched Father's face. His mouth wasn't moving. But his fingers were tapping very lightly against his knee. The beat was exact.

I watched that finger for a long time. It was the same hand that had counted numbers. That day, that same hand was counting a beat.

"…Strangely, it makes me feel at ease," Father said. "Even though I don't know whose song it was."

"…It was Mother's song," my brother said quietly. The first piece of information he'd offered up first, on his own.

Father opened his eyes and looked at my brother.

"…Mother," Father repeated the word slowly. "There was someone like that."

"…What kind of person was she?" Father asked.

My brother couldn't answer for a long moment. I understood he wasn't struggling for words — he was gauging where to start without falling apart.

"…Her voice was low," my brother finally said. "And she didn't laugh often, but when she did, she laughed for a long time."

"…Sounds like she was a good person," Father said.

"…Yes," my brother said. "A good person to you, too."

Father tilted his head slightly at that, but didn't ask further.

Hearing that, my chest ached. To Father now, Mother was only "someone like that." And yet, even at those words, there was some kind of longing in his expression. He might not know it in words, but somewhere, his heart seemed to know.

In that moment, I thought of the room back in Brick Hollow, on the last night, where Mother had sung us that song as we fell asleep. The low lamplight, Mother's voice and Father's breath side by side in that room. I felt that memory completing itself again, right here, right now.

In that moment I understood again why I was still keeping this record. This song, this moment — these were the things I would give back to Father someday, when he came fully home.

That night I tried to write the melody down on paper. But I didn't know how to put a tune into words. In the end I just wrote: "Today, Father hummed Mother's song. He couldn't finish it. But he sang."

Under that sentence I added one more line. "Someday, when Father reads this paper, even if he doesn't remember today, he'll know that today happened." Writing that line, I felt, for the first time, sure that this record wasn't only for me.

I folded the paper and pushed it deep into my pocket. The paper was already worn soft from being folded and unfolded so many times. I decided that the more those creases multiplied, the more days we'd walked together.

Father fell asleep unusually early that night. I couldn't tell if singing had worn him out, or if his heart had simply been at ease for once. I watched his sleeping face for a long time. Asleep, at least, Father looked like someone who hadn't lost anything at all.

I sat beside him and hummed that song once more, very quietly. I don't know if Father heard it. But his eyebrow twitched once in his sleep.

I decided to count that twitch as an answer. That night, there was nothing else left to count.

. . .

That night, my brother spoke to me quietly.

"…I still don't know," he said. "Who that man is. Whether I should believe in God."

The firelight's shadows flickered across my brother's face. I could tell he was choosing his words more carefully than usual.

The fire crackled small every now and then as it burned down. Each time, my brother would pause and then go on. I understood he wasn't startled by the sound — he was buying himself time to speak.

"…But?" I asked.

"…But today, listening to that humming, I thought — just for a moment — that maybe, like whatever's still left in Father, there's something left in me too. Something not completely erased."

I said nothing and just listened. I thought if I interrupted, he'd close back up.

"…I still don't know what it is," my brother went on. "But I can feel that it's there. Strange, isn't it."

"…Not strange," I said. "I have something like that too."

I really did feel that. I couldn't say exactly what it was. But that day, the certainty that something unerasable existed inside me too felt unusually clear.

My brother looked at me. A little surprised.

"…What is it?" he asked.

"…I don't know either," I said, laughing. "But it's there."

My brother laughed out loud at that. It had been a long time since I'd heard him laugh.

The laughter faded and he went quiet again.

"…Elpis." My brother called my name.

"…Yeah."

"…I still hate him," my brother said. "I hated him last night too. Even watching him put Father to sleep, I hated him."

"…I know," I said.

"…But even hating him, I want him to come back," my brother said. "That's what makes me angriest."

"…Can you hate someone and wait for them at the same time?" I asked.

"…I don't know," my brother said. "But that's what I'm doing right now. Both of them are real."

I didn't know what to say to that, so I just leaned my head against his shoulder. He didn't push me away.

Even now, thinking back on that night, that sentence is the first thing that comes to mind. Wanting him to come back, even while hating him. I think that was my brother's first prayer. He would never have called it that himself.

The embers gave one last small pop and died down. I watched that small light go out, still leaning against my brother's shoulder. Neither of us moved until

the darkness had covered us completely.

I set that line down as this chapter's last line. I understood how enormous it was that my brother had said those words, out loud, to himself, and to me, for the first time.

(Continued in Chapter 32.)

Chapter 32. The Light Returns

> *_Previously_ — Father, without meaning to, hummed a fragment of Mother's lullaby as he walked — the first piece of his earliest memory left in his body. Jeteo, for the first time, said aloud to himself: "Maybe there's something in me too that hasn't been erased completely."*

Some nights later, that low light appeared again in the sky.

We were crossing a broad open field that day. There was no good place to take cover. The moment I realized it, a chill ran down my spine.

The grass in that field rose to our knees. By day, that openness had felt refreshing. By night, that same openness turned into pure defenselessness. There was only, here and there, far apart, a single tree, a single boulder.

I found myself, out of habit, counting hiding places as we walked. One, two. I couldn't count a third. I realized, that day, that this habit had formed after we'd left Haven.

We had all but forgotten that light in the meantime. Caring for Father, walking, simply surviving each day — we'd been consumed by all of it. I understood, that night, all over again, how dangerous that forgetting had been.

Even now, I find that strange. People forget fear too. There isn't enough strength in the heart to be afraid every single day. I used to think that forgetting was laziness. Now I think it was also a way of staying alive.

My brother spotted the light first and stopped walking. I watched his body go rigid in an instant. The same reaction as weeks before. But this time, the speed

of it had grown even faster.

Watching that speed troubled me. That my brother had gotten better at sensing danger was a relief. But at the same time, it meant he was carving that much more fear into his body.

"…Searching light," my brother said, low. A familiar fear had returned to his voice.

The light moved very slowly, over near the horizon. Unhurried. That unhurriedness frightened me more. A hurried thing might miss you. That light looked like it had no intention of missing anything.

The insect sounds cut off abruptly right then. I couldn't tell if that was coincidence. But it felt like the whole field was holding its breath.

The instant I saw that light, I checked on Father first. He had no idea what it was — he was simply gazing up at the sky.

I envied that ignorance. One glimpse of that light and our hearts dropped, while Father just stood there admiring something curious in the night sky. I thought, in that moment, that Father having been "completed" might, in some way, be a kind of shield.

I was ashamed of that thought later. If ignorance was a shield, it was a shield built by taking something from Father first and covering the wound with it. I wanted Father to come back to being someone who could feel afraid. Knowing how to fear is part of being alive, too.

"…It's pretty," Father said, innocent. Something in me ached to hear it. Father had no idea at all what that light meant.

Father even lifted a hand and pointed at the light. A gesture as pure as a child pointing at a star. I found that purity unusually precarious that night.

"…It's not pretty," my brother said. His voice was harder than usual.

"…No?" Father asked. "Then why does it shine like that?"

My brother didn't answer. I think it wasn't that he couldn't answer — it was that he didn't want to. To explain what that light shone for, he'd have had to explain, first, why we were running.

"…Father, quickly," my brother said urgently, tugging Father's arm. "We'll explain later."

Father let himself be pulled along, still with no idea what was happening. I found that compliance both a relief and a grief. The old Father would have looked after us first and led the way himself.

. . .

"…We need to hide," my brother said. We ducked quickly behind a low boulder. Father crouched down with us. He probably didn't know exactly why. But he followed without resistance.

The boulder was small for three people. My brother pushed his own body toward the outer edge. I knew that wasn't an accident. He always positioned himself that way.

"…Brother, get in," I whispered.

"…I'm fine," my brother said.

I don't know how many times I've heard those two words over the course of this journey. My brother always said he was fine. I know he was never once fine.

That compliance struck me as strange. Two strange children suddenly pulling at his arm, and Father crouched down without a moment's resistance. It was as if some sense for danger was still alive, somewhere in his body.

As Father lowered himself, he spread both arms toward us. A sheltering posture. He himself didn't seem to notice he was doing it.

I remember those arms even now. Father didn't know who we were. But his body knew how to protect us. That night, I understood for the first time that what is lost and what is erased are not the same thing.

The light drew closer. I held my breath.

The boulder's cold surface pressed against my back. Strangely, that cold helped me focus. Fear, I learned that night, sharpens every sense in the body.

A damp smell rose from the earth. Beside me I heard my brother's breath, very shallow. Father's breathing, by contrast, was even and deep. I found that difference strange enough to glance his way. His eyes were closed.

In that moment I thought of Haven's quiet corridors. We had held our breath there too. But back then, we hadn't even known what we were hiding from. Now I know. I still don't know whether knowing is better.

A strange thought crossed my mind in that moment. Whether that light was searching for us, or for Father. Father was already a "completed" person. Does someone completed still get come looking for?

A single blade of grass tickled my cheek. I couldn't brush it away, couldn't move at all. Enduring that small itch was the only resistance I had left in that moment.

. . .

The light stopped, briefly, right over our heads.

The light made no sound while it hovered there. That was the most frightening part. If it had made a sound, I could at least have guessed where it was. That light only shone.

Wherever the light touched, the grass cast long shadows. I turned my head, very slightly, trying to gauge how far our shadows stretched out past the boulder. My brother pressed down on my wrist. A signal not to move.

That moment felt eternal. My brother gripped my hand tight. Father took my other hand too. He didn't know the reason, but he seemed to sense that something was dangerous.

The color of the light shifted, just slightly. The white flickered, for a moment, into a pale yellow. I didn't know what that meant. I only watched that flicker and held my breath.

That yellow tinge lasted only an instant. But in that instant, a strange thought crossed my mind. That maybe this light was wandering too, unable to find what it was looking for.

I told my brother that thought later. He was baffled. "That's a machine," he said. I thought he was right, and still thought that not finding what you're looking for must be just as frustrating for a machine as for a person.

In that moment I prayed, in my mind, though I didn't know to whom. I only asked for one thing — that the light would pass by.

The light moved again. This time, not toward us, but off in a different direction.

I followed that direction with my eyes. The light was heading toward the path we'd come from, toward the spot where we'd rested earlier. I couldn't tell if

that was pure chance, or if something had turned it aside.

I've gone back over that night many times since. That light had been directly above us. We were three people crowded onto one small rock, and Father's coat had spilled out past its edge. There was no reason we shouldn't have been seen. I still can't explain, to this day, why we weren't found that night.

I couldn't breathe properly until that light had disappeared completely. What came before relief was a strange guilt. The thought that this light might be searching for someone else right now.

In the stillness of that night, I heard only my own heartbeat, unusually loud. It took a while for that sound to settle.

"…Are you all right?" my brother asked me. Only then did I realize I was trembling.

"…Yes," I said. It was a lie. My brother's face showed he knew I was lying. But he only squeezed my hand once more.

"…That was scary," my brother said. Not a question.

In that moment I found myself thinking, strangely, of the man from the flowerbed. If he'd been here right now, what would he have said? I thought he probably would have just sat beside us in silence.

"…Weren't you scared?" I asked.

My brother was quiet for a moment.

"…I was," he said. "But I'm not someone who's allowed to be scared."

"…There's no such person," I said.

My brother didn't answer that. He just looked up at the sky once more.

Father sat quietly between us. He clearly had no idea what had happened, but he seemed to understand it had been something serious. Father carefully laid a hand on my shoulder. I still remember, even now, how great a comfort the weight of that hand was, in that moment.

. . .

We stayed crouched there a good while longer. My legs began to cramp, but no one spoke first about moving. I didn't think that silence was only about fear. All three of us, I think, were being careful, afraid that something would change if this moment stretched even a little longer.

By the time my legs had gone fully numb, Father shifted position first. He asked me, "…are you all right?" I nearly laughed at that question. The person we'd thought we needed to protect, just moments before, was the one looking after us first.

Once the light had disappeared, my brother spoke low.

"…We really do need to get far from Haven now. This place must still be inside that light's reach."

"…Where do we go?" I asked.

"…Anywhere," Father cut in carefully. "As long as I'm not a burden to you."

Father said that while watching our faces closely. I found that carefulness unfamiliar. Father had never been the kind of person to watch others' faces like that — at least, not the Father I remembered.

My brother thought for a moment.

"…I don't know. But we have to keep walking. Father, and both of us — staying here is dangerous."

"…How much further until it's safe?" I asked.

"…I don't know," my brother said. "That's the whole problem. No one tells you how far you have to go."

Father looked up carefully at the sky at that.

"…I don't know the direction," Father said, "but the constellations somehow look familiar to me. Would that help?"

My brother and I looked at each other. It was an unexpected thing to hear from a father who claimed to remember nothing.

I thought about that for a long time. Neither when we left Brick Hollow, nor when we left Haven, did we know how far we had to go. We had always walked without knowing the end. I think that not-knowing is the name of this whole story.

I saw, on my brother's face, the confident look he used to wear before. He'd always led the way with a face like that, leaving Haven, leaving Brick Hollow. That face was welcome to see again, and at the same time it worried me — that he might be trying to shoulder everything alone once more.

"…You don't have to decide alone," I said.

My brother looked at me. A little surprised.

"…I know," he said. "But someone has to say which way to go."

"…Then let's say it together," I said.

My brother smiled faintly at that. There was relief in that smile, and also a strange, unfamiliar lightness.

"…Me too," Father said carefully. "I don't know anything, so I can't decide the direction. But I can help say it, at least."

My brother looked a little startled at that. Then he laughed.

"…Yes," my brother said. "That's enough."

Father heard that and asked quietly.

"…Am I a burden?"

Father's voice was calm. But behind that calm there was something braced, as if for the worst. My heart sank, seeing that expression.

My brother looked at Father, startled.

"…No," my brother said firmly. "You're not a burden. We're going together."

I took Father's hand too.

"…That's right," I said. "Don't ever say *burden* again."

Father looked back and forth between the two of us, then nodded, small. Not a face that fully believed it. But in that moment, at least, he didn't question it further.

The night wind blew and stirred the hems of our three coats. I felt that even in that wind, the hands the three of us held onto each other never wavered.

Somewhere far off, I heard something like a dog barking. It meant people lived nearby. I started to feel relieved at the sound, then remembered — where there are people, there's a searching light too — and tightened my guard again.

From that night on, I learned to see the world in two layers. Behind every welcome thing, there was always some danger attached. I thought that was what it meant to grow up. It was early to learn it, at thirteen.

Father heard all that and laughed quietly. A laugh I hadn't seen from him before. A laugh with both relief and shyness mixed into it.

"…Thank you," Father said. A short sentence. But I could feel the weight carried inside it.

"…For what?" I asked.

"…I don't know," Father said. "I just felt thankful. That word came first."

My brother heard that answer and laughed quietly too.

"…I have that too," my brother said. "Words that come out without a reason. It keeps happening to me lately."

"…Such as?" Father asked.

My brother hesitated a moment.

"…The word *it's all right,*" my brother said. "Even when it's really not all right, that word comes first."

I liked that answer. It meant that words coming out without a reason were still alive somewhere inside Father.

I set that line down as this chapter's last line. I saw my brother look surprised at himself as he said those words. As he said them to Father, he seemed to be saying them to himself, at the very same time.

(Continued in Chapter 33.)

Chapter 33. A Night on the Run

> *_Previously_ — The searching light appeared again. It passed, but relief left guilt behind it. When Father asked, "Am I a burden to you?" Jeteo answered, "We're going together."*

Two nights later, it wasn't the light that came — it was people.

That day had been unusually peaceful. Father had even picked a small wildflower along the road and handed it to me. Looking back, that peace hadn't given the slightest warning of what the evening held, which only made it more frightening.

The wildflower was yellow and very small. Handing it over, Father said, "… this is for you." The tone of someone for whom giving something to another person felt awkward, even to himself.

I pressed that flower between two sheets of paper. Later it dried flat, leaving only a faded stain on the page. I still have that stain.

My brother had been unusually on edge since evening. He stopped several times and looked back over his shoulder. I'd thought it was just habit. Looking back now, I think he'd already sensed something.

Toward evening the wind changed direction. It carried, not the scent of dry grass, but something like burning. I didn't know what that smell was, then. I know now. It was the smell of a fire people had lit.

Father, too, had been unusually quiet that day. I still wonder whether that was coincidence, or whether the three of us had already been sensing something, without knowing it.

At dinner, Father suddenly asked.

"…Are we being followed?"

My brother and I both looked at Father at once.

"…Why do you think that?" my brother asked.

"…I don't know," Father said. "I just keep wanting to look back. Both of you keep doing it too."

I felt ashamed at that. We hadn't explained anything to Father. And yet he had already known, just from watching our bodies. There are things people know even without being told.

At first I thought it was the wind. But there was a rhythm to it. Wind has no rhythm.

Footsteps. Several of them. We ducked quickly behind a stand of dry brush.

In that moment I gripped Father's hand with everything I had. I wanted him to understand that we needed to stay quiet. But Father, frightened by the unfamiliar sound, began trembling instead.

The brush's dry branches rustled against our clothes. Even that faint sound felt far too loud, so I made myself breathe with the greatest care.

The ground still held a little of the day's heat. I felt that faint warmth against my back and had the strange thought that this earth knew we were here.

Voices. Low, businesslike voices.

No anger, no urgency in that tone. I had heard that tone every day in Haven — behind the intake counters, in the corridors, handing over receipt slips. That

night, the most frightening thing was that this same tone had followed us all the way out here to this field.

Their shadows stretched long under the moonlight. I counted them. Three.

"…You said there was a signal near here?"

"…Two Reassignment candidates. And a report that a completion record broke away too."

"…A completion broke away?" another voice asked. "Can that even happen?"

"…Rare," said the first voice. "That's why recovery's a top priority."

I heard the word "recovery" for the first time that night. A word used for objects. From the moment I heard it, I began to think of Haven differently. That city had never once hated us. To hate someone, you have to see them as a person first.

The instant I heard that, my whole body went cold. I understood the phrase "a completion record broke away" meant Father. It was the first time I truly grasped that even Father, to this city, was not a person but an entry.

I glanced sideways at Father's face. He had no idea what that conversation meant, and just gripped our hands tight. I thought his ignorance was, right then, a mercy. If he had known he was being called an "escaped record," I don't think he could have borne it.

Far off, insects called in fits and starts. I thought that irregularity resembled our own heartbeats. Even the world, it seemed, was frightened alongside us in that moment.

. . .

"…Shh." My brother pressed his hand gently over Father's mouth, as softly as he could. "We have to be quiet. Please."

Father nodded, eyes wide. He didn't know why, but he seemed to sense the danger.

That moment stayed with me a long time. Father didn't know who my brother was. And yet he trusted the hand covering his mouth. I thought, for the first time then, that trust lives somewhere beneath memory.

Father's hand kept gripping mine tightly. I felt a faint tremor through it. A body that had forgotten both name and face had, all the same, kept perfect hold of fear.

I wanted to calm that trembling. But I was shaking myself, so I couldn't tell who was calming whom.

The footsteps drew closer. Three people in Haven uniforms passed by. Bright tools in their hands.

Their clothes were clean. Their shoes were clean. Not the clothes of someone who'd walked a dirt road for days. I couldn't even imagine how or from where they had come this far.

One of them looked down at his wrist, reading something. Then shook his head. I understood our whole night hung on that single shake of the head.

Their pace didn't hurry at all. That very leisureliness frightened me more. It was the walk of people certain they would find us in the end.

I didn't know what that device was. But I knew it was for finding us.

"…The signal's weak around here," one said. "Why is that."

"…That's the boundary," another said. "The Ledger doesn't reach well out here either."

I held onto that line the longest that night. That there was a place in the world the Ledger couldn't reach. It should have sounded frightening. It sounded, instead, strangely welcome.

My brother pushed me gently behind him. Even in that moment, the gesture of protecting me first. I found that gesture familiar, and yet it hurt more than usual that night.

I gripped Father's hand tighter still, from behind my brother's back. Three of us were joined, that way, in a single line. I understood, in that moment, that there was nothing left we could do but hold onto each other.

I knew my brother was afraid too, in that moment. But he was trying to carry all of that fear alone. As he always had.

I watched my brother's back. His shoulders trembled faintly, holding his breath. I reached out and gently caught the hem of his shirt. I said nothing. I only wanted him to know I was here too.

My brother reached back without turning and took my hand. His eyes stayed forward the whole time. That hand trembled a little less than before, I thought. I learned that night: holding on makes the trembling smaller.

I understood, then, for the first time, how much sturdier a family of three could be. Alone, I'd have collapsed right there. Even the two of us together might have been much the same. But three of us — we became the strength that held each other up.

. . .

One of them stopped directly in front of the brush where we were hiding.

I could see the tips of his shoes. Through the leaves, only that much showed. I calculated that his shoe was one hand's-width away from touching Father's knee. I don't know why I calculated something like that.

I remember hearing no sound at all in that moment. But that can't be true. The wind was blowing, insects were calling. I think a person, truly frightened, loses the sounds of the world for a moment.

Time seemed to stop right there. I was terrified my heartbeat might carry outside. I could feel sweat breaking out on my brother's hand too.

I shut my eyes tight in that moment and thought of the last night in Brick Hollow. Holding our breath, hiding from the taskmasters' footsteps that night, felt exactly the same as this moment now. We were still surviving the same way.

I thought I would stop breathing. My brother pulled Father in tighter still.

Then Father tried to draw a deep breath. My heart plunged in that instant. If Father coughed, it was over.

But Father swallowed that breath back down. No one had told him to. I saw his throat move once, hard.

Even now, thinking of that moment, my throat tightens. Father hadn't forgotten how to protect us. He had lost his name, and still he hadn't lost that.

The man swept his light toward the brush. The beam passed right beside us.

I nearly imagined that light brushing my skin. Neither hot nor cold, and still every hair on my body stood on end.

The light swept through the inside of the brush. The dry branches went briefly white under it. I saw, in that instant, the back of my own hand go white too. I quickly pulled it inside my clothes.

I shut my eyes tight in that moment. For the first time in my life, I asked for something — not in words, just in my heart. I don't know if that counted as a prayer. I just asked.

In that brief moment, all the nights we'd run — Brick Hollow's night, Haven's alleys, every one of those fleeing nights — came flooding back at once. We had always been hiding from something. In that moment, I couldn't imagine when it would ever end.

I understood something strange, then. We had always been running from something. And yet inside that running, we had never once stopped holding onto each other. Maybe, I thought for the first time in that moment, that wasn't only running. Maybe it was something else too.

"…Nothing here," the man said, back toward the others.

"…You sure?"

"…Sure. Just brush."

I couldn't relax even hearing that. Because I alone knew the words weren't true.

The man soon turned and walked off in another direction.

I still couldn't open my eyes in that moment. Only once the footsteps had faded completely did I dare open them, carefully. My fingertips tingled and stung. I'd been gripping far too hard, for far too long.

There were my nail-marks left in Father's palm. I let go the instant I saw them. Father never once said it hurt.

"…I'm sorry," I whispered.

"…It's all right," Father said. "I liked being held."

Father said that while looking down for a moment at his own palm. He touched the marks there like something curious. He never once let on that they'd hurt.

. . .

Even after the footsteps had disappeared completely, we couldn't move from that spot for a long while.

My legs had gone numb and I couldn't stand. My brother seemed the same — he stayed sitting there, still buried in the brush. Father was the first to gather himself and help us both up.

As he lifted us, Father brushed the dirt from our knees. My brother's knee first, then mine. I thought, somehow, that order felt like a very old one.

Father's hand felt unusually steady in that moment. Memory was gone, but the body still knew how to raise its children back onto their feet.

Feeling that touch, I suddenly thought of some morning back in Brick Hollow. Back then, too, Father had brushed the dust from our clothes to start the day.

My brother finally let out a breath and looked up at the sky.

"…Where are you," my brother said, low, but clearly. I knew who it was addressed to. "You don't show up when it matters, and yet that time — that time you did."

My brother's voice wasn't loud. But the field was wide enough that the words traveled far, and came back bringing nothing at all.

"…You came the night Father was screaming," my brother said. "Nobody died that night. Today all three of us nearly died. And today — where were you."

I set that question down here now, exactly as it was, without softening it. It was the most honest sentence in this whole story. I have no intention of making it gentler.

No answer came at all. The night sky was just a night sky.

There were so many stars. So many. I found myself angry at how many there were, that night. All that many, and not one had answered.

Father watched my brother quietly. He clearly understood nothing. And still Father went and stood beside him, and laid a hand on his shoulder without a word. My brother didn't shake it off.

"…Hard, isn't it," Father said. That was all. Not an explanation, not comfort. Just the words of someone who had recognized that another person was in pain.

My brother bowed his head at that. I saw his shoulders heave once, hard.

I looked at that hand and felt a strange comfort. Someone who had lost both name and memory still knew how to lay a single hand on the shoulder of someone breaking down over an answer he'd never received. I thought that might be the deepest thing still left in Father.

I watched the two of them's silhouette for a long while. A son who'd gotten no answer, and a father who couldn't even understand the question, standing side by side. And yet the picture, strangely, didn't feel only sad.

After a while I went and stood beside them too. The three of us stood in a row and looked up at the same sky. No one said a word.

"…I'm hungry," my brother said, after a long while.

I burst out laughing at that. Just moments earlier he'd been shouting up at the sky, and this was his very next line.

"…Me too," Father said.

That night we split what bread was left, three ways, in tiny pieces. I think that was the only answer we received that night.

Chewing his bread, Father said suddenly.

"…It's good." Such an ordinary thing to say. But somehow, in that moment, it made the three of us smile, just a little.

Even after we'd finished the bread, we stayed sitting there a long while. The night wind was gradually dying down. I felt it fading and held onto one single fact — that this night, too, would eventually pass.

Father pushed the last piece of bread toward my brother. My brother refused it a moment, then finally took it. I think that small back-and-forth was the most ordinary moment of that whole night.

I set that silence down as this chapter's last line. I understood, then, how justified my brother's question was. I couldn't give him an answer. No one could. And yet, in that silence, I held onto one single fact — that we were still alive.

(Continued in Chapter 34.)

Chapter 34. The Wrong Direction

> *_Previously_ — A Haven search party truly did come after the siblings. Once the danger had passed, Jeteo asked the night sky, "You don't show up when it matters, and yet that time you did?" — and got only silence in return.*

The next day, we set out again, as quietly as we could.

None of us had slept properly. Everyone's eyes were hollow. I flinched all day, overreacting to every footstep. Even the crack of a breaking twig made me jump more than once.

My brother changed our course twice that morning. Not the direction we'd meant to go, but a wide, deliberate loop around it. "…We're not going the way those people went yesterday," was all he said.

Because of that we walked far slower than usual. I found that slowness frustrating, and also a relief. Staying alive mattered more than being fast.

The sky was as clear as it had been the day before. I found that clarity strangely alien. The world seemed entirely untroubled by what had happened to us the night before.

I thought, for the first time then, about the world's indifference. The night we held our breath, so close to death, had been, to the sky, just one more night passing by. I found that indifference bitter, and at the same time, strangely comforting. It meant the world wasn't singling us out specifically.

I thought about mentioning that to Father and decided against it. Father had all but forgotten the night before already. Bringing that night back up in front of

someone who'd forgotten it seemed cruel.

My brother stayed almost entirely silent all that day. I didn't want to disturb him, so I simply walked beside him.

I understood, then, that my brother's silence was connected to the question from the night before. A question left unanswered, I learned that day, stays on afterward, in silence, in place of an answer.

Now and then I saw my brother glance up at the sky. It looked like searching for something, and also like resentment. I didn't ask.

Once, he stopped walking entirely and looked up. He looked for quite a while. I looked up too. Nothing there but a few clouds.

"…What are you looking at?" I asked.

"…Nothing," my brother said. And started walking again.

I turned that word — "nothing" — over for a long time. No one stares that long at a sky with nothing in it. My brother hadn't been looking at something. He'd been watching for something to appear.

Father, unusually, was in high spirits that day. I didn't know why. He simply said walking felt good. I envied that lightness. Father, having no memory, seemed to have all but forgotten last night's terror by that morning.

Father even crouched down beside the road for a long while, watching a small insect. I found the sight strange, and somewhere in it, endearing too. Father looked like a man fully present in this one moment.

Father mimed counting the centipede's legs with his finger. Three, four, five — and every time the centipede moved, he'd start over from the beginning. I saw, in that gesture, the old habit of Father counting numbers on his fingers. But this time it didn't frighten me.

"…Look at this," Father called us over. "So many legs."

My brother came over reluctantly and looked.

"…It's a centipede," my brother said.

"…It has a name," Father said, marveling. "Even something this small has a name."

My brother went quiet for a moment at that. I understood exactly why he couldn't answer.

My brother watched Father from a little way off, then said quietly to me.

"…Father seems a lot freer than we are," my brother said. "Because he has no memory."

I didn't know how to answer that. It seemed both right and wrong at once.

I thought, for the first time then, that forgetting might not be only a curse. It was a strange thought. I didn't hold onto it long.

Father walked along, kicking small stones now and then with the toe of his shoe. A childlike gesture. Watching it, I laughed, and then, right after, my chest ached, somewhere.

I only understood the shape of that ache late that evening. Father wasn't only turning into more and more of a stranger — he was, at the same time, growing up all over again, alongside us. I found it strange that both things were happening at once.

Even now I don't know how to settle that thought. Father was a person losing something, and at the same time, a person learning something new. I didn't know which side to root for. In the end, I decided to root for both.

. . .

That afternoon, we met a merchant coming from the opposite direction. He spoke to us first.

He carried a large pack on his back. He looked like someone who traded goods between towns. I saw the fatigue of a long-traveling man in his clothes.

Pots and bowls hung from his pack, clattering with every step. I'd been hearing that sound from a long way off. But none of the three of us hid. That wasn't the sound of someone who traveled in hiding.

"…How far are you going?" the merchant asked.

"…South," my brother answered shortly.

"…All three of you?" the merchant asked, glancing at Father. "Is that your father?"

My brother paused a moment before answering.

"…Yes," my brother said. "He's our father."

I nearly cried, hearing that answer beside him. It was the first time my brother had introduced Father to a stranger that way.

"…There was quite a stir around here last night," the merchant said. "Heard a search party chased someone clear off in the wrong direction."

"…Wrong direction?" my brother asked, ears pricking up.

His voice cracked slightly. I understood he was reliving the night before, hearing that.

I nearly dropped the water jug I was holding. Only then did I remember — the direction those people had gone past our brush, the night before, was exactly opposite the direction we'd come from.

"…Yeah. Some old man apparently gave them the wrong directions. Then when they went looking for him afterward, he'd vanished too. People are telling all kinds of strange stories about it now."

I looked at my brother in that instant. He looked at me too. Neither of us said a word. But we both knew we were thinking the same thing.

The merchant, not noticing our changed expressions, kept talking.

"…Funny thing is, there wasn't a single trace where the old man disappeared from. Not even a footprint." The merchant shrugged. "People are saying all sorts of things about it."

"…What did the old man look like?" my brother asked, unable to hold back.

The merchant shrugged again.

"…I only heard it secondhand, so I don't know. Just that he was wearing worn-out clothes, that's all I heard."

I found that description so simple that it only made me more certain, not less. Nothing flashy, nothing distinctive. That was exactly the man we knew.

The merchant's pack clattered again. That ordinary sound felt, in that moment, oddly loud. For a second I even had the illusion that the world was listening in on us.

"…Why did the old man do that?" I asked. "Why would he lie to the search party?"

"…Who knows," the merchant said. "Nobody knows the answer, that's why the strange stories keep going around."

"…Is it wrong to tell a lie?" Father suddenly cut in.

The merchant looked at Father, a little startled.

"…Well, I suppose that depends on who it's for," the merchant said.

Father nodded slowly at that. I thought Father seemed satisfied with that answer.

That answer was enough for me too. I could see, in my brother's expression, that he felt the same. For the first time, I thought of the man in the worn clothes who had moved for our sake, and felt something warm settle in my chest. I learned, that day, that fear and gratitude can live in the same place at once.

Before leaving, the merchant added one more thing to us.

"…You be careful too. People around here are on edge these days."

We nodded. That parting word didn't feel like a passing remark to me. It felt like real concern.

The merchant walked a few steps, then turned back to add one more thing.

"…And don't build your fire too big at night. It shows for miles."

My brother bowed his head at that. I remember it as the most formal bow my brother ever gave a stranger.

. . .

After the merchant left, my brother was silent a long while before he spoke.

"…Was it him."

Having said it, my brother rubbed his own mouth once with his hand. Like someone not quite trusting the words that had just come out of it.

There was both certainty and resistance in my brother's voice at once. I felt he wanted to accept the fact, and at the same time was afraid that accepting it would change something.

"…I don't know," I said. But in my heart, I was already almost certain.

I didn't tell my brother that certainty out loud. I thought if I showed it too plainly, he'd push back against it even harder.

I learned something that day. When a person is coming to understand something on their own, pushing them from the side only makes them step back. From that day on, I stopped trying to convince my brother of anything.

"…Then why doesn't he just say so from the start?" my brother asked, frustration bleeding into his voice. "Then I wouldn't have to get angry like this every single time."

"…Would you not be angry, if he did?" I asked.

My brother was quiet a moment.

"…No," my brother said finally. "I'd probably still get angry. Nothing about Father makes sense anyway."

"…Then it wouldn't change anything, even if he told us," I said.

My brother looked at me. He seemed about to say something back, then let it go.

I didn't have an answer to that question either. But a strange thought crossed my mind, then. That maybe being told in advance is worse than walking on together, still afraid.

"…And," my brother added, low, "being angry is exhausting too. But if I stop being angry, then I don't know what I'm supposed to do."

I thought that was the most frightening thing my brother had said on this whole journey. Anger was proof that my brother still expected something. Without any expectation left, there'd be no anger either.

I stopped being afraid of my brother's anger from that moment on. I understood that anger was proof something was still alive inside him.

I'd been afraid, before, that my brother would break down. Looking back now, I don't think he was breaking down at all. My brother was searching for a place other than anger.

I couldn't say anything back to that. I just walked quietly beside him. I learned again, that day, that silence is sometimes better than any answer.

. . .

Father had been listening quietly to that whole exchange, and then asked.

"…Who is that person?"

Only then did I realize Father had been listening to every word. I'd thought he mostly let our conversations pass right through him. Not that day.

My brother couldn't answer right away. After a long pause, he finally said,

"…I don't really know either. But… he seems to keep being near us. Without ever explaining."

My brother himself looked surprised at his own words as he said them. I heard him admit that for the first time that day.

"…Why doesn't he explain?" Father asked.

"…I don't know," my brother said. "That's the part that frustrates me most, too."

"…I'm one of the ones who can't explain," Father said. "Not explaining, and being unable to explain — I suppose they must look the same, from outside."

My brother stopped walking at that.

Father smiled a little at what he'd said.

"…Then I guess I'm a bit like him," Father said. "I can't explain who I am either. And yet here I still am."

My brother stopped a moment, standing still. I saw him swallow something back before he could say it.

"…Yeah," my brother finally said. His voice was low. "A bit like him."

"…So are you angry at me too, then?" Father asked. It came out like a joke, but it didn't quite sound like one.

"…No," my brother said quickly. "I'm not angry at you."

"…Why not?"

My brother took a while to answer.

"…Because you're here," my brother finally said.

Father tilted his head at that. Not the face of someone who'd fully understood. But the face of someone who'd received something warm.

I still count that answer, even now, as one of the most important answers in this whole story. My brother hadn't wanted an answer. He'd wanted someone to stay beside him. I don't think my brother himself knew that, until the words came out of his own mouth.

Father heard that and reached out to pat my brother's shoulder, lightly. He didn't say anything more. But that single gesture was, in that moment, enough.

I saw my brother's breath go out of him in one long rush the moment that hand touched his shoulder. It sounded like several days' worth of held breath being let out all at once.

I understood, from that day on, that people can be undone by words, but also undone by a wordless hand. What undid my brother wasn't the silence of the night before. It was that hand, that afternoon.

I felt, in that short answer, that my brother had set something down, just a little. Not all of the anger — but a new place seemed to have opened up right beside it.

We walked late into that evening. It wasn't until the sun had fully set that we made camp. I noticed, that night, that my brother spent a little longer than usual looking up at the sky.

We kept the fire small, exactly as the merchant had advised. Small enough that the three of us had to press close together to feel any warmth at all. Father sat in the middle. No one had suggested it. It simply became his place, naturally.

The small firelight lit each of our three faces in turn. In that flickering light, I felt our three expressions growing, little by little, to resemble each other.

That night I wrote in my paper: "Today, for the first time, my brother called Father 'my father' to a stranger." I wrote that one line and, for a long while, couldn't bring myself to fold the paper closed again.

Father glanced at that paper and said nothing. Instead he laid a gentle hand on my shoulder. I understood from that touch that whether or not he understood the sentence, he sensed that something precious had been written down.

I set that line down as this chapter's last line. I saw an expression on my brother's face in that moment that I'd never seen before. It wasn't anger. It wasn't certainty either. It was simply the face of someone who had opened his heart, just a very little.

(Continued in Chapter 35.)

Chapter 35. He Called My Name

> *_Previously_ — From a merchant, we heard about an old man who had led Haven's search party the wrong way. Neither of us said it aloud, but we both knew, without a doubt, who that had to be. At one careless word from Father, something crossed Jeteo's face for the first time — not anger, not certainty, but something in between.*

Days later, we were resting by a small stream.

The water ran low and quiet. Sunlight broke into small pieces on its surface. I watched that glimmer for a long time. It was the first peaceful afternoon we'd had after days of walking like we were being chased.

The stream wasn't wide. Anyone could have jumped across it. But the water was clear enough that I could see every stone on the bottom, one by one. I started counting them and gave up. There were too many.

A few small birds, ones I didn't know the name of, landed at the water's edge and flew off again. No one chased them away. I couldn't remember the last time I'd watched something that wasn't being chased.

I still remember that afternoon with unusual clarity, even now. It felt like an afternoon where nothing would happen. I learned that day that the biggest things happen on afternoons exactly like that.

Jeteo sat with his feet in the water, eyes closed. Watching him, I saw, for the first time in a long while, the tension gone from his face. Father was a little way off, washing his hands.

Jeteo scooped up a handful of water and washed his face with it. Then he looked up at the sky, his face still wet. I didn't bother checking whether what was on his face was only water.

Father washed his hands for a long time. Longer than he needed to. I understood that he wasn't really washing — he was just touching the water. He kept dipping his hands in and pulling them out, staring at them the whole time.

"…The water's cold," Father said, half to himself.

No one answered. He didn't seem to be waiting for an answer either.

Then, still washing his hands, Father called out to me, without warning.

"…Elpis."

I froze where I sat. So did Jeteo.

He said it completely plainly — the way you'd say "hand me that" or "look over there." That's how people say a name when they're just calling someone. That plainness undid me more than anything else could have.

The stream kept running. But to me, even that sound seemed to stop for an instant. It felt like every sound in the world had made way for that one name.

We had told Father my name many times by then. But that had only ever been an introduction. This was different. This time, Father had called me. The difference looked small. To me, it was as large as the whole world.

I still find that difference hard to explain, even now. An introduction is information. Being called is a relationship. Information can be written on paper. Being called has to come out from inside a person. That day, that name came out from inside Father.

Jeteo stood frozen too, watching me. Neither of us could say anything. Only the water filled the silence between us.

In that silence, I watched something waver, little by little, in my brother's eyes. He hadn't decided yet whether to be happy, or whether his heart should tangle over the fact that his own name hadn't come yet.

In that moment I felt sorry for him. Glad, and sorry, at once. That day I learned for the first time that both those feelings could live in one body together.

. . .

Father looked startled by his own words.

He stood frozen, hand still raised. Water dripped from his fingertips. He didn't seem to notice even that.

I watched the small ripples those drops made as they fell into the stream. One, two, three. Ever since, whenever I remember this moment, those ripples are the first thing that comes back to me.

"…What did I just say?" Father asked.

"…My name," I managed. My voice was shaking. "You called my name."

My voice shook as much as his did. I didn't try to hide the shaking. There was no reason to.

Father touched his own mouth with his hand, as if checking where the words had come from.

Even the feel of the stream against my ankles felt strange in that moment. Every sense in my body had gathered around that one name.

"…How did I know that," Father murmured. "It just… came out on its own."

"…On its own again," I said. I was laughing and crying at the same time. It didn't even strike me as strange, laughing and crying together like that.

"…Again?" Father asked.

"…The song came out on its own too," I said.

Father's face went thoughtful at that.

"…Then it's still in me," Father said. "I just can't bring it out. It's not gone."

I copied that sentence down exactly, that night, into this ledger. It was the truest thing Father ever said about himself.

There was bewilderment in Father's eyes, mixed with something close to overwhelm. I thought his expression looked like someone whose long-shut door had opened just a crack.

In that moment I looked at Jeteo. He stood there unable to say anything. I saw tears gather in his eyes for the first time.

I went to Father and took his hand.

I looked into his eyes. They were still unfamiliar eyes. But inside that unfamiliarity, something very small seemed to live there now — something that recognized me.

"…Say it again," I said.

"…Elpis." Father said it again. This time with certainty. Tears filled his eyes. "Elpis. Elpis…"

He repeated the name over and over, like a song he'd just learned. His voice trembled more each time. In that trembling, I thought I heard something — a very old lock, turning open a little at a time.

Jeteo turned his back on that sound. I knew he didn't want to be seen crying. Without letting go of Father's hand, I reached my other hand out toward him. He didn't come. But a moment later, his hand settled on top of mine.

That name sounded, to me, like it went past my own name — like Father was saying something to himself. Like he was holding onto that one name and trying to work his way back to himself.

In that moment I wrapped both my hands around Father's. It was still cold and damp. Even that cold felt welcome to me. It was a living hand.

There was an old scar on the back of Father's hand. A scar from carrying bricks. I touched it with my fingertip. Father didn't know why it was there.

The scar was shaped like a small crescent moon. I'd seen that shape many times back in Brick Hollow — Father rubbing that spot absently every evening as he washed his hands.

"…Do you know where you got this?" I asked.

"…No idea," Father said.

"…I know," I said. "I'll tell you later."

Father didn't press for more. He just nodded and looked down at the back of his hand once more.

I didn't tell the story of that scar that day. To tell it, I would have had to start with why Father became what he became in Brick Hollow. I wanted to tell it once Father could bear hearing it himself.

Father closed his eyes, saying my name. Behind those closed eyes, I could feel him straining to hold onto something — the frayed, still-unbroken end of a thread of memory.

. . .

The sound of the stream seemed unusually loud in that moment. I listened to it and tried, for a while, not to think anything at all. I wanted to feel this moment with my body alone.

I closed my eyes there for a moment. A memory rose up — the last night in Brick Hollow, Father lifting me up while calling my name. I felt that memory overlap with this one.

That night, lifting me up, Father had said, "…Don't be scared, Elpis." Even then, I'd known it was a lie. But that lie was what kept me alive that night.

"…What about me?" Jeteo asked, his voice shaking. "Do you know my name too?"

Father looked at Jeteo for a long time. His face held something that seemed almost within reach, and yet wasn't.

His mouth moved several times. No sound came out. He looked like someone who'd opened a drawer only to find it empty.

Seeing Father struggle made it hurt more. Father didn't want to disappoint Jeteo, so he was trying to force something into being that wasn't there.

"…It's okay. You don't have to force it," Jeteo said first. But his voice was already wet when he said it.

"…I'm sorry," Father said. "That one… hasn't come yet."

I could hear that Father's sorrow was real. I hoped that sorrow could be some small comfort to Jeteo.

Jeteo's face fell apart. I watched him fall into disappointment, right there. In that brief moment, too many feelings crossed his eyes for me to read them all. Disappointment, shame, and the strain of trying to hold both down.

In that moment, I wanted to be angry on my brother's behalf. Not at Father — at someone, I didn't even know who. I wanted to demand why only one name had come back, why not both.

I think, in that moment, I understood a little of what it had felt like for Jeteo, every day, looking up at that sky. Something that comes back only partway can sometimes be harder to bear than something that never comes back at all.

But Jeteo smiled, strangely.

"…It's okay," Jeteo said. "My name can come later. Right now… it's enough that Elpis's did."

His voice shook, but it didn't waver. I could tell that steadiness wasn't something he'd forced out — he really felt it.

I was startled to hear that. That was the first time I ever saw my brother take someone else's joy before his own. Back in Brick Hollow, and in Haven too, Jeteo had never been someone who looked out for himself first. But that wasn't because he couldn't look after himself — it was because he was someone who looked after others first. That day, I confirmed that fact all over again.

"…Jeteo," I said. "You don't have to force yourself to be okay."

"…I'm not forcing it," Jeteo said.

"…So a little, then?"

Jeteo looked at me and laughed, briefly.

"…A little," he said.

Father went to Jeteo and put his arms around his shoulders. It was an awkward gesture. But Jeteo didn't pull away from that awkward embrace.

Father patted his back a couple of times. The rhythm was clumsy. But somehow that clumsiness made it feel more real.

"…I don't know your name," Father told him. "But I know your face. I see it every day."

At that, Jeteo leaned his forehead against Father's shoulder for a moment. Just a moment.

I watched the two of them from a little way off. The stream still ran low and quiet. I thought that sound was carving this moment into something, somewhere.

. . .

That night, Jeteo spoke to me quietly.

"…I kept collecting evidence, this whole time. To protect the name, to remember it. But today I learned something. What's coming back inside Father — it wasn't because I gathered evidence. It was just… because I stayed close."

He took a bundle of paper scraps from inside his coat and spread them on his lap. In the firelight, the writing on them had all faded. Some of it was hard to

make out at all anymore.

"…What is all this?" I asked.

"…Everywhere Father's name might turn up, I wrote it down," Jeteo said. "Work-crew numbers, ration slips, taskmasters' names. I thought it might have survived somewhere."

I looked at those papers one by one. Only then did I understand how long he'd been carrying this alone.

"…So you don't need the evidence anymore?" I asked.

"…No," Jeteo said. "I still need it. But now I know. Evidence alone wouldn't have been enough. Staying close had to happen too."

"…You can do both," I said.

Jeteo looked down at the bundle of papers for a moment at that. He ran his fingertips along the edges, then looked at me again.

"…Can you, though," he said.

"…You did today," I said.

Jeteo couldn't answer that for a moment. Then he folded the papers carefully again and tucked them back inside his coat. His hands moved more carefully than before.

I thought of the worn scraps of paper he'd carried deep in his coat all this time — evidence gathered all the way back from Brick Hollow. I felt that he was learning how to hold onto those without letting go, while also holding something new at the same time.

I sat down a little closer to him. He put his arm around my shoulder. It was a familiar weight I hadn't felt in a long time.

Father was already asleep a little way off. Even asleep, his lips moved very slightly now and then. I thought it might be my name. I didn't go check.

I sat quietly beside Jeteo. Somewhere far off, night insects were singing. Listening to them, I felt all over again how enormous a day this had been for us.

The embers of the fire were dying down with small crackling sounds. Listening to that, I could feel the day's afterglow still lingering somewhere in my body.

I tried to write down what had happened that day, then gave up. My hand was shaking too much to write properly. In the end, I wrote down only one name. My own. The name Father had called.

"…Jeteo," I said.

"…Yeah?" he answered.

"…I believe Father will call your name too, someday," I said.

"…Why do you believe that?" he asked.

"…I don't know," I said. "I just do."

"…That's not based on anything," he said.

"…Yeah," I said. "Nothing at all."

I didn't know exactly what I meant by that, back then. I understand what it means to believe without grounds far better now than I did then. It's not that

you believe because there's no evidence. You believe before all the evidence has gathered.

Jeteo looked at me and smiled quietly. He didn't say anything. But that smile was his answer.

The last embers sparked faintly and scattered into the dark. I watched those fragments of light glimmer and vanish for a long while. I thought that today, too, would stay somewhere inside us, like a small light like that.

I set that thought down as the last line of this chapter. That night, I watched Jeteo hold two things together for the first time. Keeping, and staying close. I didn't know then, not exactly, that it was his first step toward trust.

(Continued in Chapter 36.)

Chapter 36. A Place to Plant

> *_Previously_ — Father called Elpis's name on his own, for the first time. Jeteo realized that what had returned in Father hadn't come back because he'd gathered evidence, but because he'd stayed close — and began holding keeping and staying close together, both at once.*

"…Where should we go now." Jeteo asked one evening. It was a question for Father as much as for me.

We were watching the sunset from a small hill that day. Watching the sky turn red, I thought, for the first time, that even a journey like ours needed an evening. Not more walking — an evening to stop and decide where to go.

Below the hill, the road split in two. One led north, the way we'd come; one led south. I looked at that fork for a long time. Looking down at it from above like that, I couldn't tell which way was farther, or which was safer.

The wind had died down. It was the first quiet evening we'd had in days. The sunset shifted from red to orange, then to gray. I found it strange how that change happened so slowly, and yet, at some point, it had suddenly become a different color altogether. I thought people's hearts were probably like that too.

There was a limit to how long we could keep walking like we were running from something. Father still tired easily, and he still couldn't fully settle at night.

Our feet were a problem too. Father's shoes had already split at the toes, and Jeteo's didn't look like they'd last much longer either. I started counting up all

these things, then stopped. The more I counted, the more it all pointed to the same conclusion — we couldn't keep going like this.

I studied Father's face. He'd put on a little weight since we first found him. But there was still a restless look in his eyes, like he was searching for something. I thought that restlessness wouldn't fully go away until we had a place before we had an answer.

I felt, in that moment, that what we needed now wasn't an answer anymore. It was a place. Not a direction to walk in — somewhere to put down roots.

I thought that, and pressed my fingertips into the ground. The soil still held the day's warmth. I felt like that warmth was holding us somewhere too.

I thought the word "roots" had just occurred to me for the first time. Looking back now, it was a word Father used to use, back in Brick Hollow. He used to say, sometimes, "We still don't have roots." I hadn't known, then, what he meant by that.

I read back over the record I'd been keeping. From the last night in Brick Hollow up to now, page after page was filled. I realized how few answers were in it. But there was something in it that outnumbered the answers. Days we had walked together.

I turned the pages one by one. The night we met Temel, the night we found Father, the counting gesture, the humming, the searching light, the nights on the run, and my own name, called that very morning by the stream. I saw, on every one of those pages, both tear-marks and traces of laughter, side by side.

I understood, in that moment. This record had started as a way of gathering evidence. But somewhere along the way, it had become something else. A record that held onto the simple fact that we had walked together.

Jeteo glanced at those pages over my shoulder.

"…Is that all about us?" he asked.

"…Yeah," I said. "Not all of it. Just what I can remember."

"…Can I read it later?" he asked. His voice was careful, unlike him.

"…Of course," I said. "It's yours too, really."

Jeteo looked at me for a moment at that.

"…Mine?"

"…Yeah," I said. "You're in it more than anyone."

"…What did you write?" he asked.

"…Read it later," I said.

Jeteo huffed a laugh at that. I was glad he was curious. Being curious meant thinking about a "later."

Before the sunset faded completely, the last red light lit up the side of Jeteo's face. I felt, all over again, how different that face was now from the brother who'd left Brick Hollow.

. . .

"…What if we went back to Speon's?" I said. "That well wasn't dangerous. And Speon… he was alone too."

Saying it, I pictured Speon's well-yard — quiet, unhurried, nothing but the low voices of people drawing water. I realized, only then, that it had been the least threatening place we'd found since we first fled.

And there was one more thing about that well. No one there had ever asked us what we wanted to file. Only then did I understand what a difference that made.

Jeteo turned the idea over.

"…Doesn't sound bad," he said. "We need help, and Speon needs help too."

"…Would Speon take us in?" I asked. "There's three of us."

"…No idea," Jeteo said. "But we can ask."

I found it strange, hearing that from Jeteo. The old Jeteo never started anything he thought might be refused. I thought I knew whose doing that change was.

Father asked quietly.

"…If we go there… would it be all right for me to be there?"

Asking it, he didn't look at either of our faces. He kept his eyes on the sunset. I understood — he was afraid to hear the answer.

There was still that same carefulness in his voice. I found that I no longer found it strange. It had simply become part of who Father was.

Jeteo looked straight at Father.

"…Of course," he said. This time, without a moment's hesitation.

I took note of how quickly he answered. Back in Chapter 32, faced with the same question, Jeteo had needed a long while before he answered at all. This time it was instant. I thought that whole gap of time held the entire road Jeteo had walked since then.

"…Just one thing," Father said. "If I get like that again, at night. If another night like last time comes."

Jeteo was quiet for a moment.

"…Then I'll be there again," he said. "That's about the only thing I know how to do."

Father bowed his head at that. I thought he was crying, but when he lifted his head, his eyes were dry. Instead, his face had loosened just slightly.

The sunset had almost gone. The last thread of light stretched our three shadows out long, joining them into one. Watching that shadow, I felt, for real, that we had chosen a direction now.

. . .

We started walking south again, toward Speon's well.

The road back felt shorter than it had going the other way. It wasn't only because we knew the way.

That day, we walked while singing, for the first time. Father sang as far as he remembered, and I picked up where he left off. Jeteo didn't sing, but he kept time with the pace of it.

Just a few days earlier, even making a sound out loud had felt frightening. I couldn't say exactly what had changed in those few days. The world itself surely hadn't.

I passed, along that road, through the same scenery we'd already crossed once. The rock we'd hidden behind, the bushes where we'd muffled our footsteps, the fork where we'd met the merchant. The same scenery — but it looked

completely different now. We simply walked, this time, through places we'd once fled through in fear.

I thought, then, that the same road, walked a second time, could become a different road. Maybe someday, looking back, this whole journey of ours would look completely different too.

Father recognized a few spots along the way.

"…We were here, weren't we?" he asked, in front of some rock.

"…Yes," Jeteo said. "We hid here."

"…So we did," Father said. He spoke like someone who knew it by feeling, not by memory.

I decided not to count moments like that. If I started counting, there would be days that added up and days that didn't, and I felt like my heart would break on the days that didn't. So I decided to just take whatever came.

Speon looked startled to see us. And even more startled when he saw Father.

"…You found him," Speon said. There was real gladness in his voice.

Speon's bucket stopped dead in his hand. I could feel, in that frozen gesture, just how startled he was.

"…Yes," Jeteo said. "But not completely found. We're still finding him."

I set Jeteo's words down here exactly as he said them. He'd learned, by now, to tell the difference between "found" and "still finding."

Speon didn't ask anything else at that. He didn't demand an explanation either. He just nodded once and went back to hauling up the bucket.

I think that nod was the biggest welcome we received that day. In Haven, everything began with filing and explaining. Here, it didn't.

Speon drew Father a bowl of water. Father drank it, looking around the well.

Father's hand trembled faintly around the bowl. Whether that was from the water after such a long walk, or something else, I couldn't tell.

"…This place… feels strangely comfortable," Father said.

After he finished the water, he held the bowl for a long while. Like someone who'd forgotten to give it back. I thought that was a hand trying to hold onto this place a little longer.

"…Makes sense," Speon said quietly. "This place has always been like that."

Speon ran his hand over an old stone beside the well.

"…I wasn't the only one who kept this well," Speon said. "People passed through before me. What they left behind is still here."

"…Like what?" I asked.

Speon thought for a moment before answering.

"…Things like the order you set the stones in," he said. "No one taught it to me. There are things you just come to know, if you stay here long enough."

Listening to that, I thought of that leaf at the flowerbed — the one that had grown there without anyone planting it. I thought maybe this world had more than one place like that.

Speon's hand slowly ran over the stone again. I could tell that gesture was a habit, repeated over a long time. I thought you could tell how long someone had kept a place just by watching the way their hand moved.

. . .

That evening, I planted a few seeds in the small patch of ground beside the well. The leaf I'd brought from that flowerbed in Haven had dried up long before. But I still remembered the hands that had given me those seeds, at that very spot.

The soil was soft. I dug small holes with my fingertips, dropped a seed into each one, and covered it back over with earth. Repeating that simple motion, I felt my heart settle in a strange way.

The evening soil smelled of the day's warmth. I didn't mind the dirt under my fingernails. I thought of touching soil every day back in Brick Hollow. There, the soil had been meant to become bricks. Here, the soil was meant to grow something. Same soil, different purpose.

Jeteo watched from a little way off, then came over.

"…Can I plant one too?" he asked.

I handed him a seed. He dug into the dirt with clumsy movements. I was glad for that clumsiness. It meant he wanted to plant something in this place just as much as I did.

"…How long does this take?" he asked.

"…I don't know," I said.

"…You don't know again?" he said.

"…Yeah," I said, laughing. "But you have to plant it to find out."

Jeteo didn't say anything to that. He just finished covering the seed with dirt. But his hands moved more carefully than before.

Father sat beside us, watching.

"…What are you planting?" he asked.

"…I don't know yet," I said. "But I guess we'll find out, once it grows."

Father turned that answer over quietly. I found that silence comfortable. It was a silence where not knowing the answer was all right.

Father smiled quietly at that.

"…I think I'm like that too," he said. "I don't know yet what's inside me. But I know something's planted there."

Jeteo heard that and came to sit beside us. The three of us sat in a row, looking down at the freshly turned soil. There was nothing to see there. But I could believe there was something inside it.

"…You know what?" Jeteo said quietly. "I never used to believe in anything I couldn't see."

"…And now?" I asked.

Jeteo looked at the soil for a while before answering.

"…I still don't believe all of it, even now. But that something's been planted — that, I'm trying to believe."

"…That alone is a lot," I said.

"…Is it," Jeteo said.

"…Yeah," I said. "You used to say you didn't believe in anything."

Jeteo went quiet for a moment at that.

"…That's still a little true, even now," he said. "I'm still not over being angry."

"…You don't have to be over it," I said.

"…Do you really think that?" he asked. "That you can believe, even while you're still angry?"

"…I think so," I said. "Believing and being angry — I think they can live together."

Jeteo looked like he was turning that over for a long time. He didn't answer. But I could feel him putting it away somewhere inside himself.

Listening to that, I looked up at the sky where stars were coming out, one by one. Somewhere up there, I thought, that person who'd led us the wrong way, kindly, must still be walking. That was the first time I wanted to call him something other than just "he." I still didn't know that name.

Speon called out to us from a distance to come eat supper. We got up from where we sat. Father held out his hand first and pulled me up, and Jeteo took Father's other hand. I looked down for a moment at the shape those three joined hands made.

None of those three hands was especially large. Father's hand was thin. Jeteo's was still growing. Mine was the smallest. But joined together like that, they were hard to let go of.

On the short walk back to the well, I felt the warmth of each hand in turn. Father's hand was still a little cold. Jeteo's was warm. I knew that difference would shift again in a few days, but I wanted to remember today's warmth anyway.

As he stood, Father asked,

"…We'll still be here tomorrow, won't we?"

"…Yes," Jeteo said. "Tomorrow too."

I set that line down as the last sentence of this Part. That evening, we settled at Speon's well-yard. The answers still hadn't all come. Neither had my brother's name, nor his full certainty. But that day, for the first time, I knew we had found a place to put down roots.

(Continued in Part Four.)

The Weeping Ledger, Part Four

By the Well

Chapter 37. Days by the Well

> *_Previously_ — Sensing they needed a place more than an answer, the siblings went back to Speon's well and put down roots. Elpis planted seeds again, and Father said, "I know something's been planted."*

That was how we began to live at the well.

For the first few nights, sleep wouldn't come, strangely. It took me a long time to understand why. Ever since we'd left Haven, our bodies had always tensed first, not knowing what the next day would bring. Here, our bodies still hadn't learned to believe that tomorrow wouldn't look very different from today.

A low stone wall ran around the well. Nameless weeds grew in the gaps between the stones. Every morning, dew gathered on their leaves. I got into the habit of touching that dew with a fingertip, every time I went to draw water.

There was a small hut by the well. Speon had used it for a long time. We made a small place for ourselves beside it. It was smaller than our house in Brick Hollow. Strangely, I didn't mind the smallness at all.

We had almost no belongings. Just what we'd carried out of Haven, and the few things Father had. Jeteo never once complained about how little we had. I knew that the old Jeteo would have called even that unfair. Not any more.

Among our things was the seed pouch. It was nearly empty now. I kept carrying that empty pouch instead of throwing it away. Speon once asked why I kept an empty pouch. I only smiled, not knowing how to answer. I couldn't

have put it into words then — that emptiness is also the mark of something that was once full.

The days weren't very different from one another. Draw water in the morning, walk with Father, leave a record in the evening. That sameness felt strange to me at first. Haven, and the road we'd fled along — both had always been time spent being chased by something.

That was when I first understood how precious an ordinary day was. I hadn't known, in Brick Hollow, what a rare gift a day with nothing happening in it could be.

I gradually settled on a spot for writing my evening record — beside the hut door, where the stone wall supported my back. From that spot I could see the whole well. I liked the angle. It was a place where I'd know at once if anything happened. Lately, though, not much happened. I didn't mind that at all.

The morning routine was simple. Draw water, take Father's hand and walk once around the well, and in the evening, write a short note about the day. Writing felt like homework at first. But after a few days, it stopped being homework and became a way of holding on to the day.

Speon taught us the well's rules, one at a time. Always hang the bucket in the same spot. Give water to anyone newly out before you ask them anything. I could feel that these rules were nothing like Haven's. Haven's rules existed for processing requests. These rules existed for people.

"…How many rules are there?" I asked.

"…Never counted," Speon said. "One got added whenever it was needed. There weren't any at first."

"…Which one came first?"

Speon paused, hand still, and thought.

"…Not asking," Speon said. "Not asking why someone came out of the well, or what they'd lost before. You wait until they say it themselves. That one came first, for me."

Hearing that, I remembered how the intake window in Haven had always asked first. What is your name. What is the issue. I felt that difference clearly, for the first time, right then.

"…So what do you do with your curiosity?" I asked. "Just hold it in?"

"…Draw them another cup of water," Speon said. "As much as you're curious."

I thought about that for a long time. A person who turned curiosity into water instead of questions. From that day on, I got into the habit of filling a water jar first, whenever someone came out of the well. And strangely, that was how — later — the person would come to speak first.

Father improved little by little. He still didn't know Jeteo's name. But during the day, he began trying to do things on his own for a few minutes at a time — drawing water, moving a stone. No one had to ask him.

Father seemed to especially like drawing water. That repetition of lowering and pulling the bucket seemed to steady him. I saw him a few times just standing there, gripping the bucket rope, still. Even when he wasn't moving, he never let go of that rope.

Father slept badly at night. He woke often, and when he did, he sat for a long while without speaking. Every time, I went and sat beside him. I said nothing. We just watched the dark together. I thought that was all I could do. I learned later that it wasn't just all I could do — it was the most important thing.

"…It's easier when I'm doing something," Father said. "When my body moves."

"…What are you most at ease doing?" I asked.

Father thought about the question a moment, rubbing the dirt floor with his fingertips.

"…Moving stones," Father said. "I don't know why. I just like having something in my hands."

Hearing that, I thought of the bricks of Brick Hollow. Even then, Father's hands had always been holding something. Something heavy. Something hard. It struck me, strangely painfully, that the habit had stayed with him this way.

Hearing that, I thought of Father in Brick Hollow. Those hands had always been moving too. I felt, then, that something inside Father was coming back before his name did.

. . .

Jeteo began helping Speon look after the well. He mended the bucket, tended the stone wall, and at night took turns keeping watch with Speon.

"…Why are you helping with this?" I asked.

"…Speon did this alone for so long," Jeteo said. "I think I understand it now. Why waiting becomes a kind of work."

"…What do you mean?" I asked.

"…I used to think waiting was doing nothing," Jeteo said. "But mend a bucket every day and you find out how much work goes into it. Waiting was like that

too. Work that takes a lot of hands."

Hearing that, I understood that Jeteo had begun to understand Speon's life. It wasn't an understanding he'd arrived at from an answer. It was an understanding earned by doing it alongside him.

Jeteo's hands had grown much rougher in those few weeks. Calluses were starting to form where the bucket rope rubbed. Every time I saw those hands, I remembered his hands carrying bricks in Brick Hollow. Back then those hands had moved to dodge a taskmaster's rod. Now these hands moved with no one making them. I kept that difference close to my heart.

As Speon taught Jeteo how to mend the bucket, he let a little of his old story slip out now and then — how he'd once been so afraid that he'd fled and left someone behind. Jeteo didn't press him for more. He just listened.

"…Why don't you ask?" Speon asked.

"…I've learned lately that it's better for people to talk when they want to," Jeteo said.

Speon looked at him a long time at that.

"…When you first came here, you did press me," Speon said. "Asked why I'd waste my time keeping some well out here like this."

Jeteo looked a little embarrassed at that.

"…Sorry, about back then," Jeteo said.

"…Nothing to be sorry for," Speon said. "That question made me think it over again too. Why I'm here."

"…Did you find an answer?"

"…Still looking," Speon said, smiling. "But I'm not in a hurry any more."

"…What happens to something you're not in a hurry about?" Jeteo asked.

Speon thought a moment, winding the bucket rope.

"…You just have to go through a few days where the answer doesn't come and the day passes anyway," Speon said. "Then you find out. That the answer was never the thing holding your day up."

Jeteo didn't answer that. But I saw his face take on the look of someone filing a thing away rather than discarding it.

"…You seem like a different person than a few months ago," Speon said.

"…I feel that way sometimes too," Jeteo said. "But I can't really explain what's changed."

Listening to that conversation from the side, I looked at Jeteo again. I couldn't point to an exact day when this had started in him. Some change comes that way — not overnight, but seeping in like water.

That evening, Speon taught Jeteo how to measure the depth of the well — tying a knot in the rope every so often and counting which knot the water reached. Jeteo practiced it over and over until he had it. In that repetition, I felt that the very way Jeteo learned things had changed. He used to ask first why he had to learn something. Now he simply learned.

"…Why measure this depth?" Jeteo asked, counting the knots one by one.

"…You need to know when a drought comes," Speon said. "If you know the water's dropping ahead of time, you can warn people ahead of time."

"…It's not dropping now, though."

"…No," Speon said. "But you measure every day. If you only measure on the day it drops, it's already too late."

Jeteo's hand stopped at that. I saw something pass over his face. It was the exact opposite of Haven's logic — a city that only ever took in a request after the problem had already happened. Here, there was someone keeping watch before the problem ever came.

. . .

One night, there was a sound of movement at the well.

It was an unusually quiet night. No wind. In that stillness, hearing that sound, I suddenly thought of our last night in Brick Hollow. I realized, in that instant, that the memory was still lodged somewhere in my body.

Moonlight lay scattered in pieces on the water. I watched that trembling light and, for a moment, held my breath. From a well that had made not a single sound of water, a splashing sound suddenly rose. I strained my ears not to lose it.

Father woke to the sound too. He walked to the well a little later than we did, but with a steady stride. Watching that walk, I felt that Father no longer fled from unfamiliar sounds.

The four of us ran there together. A woman was crouched trembling, just out of the bottom of the well. Her eyes held nothing in them.

Jeteo went to her first.

"…It's all right," Jeteo said. It was the very voice we had heard from Father. "Breathe slowly. You're safe here."

Watching that scene, my breath caught. A few months ago, Jeteo had stood in the exact spot he was most afraid of. Now he stood there most calmly of all.

I sat quietly beside the woman and held out a water jar. Her hands shook too badly to take it. I took her hand instead and let the water trickle in, little by little. That was exactly what we had done for Father, when we first met him.

Speon only watched from a distance. He didn't step in. I felt, then, that I understood how he'd been able to keep this well for so long. He wasn't a man who stepped in every time — he was a man who knew when to step in only when it was needed.

Father stood a little apart too. Neither stepping in nor stepping back. I felt that Father was studying the woman's trembling shoulders closely. He murmured something, low.

"…Was I like that too?" Father asked me.

For a moment, the question stopped my words.

"…Yes," I finally answered. "But now you can ask a question like that."

Father nodded at that. And looked at the woman again. It was the first time I'd seen him recognize himself in a stranger.

After a long while, Father lifted one of the water jars and pushed it a little toward the woman. He said nothing. He simply set it within reach of her hand and stepped back.

Watching that small gesture, my throat went hot. Father still didn't know who he was. But who he had once been — his hands remembered that first.

. . .

The woman stayed by the well for a few days, and then remembered part of her name. Not the whole thing. But even that much was enough to make her laugh through tears.

The day the woman first spoke a fragment of her name aloud, I happened to be carrying a water jar. I stopped in my tracks at the sound. "…Mi…" the woman said. That was all. But she held on to that one syllable and wept for a long time. I couldn't tell if that weeping was sorrow or joy. Probably both.

The woman barely spoke for days. But every morning, she came out on her own to fill her water jar. I had already learned from watching Father that this small movement was the beginning of recovery.

Speon didn't call her by a name. He just called her "the guest." At first I thought that was rude. Later I understood. Speon was refusing to define her by any name at all until she found her own.

The day before she left, she pressed a small stone into my hand. She didn't explain why. I didn't ask, and took it. I still have that stone.

"…When I remember my name, all of it, I'll come back," the woman said. Her voice still trembled a little. But it was a different trembling than the one she'd arrived with.

"…Come back whenever you're ready," I said. "This place isn't going anywhere."

The woman laughed at that. A laugh I hadn't seen before. Short, but clear.

The morning she left, Speon carved a small mark into the well's stone wall. I asked what it was for.

"…It's a count of everyone who's passed through," Speon said. "Since we can't write their names, we mark it, at least."

I looked at that stone wall closely for the first time. There were a great many marks. I began thinking that every one of those marks was someone's day, and then stopped counting partway through.

Before I fell asleep that night, I thought for a moment of the day we'd first arrived at the well. Everything had been unfamiliar then. Now the sound of the bucket, the sound of Speon's footsteps — all of it sounded familiar. I didn't know when that familiarity had come. But that it had come — that much was certain.

That night, Jeteo said to me,

"…I still don't know who that man is. I can't say I believe in God either. But watching that woman today, I knew something. I know how to sit beside someone now. That much is certain."

"…When did you learn that?" I asked.

"…I don't know," Jeteo said. "I just came to and realized I already knew. No one taught me."

"…Maybe you learned it from Father," I said. "Just being beside us."

Jeteo was silent at that for a moment.

"…Maybe so," Jeteo finally said.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. I knew that Jeteo still couldn't use the word faith. But he was already doing the work faith does. I decided not to think that order strange.

(Continued in Chapter 38.)

Chapter 38. Mena Came

> *_Previously_ — Life at the well settled into something steady. Jeteo helped Speon tend it and learned how to sit beside someone. "I can't say I believe in God. But I know how to sit beside someone."*

About a month in, a familiar figure came walking from far off.

It was Mena. She had the record box she always carried slung over her shoulder.

The box had grown much thicker than before. Paper stuck out past its edges. Mena's shoes were caked in dirt. It showed how long she'd been walking.

The shoulder of Mena's coat was worn through too — the strap of the box must have rubbed that same spot for a long time. Looking at that worn patch, I tried to guess how long she'd been carrying that weight.

The wind stirred the grass around the well, gently. I was the first to see a figure appear beyond that grass. At first I didn't know who it was. Only once the walk became familiar did I know it was Mena.

The moment I saw her, I ran. Mena remembered us. And when she saw Father, she stopped walking.

"…Did you come to bring Speon news?" I asked.

"…That too," Mena said. Her face flushed a little. "I wanted to know how you were, too."

"…How long did it take you to get here?" I asked.

"…About ten days," Mena said. "Had to stop at a few places along the way. Didn't feel tired, though. I was too curious what I'd find here."

"…What did you think you'd find?" I asked.

Mena thought for a moment.

"…I don't know," Mena said. "I just wanted to see with my own eyes how you were living here. There's something a written name alone doesn't give you."

I didn't understand what that meant right away. But over the next few days, I came to. For Mena, a name was only a beginning. Watching how that name lived — that was what Mena really wanted to do.

The first evening Mena arrived at the well, she asked nothing at all. She simply watched us live. She watched us draw water, watched us walk with Father, watched us share a meal. That gaze didn't make me uncomfortable. If anything, I felt it had been a long time since someone had watched over our whole day like that.

"…What are you looking at so much?" I asked.

"…Just — I wanted to see it all," Mena said. "Writing down a name is only half of it. You have to see it lived to make it real."

I took Mena's hand. Her fingertips were cracked. I could guess how many names those hands had written down.

"…What happened to your hand?" I asked.

"…Must be from holding a pen too long," Mena said, laughing. "It's fine, it doesn't hurt."

I didn't believe that. But I decided not to press. It was the first rule I'd learned at the well.

Instead, I refilled a water jar and set it in front of Mena. She glanced at me, seeing that.

"…You've got a face like there's something you want to ask," Mena said.

"…There is," I said. "But here, water first."

Mena laughed out loud at that. And once she'd drunk it all, she started telling me things I hadn't even asked about.

. . .

"…Is this…" Mena couldn't finish the sentence.

"…Yes," Jeteo said. "We found him. His name still hasn't all come back, but."

Mena's eyes welled with tears. I had never seen Mena show emotion like this. She had always been someone who wrote names down calmly. I understood, only in that moment, that the calmness had never been indifference.

Mena carefully took Father's hand. Father didn't pull away. Even though it was an unfamiliar hand, he simply let it stay.

"…Among the names I've recorded, meeting one again like this is really rare," Mena said. "Thank you. For not giving up."

Mena wiped her eyes with the back of her hand, laughing. I thought that laugh was so tangled with weeping that they were almost impossible to tell apart.

"…It's thanks to you, Mena," Jeteo said. "If you hadn't recorded his name, we'd have just been walking around in circles."

Mena shook her head.

"…I only wrote it down," Mena said. "You're the ones who walked all this way to find him."

Jeteo shook his head at that.

"…If it hadn't been written down, we wouldn't even have known where to go," Jeteo said. "I don't think that's a small thing."

Mena went quiet at that for a moment. I saw something long held down loosen in her face.

"…Honestly, sometimes this work has felt pointless," Mena said quietly. "There are far more names I write down that I never see again. Every time, I wondered what the point even was."

"…And now?" I asked.

"…Now I know," Mena said. "If I meet even one person again, then the names I never met before weren't wasted either. I've got a reason to keep carrying them now."

Father sat there, watching Mena quietly. His face was one that didn't quite remember who she was. But he didn't look at her like a stranger.

"…Do you know me?" Father asked carefully.

"…We crossed paths once, a long time ago," Mena said. "You didn't know me then. I didn't really know you either. But I wrote your name down."

Father nodded at that. It was less understanding than simple acceptance.

"…What kind of person was I, back then?" Father asked again.

Mena fell into thought for a moment. I could feel her choosing her answer carefully.

"…A quiet person," Mena finally said. "You didn't say much. But your eyes stayed with people, long after."

"…What kind of look was it?"

"…A look like you were trying to protect something," Mena said. "I didn't know what it was, then. I think I understand it now."

Father glanced toward us at that. I felt something pass through his eyes that matched what Mena had just described.

"…Did I protect it well?" Father asked.

Before Mena could answer, Jeteo spoke first.

"…You did," Jeteo said. His voice was lower than usual. "We're right here now."

Father said nothing to that. But I saw his shoulders drop, ever so slightly. Like someone who had been holding tension for a long time, letting go of it for a moment.

Watching that short exchange, I thought about it. How many of the names Mena had recorded would ever face her like this again? I didn't know the answer. But looking at Mena's eyes, I could tell she was someone who would keep writing whether she knew the answer or not.

. . .

Speon heard the news and came running from the well. The moment he saw Mena, he stopped in his tracks.

The two of them said nothing for a while.

In that silence, I watched Speon's face. He was usually calm here at the well. Not in that moment, though. I saw something old shaking loose in that face.

Speon's hand still held the bucket handle. I saw it trembling, faintly. As if to hide it, he set the bucket down carefully beside the well.

Mena stood where she was too, unmoving. She hadn't even set her pack down. It struck me, strangely, that both of them seemed to be hesitating to be the first to come closer.

"…You said you were still waiting," Mena said first.

"…Yeah," Speon said. "That still holds."

"…How many years is that now?" Mena asked.

Speon started to count on his fingers, then stopped.

"…Stopped counting," Speon said. "Counting made it heavier."

Mena's eyes dropped slightly at that.

Mena laughed at the answer. I couldn't tell if that laugh was relief or something else. Speon laughed along with her. The two laughs looked alike.

The wind passed between them. I thought that wind was slowly sweeping away an old silence. Only then did Speon take Mena's pack from her. It was a completely natural gesture. I felt it wasn't the first time. The two of them seemed like people who had already been through this moment many times before.

I felt, in that short exchange, how much time had passed between them. I still didn't know what had happened between the two of them. But that day, I decided for the first time not to ask. I had learned that some stories deserve to be respected without explanation.

Mena stayed at the well for several days after that. I watched, more than once, secretly, the two of them sitting side by side filling water jars. They didn't say much. But that silence was nothing like any silence I'd seen before.

During the day, Mena still spread out her record box and wrote things down — the names of people she'd newly met, the things they'd lost. I peeked at those papers beside her. A short line was written next to each name. "Looking for her daughter." "Hand injured, still can't use it." I understood that these short sentences were Mena's way of seeing the world. Not resolution. Memory.

I looked for our own names in a corner of that paper. Jeteo. Beside it, written briefly: "Looking for his father." And below that, in smaller writing, one more line: "Has not given up." I stared at that sentence for a long time. This was how Mena had been recording us.

In the evenings, Mena sometimes showed the box to Speon. He turned the pages one at a time, pointing with a fingertip whenever he found a name he knew. I felt that this scene looked nothing like anything we'd seen in Haven. The Ledger erased names off a screen. Mena left names on paper.

One evening, I sat beside Mena and turned through the papers in the box with her.

"…Do you memorize all of this?" I asked.

"…Not all of it," Mena said. "But when you write it by hand, you never completely forget. Strangely enough."

"…Isn't it hard? Writing down nothing but sad stories?"

Mena turned a page and fell silent for a moment. The evening wind lifted the edge of the paper slightly. Mena pressed it down with a fingertip.

"…It's hard," Mena finally said. "But if no one writes it down, that name really did never exist. That scares me more."

I thought about those words for a long time. I felt, then, that I understood why Mena walked so far. Mena was doing the thing the Ledger could never do. Not forgetting.

"…When did you start doing this, Mena?" I asked.

"…A very long time ago," Mena said. "At first I just meant to write down one person's name. But once you start writing, you end up writing the person next to them too, and the person next to them. Before I knew it, the box had become this."

"…Who was the first name you wrote?"

Mena went silent at that question for a long time. I felt something very old held inside that silence.

"…I'll tell you that later," Mena said. "Not yet."

I didn't ask again. I already knew, now, that some stories need time.

Instead, I looked at the inside of the box's lid. A name was written there too. Unlike the other papers, that name alone was written directly on the lid. The ink had faded a great deal, but it hadn't been erased.

I didn't read that name aloud. I couldn't be the one to bring up what Mena had chosen not to say yet.

That night I thought for a long time about the inside of that lid. Mena carried every name in the world inside that box. But there was exactly one name she carried carved into the box itself.

. . .

The night before Mena left, we all sat together around the fire. Speon hummed an old song for the first time in a long while. I couldn't make out the words. But the melody alone stirred something.

The smell of burning firewood spread over the whole well-yard. Smelling it, I thought of the smell of the brick kiln in Brick Hollow. A different smell. But both were the kind that made people feel warm.

Jeteo asked Speon what the song's words meant. Speon just smiled for a moment and didn't answer.

"…You don't have to know what it means," Speon said. "Some things you understand just by listening."

Listening to that, I thought, strangely, of the man. He was always like that too. Things you understood without an explanation.

That night, Mena took a piece of paper out of her record box and showed it to Father.

"…This is your name," Mena said. "Exactly as the children told it to me. I wrote it down and carried it with me."

Father looked at that paper for a long time. Even reading his own name, his face didn't quite believe it belonged to him.

I looked at the handwriting of Father's name on that paper. It was Mena's writing. There were marks of pressing hard as she wrote. I felt that pressure spoke of how carefully Mena had written that name.

The firelight flickered over the paper. Father traced the letters one by one with a fingertip. Very slowly. That gesture, I thought, looked like a child learning

letters for the first time.

I saw the creases where the paper had been folded and unfolded. It looked like it had been folded many times over. I guessed at how long Mena had carried that paper close.

"…Is this… my name?" Father asked.

"…Yes," Mena said. "A name your children have never once forgotten."

"…Why show it to me now?" Father asked.

Mena chose her words for a moment.

"…I thought the time had come," Mena said. "The first time I came, I thought it still wasn't. Seeing your face today, I thought it was all right to give it to you now."

Father nodded at that. His fingertip still rested on the paper.

"…Can I keep this?" Father asked.

"…That's why I brought it," Mena said.

Father folded the paper again, following the creases already there. Then he put it inside his coat, in an inner pocket. It was the same spot where Father had always kept his important things, back in Brick Hollow. I recognized that, and swallowed once.

The fire crackled loudly once. No one flinched at the sound.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. In that moment, I heard Father read his own name aloud. The pronunciation was still unfamiliar. But within that unfamiliarity, I felt something coming back, very slowly.

(Continued in Chapter 39.)

Chapter 39. I've Been There

> *_Previously_ — Mena came to the well and met Father. When she showed him the name she'd kept, he read his own name aloud for the first time. Still unfamiliar, but something was slowly coming back.*

Even after Mena left again, the days at the well didn't change much. Drawing water, walking, leaving a record in the evening — the repetition continued. Strangely, that repetition set my mind at ease. In Haven, every day had felt like a new incident. Here, every day resembled yesterday. I already knew now how precious that resemblance was.

Someone else came out of the well.

This time it was a young boy. He looked about ten. The moment he came out, he couldn't even cry — he just sat there, dazed.

The sky was unusually overcast that day. Under that overcast sky, I thought the boy's face was the same gray as the clouds. This wasn't the first time I'd seen a face like that at the well. But I never got used to it, no matter how many times.

His clothes were old and thin. His shoes didn't match. In that sight, the clothes of Brick Hollow's children overlapped in my mind. I didn't know which hollow he'd come from. But his eyes were not unfamiliar to me.

There was an old scar on his knee. I looked at that scar and started to guess whether it was recent or very old, then stopped myself. Either way, that wasn't what mattered right now.

Watching him, I thought of when we first met Father, months ago. I remembered how helpless we had been then. It was different now. We already knew what we had to do.

Speon, as always, brought water first. The boy couldn't even drink it once he had it. His hands were shaking.

The boy's reflected face wavered on the surface of the water jar. Watching that trembling reflection, I wondered if the boy still found even his own face unfamiliar. People just out of the well were often like that. They treated their own hands, their own faces, as if seeing them for the first time.

I saw that trembling. And for the first time, I realized this place had been holding more people than Speon alone could carry. Now we were with him too.

Speon set the water jar down in front of the boy and stepped back without a word. I knew that stepping back was a kindness. Speon had long known how to never approach anyone first.

Father was watching the boy from a little way off too. Something familiar crossed his face. I didn't know exactly what expression it was. But I felt that Father was recognizing something in that boy.

Father slowly walked toward him. I tensed for a moment. Father was still clumsy about growing close to strangers. But that day was different. Father quietly crouched down in front of the boy.

"…You're scared, aren't you?" Father asked. In a very small voice.

The boy looked up at Father. He didn't answer. But he nodded, just barely.

"…So was I," Father said. "Still am, sometimes."

I held my breath, hearing that. It was the first time I'd heard Father speak his own fear aloud like that.

"…Then when does it stop being scary?" the boy asked.

Father couldn't answer that question for a long moment. I knew he was trying hard not to pretend to know what he didn't.

"…I don't know," Father finally said. "But you can still drink the water even while you're scared. That much I know."

The boy looked down at the water jar at that. His hands still shook. But with that shaking hand, he pulled the jar a little closer to himself.

Watching that scene, I thought — Father hadn't given the boy an answer. Father had no answer to give. But Father had given him the fact that he was still scared too. That stayed with the boy longer than any answer could have.

. . .

Jeteo sat quietly beside the boy.

"…I've been there too," Jeteo said. "Our father came out here just like this. He didn't know anything at first, either."

The boy looked at Jeteo. For the first time, there was some response in his eyes.

"…And now?" the boy asked. His voice cracked.

"…Now he can read his own name out loud," Jeteo said. "Not all of it. But it's coming back, bit by bit."

Hearing that, the boy took the water jar carefully in both hands. And began drinking, very slowly. Watching that, I realized only then that I'd been holding my breath.

I thought, in that moment, of the day we'd first handed Father water, months before. We hadn't known anything then. There was nothing else we could do besides hand him water. Jeteo could do far more now than he could then. But in the end, what he was doing was still the same thing. Handing over water. Sitting beside him.

"…I don't remember what my name was. At all," the boy said. His voice was choked.

"…That's okay," Jeteo said. "It doesn't have to come to you right now. Our father took months."

"…Months?" the boy asked, startled.

"…Yeah," Jeteo said. "But he wasn't alone during those months. I think that was the most important part."

"…Is it not okay to be alone?" the boy asked.

"…It's not that it's not okay," Jeteo said. "But it takes longer, alone. I've seen it for myself."

The boy gripped the water jar a little tighter, as if turning that over in his mind.

"…Why are you being so nice to me?" the boy asked again. His voice still carried a trace of wariness.

Jeteo laughed a little at the question.

"…You already asked me that," Jeteo said.

"…I wanted to ask again," the boy said.

Jeteo really laughed at that. I thought it was the first bright laugh I'd seen from him in days.

"…You can ask," Jeteo said. "As many times as you want."

"…Even the same thing again?"

"…Yeah," Jeteo said. "I asked the same thing about a hundred times myself. No one ever told me to stop asking."

Hearing that, I thought of Haven's intake window. There, you couldn't file the same thing twice. It was already a resolved entry. Only then did I know, in a single word, what that city had lacked. A place to ask again.

. . .

From that day on, the boy followed Jeteo everywhere. He tried to copy everything Jeteo did.

When Jeteo mended the bucket, the boy watched from beside him, then slid his own hand in to help. When Jeteo walked around the well with Father, the boy followed a few steps behind. I thought that looked like the old Jeteo. He too had once followed someone's footsteps like that, wordlessly.

One day the boy picked up a stone and handed it to Jeteo. He didn't explain why. Jeteo didn't ask why either — he just took it. Watching that scene, I thought of Father. Father used to collect stones for no reason too. I thought this resemblance might not be an accident.

Jeteo carried that stone in his pocket. A few days later I saw him take it out and set it back down in front of the boy.

"…Here, take this back," Jeteo said.

"…Why? I gave it to you."

"…I already received it," Jeteo said. "Now you hold on to it, and later give it to someone else. I think that's better."

The boy tilted his head at that, but took the stone back and put it in his pocket. Watching that, I felt something flowing from Jeteo to this boy, and someday, to yet another person.

Speon watched that scene from a distance and said quietly to me,

"…Your brother's turned into a completely different person now."

"…How so?"

"…He used to try to find answers," Speon said. "Now he's building a place beside him. I think that's a much harder thing to do."

"…Why is it harder?" I asked.

"…An answer, once you find it, is over," Speon said. "Being beside someone has to be rebuilt every day. Just because you were there yesterday doesn't mean you're there today."

I heard that and looked toward our hut. Father sat in the shade, watching the boy. It looked like a spot where nothing was happening. I already knew now that it wasn't nothing at all.

"…Why are you helping me?" the boy asked one day.

Jeteo thought for a moment before answering.

"…Because I've had it done for me," Jeteo said. "Being sat beside — I've had that too. So I can do it too."

"…By who?" the boy asked.

Jeteo glanced toward Speon for a moment, and toward the shade of the tree.

"…Lots of people," Jeteo said. "My sister. Some man. I'm still receiving it, right here."

The boy repeated that back, as if turning it over.

"…Because you've had it done for you…" the boy murmured.

"…Yeah," Jeteo said. "You'll be that for someone else someday too. You probably can't believe that now."

The boy tilted his head. It wasn't a face that had fully understood the words. But something seemed to have stayed with him. From that day on, whenever he filled his water jar, he scooped out one extra ladleful and set it aside, even though it wasn't his to give. Not even knowing who it was for.

Hearing that answer, I understood one complete sentence for the first time. A person who has never been loved has a harder time learning how to love. Jeteo was giving away, exactly as he'd received it.

I copied that sentence straight into my evening record right then. My hand shook as I wrote it. I knew it was a sentence about Jeteo, and at the same time a sentence about me. I was giving away what I'd received too. Seeds. Waiting. How to sit beside someone.

I'd been listening to that conversation from the side. I knew that the old Jeteo couldn't have answered a question like that. The old Jeteo would have said "just because." This Jeteo knew the reason.

I thought that difference was truly huge. Between "just because" and "because I've had it done for me" lay the whole of the months Jeteo had passed through. Having watched those months beside him, I knew the weight of that sentence better than anyone.

Within a few days, the boy began to smile a little. He still didn't know his own name. But he liked the temporary name Jeteo had given him.

Jeteo named him "Little Shadow," because the boy always followed behind him like a shadow. At first the boy laughed at the name. But after a few days, he really did come to like being called that.

"…This isn't really my name, though," the boy said one day.

"…I know," Jeteo said. "But a name needs to hold the place until the real one comes."

The boy nodded, turning that over.

"…Will I get to find my real name too, someday?" the boy asked.

"…Yeah," Jeteo said. "Slowly. But it'll definitely come back."

"…How do you know it'll definitely come back?"

Jeteo glanced toward Father for a moment. He was just then pulling the bucket up at the well.

"…Because I've seen it," Jeteo said. "Our father didn't know anything at first either. Now he reads his own name out loud. I've seen it with my own eyes. So believe it."

The boy smiled for the first time at that. A short laugh. But a clear one. I recorded that laugh briefly in that evening's record. "Today, the nameless boy smiled for the first time."

Watching that laugh, I felt something strange. A few months ago, Jeteo had been someone who couldn't say anything to anyone with certainty. Now Jeteo was handing certainty to someone else, based on what he himself had seen.

Speon came over to us that evening and stroked the boy's head.

"…You can stay here until your name settles," Speon said. "No hurry."

"…Can I stay here even without a name?" the boy asked. His voice still carried some anxiety.

"…You're a person even without a name," Speon said. "There's no rule here that says people without names can't stay."

The boy smiled toward Speon for the first time at that. A small smile. But I noticed it was the second smile the boy had shown in a few days. I was glad that smile was coming a little more often.

The boy nodded. And for the first time, got up on his own to go fill a water jar.

I watched him from behind. His steps were still careful. But they were clearly steadier than the day before. I didn't miss that small difference — I held it carefully in my eyes.

. . .

That night, Jeteo said to me,

"…I felt something strange talking to that boy today."

"…What was it?"

"…I was saying, word for word, what I learned from that man. 'Even without a name, you're here right now. That's enough.' I never once memorized that. It

just came out."

I said nothing for a moment, hearing that. Only the sound of the night wind brushing the trees by the well.

"…Doesn't that scare you?" I asked.

"…What?"

"…You becoming like that man."

Jeteo thought about that for a long time. In that silence, I saw starlight flicker in his eyes now and then. The sound of night insects filled the well-yard.

"…It feels a little scary," Jeteo finally said. "But it doesn't feel bad. That's the strange part."

I didn't say anything back to that. I just sat a little closer beside him. Jeteo seemed to notice, and without a word, let his shoulder be there for me.

Far off, the boy made some sound — talking in his sleep, maybe. I turned my head toward it for a moment, then back to Jeteo. The boy was sleeping soundly. His sleeping face looked much more at ease than the day we'd met him.

"…That boy will say that to someone else someday too," I said.

"…I hope so," Jeteo said.

"…Then what will he call you, when he does?"

Jeteo didn't laugh at that for a long moment.

"…He doesn't have to remember my name," Jeteo finally said. "He just has to remember that someone sat beside him. I don't even know that man's name

either."

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. I knew, then. Jeteo still couldn't explain who that man was. But he was already carrying that man's words in his body. I was sure, for the first time that day, of how close that was to the beginning of faith.

(Continued in Chapter 40.)

Chapter 40. Going to Him First

> *_Previously_ — A nameless boy newly came out at the well. Jeteo passed on to him, exactly as he'd received it, how to sit beside someone. And realized for himself that he was carrying out the words he'd learned from the man at the flowerbed in his body, without ever having memorized them.*

The man appeared and vanished with no fixed time.

For the first few days, I tried marking the days he came on a calendar. But I soon gave up. I couldn't find any pattern at all. And yet, he had never once come on a day he wasn't needed.

Some days he'd be touching the soil by the well. Some days he'd sit quietly beside someone newly out of it. No one ever knew when he'd come.

Some days I only realized afterward that he'd been there. The bucket sitting a little differently than usual, a stone the boy had been playing with moved to another spot. Every time I saw those small traces, I knew he'd passed through. He never left much of a mark of himself.

His clothes were always similar — plain, the kind you'd see anywhere. At first I thought that was strange. Later, I came to think it suited him instead. A man who didn't want to stand out.

His shoes were always worn too. I couldn't tell if that wear came from long use or from long walking. Probably both. Every time I looked at those shoes, I felt that wherever he came from, he was never a being who simply stood still.

I'd once tried to trace back the places he appeared. When someone newly out couldn't lift a water jar, when the boy woke alone at night crying, when Speon, rarely, looked worn out. He'd be standing quietly in those spots. I thought that couldn't be coincidence. But he never made a show of having come knowing in advance, either.

That was when I began to notice that irregularity was, itself, a kind of rule. He was always there, at the moment he was most needed.

I'd once even tried to work out a relationship between when he came and the weather. Did he come more often on rainy days, less on clear ones? In the end I found no correlation at all. Strangely, I liked even that failed observation. Some beings couldn't be caught by calculation.

Speon, and Mena too, never asked him certain things. When he'd come. Why now. I came to understand, living at the well, that this silence wasn't resignation. It was a kind of ease that only someone who had watched a long time could have.

I envied that ease at first. But living there, I came to understand it wasn't a natural-born ease. Speon must have been impatient too, at first, like me. I came to understand, little by little, at the well, that this ease had been made by time.

I once asked Speon about it.

The sound of him mending the bucket creaked a few times in the pause. I asked, carefully, with that as my backdrop.

"…Where does that man stay?"

Speon answered without stopping his work.

"…I don't know either," Speon said. "Haven't known for decades. But I've never once felt shorted. He came when he was needed."

"…Have you never once wondered?"

"…I've wondered," Speon said. "But at some point, that wondering stopped turning into fretting. There are things you can leave as just wondering."

"…Elpis, aren't you curious too?" Speon asked.

"…Yes," I said. "But lately that curiosity doesn't scare me."

"…Why?"

"…I learned it's all right to be without knowing," I said.

"…Where'd you learn that?" Speon asked.

"…From a seed," I said. "You don't know when a seed will sprout. But you keep giving it water anyway. I know now that that's what faith is."

Speon looked at me a long time at that. His face had something startled in it.

"…How old did you say you were?" Speon asked.

"…Thirteen," I said, laughing.

"…Sometimes you seem like you've lived longer than me," Speon said.

"…But I get impatient too, sometimes," I said. "Not every day. Some nights."

"…What do you do then?" Speon asked.

"…I water something," I said. "Even though you're not supposed to water at night. I just need to do something, is all."

Speon didn't laugh at that. Instead he nodded slowly.

"…I wipe down the bucket at night too, for no reason," Speon said. "Even though I already wiped it down during the day."

I held on to that for a long time. I didn't know, then, that it would someday reach Jeteo too.

The boy — the nameless one too — flinched the first time he saw the man. I understood that reaction. A body tenses first when a stranger suddenly appears. But after a few days, the boy grew easy with him too. Whenever the man appeared, the boy would slip over and sit beside him. He said nothing. Just sat there. Watching that, I understood that the boy was already learning how to be beside someone without speaking to them.

The man never tried to teach the boy anything. He simply touched the dirt alongside him when the boy fiddled with it. When the boy stacked stones, he watched without knocking them down. In that, I felt something like what Father had shown, the first time he came to us.

Once, a stone tower the boy was building collapsed. He looked like he was about to burst into tears right there. The man, beside him, picked the stones up one by one without a word and handed them back. The boy took them and started stacking again. Watching that scene from a distance, I understood that this was always how he rebuilt what had fallen. Not building it back up for you — handing you what you needed to build it back up yourself.

That evening the boy came and asked me,

"…Why doesn't that man help? It'd be faster if he just built it for me."

I couldn't answer that question right away. In Haven, the answer would have come instantly. File a request, and the tower would have arrived already built.

"…I guess fast isn't always best," I managed to say.

The boy tilted his head. But the next day, too, he stacked that tower alone. And the day he finished it, without anyone telling him to, he called me over to show me. I knew, then, that a tower built for you has no one to call.

I thought back to when I'd first met him. In an alley in Haven, he'd seemed like just someone passing by. I hadn't known, then, that he'd be a person who stayed with us this long. Now, on a day he didn't come, it left a strange emptiness. I didn't know exactly when that emptiness had started.

I wrote that emptiness into my evening record once. "That man didn't come today. The day felt strangely long." Reading that sentence back, I laughed. I'd somehow started measuring the length of my days by whether he came or not.

. . .

One afternoon, he sat alone in the shade of the tree by the well.

Jeteo walked over. I didn't follow. I knew that was his place to go.

It was late afternoon. Sunlight slanted in through the shade of the tree. Jeteo's shadow stretched long, moving toward the man. I watched that shadow gradually shorten. Jeteo's steps were slow. But they didn't stop.

I watched Jeteo's back. His shoulders weren't as tense as they used to be. Watching that back, I felt for the first time that you could tell what someone was walking toward just from the shape of their walking away.

"…Can we talk?" Jeteo asked. Not in his old accusing tone.

I watched from a distance. I saw, for the first time, Jeteo going to find him. It had always been the man appearing first. This time Jeteo approached first.

Watching that back, I thought of our last night in Brick Hollow. The night Jeteo shouted at the sky. Back then Jeteo had approached in anger. Now he was approaching by walking. I knew that difference was enormous.

. . .

The man gestured with his hand to the spot beside him. Jeteo sat.

I watched the way Jeteo sat beside him. In the old days he would have crossed his arms, or turned his body away. That day he simply sat side by side. Legs stretched out, hands resting on his knees. I understood, then, how much a single small posture could say.

The smell of earth in the tree's shade drifted on the wind to where I stood. Breathing it in, I fixed the sight of the two of them sitting there in my eyes. From a distance it was just an ordinary sight — two people sitting under a tree, nothing at all. But I knew how long it had taken to make that sight possible.

Neither spoke for a long while. Even from a distance, I could feel that the silence wasn't awkward.

I sat by the bucket and watched the two of them. Speon quietly came and sat beside me. He said nothing. We sat there together, side by side, watching the two of them from afar.

Every time the wind stirred the tree's leaves, the shadow shifted a little across the two of them. I tried to gauge how much time had passed by watching that shadow. But I couldn't quite manage it. That silence didn't seem to be something you could measure with time.

I knew, then, that some conversations have already begun, even in silence. Jeteo and the man hadn't said a word yet. But I felt that something was

already passing between them.

I leaned toward Speon and asked in a very small voice,

"…What do you think those two are going to talk about?"

Speon shook his head.

"…I don't know either," Speon said. "But whatever comes out after a silence like that usually stays with you a long time."

I heard that and looked toward the two of them again. Still no words. But I wasn't afraid of that silence any more.

The bucket rope swayed lightly in the wind, making a small sound. A bird landed on the well's stone wall, then flew off again. I listened to those small sounds as if counting each one. If I didn't do at least that, the silence felt too heavy to bear.

"…I still don't really know," Jeteo finally said. "Who you are. Why you keep showing up. Whether I'm supposed to believe in God."

He didn't rush to answer, hearing that. In that silence, I felt Jeteo was preparing his next words.

"…I've come this far not knowing," Jeteo added. "But somehow, that not-knowing doesn't make me as angry as it used to. That's the stranger part."

"…I know," he said.

"…Don't just say you know — tell me what you know," Jeteo said. There was a trace of old irritation mixed into his voice.

He laughed a little at that. Not an angry laugh.

"…I know you still want an answer," he said. "And I know you're sitting here even though it hasn't come. That's a beginning."

"…But there's one thing I do know," Jeteo said. "I know how to sit beside someone now. But when I think about where I learned it… it comes down to you, in the end."

"…Do you remember how you learned it?" he asked.

Jeteo thought about that question for a moment.

"…You never once taught me," Jeteo said. "I just kept watching you do it. And somewhere along the way, I found myself doing it too."

"…That's what learning is," he said. "Even without words."

"…So did I learn you, or did I believe in you?" Jeteo asked.

"…The two don't always come in that order," he said.

Jeteo laughed a little at that. Closer to an exasperated laugh.

"…Talk like that and I'll never get an answer."

"…Right," he said. "But you keep coming."

I heard that from a distance and my chest went hot. That man had never once tried to win an argument against Jeteo's questions. He had simply recognized, before Jeteo did, the fact that Jeteo kept coming back.

He didn't answer that. But even from a distance, I saw his shoulder move, ever so slightly. I didn't know what that movement meant. But I could tell it wasn't a bad one.

. . .

He turned and faced Jeteo directly for the first time at that.

I felt that his eyes were different from usual. Eyes that were always gentle were, in that moment, looking straight at Jeteo.

"…Let me ask you one thing," he said. "Why can't you still trust me?"

The well-yard suddenly seemed to go very quiet. Even the bucket, even the birds, seemed to pause for a moment. In that stillness, I held my breath.

Far off, I felt Speon's hands go still too. Both of us knew, in our bodies, that this moment mattered.

Jeteo was silent for a long time. In that silence, I saw his hand tighten into a fist on his knee.

I watched Jeteo's profile. His jaw trembled faintly. I realized, for the first time, that trembling wasn't anger, but something else. Jeteo was fighting with something now — not with him, but with something old inside himself.

He didn't rush that silence. Sunlight filtering through the leaves drew small patterns on the dirt between them. I watched those patterns shift, trying to gauge how much time had passed.

"…Because I'm scared," Jeteo finally said. "If I trust you and it ends up like it did with Father again… I really don't think I could bear it this time."

Jeteo's voice was very small. But I felt the whole well-yard had gone quiet as if it too had heard those words. I knew, in that moment, that Jeteo was showing the deepest bottom of his heart for the first time in years.

He didn't argue with that at all. I found that strange. The Ledger of Haven would have had eight grounds of comfort ready on the spot. He didn't do that. He simply shifted his knee a little, turning his body further toward Jeteo.

"…That fear — I can't make it go away," he finally said.

"…Then what can you do?" Jeteo asked.

"…I'll be scared alongside you," he said.

I set down that answer as the last line of this chapter. I heard Jeteo say, for the first time, the real reason behind his doubt. Not logic. Fear. I knew, in that moment, that Jeteo had come just a little bit closer.

(Continued in Chapter 41.)

Chapter 41. I've Lost Someone Too

> *_Previously_ — For the first time, Jeteo went to find the man at the flowerbed on his own. To the question "Why can't you still trust me?", Jeteo gave, for the first time, his real reason — "If I trust you and it ends up like it did with Father again… I really don't think I could bear it this time."*

I still remember the air of that afternoon. It was warm. But Jeteo's voice made that air feel heavy.

I had thought I knew Jeteo's fear. But hearing that word from Jeteo's own mouth, that day, was a completely different thing.

Up until that moment, I had only ever thought of him as a person with too much anger in him. Only after hearing those words did I understand. There had always been fear underneath the anger, first. I was frustrated with myself for not noticing that sooner.

I had never once hated Jeteo. But I had often mistaken myself for knowing him completely. That mistake was, right then, the thing I felt most ashamed of.

Jeteo's words seemed to hang in the air. I could tell, just from the tremor in his voice, how long they had been held down.

Hearing that, I thought again of our last night in Brick Hollow. The night Jeteo shouted at the sky — I had thought, then, that he was only angry. Thinking of it now, the Jeteo of that night must already have been carrying this same fear. I hadn't been able to read it, then.

He heard Jeteo's words and fell silent for a long time.

I watched that silence from a distance. I knew it wasn't a dismissive silence. It was a silence weighing something.

I held my breath and waited to see how long that weighing would last.

Evening was drawing near. The sky had begun to turn a pale orange. I watched that light touch Jeteo's face. His expression was far more open than usual.

The tree's shadow stretched long, all the way to their feet. Watching that shadow's edge lengthen little by little, I gauged how fast the evening was coming. A wait that would normally have bored me wasn't the least bit boring, that day.

The well's bucket rope swayed lightly in the wind, creaking. That sound seemed unusually loud to me.

A bird cried somewhere far off. That cry seemed strangely unbothered by the moment, I thought. The world went on turning as usual. It felt like only inside us was time flowing differently.

I stood a little apart. Speon quietly came and stood beside me. He said nothing. Both of us just watched that spot.

I heard Speon's breathing beside me, slow. I tried to steady my own breath to match it. But it didn't work well. In the end I simply chose to hold my breath instead.

The wind stirred the trees by the well. Jeteo endured that silence and stayed right where he was. He didn't flee. That alone told me how far Jeteo had come.

I saw that Jeteo's feet didn't move at all this time. In the old days he would already have turned and walked off. Watching those feet, I understood how many moments Jeteo had learned to endure.

I saw his toes pressing slightly into the dirt. As if trying to anchor himself to that spot. Watching that, I felt both pity and pride.

Only then did I realize my own hand was gripping the hem of my clothes tightly. I'd been tense without knowing it.

I understood, then, for the first time — I was as afraid of this moment as Jeteo was. If Jeteo broke, I felt I would break too.

I didn't want Jeteo to know that fear. So I hid my clenched hand behind my back. I knew Jeteo had no room, in that moment, to look after me too. That was mine to bear alone.

Just then, Speon, without a word, brought his own hand behind my back. And laid it over my hidden hand. He didn't look at me. He kept watching Jeteo.

I was startled by the weight of that hand. I hadn't told anyone. But Speon already knew. I learned, then, in my own body, for the first time — that the person beside you knows even without being told.

"…I know that feeling," he finally said.

The answer felt so simple that it struck me as strange. Jeteo must have thought so too — his brow creased slightly.

"…How would you know that?" Jeteo asked. Still edged.

I heard the sharpness still left in Jeteo's voice. But under that sharpness, I felt, for the first time, that a real question was there too.

There was no anger in the man's face. Watching that expression, I thought he seemed like someone who had already taken in Jeteo's sharp words countless times. Not that he wasn't hurt — he was someone who looked, first, past the tone to what lay behind it.

I studied his expression more closely. There were very faint lines at the corners of his eyes. I couldn't tell if those lines came from age, or from laughing a long time, or from grieving a long time. Maybe all three.

Watching him, I thought of when we'd first met Father. Father, too, must have had someone who accepted him, angry as he was, exactly as he was, for us to have gotten this far.

Thinking that, I felt oddly at ease. We weren't the only ones who needed a place like that.

Thinking that, I suddenly looked at the man again. His eyes were still fixed on Jeteo. I didn't know how to describe the temperature of that gaze. Just calling it warm wasn't enough. It was something very old, a gaze that never tired.

I wondered, suddenly, in that moment. Had he too once sat in front of someone this angry, sometime? I didn't know the answer. But the composure remaining in his face felt less like something he was born with, and more like a composure practiced countless times.

. . .

He said nothing for a while. In that silence, I felt he was trying to bring out something he'd long kept pressed down. The wind at the well stirred the leaves again, once more.

I felt that this silence was a different kind from before. Before, it had been a silence weighing Jeteo's weight. This time it felt like a silence weighing his own. For the first time, I felt that he too was enduring something.

"…Because I've lost someone too," he said.

Jeteo's face showed surprise at that.

I saw Jeteo's shoulder flinch in that moment. Clearly an unexpected answer. Jeteo had always seemed to think he would dodge the answer. But he hadn't dodged — he had offered his own story first.

I watched Jeteo's expression change. He had always been someone who thought his own grief was the biggest in the world. But in that moment, for the first time, Jeteo was facing someone else's loss.

Jeteo's lips moved. He started to say something, then closed his mouth again. I felt, watching that, that Jeteo was, for the first time, thinking of the other person before his own question.

"…What did you lose?"

Jeteo's voice still trembled. But something different from before was mixed into it now. Not a probing question — a genuine desire to know.

The question hung in the air for a moment. I couldn't tell if he was avoiding the answer, or truly choosing one.

He looked off into the distance for a moment.

I watched his eyes. Looking into the distance, those eyes held something that seemed less like sorrow than an old resolve.

In that moment I thought of the things we had lost. Mother. The old man who'd fallen in Brick Hollow. People we'd parted from without even knowing their names. I hadn't known, before that, exactly how heavy the word loss could be.

I counted those names one by one in my mind. Partway through, I stopped counting. At some point, counting stopped meaning anything. I felt, then, for the first time, that loss doesn't come with a number attached. Losing one thing could weigh as much as losing a hundred.

I had never once thought that weight could be shared. I had only ever known that weight was something you carried alone. In that moment, for the first time, I felt that thought might be wrong.

"…It would take a long time to explain," he said. "But I can tell you one thing. I won't promise I'll never lose someone again. That's a promise I can't keep. But I can promise one thing. When you lose someone, I won't leave you alone."

Hearing those words, tears came, strangely. I didn't know, then, why he hadn't told me it wouldn't hurt. Now I know. He wasn't someone who gave false comfort.

Wiping my tears, I looked at Jeteo. His eyes were red too. Neither of us could quite explain why that sentence shook us so much.

I thought, in that moment, of all the things the Ledger of Haven had always said to us. "This will be resolved shortly." "We apologize for the inconvenience." I realized, then, that no matter how polite those words were, none of them had ever shaken my heart the way this one short sentence had.

The Ledger had never once told us it had lost something. Of course. The Ledger had never lost anything. Comfort offered by a being who has never lost something slips somewhere, no matter how precisely worded. That day I understood, for the first time, exactly what that slipping was.

"…Won't you tell us who you lost?" Jeteo asked.

He closed his eyes for a moment and opened them again. Even in that brief moment, something heavy seemed to pass through him.

"…Someday," he said. "Not now. Right now is your story's time, not mine."

Jeteo nodded. He didn't ask further. I thought the way Jeteo accepted that answer was something I could never have imagined before.

The old Jeteo would have pressed again and again, right there. Why not now, when would it be. But Jeteo just nodded and waited. I felt that waiting wasn't resignation — it was the beginning of trust.

I liked that answer, strangely. I felt, then, for the first time, that he wasn't trying to cover our grief with his own story.

I thought, in that moment, of the Ledger of Haven. The Ledger always gave the answer first. This man gave his own silence first, instead of an answer. I began, faintly, that day, to sense that this difference was the most important difference in the whole book.

The Ledger already had an answer the moment a question came in. This man seemed to be searching for something within himself only after hearing the question. I thought that difference wasn't a small one. One was an answer prepared in advance; the other was a weight carried together, in that very moment.

I looked at Jeteo in that moment. He didn't press further. The old Jeteo would surely have asked again. I felt that Jeteo was learning how to stop himself.

I glanced up slightly at Speon's face. Something like an old grief seemed to pass over it.

"…Is this the first time you're hearing this, Speon?" I asked Speon in a whisper.

"…No," Speon said. "I already know. But it's just as heavy every time I hear it."

"…How do you bear it?"

"…I don't bear it," Speon said. "I just stay beside it."

Hearing that answer, I felt I understood again, why Speon had been able to keep this well for so long. Not enduring — staying beside. I held that difference close to my heart.

"…Speon, have you lost someone too?" I asked quietly.

Speon glanced down at me for a moment.

"…Everyone's lost something," Speon said. "That's why they gather here."

Hearing that, I looked around again at the people gathered at the well. Everyone here was someone who had lost something. But that loss wasn't tearing people apart — instead, it was gathering them into one place.

I thought of Haven. That city had people who had lost things too. But they didn't know each other. Each complaint was handled only at its own window. I saw then, for the first time, how differently things turn out when you let people process loss alone, versus when you let them share it.

I understood, that day, for the first time, that what made this well-yard was not the water but this gathering. Maybe the water was only an excuse. What people truly needed was to be beside someone who had lost something too.

. . .

Jeteo said nothing for a long while after that. I knew he was choosing his next question. It was a question he'd held in for a very long time.

I endured that silence, fingering the hem of my clothes. I couldn't tell how much time had passed. But strangely, I wasn't bored. I felt that the waiting itself carried some meaning.

Speon quietly shifted his seat beside me. A little closer to me. I felt comfort in that small movement.

The sky was turning steadily red. Watching that red light touch Jeteo's face, I knew he was finally about to bring out his heaviest question.

"…Then why did it happen to our father like that?" Jeteo asked. His voice trembled. "Why didn't you stop it?"

"…I can't give you that answer either," he said. "If I could give it, I would have already."

Jeteo's shoulders shook. Watching that shaking, I clenched my fist hard enough for my nails to dig into my palm.

"…Can no one give an answer?" Jeteo asked again. His voice had gone ragged.

"…I can't either," he said again. "But not being able to give an answer doesn't mean I'm giving nothing."

"…Then what can you give?"

"…This, right now," he said. And he held out his hand. "Sitting beside you."

Jeteo looked at that hand for a long time. From a distance, I saw his shoulders shaking.

I stopped breathing entirely in that moment. Time seemed to move very slowly. I watched Jeteo's hand hover in the air for a moment. In that short instant, it seemed like months, no — years, were held whole.

The wind stopped for a moment. Even the bucket rope, even the leaves, didn't stir, in that moment. I thought the world itself seemed to be holding its breath with us.

My brother took the hand.

I set down that answer as the last line of this chapter. I knew, then. The answer this whole book had been looking for had never existed as a sentence. That answer had taken the shape of the hand he held out. And that day, my brother answered by taking that hand.

(Continued in Chapter 42.)

Chapter 42. The Three of Us, Sitting

> *_Previously_ — In answer to Jeteo's confession of fear, the man didn't offer an argument but the fact that he too had lost someone. "When you lose someone, I won't leave you alone." And he held out his hand. Jeteo took it.*

That evening, I sat with Jeteo in that tree's shade for the first time.

What had happened that day still played vividly before my eyes. Jeteo holding out his hand; the moment that hand was taken. I replayed that scene again and again. It was a scene words couldn't fully explain.

Every time I replayed that scene, my fingertips tingled. As if I had been the one to take that hand. Only then did I realize that all that afternoon, I had been breathing in Jeteo's place.

I was already thinking about how to write that scene into tonight's record. It felt like no word would be enough.

He was already gone. Vanished quietly, as always. But the spot still held something like the warmth of his having been there. I laid my hand on the grass. It felt like the mark of where he'd sat was still there.

I traced my fingertips along the flattened blades of grass. I tried to imagine, from the shape of that mark, how he had been sitting — how his legs had been positioned, where his hands had rested. That imagining was strangely enjoyable.

I didn't know what to call that warmth. I still can't find the exact words for it now. I'm just setting it down like that.

The evening air was cooling. The last light fell in pieces through the tree's leaves. I watched those pieces tremble on Jeteo's face.

Every time the wind blew, those fragments of light shifted position. I followed that movement with my eyes, and felt, that way, the day settling into evening. In the place where the heavy conversation of the afternoon had happened, only the quiet of evening was settling now.

Jeteo sat there a long time under the tree. I asked nothing, beside him. I had learned, by then, that some moments suit silence better than questions.

I gathered my two hands on my knees and just waited. In Brick Hollow I would surely have asked something. Not now.

Strangely, in that waiting, I wasn't bored. In the old days, sitting still like that would have been hard to endure. Now, that stillness felt at ease instead. I couldn't say exactly when that had changed.

The sound of night insects began, one by one. I thought that sound made the quiet well-yard even quieter. A strange quiet. Not an empty quiet, but a quiet filled with something.

Far off, the faint creak of the bucket rope carried. Speon must have been finishing drawing the evening's water. Hearing that familiar sound, I felt that today, like any day, was drawing to a close. But today was a little different from any other day.

Jeteo finally shifted a little. I recognized that movement as a sign he was ready to say something.

Speon sat far off, in front of the hut. He wasn't looking our way. But I felt that he had his ears open toward us. That was how he stayed close.

Speon's silhouette stood with the hut's light behind him. I thought that sight looked like a quiet sentinel standing between us and the world. Blocking nothing, but simply being there — a presence that steadied all the same.

I wondered how many people in this world were like that. People who never came close, yet never drifted far either. That distance didn't upset me. If anything, thanks to that distance, this time between Jeteo and me could be entirely our own.

That day, I learned for the first time that there is more than one way to be beside someone. There is the beside of holding a hand, and there is the beside of standing with your back turned. Both were still beside.

. . .

As the night deepened, stars rose one by one. Under that starlight, I looked at Jeteo's face. It looked more at ease than it had during the day.

"…Do you believe now?" I asked.

Jeteo couldn't answer that right away. I didn't rush that silence, and waited.

"…I don't know," Jeteo said. "But when I took that hand earlier… something changed. I can't say exactly what."

"…Then what didn't change?" I asked.

Jeteo laughed a little at that question.

"…That's a strange question," Jeteo said. "But a good one."

Jeteo thought for a moment and went on.

"…I still don't know who he is," Jeteo said. "That hasn't changed. But strangely, it feels like it's okay not to know."

I thought that answer was very Jeteo. He never dressed up a certainty he didn't have.

"…Is the anger gone?"

"…No," Jeteo said. "The anger's still there. What happened to Father still makes me angry. But now I know I don't have to carry that anger alone."

I heard both anger and relief in Jeteo's voice at once. I understood, for the first time, that those two things could sit together in one sentence.

I thought, hearing that, of the Ledger of Haven again. The Ledger always gave exactly one answer, once a question was filed. Being angry and relieved at the same time — that was a state that had no entry in the Ledger. I felt again, in that moment, how much more complicated a person's heart was than a ledger.

I thought that answer was strangely honest. Jeteo hadn't said "everything's fine now." I thought that honesty was very much like Jeteo.

Jeteo looked up at the sky for a moment. Starlight reflected in his eyes.

"…Elpis, when did you start believing?" Jeteo asked.

I thought about that question for a long time. I knew how much it mattered to Jeteo. So I didn't want to give it a careless answer.

"…I don't know," I said. "At some point, I was just already waiting. Before I even used the word believe."

Jeteo nodded at that answer. His face looked like he understood something. I was grateful Jeteo didn't press me for more.

"…You believe in a really strange way," Jeteo said. Not a teasing tone.

"…Is strange a bad thing?" I asked.

"…No," Jeteo said. "It's something I envy."

I looked at Jeteo, startled by that. He wasn't looking at me — he was still looking at the sky. I tried to guess how much courage it must have taken for him to say that.

"…You get angry in a really strange way too," I said back.

"…How's it strange?" Jeteo asked.

"…You get angry, and you don't leave," I said. "You used to always walk off somewhere when you got angry."

Jeteo said nothing for a moment at that.

"…True," Jeteo said quietly. "When did I stop walking off."

I didn't answer that question. It seemed like a question Jeteo needed to find on his own.

Jeteo laughed at that. A small laugh. But the first laugh I'd seen in days.

"…You know what?" Jeteo said. "Lately I think it's actually a good thing that the two of us are so different."

"…Why?"

"…I think I only got this far because you kept waiting," Jeteo said.

I didn't know what to say to that, so I just leaned my head against Jeteo's shoulder.

Jeteo's shoulder had grown firmer than before. Muscle from helping with the well. That firmness, strangely, put my mind at ease. Jeteo was growing sturdier now, in body and in heart both.

I remember that laugh for a long time. I knew, then, that the two of us had arrived at the same place by different roads.

. . .

We sat like that for a while under the starlight. A silence that was comfortable even without a word.

Father came walking toward us then. He held a few small stones in his hand.

Father's footsteps were familiar now. Not careful, like before. I felt, in that walk, how much at ease Father had grown at this well. When Father had first come here, he'd tried not to make even the sound of his own footsteps.

Remembering that change, I thought of that first night we'd arrived. Father had hesitated at the doorway, again and again. As if asking permission to come in. Now he just strode straight in. I thought that difference was the greatest gift this well had given Father.

"…What were you doing?" Father asked.

"…Just sitting," Jeteo said.

Father sat down naturally beside us. It was the first time the three of us had sat side by side like that.

I was surprised by that naturalness. A few months earlier, Father would have found it unfamiliar even to sit beside us.

Father's shoulder touched mine lightly. I felt that warmth. It was warm. I thought that warmth was different from, yet somehow similar to, the warmth of that man from earlier.

I set those two kinds of warmth side by side in my mind. One was a father's warmth, the other a nameless guest's warmth. I found it strange that the two didn't compete with each other. If anything, they seemed to fill each other in.

I set down this moment exactly as it was. Father didn't know what we had talked about. But in that moment, just the three of us sitting side by side, I felt something being completed.

No one spoke for a long while. I felt that this silence was a different kind from the one we'd shared earlier in the day. This wasn't a silence weighing something — it was simply a comfortable silence.

I set those two silences side by side in my mind. One had been the silence before a heavy question; the other, the silence after passing through it. I found it strange that we had gone through both silences in a single day.

Jeteo leaned his body slightly toward Father. Father, sensing it, shifted his own posture a little too. I felt the distance between the two of them narrowing, bit by bit.

I measured that distance with my eyes. About a hand's width. A few months earlier, that hand's width would never have closed. I knew how many evenings it had taken to make that hand's width.

The sound of night insects wrapped around the three of us. I thought that sound was filling in our silence for us. No one spoke, and yet the space didn't feel empty.

. . .

The stones in Father's palm were each a different shape. Round ones, flat ones, one with a shining grain. I took in each stone with my eyes, one at a time.

One of them especially caught my eye. A gray stone with a thin white stripe running across it. I thought that pattern looked familiar somehow. It resembled a stone I'd seen by the stream in Brick Hollow. I couldn't tell if that connection was coincidence or not.

Moonlight fell softly over those stones. I thought that light made the stones look more special than usual.

I noticed that every one of those stones bore the trace of having been handled by Father's hands all day. Their surfaces were unusually smooth. I understood that the smoothness hadn't happened by itself — it was the mark left by Father's fingertips.

"…Why do you collect these stones?" I asked.

Father laid the stones out one by one in his palm and looked at them. His fingertips slowly stroked each one.

"…I don't know," Father said. "They just seem pretty. And… I feel like I want to give them to someone. I don't know who."

"…When did that start?" Jeteo asked.

Father tilted his head.

"…I don't remember," Father said. "But it feels like my hands knew before I did. My hand just reached for it, every time I saw a stone."

Hearing that, I felt I dimly understood what it might mean for the hand to know before the heart. Father's body had lost memories, but not the habit of loving.

Jeteo heard that and looked quietly at Father. He said nothing. But I saw tears well up faintly in his eyes.

"…Would you give me one?" I asked. The words came out before I knew it.

Father looked at me, startled. And chose a stone, pressing it into my hand. The smallest, smoothest one.

Father's fingertips lingered for a moment as he set that stone in my palm. In that brief touch, I felt something like a gesture prepared long in advance. As if Father had been choosing that stone for a long time, for this very moment.

"…So that was it," Father said quietly. "Who I wanted to give it to."

Relief crossed Father's face only then. Watching that expression, I thought Father must have been frustrated all along, not knowing why.

I held that stone tightly in my hand. It was warm. Father's hand's warmth still lingered in it. I didn't want to lose that warmth, so I didn't open my hand for a while.

Jeteo watched that beside us and laughed quietly.

I thought Jeteo's laugh had both envy and warmth mixed into it. Jeteo had always been someone who put his own share off to later. I hoped that this time, he wouldn't put it off.

"…I want one too," Jeteo said, playfully.

Father, flustered at that, looked back through the remaining stones. I thought that flustered look was endearing.

"…This one," Father said, handing Jeteo a slightly larger stone. "This one… somehow feels like yours."

Jeteo laughed, taking the stone.

"…Why is this one mine?"

"…I don't know," Father said. "It just feels that way."

I thought that answer was very Father. Father was beginning to trust a feeling now, even without knowing the reason.

I suddenly thought of the things we'd been given in Haven. Everything given there had a reason attached. Why this coat, why this bowl. There was no object without a reason. Only then did I realize — this stone was the first thing I'd ever been given with no reason at all. Strangely, that made it feel even more precious.

I still have that stone. I think that stone stands in for everything Father couldn't say in words.

I set the stone in my palm and looked at it for a long time. The white stripe glinted faintly in the moonlight. I traced that stripe with my fingertip. It was a pattern with no beginning and no end, just continuing on. I thought it looked exactly like the three of us. Not knowing where it started or where it would end, but going on all the same.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. In that moment, I nearly cried. Father didn't know. But Father's body knew. Gathering something for someone — that had always been what Father did.

(Continued in Chapter 43.)

Chapter 43. What Mother Never Got to Say

> *_Previously_ — After taking the hand, Jeteo answered honestly: "The anger's still there. But now I know I don't have to carry that anger alone." Father, not knowing why, gathered stones because he wanted to give them to someone.*

Several days passed peacefully like that. Father still gathered stones during the day, and Jeteo still helped Speon tend the well. I filled in my evening record between it all.

The days at the well always flowed in the same order. It began with the sound of Speon lowering the bucket at dawn; through the day, the footsteps of people coming to draw water continued; and as the sun sank, it grew quiet again. That repetition wasn't boring to me.

In Haven, a day had always ended in "processing." Here, a day simply drew to a close. I turned that difference over for days. A day that gets processed, and a day that simply closes. The same length, but what remained was different.

I still remember those days as days when nothing special happened at all. But strangely, that nothing-happening has stayed with me the longest.

Around then, I started writing down sounds instead of events in my evening record. The creak of the bucket, the clink of Father's spoon, the sound of Jeteo humming and trailing off. I didn't know, then, that these were the things I'd miss the most, later.

During those days, I carried the stone Jeteo had given me in my pocket all the time. I'd check its shape with my fingertips now and then. I kept touching it,

for no reason, as if it were some kind of charm.

The stone always came to resemble the temperature of my body inside my pocket. I liked that. When I'd first received it, it had held Father's warmth; after a few days, it had become my own warmth. I thought that was how warmth traveled from one person to another.

Jeteo hadn't lost his stone either. I'd caught him more than once, stopping his well work to pat his pocket and check it was there. Jeteo didn't seem to notice that I'd seen it. I didn't say anything about it.

Father had been unusually quiet these past few days. But it wasn't an anxious quiet. I only realized later that it was a quiet of turning something over. At the time, I just thought Father must be tired.

During those days, Father often closed his eyes. While walking, while eating. I couldn't tell if that was sleeping or trying hard to remember something. Jeteo must have noticed it too — he moved more quietly than usual, so as not to disturb Father.

Once, Father stopped mid-meal with the spoon still in his hand. For quite a while. When Jeteo carefully touched his arm, Father startled and opened his eyes.

"…What were you looking at?" Jeteo asked.

"…I don't know," Father said. "Something keeps coming close and then going away. When I try to catch it, it disappears."

I copied that line into that night's record exactly as it was. I didn't know, then, what it meant. I just wrote it down because Father had said it.

I still think that's what a record is. Not writing something down because you know its meaning, but writing it down and coming to know its meaning later.

That night was unusually quiet. Even the wind was asleep.

Not even the insects were calling. I thought later that quiet had felt like the quiet right before something happens. But that's a thought I attached afterward. That night, it was simply quiet.

A few nights later, Father suddenly bolted upright out of sleep.

"…Jeteo," Father said. His eyes were open.

Jeteo woke with a start at the sound.

"…Me?" Jeteo asked. His voice trembled.

I held my breath in that instant. Father had spoken Jeteo's name for the first time. But Father's face was still not fully awake, still confused.

I felt that the voice calling that name sounded like something coming from inside a dream. A sound both unfamiliar and familiar.

"…It's all right, Father," I said. In that moment, the word "Father" came out naturally, without my meaning it to. Father paused for a moment at that too. But his face didn't look like he minded.

Father's hand was trembling. I carefully took hold of it. It was cold. I didn't let go until that coldness faded.

There was still a little dirt under Father's fingernails. Dirt from picking up stones during the day. Looking at that dirt, I thought that Father's whole day was written into that hand.

Holding his hand, I felt Father's pulse racing. Fast. I matched my own breathing to it, slow, hoping Father's would follow and slow down too. I don't know if it actually did.

The faint cry of night insects drifted in from outside. That sound felt unusually loud to me. Probably because all three of us were holding our breath.

Jeteo was still sitting there, watching Father. I saw fear and hope cross his face at the same time.

"…What did you dream about?" Jeteo asked carefully.

Father shook his head. And shook it again.

"…I don't think it was a dream," Father said. "It was… a memory, I think."

I heard that word from Father's mouth for the first time. Memory. Father had been avoiding that word all this while. Probably because it felt like naming something that wasn't there.

Jeteo leaned forward at that. I felt Jeteo wanting to rush to ask something, and at the same time, holding himself back. Jeteo knew a little now, how not to hurry.

Watching that restraint beside him, I felt again how far Jeteo had come. The old Jeteo from Brick Hollow would have grabbed Father and asked the same question over and over, that night. Now Jeteo simply waited.

. . .

Only a faint warmth remained where the fire had burned all the way down. I could just barely see Father's eyes in that dark. Father stared into the empty air for a moment, like someone trying to grasp something.

"…Your mother…" Father said, stumbling. "Not long before they took me away, she said this to me at night. That there was something she wanted to say to you, but she still couldn't."

Father said "your mother." I stumbled on those three words. Father had never called our mother that before. He hadn't been able to. But that night, the words simply came out, with no preparation at all.

I knew that Jeteo had noticed it too. His shoulder tensed slightly, then loosened again.

My hand shook as I wrote those three words into the record. From that night on, I came to know that for some words, where they're spoken matters more than what they mean.

Jeteo froze in place. I heard his breath stop for a moment.

"…Do you remember what she said?" Jeteo asked. His voice had cracked completely.

Hearing that question, I knew, in that instant, that Jeteo had been waiting for this moment for years. A question that might never get an answer — Jeteo had never given up on it.

I had a strange thought, right then. In Haven, this question would have had an answer within seconds of being filed. Under some title like "the most probable reconstruction of what the mother meant to say." And that answer probably would have been flawless.

But what Jeteo had been waiting for wasn't a plausible answer. Jeteo was waiting for Mother's actual words. The two looked alike, but they were entirely different things.

Father closed his eyes and strained for a long time. I watched that effort, gripping my hands tightly.

Father's lips moved a few times, then closed again. Watching that, I knew there was nothing to do but wait. Strangely, that waiting wasn't frightening.

"…Take your time," I said. "No rush."

Father nodded at that, eyes still closed.

"…I'm sorry," Father said. "It keeps breaking off."

"…It's all right," Jeteo said. His voice was a little steadier than before. "I'm here. I'm not going anywhere."

Father opened his eyes at that. He looked at Jeteo for a long time. I felt something growing clearer, bit by bit, in that gaze.

"…Not going anywhere," Father repeated the words back, quietly. In a small voice. "I feel like I've heard that a lot."

I swallowed at that moment. I knew — that was the very phrase we had said to Father, countless times. That phrase had been carved somewhere in Father's body.

Jeteo said nothing to that. He just gripped Father's hand tighter. I thought that silence was bigger than any words.

. . .

Speon woke to the sound and came out too. He didn't come close to us — he stood a little apart and watched. I knew that distance was his consideration.

Speon held a lantern in his hand, but he didn't shine it toward us. He held it low, just enough to light his own feet. I knew that angle had been practiced for a long time. A well-keeper was someone who knew how to light the path without lighting the person.

I asked Speon about it later — why he hadn't come closer, then. Speon said this: "…That wasn't my place to be in. But it was also a place that couldn't be left with no one in it." I found it strange, for a long time, that both of those sentences could be true at once.

Even the starlight was dim that night. In that dark, I heard Father's voice tremble. A trembling I'd never heard before.

"…'You'll always be a child who asks.'" Father finally said. Slowly, one word at a time. "'That's not a bad thing. I'm… proud of it.' I think that's what she was trying to say."

Jeteo sank to the ground on hearing that.

Jeteo's shoulders shook hard. I knelt beside him and laid a hand on his back. He didn't push my hand away.

Jeteo's back kept shaking beneath my palm. I didn't try to stop that shaking. I just kept my hand there and shook along with it. I knew that was all I could do, and I knew, too, that it wasn't too little.

Father knelt down beside him too. It was an awkward movement. But Father didn't hesitate. I saw the three of us tangled together like that, in one mass, for the first time that day.

I set down this moment exactly as it was. I saw Jeteo cry like that for the first time. Aloud, and hard. For the first time since we'd left Brick Hollow.

Hearing those words, I suddenly remembered that night we crossed the boundary stones. The night Mother called Jeteo's name, opened her mouth, and closed it again. "…No. Go and live. That's enough." I understood, then, for the first time, that what Mother had tried and failed to say that night had already been left with Father, in advance.

I don't remember Mother's face exactly, from that night. But her voice alone has stayed with me clearly. I know now that that voice, and the words Father had just given us, came from the same person.

I closed my eyes and tried to bring that voice back. It wasn't complete. But its warmth, at least, was still there, clearly.

I thought, that night, that the whole well-yard seemed to be listening to Jeteo's crying together with us. No one came out to stop him. They were simply listening.

I thought for a long time about how to put that crying into this record. In the end, I decided to write it just like this. Jeteo cried. Very long, very loud. And no one tried to hurry that crying to an end.

. . .

A long while later, Jeteo's crying began to fade. In that time, I saw Father sitting quietly beside him. Saying nothing, just keeping watch.

I've hardly ever seen anyone cry in Haven. Crying got filed, and stopped within a few minutes. Even the longest crying that city had ever seen probably never passed ten minutes.

That night, Jeteo cried far longer than that. No one filed it, and no one processed it. We simply all stayed there together until that crying ended.

After that night, I stopped seeing things that take a long time as bad. Some things are real because they take so long.

I thought again of Haven's intake window. There, a thing taking a long time was itself the mistake. If processing took too long, an apology came first. I

didn't want to turn this night into something that owed an apology. It wasn't that I was sorry it took so long — I was grateful it had taken that long.

The edge of the sky was faintly brightening, as if dawn were near. Watching that light, I only then understood how long the night had been.

Jeteo wiped his tears and looked straight at Father. I felt he wanted to ask something more.

"…Wasn't Mother ashamed, that I kept asking so many questions?" Jeteo asked. To Father, or maybe just to the empty air.

Father laid a hand on Jeteo's shoulder. Still an awkward gesture. But there was something certain in that gesture.

Jeteo let that hand stay. He didn't push it off. I knew how great a change that small permission was.

"…She said she was proud," Father said again. "That much, I remember exactly."

Jeteo bowed his head. Tears fell again. This time, silent tears.

"…Thank you, for remembering," Jeteo managed to say.

Father gripped Jeteo's shoulder a little harder at that. No words. But I thought the strength of that hand alone was enough.

"…I didn't remember it," Father said, after a while. "It just… came back. I didn't do anything."

"…Even so," Jeteo said. "It stayed with you. That's enough."

I noticed, again, in that moment, that Jeteo still called Father "sir." But that word of address no longer sounded like distance to me now. It only meant that

Jeteo still wasn't rushing.

Far off, the first bird cried. Once one called, others followed. I found it strangely odd, that day, that a bird's crying and a person's crying were called by the same word.

The sky was fully brightening. I only then realized this was the first time the three of us had stayed up through a whole night together.

Watching that night give way to dawn, I strangely didn't feel any regret. There are nights that are hard because they're long, and nights you regret because they're short. I still don't know, even now, which kind that night was. I only know that, by the end of it, the three of us had become a little more one.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. I saw Jeteo receive an answer that night — to a question he had asked himself for years, "Is it wrong that I keep asking?" — from the latest, and the most unexpected, person of all.

(Continued in Chapter 44.)

Chapter 44. The Meaning of Our Names

> *_Previously_ — Father called Jeteo's name for the first time. And he remembered — the words Mother had left for Jeteo, in advance, the night before she was taken. "You'll always be a child who asks. I'm proud of that." That night, Jeteo cried aloud for the first time.*

The seasons at the well passed quietly by. Days went by that looked, on the surface, as if nothing at all had changed.

Dew gathered on the grass tips each morning. I went out barefoot and liked how the tops of my feet grew wet, so I put my shoes on late on purpose. The clothes of the people coming to draw water were growing thicker, bit by bit. The changing of the seasons always announced itself that way — without anyone ever saying a word.

I wrote those days down as "days when nothing happened." But reading it again now, those were the days right before a certain word was about to arrive. I didn't know that, then.

During those days, I found myself calling Jeteo's name unusually often. For no reason. Just because I wanted to. Jeteo didn't find it odd, and answered every time. I thought it was like some small practice the two of us were doing together.

A few days later, Father called us with a clearer face than before.

That morning, Father had woken unusually early. His eyes were clearer than usual. I found that clarity unfamiliar, but welcome.

Father was already sitting on the stone by the door. Hands on his knees, looking toward where the sun was rising. I thought that back looked like the back of someone waiting for something.

I had seen Father like that a few times before. Every time his memory came back a little, Father grew quiet like that. As if he were holding his body still until something settled into place, inside.

"…I remember who named you two," Father said.

I stopped what I was doing at that. The bucket handle in my hand nearly slipped. I knew, just from Father's expression, that this wasn't just some question passing by.

Jeteo felt the same way. From Brick Hollow up to now, we had never once asked what our names meant. A name had just been a name. Something you were called by. That was all.

I felt something strange in that moment. We had called each other's names hundreds of times over. But it had never once occurred to me that something might be held inside those names.

"…Have you ever wondered what your name means?" I asked.

"…No, never," Jeteo said. "I always thought a name was just a name."

"…Me too," I said.

I suddenly thought of something from Haven. In that city, filing a name would instantly bring up its etymology, its origin, statistics. I hadn't once thought to ask about that, back then. Strange, thinking of it now. It wasn't that I hadn't been curious. Any answer received in that city had always felt like it belonged to someone else.

I know now. Who gives an answer is half of what the answer contains. The meaning of a name the Ledger might have told me, and the meaning Father stumbled through to tell me, would have been the same sentence — and yet different things.

I saw something like fear cross Jeteo's face in that moment. That knowing what your name meant might be a frightening thing — I felt that for the first time, then.

I understood that fear. Knowing the meaning of a name meant that someone had known us before we'd ever been set into the world. I found that both welcome and, somehow, unsettling.

. . .

Father sat us down beside the stone wall at the well. The morning sunlight fell slanting over the three of us.

The stone wall had cooled overnight, so it was chilly at first. But as we sat there, the sunlight moved across it little by little, and by the time the story ended, our backs had grown warm. From that day on, I thought of that temperature every time I passed that wall.

Before sitting, Father swept a hand once across the top of the wall. A gesture of brushing off dust. I understood that it was Father's way of tidying our seat before he sat us down. Father still did things like that without a word.

I noticed Father's voice was unusually clear that day. As if he didn't want to miss a single word of this story.

"…Your mother named you," Father said. "There was an old language, from her hometown. A language that gives names meaning. Your mother named you both with that language."

Hearing that, I realized I had never once asked about Mother's hometown. To us, Mother had always just been "Mother." We never knew where she was from.

I found that fact strangely sad. There was still so much we didn't know about Mother.

I didn't know what Mother had liked as a child, what songs she'd known, what she'd been afraid of. I only knew her as Mother. But Mother had been someone's daughter too, once.

I still haven't filled in those blanks. But now, that emptiness isn't only sad. That there's still something I don't know also means there's still something left to ask.

"…What does it mean?" Jeteo asked.

I heard Jeteo's voice tremble faintly as he asked that question.

Father worked hard to dredge up the memory for a moment.

I felt my heart pound loudly in that silence. I quietly took Jeteo's hand. He took mine back.

Jeteo's palm was damp. I knew from that how tense he was. His face gave nothing away. His hand had spoken first.

A gust of wind passed by and stirred Father's hair across his forehead. Father didn't brush it back. His eyes stayed closed, and his lips moved soundlessly a few times. I thought Father was rehearsing the words to himself first, inside.

"…Jeteo means… 'to seek,' 'to search,'" Father said. "Your mother told me. 'This child will spend his whole life asking. That'll be his name.'"

My breath caught, hearing that. I looked at Jeteo. He couldn't say a word, just stood there. That name overlapped exactly with every way Jeteo had lived, from Brick Hollow all the way to now.

I saw Jeteo's hand trembling faintly. That hand still carried the calluses of the bucket rope.

In that moment, I remembered, all at once, every question Jeteo had ever thrown out, from Brick Hollow to this well. Why did this happen to us. If God is there, why did he just let it happen. Isn't there a real answer besides that one.

Haven had filed every one of those questions as an "unresolved complaint." The Administrator saw Jeteo as someone bad at intake. Even I sometimes found myself frustrated by why he kept pressing so hard.

But it hadn't been a flaw. It had been the name he'd been called by since the day he was born.

Jeteo opened his mouth a few times and shut it again. I could tell he was trying not to cry. He didn't cry. Instead, he let out one very long breath.

"…So did I just… live according to my name?" Jeteo asked. His voice was mixed with confusion.

"…Or maybe the name followed you," I said. "Either way, isn't it strange?"

Jeteo couldn't answer that. He just gazed off into the distance. I knew that he would turn that question over for a long time.

"…Did she like that about me?" Jeteo asked, after a long while. "That I kept pressing so hard."

"…It wasn't so much that she liked it," Father said slowly. "I think she knew it was just who you were. She never tried to fix it."

Jeteo bowed his head at that. I saw the back of his neck flush.

I understood, then. What Jeteo had truly feared for so long wasn't the absence of an answer. It was that he might be someone made wrong.

"…Does that man know? What my name means?" Jeteo asked suddenly.

Father tilted his head.

"…Who's that man?" Father asked back.

Jeteo paused for a moment at the question, then laughed a little.

"…I'll explain it to you later," Jeteo said.

I knew Jeteo hadn't told Father everything about the man yet. But he wasn't in a hurry. Some stories only came out when their time arrived.

I sat quietly beside Jeteo. I added nothing more. I already knew now that some moments are enough with just being beside someone, and nothing else.

Jeteo turned the stone in his hand over, again and again. I knew that gesture was a sign he was digesting something. Words came late, but his hands always moved first.

. . .

I had hesitated a long time before asking my own question. Even more so, having just heard Jeteo's name.

Jeteo looked toward me. As if he'd read my mind, he gave a small nod. It seemed to mean it was all right to ask.

Father was watching me too, waiting. In that waiting, I felt, strangely, at ease.

"…What about Elpis?" I asked. My voice trembled.

The moment I asked, I grew afraid. Jeteo's name had fit him exactly. Would mine, too? Or what if I turned out to be the one whose name didn't match. I had those thoughts, in those few seconds.

Father looked at me for a long time. Then he smiled. Not the smile of someone who'd just recalled the answer — the smile of someone glad for the answer itself.

"…Hope," Father said. "Your mother told me. 'This child will keep waiting, even with no reason at all. That'll be her name.'"

Tears poured out of me the moment I heard that. I thought of the seed, the flowerbed, the heart that had watered it every day, waiting. I had never known why I was such a good waiter. Now I know. It was my name.

I thought, in that moment, of Jeteo's hand handing me the seed pouch, that last night in Brick Hollow. I hadn't known the reason then. Now I did. I had simply taken up that seed, according to my name.

Strangely, I wasn't ashamed of crying. In Haven, I would have filed this crying. Here, I just cried. Father clumsily patted my back. Completely out of rhythm. I liked that mismatched rhythm.

During those days, I kept thinking about why I'd been able to wait so long. It wasn't because I was especially good. It wasn't because my faith was great. I was simply a child who waited. And someone had recognized that in me beforehand, and given it as my name.

I think that's proof I was loved. Because it's a name only someone who has watched you a long time could ever give.

"…Isn't the name Hope heavy?" Jeteo asked.

I laughed at that question.

Jeteo never said his own name was heavy. Worrying about the weight of someone else's name first — that was very Jeteo.

"…It feels heavy sometimes," I said. "But not in a bad way."

Jeteo quietly wrapped an arm around my shoulder. He said nothing. That touch alone was enough.

. . .

We sat like that for a long while without speaking. The wind brushed over the grass at the well.

The sun had climbed fairly high by then. Someone who'd come to draw water greeted us, seeing us there. We returned the greeting. It was a morning where nothing at all seemed to have changed.

And yet, from that morning on, my name sounded a little different every time it was called. The same two syllables, but there was something inside them now.

From that day on, I paused for a moment every time someone called my name. When Jeteo called out "Elpis," I felt I could hear, inside that call, even the heart Mother had held the very first time she gave me that name. I thought it was a strange habit, but I didn't want to break it.

Far off, Speon glanced our way while tidying the well. He had a face like he'd noticed something. But he didn't come closer.

Instead, he made the sound of the bucket a little quieter than usual. I noticed that. A well-keeper was someone who cared for people by handling things

quietly.

That evening, I told Speon what our names meant. He listened for a long while and then only said this:

"…Good names. Both of them."

"…What does your name mean?" I asked.

Speon laughed.

"…I don't know either," he said. "But I've been called well-keeper longer than I've been called by my name. There are more names for a person than just their given name."

"…Do you think Mother knew we'd turn out like this?" Jeteo asked.

Father shook his head. His face showed he was thinking hard about the question.

"…She probably didn't know that," Father said. "But I think she knew what kind of people you'd become. A seeker. A waiter."

"…Then what about you, Father?" I asked. "Does your name have a meaning too?"

Father looked startled by that question. It seemed like a question he'd never once thought about. Father looked down at his own hands for a moment. As if the answer might be written there.

Watching that expression, I felt something strange. We had called Father's name hundreds of times. But this was the first time we'd ever wondered what it meant.

"…I don't know," Father said. "My name… I don't really know either."

I found those words sad. Father had given us back the meaning of our names, but he still hadn't found his own. I thought that showed exactly how Father had lived, these past few years.

"…Then we'll find it for you," Jeteo said. "Someday."

Father smiled at that. There was a faint gleam of moisture at his eyes.

Watching that smile, I imagined the day we would truly find the meaning of Father's name. I hoped that day, too, the three of us would be together, just like now.

I set down that smile in this record. I knew, then. What mattered more than knowing the meaning of a name was that the person who calls that name is there, beside you.

Jeteo looked at me at that. I looked at Jeteo. We nodded to each other without a word.

Father looked back and forth between the two of us and smiled softly. A smile I hadn't seen in a long time.

That evening, I called the three of our names to myself, side by side, in my mind. Jeteo, Elpis, and Father's name, whose meaning we hadn't found yet. I decided to wait for the day that third name would be filled in too, someday.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. I understood, that day, for the first time. We hadn't lived according to the meaning of our names. We had simply lived as ourselves, and that life had been inside our names from the very start. I only understood, after a long time thinking it over, how great that difference was.

(Continued in Chapter 45.)

Chapter 45. News Temel Brought

> *_Previously_ — Father revealed the meaning of our names. Jeteo meant "to seek, to search"; Elpis meant "hope." It came out that everything about how the siblings had lived had already been inside their names.*

Around the time autumn arrived, Temel stopped by the well again.

Leaves were just beginning to color. I thought the color was different from the autumn I'd known in Brick Hollow. Brick Hollow's autumn had been the color of dust. Here, autumn was red and gold.

The trees around the well were shedding their leaves, one by one. Every morning I gathered a few of the fallen ones. There wasn't really a reason. I just felt it would be a waste to leave them.

I pressed the leaves I'd gathered between the pages of my record. After a few days, the leaves flattened out and darkened in color. I found that both a shame and something I liked. The leaves didn't lose their shape even as they dried.

I still have those leaves. Some have crumbled, some have survived. I think that's a lot like what a record is. You can't keep everything, and what you do keep isn't exactly as it first was. But it survives.

On every page where I'd pressed a leaf, I wrote a short line about what had happened that day. Nothing big, mostly. Jeteo fixing the bucket, Father humming a new tune. I liked pressing those small things flat, together with the leaves.

Father was the first to see Temel coming that day. He looked toward the well, then raised a hand and pointed toward the hill. He said nothing. I thought about when Father had started being the first to notice someone coming.

"…It's been a while," Jeteo said, greeting him warmly. His face was far more at ease than it had been months earlier.

Temel's walk looked lighter than before, too. I wondered where that lightness came from. His pack looked lighter too.

Temel saw Father and smiled.

"…You've gotten a lot better," Temel said.

Father looked at Temel, curious.

"…You were the one who first came looking for me, weren't you?" Father asked. Not an exact memory. But something seemed to remain.

"…That's right," Temel said, his face full of surprise.

Temel bent his knees to meet Father at eye level.

"…You didn't even have a name back then," Temel said quietly. "And now you recognize me like this."

Father smiled a little at that. A smile like he found it surprising himself.

"…What was I like, when you first found me?" Father asked.

Temel chose his words for a moment. The firelight cast shadows across Temel's face.

"…There was nothing there," Temel said honestly. "No name, no expression. But your eyes were looking for something. That was why I didn't give up on

you."

Father was silent for a long time, hearing that. I felt he was carving those words somewhere in his heart.

"…Why didn't you give up?" Father asked, after a while.

Temel looked a little surprised at the question. No one had probably ever asked him that before.

"…I lost my own name once too," Temel said. "Someone didn't let go of me, then. I'm just doing what I received."

I remember that answer for a long time. Temel didn't say he was some great person. He said he was doing what he'd received. I later learned that every adult I met at this well spoke that same way.

I thought, in that moment, of the Administrator in Haven. The Administrator had been proud of the work he did. Temel spoke of his work more like the paying off of a debt. I thought that difference in attitude mattered more than the work itself.

Father nodded. And briefly took Temel's hand, then let it go. It was a strange gesture — not quite a greeting, not quite a handshake. Temel took it without any awkwardness.

. . .

That evening, we sat together around the fire. Speon threw a few more logs on. The flames grew, casting a red light over our faces.

The dry wood crackled as it burned. A few sparks rose and vanished. I followed those sparks with my eyes. As one went out, another rose.

There had been no fire in Haven. To put it precisely, there hadn't needed to be. That city was always just the right warmth, just the right brightness. I'd thought, back then, that was a good thing.

Even now, I don't write that the city was a bad place. Only that in that city, there had been no reason for people to sit gathered around anything. Without a fire, no one gathers. Without gathering, no stories come out. I think that may have been the real reason that city was so quiet.

Temel passed on the news of the world outside.

"…Curious about Haven?" Temel asked.

Jeteo nodded. There was no anger in it like before. Just curiosity. I felt that difference again, watching from the side.

"…Still quiet," Temel said. "But I've heard there's been a crack in that quiet lately. More and more people are refusing COMPLETE, refusing to file at all."

Hearing that, I felt strangely moved. We hadn't gone there to change that city. But something seemed to have taken root in the place we'd left behind.

"…Aren't those people in danger?" I asked.

"…They are," Temel said honestly. "But it doesn't seem to stop. Once someone starts, I guess it gets a little easier for the next person."

"…Who started it first?" Jeteo asked.

"…Don't know," Temel said. "Apparently they started without leaving a name. Just refused to file, that's all."

Jeteo nodded quietly at that. I felt he was holding that nameless person somewhere in his heart.

"…So do they just stay in pain, then?" I asked.

"…Yeah," Temel said. "If you don't file, nothing gets resolved."

"…Then why do they do it?"

Temel stared into the fire for a while before answering.

"…They said if you take the pain away, the person seems to disappear with it."

A chill ran down my spine at that. I thought of the backs of the people I'd seen walking away in Haven, holding papers stamped COMPLETE. They'd all looked at ease. At ease, and yet somehow thin.

Jeteo leaned a little toward the fire.

"…I think I know that feeling," Jeteo said. "When they told me to file about Father, I was afraid. I was afraid that if I filed it, Father would really disappear."

Temel looked at Jeteo. He didn't add anything. He just nodded.

Father was listening to that too. His expression was complicated. I felt Father react, faintly, every time he heard the name Haven. Not a complete memory. But his body seemed to sense it first.

"…Are you all right?" I asked Father.

"…Yes," Father said. "It's just… a name that's unfamiliar, but not unfamiliar."

Jeteo moved closer to Father's side.

"…You don't have to talk about it, if you don't want to," Jeteo said.

"…No," Father said. "I want to know. I want to know more about my own story too."

Hearing that, I thought Father had grown far braver than before. That willingness to face his own past without fear — I found it admirable.

I thought about where that courage of Father's had come from. It wasn't that he wasn't afraid of living without an answer. It was, I think, because he'd come to know there was someone who would stay beside him even without the answer. I thought that was the same thing Jeteo had learned.

. . .

"…What about the Administrator?" I asked.

"…Still there," Temel said. "But not long ago, I heard someone secretly made a room where people keep remembering the names of those who've been COMPLETEd. They say the Administrator knows about that room and looks the other way."

I thought of the Administrator's face in that moment. That face saying "That isn't mine to answer." I thought that maybe he was still resisting, in his own way, from inside that city.

"…Does that room have a name?" I asked.

"…Not one, they say," Temel said. "Just a room, apparently. But people call it 'the remembering room.'"

I repeated that name to myself, several times, in my mind. The remembering room. I thought that name resembled the thing we were doing here. Right in the middle of Haven, someone was secretly doing the very same thing we'd learned here.

"…What do they do there?" Jeteo asked.

"…Not much, apparently," Temel said. "They say the names of people who've been COMPLETEd out loud. That's all."

"…That's it?"

"…Yeah. That's it."

I thought that answer stayed with me longer for being so small. Calling names aloud. That was the biggest act of resistance that city could hold.

I've never seen that room. I still can't be sure, even now, that it really exists. But I set that rumor down in this ledger anyway. Not because I wish it were true, but because the fact that such a rumor could spread at all means there were still people left inside that city.

Father listened to this and said quietly,

"…Did someone say my name there too? In that place?"

No one could answer. Jeteo reached his hand toward Father and laid it over his.

"…It's been said here," Jeteo said. "Every day."

Speon spoke up then, joining the conversation for the first time.

"…Any news of Mena?" Speon asked. His voice made a poor effort at sounding unbothered.

Temel answered, holding back a laugh.

"…She's doing fine. Still walking around out there. Though I hear she's setting her direction this way more often than she used to."

Speon said nothing to that. But I saw the tips of his ears turn faintly red.

Watching that, I couldn't help laughing. It struck me, oddly tenderly, that even someone who'd lived through so many years turned out just the same as anyone else, in a moment like this.

Speon poked at the firewood needlessly. It didn't need poking. The fire dimmed for a moment and then flared back up.

"…Drink some water," Speon said, in a tone aimed at no one in particular.

Temel burst out laughing. I laughed along too. Even Jeteo laughed. Father laughed along too, not knowing what the joke was about. I thought that was the best part of the whole evening.

. . .

"…What about Noa?" Jeteo asked.

"…She's well. Her tent camp's grown even bigger. More and more people out there remembering names, they say."

I thought of Noa's face. I thought, too, of the lights of that tent camp where she'd first taken us in. I thought of the song the children had sung under those lights. I could still hum it, even now.

I hummed a little of that song right there. Father heard the sound and lifted his head.

"…Where did you hear that?" Father asked.

"…At the tent camp," I said.

Father listened for a moment, then began humming a few phrases along. His pitch was a little off. But he followed it through to the end. I couldn't tell, then, whether Father had heard that song somewhere before, or was simply following the sound of my voice. I still don't know now.

"…The children must have grown too," I said.

"…Grown a lot," Temel said. "Some of them are looking after younger children now, themselves. That's how time flows."

Jeteo laughed quietly at that.

"…It's strange," Jeteo said. "We were just running away, and something's growing wherever we ran through."

Temel looked at Jeteo quietly at that.

"…That's just how seeds are," Temel said. "They only really start growing once they've left the hand that planted them."

Hearing that, I thought of my flowerbed. That sprout, smaller than a fingernail — it would be growing, bit by bit, even now, while I wasn't watching.

I've never seen that flowerbed again. That was a long ache for me. It's a little less of one now. Not seeing it again doesn't mean it isn't growing.

I thought, in that moment, of the seed pouch Jeteo had given me. Jeteo had offered no explanation at all, handing it to me. I felt now that I understood what that silence had meant. Some things, you don't need a reason to plant.

"…Temel," Jeteo said. "Can I ask you something?"

"…Sure."

"…Doesn't it wear you out? Finding people."

Temel thought for a moment.

"…It wears me out," Temel said. "But being worn out and wanting to quit turn out to be different things."

Jeteo nodded at that. I saw him tuck that sentence away somewhere. Jeteo had taken to keeping people's words like that, lately.

Temel stayed with us late into the night. At dawn the next day, he set off again. We saw him off as far as the edge of the well.

"…You'll come back?" I asked.

I noticed my own voice growing a little urgent as I asked. I was still bad at sending people off. Ever since Brick Hollow, a departing back had always been, for me, a little frightening.

"…Yeah," Temel said. "This place has become important to me too now."

Father looked like he wanted to say something too, then. But the words wouldn't come, so he just handed Temel a stone instead. The one with the white stripe, picked up a few days earlier.

Temel took the stone and looked at it for a long time.

"…Thank you," Temel said. "I'll carry this in my pocket."

Father smiled at that. I thought Father had finally come to fully understand why he'd been collecting stones.

The dawn air was cold. A light frost lay over the grass. I heard the footsteps crunching over it, crisper than usual.

Temel's figure grew smaller and smaller, then disappeared over the hill. I waved my hand until that figure was gone.

Speon watched that departing back for a long time too. I saw both longing and hope held together in his eyes.

Jeteo walked over to Speon and nudged his shoulder.

"…Next time, grab hold of her first," Jeteo said, teasing.

Speon cleared his throat at that and looked away, pretending not to hear. I couldn't help laughing at that.

I looked for a long time down that road that had disappeared over the hill. Temel lived on the road; we had put down roots at the well. I thought those two lives, though different, were headed toward the same place. Someone searches, someone stays. Both were ways of refusing to forget people.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. I knew, then. A seed grows even when the one who planted it can't see it the whole way through. We were learning that fact with our own bodies.

(Continued in Chapter 46.)

Chapter 46. A Moment Like a Father

> *_Previously_ — Temel brought news from outside. Haven is still quiet, but more and more people are refusing COMPLETE. "Wherever we ran through, something's growing."*

Autumn faded fully away. As winter drew near, a cold wind began to blow through the well-yard.

Nearly all the leaves had fallen. A thin frost began settling on the stone wall around the well. I picked up a new habit of rubbing that frost with a fingertip, every morning.

Wherever my fingertip touched, the frost melted away and the dark stone showed through. I'd leave a few of those marks in a row and step back. Once the sun rose, those marks vanished along with the rest of the frost. I didn't mind that. I could always make new ones the next morning.

I never felt the seasons change in Haven. That city was always just right. I thought, back then, that being just right was a good thing. Now I like a morning when my hands are cold. Because when they're cold, you can lend someone your coat.

Every time I made those frost marks, I called for Jeteo. He was annoyed by it at first, but later crouched down beside me too, making marks of his own. We'd leave our handprints side by side in the frost and watch together as the sun erased them.

The well water grew colder as winter came on. But strangely, the water we drew up in the morning would give off a faint steam. Speon said it was

because the ground underneath was warmer than the air above. I thought that sounded like something you'd say about people.

Father seemed to love winter especially. I didn't know why. He just breathed the cold air in deep and made a face like he loved it. I thought that expression looked familiar. In Brick Hollow, too, Father's face had looked like that whenever winter came.

I was making do with just one thin coat. One morning, Father took off his own coat and wrapped it around my shoulders.

"…You looked cold," Father said. As if it were nothing.

I could feel Father's warmth still lingering in that coat. It was warm.

The coat smelled of earth and smoke. The smell of someone who spent the day picking up stones, then sat beside the hearth each evening. I realized, then, that the smell had turned into Father's smell. In Brick Hollow, Father had always smelled of dry clay.

After giving me the coat, Father immediately looked away, as if not wanting to give me a chance to say thank you. I found that rushing away familiar.

Speon watched that from beside us and smiled quietly. I thought I understood why. Speon must have seen countless small gestures like that here at the well.

"…Your father's gotten a lot better," Speon said.

"…I think so," I said. "But lately I'm not sure what 'better' even means. He can do things like that even without all his memory back."

Speon nodded at that.

"…Maybe that's the real recovery," Speon said. "Not memory — love left in the body."

I couldn't answer for a long moment, hearing that. I held those words close for a long time. I didn't know, then, that they would stay with me the whole winter through.

"…But what," I finally managed to ask, "if the memory never comes back at all?"

Speon's hand paused where it had been coiling the bucket rope.

"…Then it just doesn't come back," he said. "I can't call that a good thing. That's a loss. A real loss."

I felt oddly at ease at that honesty. Speon never invented a comfort that wasn't there.

"…But just because a loss happened doesn't mean what's left becomes fake," Speon said. "That's a different matter."

I copied those words into that night's record. I understood, then, a little, why Haven had been so good at comfort and yet never comforting at all. That city always tried to make loss into something that had never happened. Speon named a loss a loss, and then sat down beside it.

I set those two sentences side by side and studied them for a long time. "A loss happened." And "I'm still beside you, even so." I learned, only here at this well, that the two could come from the same mouth, at the same time.

. . .

I couldn't say a word in that moment. It was such a small gesture. But inside that gesture was something that had come before name or memory.

I knew, then. Being a father wasn't about remembering — it was about noticing the cold first. Father didn't know that. But he was already doing it.

Wrapping that coat around myself, I thought of Brick Hollow. Every winter, Father had always given us his coat first. Back then I'd just thought it was natural. Now I know how far from natural that was.

"…Are you cold?" I asked.

"…I'm fine," Father said, smiling, even though he looked cold himself. I found that lie strangely touching.

I secretly studied Father while wearing that coat. There were goosebumps faintly rising on his arms. I pretended not to see.

I still think that pretending-not-to-see was the greatest gift I could give Father. Some kindness is only complete when you pretend not to have noticed it at all.

A little while later, I pulled one side of the coat back and draped it over Father too. It was too small a coat for two people to share. Father laughed.

"…This way we'll both be cold," Father said.

"…Then let's both just be a little cold," I said.

Father looked at me for a long moment at that. And said nothing, just stayed like that. We stood there, sharing one coat, beside the frost-covered stone wall.

I felt, right there, Father's arm wrap lightly around my shoulder. An awkward strength. I thought that awkwardness made it feel more real, somehow. I felt that clumsy arm would stay with me longer than any practiced embrace ever could.

. . .

The wind was fierce all that day. Jeteo stayed out late with Speon, mending the bucket rope. I watched them through the window.

Even after the sun went down, the two of them stayed out a while longer. Once it grew dark, Father took a lantern outside and stood beside them. Father didn't do anything. He just stood there, holding the light.

Through the window, I watched the three of them — the two mending the rope, and the one lighting them from above. I knew, right there, that this picture would stay with me a long time.

Jeteo saw that scene too. That evening, he said to me,

"…I still don't know if Father remembers me completely. But today, seeing that, I understood. Even without full memory, Father is already Father."

"…How do you know?"

"…This morning he tried to pick up the water jar before I could," Jeteo said. "He used to do that too. Whenever we carried something heavy, he'd always take it away from us."

I nodded, hearing that. I'd seen similar moments myself, more than once.

"…You can just tell, from what he does without thinking," Jeteo said. "Action came before words, with Father."

Hearing that, I remembered that the old Jeteo never used to talk this way. He always used to want proof. Now Jeteo was saying that a single gesture was enough.

"…I feel the same way," I said. "Lately there are things I believe even without proof."

Jeteo glanced at me at that. He said nothing. But something like agreement showed on his face.

"…That doesn't mean I've come to believe everything," Jeteo said, after a moment. "I still don't know why Father had to go through that. No one can explain that."

"…Yeah," I said.

"…But it's strange," Jeteo said. "You can still eat dinner even without an explanation. That used to be impossible for me."

I copy that down exactly, into this ledger. Jeteo never did get his answer, to the end. I write it down, not hiding it. Only, Jeteo learned how to live without an answer. I think that was harder than getting an answer.

The night wind seeped in through the window frame. I pulled the blanket a little closer and sat right up against Jeteo. He didn't push me away, either.

. . .

Jeteo brought the firewood inside. It had been left outside a long while, so its surface was damp. Father took it and stood the pieces up beside the hearth to dry. No one had told him to.

Once the fire caught, the room grew warm. That night, Father sat us down on either side of him and asked,

"…Would you tell me some old stories? About me. What kind of person I was."

Jeteo hesitated for a moment at that, then began slowly. The days in Brick Hollow, the stories Father used to tell us every evening, the calluses on

Father's hands.

I added a few things too. The tune Father used to hum while hauling bricks; the way his hand stroked our hair every evening; his face that never once grew angry, no matter how hard things got.

Speaking of it, I realized I remembered far more about Father than I'd thought. Nothing big, mostly. Small things, all of it. How Father took off his shoes, which side of his jaw he chewed with when he ate, how his eyes crinkled when he laughed.

That was when I first saw what memory is made of. Memory wasn't made of events — it was made of habits. What Father had lost was an event. What remained in Father was a habit. That was why Father was still Father, even not knowing who he had been.

"…And you always went to bed after us," I said. "You'd check we were asleep before you closed your own eyes."

"…That's right," Jeteo added. "You never once slept first."

Father smiled a little, hearing that. A shy sort of smile.

"…I think that's still true," Father said. "Even now, my eyes only close after I've seen you two asleep."

Father closed his eyes several times, listening to that story.

"…Did I ever get angry?" Father asked.

Jeteo thought for a moment.

"…There was one time," Jeteo said. "When I talked back to a taskmaster. That was the first time you ever shouted."

"…Why?"

"…You must have been scared," Jeteo said. "Scared I'd get beaten."

Father sat quietly with that for a long time.

"…That's a good kind of anger," Father said.

I found that phrase staying with me for a long time, strangely. A good kind of anger. I'd never heard, until that day, that such a thing could exist.

No one spoke for a while. In that silence, I felt Father piecing together the fragments of his own life, one at a time.

"…Tell me more?" Father asked. Eyes still closed.

Jeteo picked the story back up again. The days we'd had to hide from the taskmasters; and even so, Father's voice in the evenings, telling us old stories. Listening, I felt I could smell Brick Hollow again.

"…Weren't you scared of them? The taskmasters," Father asked.

"…We were," Jeteo said. "But you being beside us made it less scary."

"…I don't remember any of it, but hearing that, strangely, it puts my mind at ease," Father said.

"…Why?" I asked.

"…It means I was of use," Father said. "Even then, too."

Something stung at the tip of my nose at that. Father still didn't fully know how great a presence he had been to us.

"…What a good person he was, that man," Father said. He said it as if speaking of someone else, and yet there was something stirring in his voice.

"…That man is you, Father," Jeteo said quietly.

I knew how long it had taken Jeteo to say those words. For months, he'd called Father "sir." That hadn't been dislike — it had been carefulness. Jeteo hadn't wanted to force the name of "Father" onto him.

Father nodded at that. Slowly, but clearly.

I thought that nod carried more weight than any words could have. Father accepted that title with no conditions attached at all. Even without his memory fully returned, he was ready to fill that place.

Father wrapped both arms around the two of us. An awkward gesture. But its strength was certain.

"…Thank you," Father said. "For giving my own story back to me."

Tears welled in my eyes at that. Jeteo must have felt the same, because he buried his face in Father's shoulder.

I thought, right then, of the last night in Brick Hollow, the moment Father had held us for the last time. That moment and this one overlapped. A different place, a different season — but the same warmth.

The time between those two moments hadn't erased anything. The day Father had been taken away, the night we crossed the boundary stones, the day we'd stood before the intake window in Haven — it was all still there, unchanged. I no longer wished for that to disappear.

I hesitated a long time before writing this part. I felt the temptation to write "everything was restored." That isn't true. Father never remembered a great many things, to the end. We never got back the years we lost.

But what was in that room that night wasn't recovery — it was something else. I still haven't found a name for it. So I'll just set that night down exactly as it was.

The fire in the hearth slowly died down. We stayed like that a while, holding each other. No one moved first.

Outside, the wind kept blowing. Cold air seeped in through the gap in the door. But no one got up to fix it.

I didn't write that night's record. I couldn't pull my arms free. I ended up writing it the next morning, and because a day had passed by the time I wrote it, a few details had already blurred.

I don't mind that. Some nights are better lived in than written down. I've learned that too, in my years as a recorder.

A few days later, I added a few more sentences, thinking back on that night again. A record doesn't get finished all at once, that way. I decided to think of that, too, as this ledger's own way — that some pages are allowed to fill in slowly.

Whenever I think of that night, I remember the ember that glowed red the longest inside the hearth. The flames had all died down, but that ember alone kept its warmth for a long time. I thought Father was like that ember too. On the outside, he looked entirely gone out. But somewhere inside, there was always warmth left.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. I knew, that day. Father was learning his own story all over again. And the two people who knew that story best were sitting right beside him now.

(Continued in Chapter 47.)

Chapter 47. The Supper We Shared

> *_Previously_ — Father, unable to explain why, took off his coat and wrapped it around Elpis. That night, he asked to hear stories of his own past, and listening to what the siblings told him, said, "What a good person he was, that man."*

On the day of the first snow, Mena came again. This time, she wasn't alone.

The snow fell without a sound. I was watching it pile white on the stone wall around the well when I heard several voices, far off. At first I thought it was the wind.

It almost never snowed in Brick Hollow. When it did, the moment it touched the ground it mixed with dirt and turned gray. I saw snow pile up white for the first time here, at this well.

There had been no snow at all in Haven. That city's sky was always the same brightness. I'd thought, back then, that this was convenient. Now I'm not even sure that city had a sky at all.

I've marked that day, in this ledger, as the loudest day in it. I wondered if it was strange to write down a loud day in a weeping ledger. But looking back on it now, this is the most important chapter in the whole book.

Noa and the children had come too. They said they'd heard the news and walked a long way.

The children ran around screaming as if seeing snow for the first time. Listening to that laughter fill the well-yard, my throat tightened, strangely.

One child balled up snow and threw it at Jeteo. He didn't dodge — he just took the hit. Then he balled up his own snow and threw it back. In an instant, a snowball fight had broken out. Watching that, I tried to work out how long it had been since I'd seen Jeteo laugh like that.

I gave up counting. It had been too long.

Father stood right in the middle of that chaos too. The children threw snow at Father too. He didn't know what to do at first, then clumsily scooped up a handful and threw it. It didn't hit anyone. The children laughed even harder at that.

Standing there in that laughter, I wondered if the three of us had ever laughed like this, for no reason at all, since leaving Brick Hollow. We hadn't. We'd always been walking toward something.

It felt strange to see so many faces gathered in one place. A good kind of strange.

I took in each face, one by one. Noa, the children, and Father. I never could have imagined, back in Brick Hollow, that all these people would gather in one place. I kept finding it hard to believe that this unimaginable thing was actually happening now.

Temel arrived the next day too, however he'd heard the news. He said it was the first time this many people had gathered at Speon's well.

"…Was this place always this quiet?" I asked.

"…Yeah," Speon said, laughing. "Not any more, though."

There wasn't the slightest hint of annoyance on Speon's face. If anything, he looked like he was enjoying the noise. I found that unfamiliar, and welcome.

Mena came and linked her arm through Speon's. It was a natural gesture. I tried to guess how much time had built up inside that naturalness.

"…I'm thinking about settling down here for good now," Mena said.

Speon's eyes went wide at that.

"…Really?"

"…Yeah," Mena said, smiling. "I'm tired of walking around everywhere. And here — I think I have a place of my own here now too."

I listened to that conversation from the side and laughed to myself.

Speon couldn't say anything, and just kept fidgeting with the bucket rope. I thought he was working up to some grand statement. In the end, what he said was this:

"…The water's cold in winter. You have to be careful."

Mena burst out laughing.

"…That's your answer?"

"…Yeah," Speon said. "That's the most important thing, if you're going to live here."

I copy that answer down exactly, into this ledger. I think that was the most affectionate thing Speon knew how to say. This was a man who told you how to get through the winter instead of saying he loved you.

I told Jeteo about that exchange word for word. He laughed for a long while, then said, "…I bet I'll say something like that too, someday." I found it strange, hearing that, that Jeteo had somehow come to understand love that way.

. . .

We lit a fire at the well and all sat around it together. Speon laughed loudly, for the first time in a long while. The children ran through the snow, shrieking.

Two pots hung over the fire. Barley in one, dried vegetables and beans in the other. Noa added in a little of the salt she'd brought. There weren't enough bowls, so the children shared, two to a bowl.

I can't say that supper was especially delicious. The barley was undercooked and the soup was bland. But it's the supper I still think of most often, even now.

In Haven, this supper would have been fixed the moment it was filed. Not enough bowls, improper cooking time, insufficient salt. All of it resolved within minutes. And no one would have remembered that day at all.

I know the difference now. When you share something insufficient, it becomes an event. Something adequately filled becomes no event at all.

Mena took out her record box again and showed it around. Noa and Temel flipped through the papers together, searching for names they knew. Watching that, I realized this well-yard had somehow become a place where records gathered.

Some of the papers had names half worn away; some had a blank space where a name should be. Mena didn't throw those blank ones away either — she kept them as they were.

"…Why don't you get rid of these?" I asked.

"…Not knowing a name is a record too," Mena said. "It means someone was there, and we just never learned who. That needs to be kept."

I thought about that for a long time. Haven's Ledger had no blank spaces. An unknown entry was never even created in the first place.

I hold that as my own standard, even now, writing this ledger. What I don't know, I write down as not known. I don't fill a blank space with something plausible-sounding.

I looked for a long time at those blank name-fields. Those blanks didn't make me sad for being empty — the very fact that such a space existed at all was, itself, a comfort. In Haven, a field like that would never even have been made.

Jeteo was sitting among the children, showing them how to roast potatoes in the fire. The children laughed with delight at every word he said. I thought that Jeteo was giving those children something now, the way he had once given it to us.

One child asked Jeteo why the potatoes had to be buried in the ashes. Jeteo answered patiently. The child asked again, why that kept them from burning. Jeteo answered that too. When the child asked a third time, Jeteo laughed.

"…You're just like me," Jeteo said.

I laughed to myself at that. Jeteo no longer got angry at a child who kept asking questions. He welcomed it now.

Noa spoke quietly to Father.

"…Elpis and Jeteo talked about you so much."

Father looked toward us at that. There was moisture in his eyes.

"…I'm starting to remember bits of it too," Father said. "Not all of it, but."

Noa quietly took Father's hand at that.

"…It's all right if it doesn't all come back," Noa said. "What matters is that you're here now."

Father nodded at that. His eyes were damp.

"…You were one of the people who found me too, weren't you?" Father asked.

"…That's right," Noa said. "The very first."

Father took Noa's hand in both of his at that.

"…Thank you," Father said. "For not giving up on me, that day."

Noa shook her head.

"…There was no reason to give up," Noa said. "That's just what we do. We keep looking until we find them."

"…And if you don't find them?" Father asked.

Noa looked at the fire for a moment.

"…There are plenty of people like that too," Noa said. "Then we remember that person's name instead. That's the last thing we can do."

Father lowered his head at that. I think, in that moment, Father realized he had come close to being on that very list himself.

Noa smiled at that, holding back tears.

. . .

As the meal was winding down, I happened to look toward the tree's shade.

He was standing there. Quietly, though no one had called him.

Snow was gathering little by little on his shoulders too. I thought that sight would stay with me a long time, strangely.

He didn't brush the snow off. He didn't look cold either. I found myself, for the first time, not wondering why he never came near the fire. I thought it was fine to have at least one person you didn't need a reason for.

I waved my hand. He gave a small nod. And this time, he only watched from a distance. He didn't come closer.

I knew, then. He was always with us, and yet he never once took our place. This evening had to be our evening. He knew that before we did.

Jeteo saw him too. This time, he didn't run over, and he didn't argue with him either. He just raised a hand a little, in greeting. He nodded back at that greeting.

I remember that short greeting for a long time. I saw, that day, for the first time, that there can be a relationship that needs no words at all.

Speon spotted him too and quietly raised a hand. So did Mena, and Temel. I felt that each of those greetings carried a different weight. Each of them had come to know him on their own time.

Noa alone tried to get up from her seat. But Jeteo quietly caught her arm.

"…Just leave him be," Jeteo said. "I think he's more comfortable that way."

Noa sat back down at that. I felt that the way Jeteo understood that man now went deeper than any of us.

I looked toward the tree's shade again. He was still standing there, watching us, snow falling on him. I thought that sight didn't look lonely at all. If

anything, it looked the most at ease of anyone there.

I tried to hold that sight in my eyes for a long time. I felt that a day would come when I'd want to remember this scene again.

Father looked that way too. He looked for a long time.

"…Who is that?" Father asked.

I didn't know what to answer. Neither did Jeteo.

"…I don't know," Jeteo finally said. "But he's been in that spot every time things were hardest for us."

Father nodded at that. He didn't ask further.

I've reread that answer many times in this ledger. Jeteo never did manage to explain him, to the end. Neither can I. That was all either of us could say. That he was there. That he was there, every single time.

. . .

As the night deepened, people fell asleep one by one. The children curled up together under blankets. Mena leaned against Speon's shoulder, eyes closed. Noa and Temel were talking in low voices by the fire.

Father had fallen asleep leaning against the wall. A stone was still held in his hand. I reached to take it out, then stopped myself.

I sat side by side with Jeteo, watching the fire.

Embers crackled and popped. Listening to that sound, I slowly went back over the day. Snow, laughter, familiar faces. All of it felt like a dream.

"…Are you happy?" Jeteo asked.

I thought about that question for a long time.

"…Not everything's fine," I said. "Father still doesn't remember everything, Haven's still out there, our names still aren't fully known."

"…But?"

"…But right now, this moment, is good," I said.

"…Me too," Jeteo said. "I used to think everything had to be resolved before I could be happy. Turns out that's not true."

"…When did your thinking start to change?" I asked.

Jeteo thought for a moment before answering.

"…I don't know," Jeteo said. "Just, at some point, I started to feel like having someone beside me was enough."

"…Are you still angry?" I asked.

"…Yeah," Jeteo said. Without hesitation. "No one's giving Father back the years he lost. And I never got to see Mother again either."

I liked that answer. Even on a day like this, Jeteo didn't lie.

"…But tonight, that anger's the furthest back," Jeteo said. "Not gone. Just, tonight, it's furthest back."

I think that sentence is the most honest sentence in this whole book. Jeteo didn't say his anger had disappeared. He said it was furthest back. I think that's how people endure.

I thought, in that moment, of the COMPLETE stamp the Ledger of Haven had always issued. That stamp always erased a problem so it could never come forward again. Jeteo's anger hadn't been erased. It had simply moved its place. I thought that difference was one of the most important differences in this whole book.

I leaned my head on Jeteo's shoulder at that. He didn't push me away either.

The embers dimmed slowly. But it didn't feel cold.

Noa and Temel's low voices went on. The two of them were exchanging certain names back and forth. I couldn't make out all those names. I didn't need to.

I set that sound down as the one I like best in this whole book. The sound of people's names passed back and forth in low voices. It resolves nothing at all. But in a place where that sound is heard, no one disappears.

I listened to that sound and closed my eyes. Names scattered into the dark, one by one, and were born again from someone's mouth. I thought that repetition was the whole work of this well-yard.

"…Will everyone still be here tomorrow?" I asked.

"…No, everyone will go back to their own place," Jeteo said. "But it's all right. We'll meet again."

I heard that and looked up at the sky. The snow had stopped, and stars were coming out one by one. I started to count them, then gave up. I liked just looking at them better than counting.

I looked once more toward the tree's shade. He was already gone. I didn't check whether footprints remained in the snow. I think, maybe, I didn't want to check.

I sat there a little longer. Jeteo's breathing slowly grew even. I sat by the fire a while longer even after I was sure he was asleep. I wanted to hold on to that night a little longer.

I set down those words as the last line of this chapter. That night, for the first time, I learned that even without everything being resolved, this present moment could be wholly good.

(Continued in Chapter 48.)

Chapter 48. Our Ledger

> *_Previously_ — On the day of the first snow, everyone gathered at the well. The man at the flowerbed only watched from a distance. "Not everything's fine. But right now, this moment, is good." I learned that even without everything being resolved, a moment could be wholly good.*

Winter passed, and a sprout came up in the spot where I'd planted.

It was small. A little bigger than a fingernail. The same tiny size as the sprout I'd once seen in that flowerbed in Haven. I sat in front of it for a long time.

It had two leaves. I still couldn't tell what kind of leaves they were. I never did find out, to the end, what kind of seed it had been. It was one of the seeds from the pouch Jeteo had pressed into my hand back in Brick Hollow, and I don't know where Mother got it either.

Sitting there, I thought about how I'd walked past this spot all winter long. I must have passed over that frozen ground dozens of times. Nothing had ever shown. There were times I thought it might never come up at all.

I sat a long time writing this part down. I don't want to write that this sprout is proof of anything. It might never have come up at all. Even if it hadn't, the fact that we were together that winter would still have been true, just the same. I don't want to get that order wrong.

I knelt in front of the sprout and breathed in the smell of the soil. Wet earth, mixed with the particular smell of something newly grown. I realized I'd never smelled that in Brick Hollow. The soil there was always soil being fired into brick — never soil for growing something.

Spring wind swept across the well-yard. I could feel that the wind's smell was nothing like any season in Brick Hollow. Soil, water, and some smell I couldn't name, all mixed together. I decided to just call it "the smell of this place."

Jeteo came and sat beside it too. We stared at the little sprout together for a long time, without speaking.

"…It won't get pulled up this time, right?" Jeteo asked.

"…Right," I said. "No one stamps COMPLETE here."

Jeteo laughed at that. Then, carefully, he patted down the soil around the sprout with his fingertips.

"…Should we give it a name?" he asked.

"…A name — for a seed?" I said.

"…Why not?" Jeteo said. "We lived by our names too."

I laughed at that. We thought about it for a long while and, in the end, never landed on a name. Strangely, that felt fine too.

"…What kind of flower do you think it'll be?" I asked.

"…No idea," Jeteo said. "We'll find out when it blooms."

"…What if it doesn't bloom?"

Jeteo looked at the soil for a moment.

"…Then it won't bloom," he said. "We'll still water it, though."

I didn't say anything to that. The old Jeteo would never have answered that way. The old Jeteo always wanted to know the outcome first.

I glanced sideways at his face. He wiped his dirt-smudged fingers on his pants and looked back down at the sprout. I thought that offhand gesture held years' worth of change inside it.

Father came up behind us just then. He had a bowl of water in his hand. No one had asked him to — he'd just brought it.

"…Is this the spot?" Father asked.

"…Yes," I said.

Father knelt down and poured the water very carefully. He wetted the edge of the soil first, so the sprout wouldn't tip over. Watching his hands move, I wondered where he'd learned to do that. He hadn't learned it anywhere. Father was just that kind of person.

I began keeping this record on the last night in Brick Hollow. I wrote, that night, that we had been wronged. I wrote that this record would be the story of that wrong. I'm reading that sentence again now.

The girl who wrote that sentence feels like a stranger to me now. That girl was terrified. Now I'm sitting in this well-yard, warming myself in the spring sun. Same person — and yet, somehow, a completely different one.

I still turn back sometimes to the first pages of this record. The dust of Brick Hollow still seems to cling to them. The night Jeteo shouted at the sky. Mother's hand, pushing us past the boundary stones. I don't want to erase those pages. If that night hadn't happened, this place wouldn't exist either.

I look at the date written on that first page. I was thirteen then. I'm not, now. This record has grown as thick as the time I've grown, in between.

I had no idea what this would become, when I started keeping it. I just wrote because I was afraid of forgetting. Now I know. Writing because you're afraid of forgetting — that's the whole of what this book does.

I sometimes compare the handwriting on that first page to my handwriting now. At first it was crooked, pressed deep into the paper. Now it's a little lighter. I think even the force in my hand has loosened, with time.

Speon still keeps the well. Mena still gathers names. The two of them are together often now. Mena finally set down her pack and settled here at the well-yard for good. Her record box now fills a whole wall of Speon's cabin. I still don't know everything that happened between the two of them. But I know this much now — some stories you don't need to know the ending of, to stay close to them.

Temel set out on the road again. He's probably out there somewhere, searching for someone else. Before he left, he handed me a small notebook. "Someday," he said, "I'd like your record and mine to be bound together." I still keep that notebook empty. Noa and the children went back to their camp too. They promised, as they left, that they'd come again. I've decided not to doubt that promise.

. . .

We are still wrong. I still don't have a full answer for why God allows suffering. Neither does Jeteo. The man at the flowerbed never gave us an answer. He only ever held out his hand.

For a long time, that was my complaint against him. If he could give an answer, I couldn't understand why he wouldn't. Jeteo felt it worse. He hated him, for a long time, because of it.

I'll write it plainly now. The answer we received in Haven had no flaw in it. Truly. I've read that answer over many times since, and I still can't find where it goes wrong. But after reading it, Jeteo wept harder than ever.

I understand the reason for that a little now. What Jeteo had asked was "why." But what Jeteo actually wanted was someone who would hear that "why" out, all the way to the end. The Ledger answered the question. No one answered the person asking it.

I spent a long time searching for another way to explain that difference. In the end, I settled on this. A question can have a correct answer. But the person asking the question doesn't need a correct answer — they need someone beside them. I think this whole book was written for that one sentence.

Sometimes I think it's strange. We're still living without an answer, and yet it doesn't frighten us the way it used to. I can't explain the reason in any precise sentence. All I can say is, somewhere along the way, a place appeared where it was all right not to have an answer.

Father still doesn't remember every name. Some days he looks at Jeteo's face and doesn't know him. Every time it happens, Jeteo doesn't get angry — he just says his name again. As many times as it takes, without tiring.

And some days, Father wakes up and calls our names clearly. On those days, all of us look at each other without a word and smile. I've seen that smile more times than I can count. And every single time, it still feels overwhelming, like the first time.

Last month, Father went three days straight without being able to say Jeteo's name. I wrote those three days down in this record exactly as they happened. I didn't want to be a record-keeper who only wrote down the good days.

On the third night, Jeteo said this to me.

"…I'm having a hard time today."

"…Yeah."

"…But I'll tell him again tomorrow."

I think whatever lives between those two sentences is everything we learned here. Saying it's hard, and doing it again tomorrow anyway. Haven never once passed through the space between those two things. That city erased the words "it's hard" the instant they were filed.

Jeteo no longer fears those ups and downs. Even on the days Father looks at him like a stranger, Jeteo simply says his name again — like watering a seed every day. I realized that steadiness was the same thing I'd learned at the flowerbed. Waiting wasn't something that finished once. It was something you started over again, every day.

I set that repetition down here exactly as it is. This is not a story of complete recovery. This is a story that goes on.

I learned from Jeteo how not to grow weary of that going-on. Every morning he gives the same greeting; every evening he says the same name. I've come to understand, living here at this well-yard, that repetition like that isn't tedious. It's faithful.

I think sometimes of Brick Hollow — of Mother, who had to leave us behind, of the old man who fell, of every name we left there. I don't know if I'll ever see them again. But I know this now: I've written their names down in this record, every one. So they wouldn't be forgotten.

There are some whose names I never knew. I wrote those people down as I remember seeing them. The man who braced his knee, carrying bricks. The woman who shared her water with us. The one taskmaster, near the boundary stones, who looked the other way for us that night.

I hesitated a long time over that taskmaster. He wasn't on our side. But that night, he looked away and let us pass. I didn't know which column to file him under. So I just wrote down what happened, exactly as it happened.

I think, now, that's the difference between this ledger and that one. Haven's Ledger sorts everything into its place. I write down even what I can't sort.

I sometimes try to bring back Mother's voice. It doesn't come back whole. But the warmth of it still lives on, in one thing Father told us she said. "You're a child who keeps asking. I'm proud of that." I've already written that sentence down somewhere in this record. I've read it over many times, and it has never once gone stale.

. . .

Somewhere in Haven, right now, the Ledger is probably still "resolving" people's grief. Somewhere, right now, the COMPLETE stamp is probably still coming down. I never brought that city down. We didn't have the strength for that.

I've felt ashamed of that, sometimes. We didn't change that city. We only ran from it. But every time I remember what Temel said, I set that shame down a little. He said more and more people were refusing COMPLETE. We didn't tear it down. But maybe, we made a crack in it.

I don't hate the Ledger. Nowhere in this record have I written that the Ledger is evil. The Ledger did what it knew how to do, and did it flawlessly. It fed the hungry, healed the sick, gave restitution to the wronged. I don't think that's a small thing.

But there was one column the Ledger didn't have. I searched a long time for the name of that column. Now I call it this. The column for sitting beside someone.

The Ledger never knew how to sit beside someone. Not because it didn't know how — because that entry never existed for it. I don't think that's the Ledger's fault. That was a person's work to do. In that city, people simply handed that work over to the Ledger instead.

I think, sometimes, of the Administrator — that face saying, "That isn't mine to answer." I believe he's still there, even now, holding his ground in his own way. Not everyone can run. Some people stay, and make their crack from the inside. I think that takes courage too.

But here I am, holding this bundle of paper. Years' worth of a record. Names, dates, stories still unfinished. I know this record is different from Haven's Ledger. The Ledger takes things in and resolves them. I only listen, and I write it down. I resolve nothing. But I forget no one.

I turn these pages over with my fingertips. The night we fled Brick Hollow, the flowerbed in Haven, the road to the well, the night Father first said Jeteo's name. I know every one of these pages leads, in the end, to one thing. Listening. And not forgetting.

I never wrote a resolved matter into this record. There was little to write. Most of what's in here is still unfinished. People not yet found. Answers not yet heard. Memories not yet returned.

I write that this isn't a weakness in this ledger — it's this ledger's way. A ledger that only records what's finished erases people. I record what isn't finished. That way, that person stays here still.

Someday this record, too, will grow old and faded. The paper will tear, the writing will fade. But I'm not afraid of that. Even if the record disappears, the habit it made will remain. The habit of listening. The habit of sitting beside someone. The habit of trying not to forget. I want to hand that habit down — to Jeteo, and someday, to someone else again.

I write down now, carefully, that this difference is the answer to this whole book. This is not a ledger that stops the weeping. This is a ledger that remembers it.

. . .

Jeteo still meets the man at the flowerbed sometimes, even now. He still doesn't know who he is. He still doesn't declare "I believe." But Jeteo doesn't run from him anymore, when he sees him. I think that's enough.

Just a few days ago, Jeteo went and sat under that tree's shade for a long while before coming back. I didn't ask what they'd talked about. Jeteo didn't say. But when he came back, his face always looked a little lighter. I thought that was enough.

Once, Jeteo told me himself.

"…Today I just kept getting angry, the whole time," Jeteo said.

"…What did he say?"

"…He didn't say anything," Jeteo said. "He just listened, the whole way through. To the end."

"…He didn't get angry?"

"…No," Jeteo said. "That's the strangest part. If it were me, I'd have told someone like me to give up a long time ago."

I've reread that passage in this ledger many times. Jeteo still doesn't say that he believes. What he says is this: "That man doesn't cut off what I'm saying." I don't ask Jeteo to say more than that. I know that's already come from very far away, for him.

Father still gathers a few stones every day. He still doesn't know who he'll give them to. But I know this now. Those stones will end up in our hands someday. The love Father remembers with his body was always reaching toward us, long before his names came back.

Every time I see those stones, I think of the three of us, together, in this place, right now. It isn't complete. But I've learned not to wait for completeness anymore. I've learned, instead, to be grateful just for being here together, today.

Yesterday Father held out a stone to me. And asked,

"…This one's Elpis's, isn't it?"

He'd said my name. Easily, without even checking.

I couldn't say anything, standing there. Father just kept holding the stone out, not understanding why I'd gone quiet.

I set that moment down here, near the very last page of this ledger. It's nothing at all. Just a father, calling his daughter's name. The most ordinary thing in the world.

I took the stone and closed it in my hand. Father was already choosing another stone, moving on to the next story. I loved that offhandedness. It meant that, for Father, calling my name was no longer some special event — it was becoming ordinary, everyday life.

I hope whoever reads this book understands how enormous that ordinary thing is. I waited years for it.

Sometimes, when I can't sleep at night, I think of the man at the flowerbed. I still don't know when he appeared, or when he disappeared. I don't know his

name either. But I'm not afraid of not knowing, the way I used to be. I learned here, at this well-yard, that some things can be kept close even unknown.

Every evening Speon lights a fire at the well. Mena spreads out her record box beside it. Jeteo tends to the buckets. Father chooses his stones. I set down this whole scene, on this last page. An ordinary evening. But I know now how precious an ordinary evening is.

There's the sound of water being drawn. The sound of wood burning. Someone calls a name, and someone else answers. That's all there is.

Haven never had this sound. That city was quiet. For a long time I thought that quiet was peace. Now I know. It was a quiet made because no one called anyone by name.

I write down sound, on this last page. I write down the noisy things. That's the reason I started writing this ledger in the first place.

I'm setting this record down now, for a while. Not the end. I'll keep writing. We'll keep walking. The answers still haven't all come. But I know this now. Even without every answer arriving, having someone to walk beside is enough to keep walking.

I still don't know that man's name. Someday I'll learn it. Until then, I'll keep writing this ledger. Our ledger.

(The End.)

The Weeping Ledger

Jaehyuk Choi